

Malayalam, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

Adhithya Rajasekaran

This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

Copyright © Adhithya Rajasekaran. Licensed under Creative Commons
Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (CC BY-SA 4.0). Malayalam set
in Noto Sans Malayalam (SIL Open Font License).

Preface

This book teaches Malayalam one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Malayalam letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read **നമസ്കാരം** *and* learn that it means “greetings” in the same few minutes. There is no alphabet drill to sit through first. (A reader who already reads Malayalam simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Malayalam is the youngest of the four literary **Dravidian** languages — a family entirely separate from the Indo-European one that gave us English, Latin, and Sanskrit — and it is the **closest sister of Tamil**, having split from it only about a thousand years ago. That double nature runs through this book: its everyday core is strikingly Tamil-like (“thanks” is **നന്ദി** *nandi*, twin of Tamil *nanri*; “no” is **ഇല്ല** *illa*, twin of Tamil *illai*), while a vast Sanskrit layer — the old *Maṇipravāḷam* tradition mixed the two freely — gives it a Sanskrit formal greeting (**നമസ്കാരം**) and the largest alphabet of the family. Each lesson sets the word beside its cousins across the family — English always, and Sanskrit, Hindi, and the other Dravidian languages where they illuminate — every form supplied in full, so no prior knowledge of any of them is assumed.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Malayalam out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in

brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

Released under CC BY-SA 4.0 — share it, adapt it, teach from it.

Contents

Preface	iii
1 Greetings	1
1.1 namaskāram	1
1.2 na ma	2
1.3 na-ma	3
1.4 na-ma	3
1.5 na-ma	4
1.6 sa, chandrakkala, ka	4
1.7 long ā, ra, final m	5
1.8 namaskāram	6
1.9 namaskāram	6
1.10 nandi	7
1.11 athe	9
1.12 a	10
1.13 illa	11
1.14 sari	13
1.15 Practice	14
2 Introducing Yourself	17
2.1 pēr	17
2.2 pa	18
2.3 ē	19
2.4 enre	20
2.5 e	21
2.6 ra	22
2.7 āṇṭ	23
2.8 ā	24
2.9 ṇa	25

2.10	enre pēru ... āṇṭ	27
2.11	nī / nīṇṇaḷ	27
2.12	ī	28
2.13	ḷ	29
2.14	entū	31
2.15	nīre pēru entāṇṭ?	31
2.16	santōṣam	32
2.17	u	33
2.18	ṇ	35
2.19	santōṣam	36
2.20	Practice	37
3	How Are You?	39
3.1	eṇṇane	39
3.2	ō	40
3.3	sukhamāṇō?	41
3.4	e	42
3.5	ñān	44
3.6	sukham	45
3.7	i	46
3.8	sāramilla	47
3.9	Practice	48
3.10	santōṣam	49
4	Farewells	51
4.1	va	51
4.2	u	52
4.3	pōkuka	53
4.4	ū	54
4.5	pōyi varāṇi	55
4.6	nāḷe kāṇāṇi	57
4.7	vīṇḍum kāṇāṇi	57
4.8	Practice	58
5	The First Verbs	61
5.1	samīsārikkuka	61
5.2	ña	62
5.3	n	64
5.4	ya	65
5.5	ñān malayāḷam samīsārikkunnu	66

5.6	o	67
5.7	ca	68
5.8	l	69
5.9	tāmasikkuka	70
5.10	ha	71
5.11	jōli ceyyuka	73
5.12	ja	74
5.13	la	75
5.14	Practice	76
6	Case Endings and Dative Subjects	79
6.1	-ikku	79
6.2	ka	81
6.3	ra	82
6.4	enikku malayālam ariyām	83
7	Numbers One to Ten	87
7.1	onnu randu moonnu naalu anchu	87
7.2	one, two, three	88
7.3	four, five	89
7.4	independent o	89
7.5	one to five	90
7.6	one to five	91
7.7	one to five	91
7.8	aaru ezhu ettu ompathu pathu	91
7.9	six, seven, eight	92
7.10	nine, ten	93
7.11	long e, zha	94
7.12	six to ten	94
7.13	ezhu, seven	95
7.14	ezhu, seven	95
7.15	Practice	96
7.16	virama	96
8	Please	99
8.1	dayavāyi	99
8.2	i	101

9	Sorry	103
9.1	kṣamikkaṇaṇi	103
9.2	ā	105
10	Days of the Week	107
10.1	thiṅkaḷ covva budhan vyāzham velli	107
10.2	na	109
11	Four Core Colours	111
11.1	karuppū vella cuvappū nīla	111
11.2	ma	112
12	Family	115
12.1	acchan amma cēṭṭan aniyān cēcci aniyatti	115
13	Head and Hand	117
13.1	thala kai	117
13.2	ta	118
13.3	ṭa	119
14	Seasons	121
14.1	vasanthakālaṇi venalkkālaṇi mazhakkālaṇi	121
14.2	lla	123
15	Water and Rice	125
15.1	vellaṇi ari cōru	125
15.2	ō	126
16	The Traditional Months	129
16.1	ciṇṇaṇi kanni tulāṇi vṛścikaṇi dhanu	129
16.2	anusvara	130
17	Noon and Midnight	133
17.1	ucca	133
17.2	pāthirā	134
18	Telling Time	137
18.1	maṇi	137
18.2	ṣa	139

19	Asking Someone's Age	141
19.1	ninnaḷkkū ethra vayassuṇṭū?	141
20	Numbers 11–20 and Weather	143
20.1	pathinonnū — irupathū	143
20.2	kālāvastha	144
20.3	da	145
21	Dog and Cat	147
21.1	nāya, pūcca	147
21.2	sa	148
22	Green and Yellow	151
22.1	pacca, mañña	151
23	Day	153
23.1	divasam	153
23.2	nāḷ	154
24	Night	157
24.1	rāthri	157
24.2	iravū / iruḷ	158
25	Good Night	161
25.1	śubha rāthri	161
25.2	bha	163
26	Morning	165
26.1	rāvile	165
27	Evening	167
27.1	vaikunnēraṁ	167
28	Afternoon	169
28.1	uchakaliññ	169
29	Good Morning	171
29.1	suprabhātaṁ	171
30	Good Evening	173
30.1	śubha sāyāhnaṁ	173

31	Good Afternoon	177
31.1	śubha madhyāhnamī	177
31.2	ū	178
31.3	śubha madhyāhnamī — three-way convergence	179
32	The Core Verbs	183
32.1	uṇṭū	183
32.2	pōkuka	185
32.3	varuka	187
32.4	tinnuka	188
32.5	kāṇuka	190
32.6	ariyuka	192
33	The Mind and the Page	195
33.1	cintikkuka	195
33.2	manassilākkuka	197
33.3	vāyikkuka	199
33.4	eḷutuka	201
34	Taking, Asking, Helping, Liking	203
34.1	eṭukkuka	203
34.2	cōdikkuka	205
34.3	sahāyikkuka	207
34.4	enikku malayāḷam iṣṭamāṇū	208
35	Family and Friend	211
35.1	kuṭumbamī	211
35.2	suhṛttū	213
35.3	-ṛ	214
36	Child, Son, Daughter	217
36.1	kuṭṭi	217
36.2	maṇa	218
36.3	maṇaḷ	220
37	Face Words	223
37.1	kaṇṇū	223
37.2	cevi	224
37.3	mūkkū	225
37.4	vāy	226
37.5	tha	228

38	The Two Hearts	231
38.1	hṛdayani	231
38.2	nenchŭ	232
39	Tea, Coffee, Milk	235
39.1	chaaya	235
39.2	kaapi	237
39.3	paal	238
39.4	ga	239
40	The Meal	241
40.1	ūṇ	241
41	Pointing, and Asking	245
41.1	itŭ	245
41.2	atŭ	246
41.3	ivite	246
41.4	avite	247
41.5	ārŭ	248
41.6	evite	248
41.7	i- / a- / e-	249
42	Describing Things	251
42.1	valiya	251
42.2	ceṛiya	252
42.3	nalla	252
42.4	putiya	253
42.5	paḷaya	254
42.6	before the noun, unchanged	254
43	More Everyday Verbs	257
43.1	ōṭŭ	257
43.2	uraññŭ	258
43.3	nilkkŭ	258
43.4	tarŭ	259
44	Verbs of Seeing and Saying	261
44.1	nōkkŭ	261
44.2	kēḷkkŭ	262
44.3	saṁsārikkŭ	262
44.4	eḷutŭ	263

45	Grandparents, and the Married Pair	265
45.1	muttacchan	265
45.2	muttaśśi	266
45.3	bharttāvũ	267
45.4	bhārya	267
46	Things You Ask For	269
46.1	paḷaṁ	269
46.2	tuṇi	270
46.3	viḷakkũ	271
46.4	uppũ	272
46.5	pustakaṁ	273
47	The Leg and the Tooth	275
47.1	kāl	275
47.2	pallũ	276
47.3	muṭi	277
47.4	viral	278
47.5	vayaṛũ	279
48	Who Someone Is	281
48.1	adhyāpakan	281
48.2	vidyārtthi	282
48.3	vaidyan	283
48.4	karṣakan	284
48.5	atithi	284
49	Short Replies	287
49.1	satyaṁ	287
49.2	mati	288
49.3	tīrccayāyumi	289
49.4	orupakṣē	290
49.5	aṇṇane	290
50	Taking Leave	293
50.1	ippōḷ	293
50.2	marrannāl	294
50.3	yātra	295
50.4	purappetuka	296
50.5	viṭa	296

51	Courtesy	299
51.1	kṛtajñata	299
51.2	upakāraṇi	300
51.3	bahumānaṇi	301
51.4	anugrahaṇi	302
51.5	vandanani	302
52	Welcoming a Guest	305
52.1	vātil	305
52.2	kaśēra	306
52.3	kōlaṇi	307
52.4	pūvū	308
52.5	māla	308
53	Overhead	311
53.1	ākāśaṇi	311
53.2	sūryaṇ	312
53.3	candraṇ	313
53.4	nakṣatraṇi	314
53.5	veyil	315
54	A Tree, Part by Part	317
54.1	maraṇi	317
54.2	kompū	318
54.3	taṭi	319
54.4	vērū	320
54.5	vittū	320
55	Ground Underfoot	323
55.1	pūla	323
55.2	pāra	324
55.3	nāṭū	325
55.4	vali	326
55.5	vayal	326
56	Things About the House	329
56.1	pāya	329
56.2	koṭṭa	330
56.3	katti	331
56.4	pātraṇi	332

	56.5	peṭṭi	332
57		Five More of the Body	335
	57.1	ka <u>l</u> uttū	335
	57.2	mu <u>t</u> ukū	336
	57.3	cu <u>ṇ</u> ṭū	337
	57.4	na <u>k</u> hami	338
	57.5	ellū	338
58		Five More Short Answers	341
	58.1	kū <u>ṭ</u> atal	341
	58.2	ku <u>r</u> avū	342
	58.3	ku <u>r</u> accū	343
	58.4	vē <u>ṇ</u> ṭa	344
	58.5	pōrumi	344
59		What the Air Carries	347
	59.1	kā <u>r</u> rū	347
	59.2	ma <u>ṇ</u> al	348
	59.3	ce <u>l</u> i	349
	59.4	pu <u>k</u> a	349
	59.5	ka <u>n</u> al	350
60		Animals Around a House	353
	60.1	pa <u>s</u> u	353
	60.2	ā <u>ṭ</u> ū	354
	60.3	kō <u>l</u> i	355
	60.4	kā <u>k</u> ka	355
	60.5	ā <u>n</u> a	356
61		On the Kitchen Shelf	359
	61.1	tē <u>ṇ</u> na	359
	61.2	e <u>ṇ</u> ṇa	360
	61.3	ta <u>i</u> rū	361
	61.4	śa <u>r</u> kkara	361
	61.5	mu <u>ḷ</u> akū	362
62		Made by Hand	365
	62.1	ka <u>y</u> a <u>r</u>	365
	62.2	nū <u>l</u> ū	366
	62.3	sū <u>c</u> i	367

62.4	cūlū	367
62.5	murāṇi	368
63	How the Body Reports	371
63.1	viśappū	371
63.2	kṣīṇaṇi	372
63.3	vēdana	373
63.4	cuma	373
63.5	pani	374
64	Five Words That Join	377
64.1	pinne	377
64.2	uṭane	378
64.3	cilappōḷ	379
64.4	mātram	379
64.5	ennāl	380
65	Asking Well	383
65.1	apēkṣa	383
65.2	anuvādaṇi	384
65.3	sammataṇi	385
65.4	maryāda	386
65.5	viśvāsaṇi	386
66	Out in the Paddy	389
66.1	nellū	389
66.2	pullū	390
66.3	katirū	391
66.4	kalappa	392
66.5	koyttū	393
	The Malayalam script (reference)	395
	Glossary	397
	Review Questions	417
	Answer Key	419
	Index	421

Chapter 1

Greetings

Modes:  voice (1)  eyes (4)  pen (10)  **Hands-free start:** first 1 of 15 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone in Malayalam, read and write namaskāram from sound, recognize the reply, and choose an appropriate response.

Greet and respond, read namaskāram aloud, then write it from dictation and check the three practised groups.

1.1 Namaskaram — first hear the greeting

Imagine meeting someone with your palms together and a small bow. First, only listen: *namaskāram*.

The exchange

Namaskāram is a respectful Malayalam greeting. It can open a conversation, and it can also close one. Hear its five beats slowly: *na-ma-s-kā-ram*. Answer with the same greeting once.

The Malayalam spelling is deliberately absent from this first pass. The next tiny lessons give your eye and hand no more than three reusable shapes at a time. Only after every shape is familiar will the book show the whole written greeting.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The greeting comes from Sanskrit *namas*, “a bow or homage,” plus *kāra*, “a making,” from the root *kr*, “to do.” Its memory hook is therefore **the making of a bow**. Malayalam is Tamil’s closest sister, but this formal greeting is part of Malayalam’s large Sanskrit layer. The same idea, five ways:

Language	“Hello”	Source
Malayalam	<i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Telugu	<i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Kannada	<i>namaskāra</i>	Sanskrit
Hindi	<i>namaste</i>	Sanskrit
Tamil	<i>vaṇakkam</i>	native Dravidian

Even Tamil’s closest sister took the Sanskrit greeting; Tamil alone kept its own. Hold that beside the next lesson, where the word for “thanks” splits the family the other way round.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *namaskāram* once as a greeting
- its five beats — *na-ma-s-kā-ram*
- its literal memory hook — “the making of a bow”

Before you move on

What can you say when you meet someone respectfully? (***Namaskāram***.) What gesture and literal history help you remember it? (**A small bow; “the making of a bow.”**) Do you need to decode its Malayalam spelling yet? (**No.** The script starts next with only two shapes.)

1.2 **ᳵ · ᳚** — two sounds you already heard

Say *na-ma* — the first two beats of *namaskāram*. Your hand meets only those two familiar sounds today.

Script

Malayalam is an abugida: a bare consonant already carries a short *a*.

- **ᵐ** is *na*.
- **ᵑ** is *ma*.

Put them together: **ᵐᵑ**, *na-ma*. Keep both models visible.

Writing — observe and trace

Finger-trace **ᵐ** once, then **ᵑ** once. Trace **ᵐᵑ** once from left to right. Say *na-ma* after your finger stops. This is observation with a visible model, not a memory test.

Before you move on

Point to *na*. (**ᵐ**.) Point to *ma*. (**ᵑ**.) What vowel did you write after either consonant? (**None** — the short *a* is inherent.)

1.3 ᵐᵑ — one guided copy

Keep **ᵐᵑ** visible. Point left to right and say *na-ma*.

Writing — copy with help

Copy **ᵐᵑ** once directly below the visible model. Look back as often as you need. Check **ᵐ** first and **ᵑ** second; repair only one place, then stop.

Before you move on

Read your copy. Which longer greeting begins with these two beats? (***Namaskāram***.) No new shape was added here: the work was moving from a finger trace to one supported copy.

1.4 ᵐᵑ — one delayed copy

Look at **ᵐᵑ** for five seconds. Say *na-ma*, then cover the model.

Writing — retrieve after a delay

Write the two shapes once while the model is covered. If one shape will not come, peek briefly, cover it again, and finish. This is retrieval practice, not a speed test.

Before you move on

Uncover **നമ** and compare. Repair one shape if needed. What changed from the last lesson? (**The model was hidden before writing.**)

1.5 Two heard beats — write them

Cover the answer lower on this page. No new Malayalam shape is hiding here.

Writing — short dictation

[YOU HEAR: *na-ma*]

Write the two-beat unit from sound alone. Now uncover and compare: **നമ**. Check **ന** first and **മ** second. Repair one place if needed.

Before you move on

You have moved the same small unit through trace, visible copy, delayed copy, and dictation. Say the complete greeting it begins. (*Namaskāram.*)

1.6 ന · ് · ങ — build ska without a leap

Write **നമ** from the heard cue *na-ma*. Now set it aside. This lesson adds exactly three shapes.

Script

- **ന** is *sa*, with its inherent *a*.
- **ഃ** is the *chandrakkala*. Attach it to remove that inherent vowel: **നഃ**.
- **ക** is *ka*.

Join the vowel-less first consonant to the next one: സ്ക, *ska*. The cluster is not a fourth shape; it is the three pieces you just met working together.

Writing — observe and trace three pieces

Keep the models visible. Trace സ്, then ി, then ക once each. Point through സ്ക and say *ska*. Stop after one slow pass.

Before you move on

What does ി remove? (**The inherent vowel.**) Read സ് and then സ്. (*sa; s.*) What does സ്ക say? (*ska.*)

1.7 ി · ര · ു — finish the sound inventory

Read സ്ക once: *ska*. The greeting needs only three more written pieces.

Script

- ി is the long-*ā* vowel sign. Attach it to known ക: കി, *kā*.
- ര is *ra*.
- ു is the *anusvaram*, the final nasal *m* here. With ര: രു, *ram*.

These are the last new shapes in the greeting.

Writing — observe and trace the last three

Trace ി, ര, and ു once each while the models remain visible. Then trace കി and രു once. Say *kā-ram* after your finger stops.

Before you move on

What makes ക into കി? (**The long-*ā* sign, ി.**) What does the final circle ു contribute here? (**A final nasal *m*.**) How many new shapes remain before reading the whole greeting? (**None.**)

1.8 നമസ്കാരം — every shape is already yours

Say *namaskāram*. Now the written greeting may appear: it contains no unfamiliar shape.

Script — assemble and read

ന + മ + സ + ് + ക + ാ + ര + ു → നമസ്കാരം

Read the pieces in the groups you practised:

- നമ — *na-ma*
- സ്ക — *ska*
- ാരം — *ā-ram*

Together: നമസ്കാരം, *namaskāram*. The conjunct സ്ക is still just സ with its vowel removed by ്, joined to ക.

Writing — one visible whole-word copy

Keep നമസ്കാരം visible and copy it once in the three groups above. Look back whenever needed. Independent production waits for the next tiny lesson.

Before you move on

Read നമസ്കാരം. How many new shapes did this lesson add? **(None.)** What does the greeting literally evoke? **(The making of a bow.)**

1.9 One heard greeting — write the whole

Cover the written answer below. You have already traced every shape, carried നമ through dictation, and copied the whole greeting once.

Writing — whole-word dictation

[YOU HEAR: *namaskāram* — “greetings”]

Write the greeting from sound alone. Use the three remembered groups: *na-ma*, *ska*, *ā-ram*. Then uncover and compare: നമസ്കാരം. Repair one group if needed; do not rewrite the whole word.

Before you move on

Read your greeting and say what it does. (**It respectfully opens or closes a conversation.**) This is independent production of a fully taught word, not a preview of untaught shapes.

1.10 നന്ദി (*nandi*) — “thank you,” and the Tamil kinship made visible

After a Sanskrit greeting, the native core shows itself: Malayalam’s “thank you” is **not** the Sanskrit word its neighbours Kannada and Telugu use. It is *nandi* — the very cousin of Tamil’s *nanri*.

The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Malayalam.*)

- ന = “na.”
- ന്ദി = “ndi” — a **conjunct**: ന (na) loses its vowel and joins ദ (da) into “nd,” then the “i” **vowel sign** gives “ndi.”

Left to right: ന · ന്ദി = *na-ndi* →

നന്ദി = **nandi**

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

നന്ദി (*nandi*) is **native Dravidian**, from the same root **nal** / **nan** (“good”) that gives Tamil **nanri** (“goodness → gratitude”).

Malayalam and Tamil split from one language about a thousand years ago, so their oldest, most everyday words are near-twins — and “thanks” is a perfect example: Malayalam *nandi*, Tamil *nanri*, one

word lightly reshaped.

Its neighbours went the other way: Kannada and Telugu use the Sanskrit *dhanyavāda*. So the map of “thanks” traces the family’s fault-line exactly — Tamil and Malayalam on the native side, Kannada and Telugu on the Sanskrit side.

The same idea, five ways:

Language	“Thanks”	Note
Malayalam	<i>nandi</i> (നന്ദി)	native (root <i>nal</i> , “good”)
Tamil	<i>nanri</i> (நன்றி)	the same native root
Kannada	<i>dhanyavāda</i> (ಧನ್ಯವಾದ)	Sanskrit
Telugu	<i>dhanyavādamulu</i> (ధన్యవాదములు)	Sanskrit
Hindi	<i>dhanyavād</i> / <i>shukriyā</i>	Sanskrit / Perso-Arabic

Why it’s said this way

Like *nanri* in Tamil, *nandi* is a touch formal — among close family it can feel oddly stiff, as if you were thanking a stranger; warmth is usually assumed and shown in tone. The explicit word is for when you want to *mark* the gratitude. (In casual speech you’ll also hear the English *thanks*.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- na · ndi → “nandi”
- the pair across the split — Malayalam *nandi*, Tamil *nanri*
- how *ṇ* joins two consonants into one “nd” block

Before you move on

Read നന്ദി. Is it native or a Sanskrit loan, and which language has the twin word? (Native — root *nal*, “good”; Tamil’s *nanri*.) Which two Dravidian languages use the *Sanskrit* word for thanks instead?

(Kannada, Telugu.)

1.11 അതെ (athe) — “yes,” literally “that [is so]”

The plain “yes” — and a small window into how Malayalam thinks, because the word is really the pointing-word “that.”

The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Malayalam.*)

- അ = “a” — an **independent vowel** (the word starts with a vowel, so it gets a full letter).
- തെ = “the” — ത (tha, a soft *th* as in *this*) with the “e” **vowel sign** written *in front* of the consonant.

Left to right: അ · തെ = *a-the* →

അതെ = **athe** = “yes.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

അതെ (*athe*) is native Malayalam, and it grows from അത് (*athu*), “that.” To say “yes,” Malayalam essentially says “**that [is so]**” — you affirm by pointing at the truth of what was said. Its natural partner is the negative *alla*, “[it is] not that” — the next lesson.

Grammar Lens: yes and no as “that is” / “not that”

Malayalam’s yes/no pair are demonstratives in disguise: *athe* (“that [is so]”) and *alla* (“not that”). Like its sisters, Malayalam also readily answers by **echoing the verb** of the question (*vannu*, “[I] came,” for “did you come?”). Bank *athe* as the simple word, but hear the logic underneath — you agree by confirming *that* is how things are.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- a · the → “athe”

- note the “e” sign sits *before* ത but is read *after* it
- “athe” — “yes, that’s so”

Before you move on

Read അതെ. What everyday word is it built from, and so what does “yes” literally assert? (*athu*, “that” — so “yes” = “that [is so]”). Where does the “e” vowel sign sit, and where is it read? (Written before the consonant, read after.)

1.12 അ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: നമസ്കാരം — can you still read it back?

One character this time. One only. It has been sitting in front of you on pages you have already read.

Script you’ll notice: അ

അ — *a*.

It is an **independent vowel** — the shape this vowel takes when a word *begins* with it, rather than the sign it becomes inside a word.

You have already said a word that starts with it.

- അതെ *athe* — yes (“that [is so]”)

Malayalam writes a word-initial vowel with a letter of its own. Inside a word this vowel would be a small sign hung on a consonant; at the front of a word there is no consonant to hang it on, so the vowel stands up as അ.

Writing: അ — **copy what you see**

Put your pen on അ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find അ in the ones that have it
അതെ · നന്ദി · നമസ്കാരം
- *Trace it:* അ three times, saying *a* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find അ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — അ? What sound does it carry? (*a*)
Where in a word does a vowel need a full letter of its own? (At the start.)

1.13 ഇല്ല (illa) — “no,” the word Malayalam and Tamil share almost exactly

The partner of *athe*, and more family evidence: this Malayalam “no” is essentially the **same word** as Tamil’s *illai* and Kannada’s *illa* — the old Dravidian *il-* runs right through.

The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Malayalam.*)

- ഇ = “i” — an **independent vowel** (word-initial, so a full letter, like അ in *athe*).
- ള്ല = “lla” — a **conjunct**: ല (la) loses its vowel and joins another ല (la) into a doubled, held “ll.”

Left to right: ഇ · ള്ല = *i-lla* →

ഇല്ല = *illa*

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ഇല്ല (*illa*) is built on the ancient Dravidian root **il**, “not-being, absence” — so, exactly like Tamil *illai*, it really means “[it] is not,

[there] is not,” and serves as the everyday “no.” The positive partner will come much later, after you have enough sentence pieces to use the contrast.

The same idea, five ways:

Language	“No / isn’t”	Note
Malayalam	<i>illa</i> (ഇല്ല)	native, root <i>il-</i>
Tamil	<i>illai</i> (இல்லை)	the same root
Kannada	<i>illa</i> (ಇಲ್ಲ)	the same root
Telugu	<i>lēdu</i> (లేదు)	native, a different root
Hindi	<i>nahī</i> (नहीं)	Indo-European (unrelated)

Grammar Lens: Dravidian negates by *being*

English inserts *not* / *no*. Malayalam — like Tamil and Kannada — can instead use a **negative verb of existence**. So *illa* is both the plain “no” and, later, a word that can make a whole sentence mean “there is not.” Today, only the short answer is yours to use. This is a **shared Dravidian inheritance**, strongest across the Tamil–Malayalam pair: Tamil *illai*, Malayalam *illa*, Kannada *illa* — one family, one way to say a thing is not. (Recall Telugu was the outlier here, using *lēdu*.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- $i \cdot lla \rightarrow \text{“illa”}$
- the pair — *athe* (“yes”) / *illa* (“no”)
- *illa* once as the short answer “no”

Before you move on

Read ഇല്ല. Literally, is it closer to “no” or “is not”? (“Is not / there is not.”) Which languages share this exact *il-* root, and which Dravidian sister does *not*? (Tamil and Kannada share it; Telugu is the outlier, with *lēdu*.)

1.14 ശരി (śari) — “okay,” the whole-family word once more

The easy middle between “yes” and “no”: “okay, alright, correct.” You have now met it in four languages — Tamil and Kannada *sari*, Telugu *sarē*, and here Malayalam *śari*.

The letters in this word

(Skim if you read Malayalam.)

- ശ = “śa” — a *sh*-sound (the palatal ś). Malayalam, having borrowed so much Sanskrit, keeps the full set of Sanskrit sibilants (ś, ṣ, s) as separate letters — more than Tamil, which makes do with one.
- രി = “ri” — ര (ra) with the “i” vowel sign.

Left to right: ശ · രി = śa-ri →

ശരി = śari = “okay / correct.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ശരി (*śari*) is the pan-Dravidian “**correct, right** → **okay, agreed**,” the verbal nod of Malayalam. It is the same family word carried by Tamil and Kannada as *sari* and Telugu as *sarē*; Malayalam simply spells its opening sound with ശ (ś). Doubled, *śari śari*, it means “yes yes, fine.”

Grammar Lens: one word, four scripts

sari / *sarē* / *śari* is the clearest single proof of how close these four languages are: essentially one word and one meaning, wearing four different scripts. As you learn to read each, catching a shared word change its clothes but not its sense is the fastest way to feel the whole Dravidian family at once — and the reason the four are worth seeing side by side.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- śa · ri → “śari”
- the everyday triple — *athe* (yes) · *illa* (no) · *śari* (okay)
- the word across the family — *sari* / *sarē* / *śari*

Before you move on

Read ശരി. What does it mean, and how do its Tamil, Kannada, and Telugu twins sound? (“Okay, correct”; *sari*, *sari*, *sarē*.) Why does Malayalam keep a separate ശ (*ś*) letter where Tamil uses one all-purpose sibilant? (It borrowed heavily from Sanskrit and kept Sanskrit’s sibilant letters.)

1.15 Chapter 1 — a five-word recap

Five words, and a first handful of Malayalam letters read straight off the page. Let’s gather only what you have already learned and make it feel easy.

The exchange — read them back

Sound each out, left to right, before checking:

Read		Meaning	Origin
നമസ്കാരം	<i>namaskāram</i>	hello / greetings	Sanskrit
നന്ദി	<i>nandi</i>	thank you	native (= Tamil <i>nanri</i>)
അതെ	<i>athe</i>	yes	native (“that [is so]”)
ഇല്ല	<i>illa</i>	no / there isn’t	native (= Tamil <i>illai</i>)
ശരി	<i>śari</i>	okay	native (= <i>sari</i>)

The letters that did it: consonants carry a built-in “a”; the **chan-drakkala** strips that vowel so consonants can **join into conjuncts** (ന്മ, ന്, ല്); a **vowel sign** swaps the vowel (ഃ ā, ി i, ൈ e — the *e*-sign written *before* its consonant); the **anusvāram** (ം) adds a final nasal; and a word-initial vowel gets a **full letter** (അ, ഇ).

Notice how **Tamil-like** the native core is: four of the five everyday words (*nandi*, *athe*, *illa*, *śari*) are shared with Tamil — because Malayalam *is* Tamil’s closest sister — while only the formal greeting reached for Sanskrit.

Why it's said this way

Malayalam has a warm departure phrase built around going and coming back. It belongs in the later chapter where you learn those actions one at a time. For now, repeating the greeting is enough when you part.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- all five — namaskāram · nandi · athe · illa · śari
- greet and thank — “namaskāram!” ... “nandi.”

Writing checkpoint

Hide the model. Hear *namaskāram* once, write നമസ്കാരം, then uncover the word in the table and check one group at a time: നമ · സ്ക · ാരം. A mismatch is a signal to repeat the earlier two-minute shape lesson, not to push faster.

Script check — the letters of this chapter

Cover the romanizations. Find each letter once in the Malayalam above, then say the word it sits in.

- അതെ — അ *a*
- *Look:* at each letter, then find it in the word beside it

Before you move on

Read all five aloud. Which one is Sanskrit, and which four are native Dravidian shared with Tamil? (Sanskrit: *namaskāram*. Native: *nandi*, *athe*, *illa*, *śari*.) Which word can mean both “okay” and a casual sign-off? (*śari*.)

That completes the four Dravidian first chapters — Tamil, Kannada, Telugu, Malayalam. Next chapter starts introducing yourself, one short possession form at a time.

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 👁️ eyes (6) ✍️ pen (12) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 20 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can introduce myself in Malayalam, give my name, and understand the other person’s name.

Complete ML-C02-practice, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate the chapter promise: introduce myself in Malayalam, give my name, and understand the other person’s name.

2.1 പേര് (pēru) — “name,” the native Dravidian word

“Name” — native, as you’d expect from Tamil’s closest sister.

The letters in this word

(Skim if you read Malayalam.) പ (pa) + െ (the ē-sign) → പേ (pē); ൾ (bare r, chandrakkala). Read പേ · ൾ → pēru.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

പേര് (pēru, “name”) is **native Dravidian**, from Proto-Dravidian ***pēr** — the same word as Tamil *peyar* and Telugu *pēru*, a cousin of Kannada *hesaru* (*p*→*h*). Being Tamil’s closest sister, Malayalam keeps the native word, *not* Sanskrit *nāma* (Hindi *nām*, English *name*).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pēru”
- its cousins — *pēru* / *peyar* / *pēr* / *hesaru*

Before you move on

Is பேர் native or borrowed, and what Tamil word is its twin?
(Native Dravidian, **pēr*; Tamil *peyar*.)

2.2 ஶ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ஶ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has been sitting in front of you on pages you have already read.

Script you’ll notice: ஶ

ஶ — *pa*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *p*, it is **pa**.

You have already said a word that begins with it.

- பேர் *pēr* — name

It is the first shape of the first word of this chapter, so it is the easiest one in the book to go back and find.

Writing: ஶ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ஶ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find പ in the ones that have it

പേര് · അതെ · നമസ്കാരം

- *Trace it:* പ three times, saying *pa* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find പ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — പ? What sound does it carry? (*pa.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

2.3 േ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: പ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has been sitting in front of you on pages you have already read.

Script you'll notice: േ

േ — $\bar{e}$.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with $\bar{e}$. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

Look at പേര് again. The പ you read on the page before carries an *a* of its own — *pa*. The hook standing in front of it, േ, takes that *a* away and puts a long $\bar{e}$ in its place: *pa* → *pē*.

- പേര് *pēr* — name

Malayalam prints this sign to the LEFT of its consonant even though the vowel is pronounced AFTER it. Your eye reads it first; your mouth says it second.

Writing: േ — copy what you see

Put your pen on േ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find േ in the ones that have it

പേര് · പ · േ

- *Trace it:* േ three times, saying $\bar{e}$ as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find േ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — േ? What sound does it carry? ($\bar{e}$)
Which side of its consonant is it printed on, and which side does it sound on? (Printed to the left; pronounced after.)

2.4 എന്റെ (enre) — “my”

“My” — native Dravidian.

The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Malayalam.*) എ (independent e) + the conjunct ന്റെ (nre) → **enre**.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

എന്റെ (enre) means “my.” It belongs to Malayalam’s native Dravidian first-person family, not to the Indo-European family behind English *I/my*. You will meet the related word for “I” in its own lesson; today you

only need *enre*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “enre”
- *enre* once with its meaning, “my”

Before you move on

What does എന്റെ mean? (“My.”) Is it native Dravidian or an Indo-European loan? (Native Dravidian.)

2.5 എ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: േ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has been sitting in front of you on pages you have already read.

Script you’ll notice: എ

എ — *e*.

It is an **independent vowel** — the shape this vowel takes when a word *begins* with it, rather than the sign it becomes inside a word.

You have already said a word that starts with it.

- എന്റെ *enre* — my

You met its sign form two pages ago: േ inside പേര്. One vowel, two jobs — a sign when it lands on a consonant, the letter എ when it opens a word.

Writing: എ — copy what you see

Put your pen on എ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find എ in the ones that have it
എന്റെ · പേര് · അതെ
- *Trace it:* എ three times, saying *e* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find എ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — എ? What sound does it carry? (*e*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

2.6 റ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: എ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has been sitting in front of you on pages you have already read.

Script you'll notice: റ

റ — *ra*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *r*, it is **ra**.

Malayalam has two *r* letters. ര is the soft one you have been reading inside നമസ്കാരം and ശരി. റ is the hard one, made further forward in the mouth — and it is the one hiding inside your new word.

- എന്റെ *enre* — my

Here റ sits underneath ന as the stacked pair ന്റ, which is why it does not announce itself at first. Find its curl in the lower half.

Writing: റ — copy what you see

Put your pen on റ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find റ in the ones that have it

എന്റെ · ശരി · റ

- *Trace it:* റ three times, saying *ra* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find റ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — റ? What sound does it carry? (*ra*.)
Which of the two *r* letters is this — the soft റ or the hard റ? (The hard one.)

2.7 ആണ് (āṇ) — “is,” where Malayalam breaks with its sisters

A small surprise: Malayalam has a real word for “is,” where its Dravidian sisters have none.

The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Malayalam.*) ആ (independent long ā) + ണ് (bare retroflex ṇ) → āṇ.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ആണ് (*āṇ*, “is”) is Malayalam’s **copula** — a real “to be” word, grown from the verb ആക (*āka*, “to be, to become”). Here’s the point: Tamil, Kannada, and Telugu all use the **zero copula** — *no* word for “is.” Yet Malayalam, though it is Tamil’s *closest* sister, grammaticalised a “to be” verb. So where Tamil says only *en peyar Arun*, Malayalam adds *āṇ*: *enre pēru Arun āṇ*.

Grammar Lens: the verb comes last

Like Hindi’s *hai* (and unlike Tamil), *āṇ* closes the sentence — Malayalam is subject–object–**verb**: “my name Arun **is**.” (Malayalis sometimes drop *āṇ* in fast speech, but the full form keeps it.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*āṇ*”
- the contrast — Tamil *en peyar Arun* (no verb) vs. Malayalam *enre pēru Arun āṇ*

Before you move on

What is ആണ്, and how does Malayalam differ from Tamil here? (The copula “is,” from *āka*; Malayalam *has* a word for “is” where Tamil uses none.)

2.8 ആ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഏ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has been sitting in front of you on pages you have already read.

Script you’ll notice: ആ

ആ — *ā*.

It is an **independent vowel** — the shape this vowel takes when a word *begins* with it, rather than the sign it becomes inside a word.

You have already said a word that starts with it.

- ആണ് *āṇũ* — is

അ was the short one, from the yes-word. ആ is the same vowel held longer, and the shape says so: the short letter grows a loop on its right. Say them as a pair — *a · ā* — then look again.

Writing: ആ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ആ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ആ in the ones that have it
ആണ് · അതെ · ആ
- *Trace it:* ആ three times, saying *ā* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ആ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ആ? What sound does it carry? (*ā*.)

Which of the two is longer — അ or ആ? (ആ.)

2.9 ണ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ആ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has been sitting in front of you on pages you have already read.

Script you'll notice: ണ

ണ — *ṇa*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *ṇ*, it is **ṇa**.

You have already said a word that ends with it.

- ആണ് *āṇ* — is (the copula)

This is not the ണ of നന്ദി. ണ is a **retroflex** *ṇ*: the tongue curls back to the roof of the mouth. Malayalam keeps the two apart in spelling because it keeps them apart in sound.

Writing: ണ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ണ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ണ in the ones that have it

ആണ് · നന്ദി · ണ

- *Trace it:* ണ three times, saying *ṇa* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ണ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ണ? What sound does it carry? (*ṇa*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

2.10 എന്റെ പേര് ... ആണ് (enre pēru ... āṇṁ) — “my name is...”

Assemble the three atoms — including the copula *āṇṁ* that Tamil lacks.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- enre (my) + pēru (name) + your name + āṇṁ (is).

എന്റെ പേര് ... ആണ് = “my name ... is” = “**my name is...**”

Enre pēru Arun āṇṁ. → “My name is Arun.”

Grammar Lens: verb last

Malayalam is subject–object–**verb**, so *āṇṁ* (“is”) sits at the end — “my name Arun **is**,” like Hindi *hai* and unlike Tamil’s verbless *en peyar Arun*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “enre pēru ... āṇṁ” with your name
- note the copula at the end — *āṇṁ*

Before you move on

Give your name in Malayalam. (*Enre pēru ... āṇṁ.*) What word does Malayalam add that Tamil omits? (The copula *āṇṁ*, “is.”)

2.11 നീ / നിങ്ങൾ (nī / niṇṇaḷ) — “you,” familiar and respectful

“You” — respect made by the plural, the family’s shared trick.

The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Malayalam.*) നീ (*nī*); നിങ്ങൾ (*niṇṇaḷ*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

നീ (*nī*, familiar “you”) ← Proto-Dravidian ***nīn** — the same native root as Tamil *nī*, Kannada *nīnu*, Telugu *nuvvu*. നിങ്ങൾ (*ninnāl*) is the respectful/plural “you” — *nī* + a plural ending, the exact cousin of Tamil *nīngal*.

Grammar Lens: respect by the plural

nī (familiar) vs. *ninnāl* (respectful, literally plural) — the family’s shared politeness-by-plural, same idea as French *vous*. For a first meeting, **ninnāl**.

Your turn

- Say it: “nī” (familiar), “ninnāl” (respectful)

Before you move on

How does Malayalam make “you” respectful, and which Tamil word is *ninnāl*’s twin? (By the plural; Tamil *nīngal*.)

2.12 ീ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ണ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has been sitting in front of you on pages you have already read.

Script you’ll notice: ീ

ീ — *ī*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with *ī*. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

Look at നീ. The ണ you already read carries an *a*; the sign hanging off its right, ീ, replaces that *a* with a long *ī*: *na* → *nī*.

- നീ *nī* — you (familiar)

It is the long partner of the small hook you have been reading at the end of നന്ദി and ശരി; that one is short *i*, this one is held.

Writing: ി — copy what you see

Put your pen on ി and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ി in the ones that have it

നി · ന · ി

- *Trace it:* ി three times, saying *ī* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ി once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ി? What sound does it carry? (*ī*.) Name one word you already say that contains it.

2.13 ശ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ി — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has been sitting in front of you on pages you have already read.

Script you'll notice: ശ

ശ — *ḷ*.

It is a **chillu** — a consonant with its vowel stripped away and given a shape of its own, so that it can end a word without a dangling mark.

You have already said a word that ends with it.

- നിങ്ങൾ *ninnal* — you (respectful)

Every consonant in this script arrives carrying an *a*. A word that ends in a bare consonant therefore needs a way to say “no vowel here.” Malayalam gives a handful of consonants a special end-of-word shape called a **chillu**, and ശ is the chillu of the retroflex *ḷ*.

Writing: ശ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ശ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ശ in the ones that have it

നിങ്ങൾ · നീ · ശ

- *Trace it:* ശ three times, saying *ḷ* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ശ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ശ? What sound does it carry? (*ḷ*.) What does a chillu tell you about the vowel? (That there isn't one.)

2.14 എന്ത് (entŭ) — “what”

The last piece of the question: “what.”

The letters in this word

(*Skim if you read Malayalam.*) എ (e) + the conjunct ന്ത് (ntŭ) → **entŭ**.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

എന്ത് (entŭ, “what”) is native Dravidian, on the interrogative stem ***yā-/*e-** — the same Dravidian question-root as Tamil *enna* and Telugu *ēmiti*, heading Malayalam’s question family: *entŭ* (what), *ār* (who), *evite* (where).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “entŭ”
- the question family — entŭ, ār, evite

Before you move on

What Dravidian stem heads എന്ത്? (**yā-/*e-*, same as Tamil *enna*, Telugu *ēmiti*.)

2.15 നിന്റെ പേര് എന്താണ്? (ninre pēru entāṇŭ?) — “what’s your name?”

Assemble the question — your + name + what-is. And notice the copula hiding in the last word.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- നിന്റെ (*ninre*, “your”) = the possessive of *nī* (“you”).
- എന്താണ് (*entāṇŭ*) = **entŭ** (what) + **āṇŭ** (is), fused into one.

നിന്റെ പേര് എന്താണ്? = literally “**your name what is?**”

Unlike the Tamil question (which had **no** verb), Malayalam carries its copula *āṇṁ* right inside the question-word *entāṇṁ*.

Grammar Lens: answer, and the respectful version

Answer with the sentence you built: **Enre pēru Arun āṇṁ**. The respectful “your” is *ninnāḷuṭe*: *ninnāḷuṭe pēru entāṇṁ?*

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*ninre pēru entāṇṁ?*”
- hear the copula inside — *entṁ* + *āṇṁ* → *entāṇṁ*

Before you move on

What two words fuse into എന്താണ്, and how does this differ from the Tamil question? (*entṁ* “what” + *āṇṁ* “is”; Tamil’s question has no verb, Malayalam’s carries the copula.)

2.16 സന്തോഷം (*santōṣam*) — “joy,” and “pleased to meet you”

The warm close — a Sanskrit word even in native-loving Malayalam.

The exchange — the words you can use

സന്തോഷം (*santōṣam*) literally means “joy.” At the end of a short introduction, it can stand by itself for “pleased to meet you.” A fuller phrase exists, but it needs words and grammar you have not learned yet; the one-word version is complete and useful now.

Script: two new shapes to notice

Keep സന്തോഷം visible. Most of its shapes have already appeared in this chapter. Point to just two new ones:

- ഷ carries the *ṣa* sound near the end.
- ഓ is the long *ō* vowel sign attached to the consonant before it.

Look, point, and say the whole word once. The next two-minute lesson will let your hand copy it with the model still present.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

സന്തോഷം (*santōṣam*, “joy”) is **Sanskrit** — the same loan Kannada and Telugu use. So even Malayalam, the great keeper of native words (recall *nandi* for “thanks” in Chapter 1), reaches for Sanskrit here. The loanwords spread **selectively**, word by word — which is exactly what these cognate notes trace: native for “name” and “thanks,” Sanskrit for “pleased.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “santōṣam”
- the pattern — Malayalam keeps native *nandi* (thanks) but borrows Sanskrit *santōṣam* (pleased)

Before you move on

Is സന്തോഷം native or Sanskrit, and what does that show about how Malayalam borrows? (Sanskrit; it borrows *selectively* — native for some words, Sanskrit for others.)

2.17 ി — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ി — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has not been on a page yet: it arrives with the word on the next one.

Script you'll notice: ു

ു — *u*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with *u*. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

The dialogue on the next page introduces two people by name, and one of the names carries this sign.

- അരുൺ *arun* — a common man's name in Kerala

The sign hangs under its consonant and replaces that consonant's built-in *a* with *u*: ര *ra* → രു *ru*.

Writing: ു — copy what you see

Put your pen on ു and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ു in the ones that have it

അരുൺ · ര · ു

- *Trace it:* ു three times, saying *u* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ു once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ു? What sound does it carry? (*u*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

2.18 ണ് — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ണ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has not been on a page yet: it arrives with the word on the next one.

Script you'll notice: ണ്

ണ് — *n*.

It is a **chillu** — a consonant with its vowel stripped away and given a shape of its own, so that it can end a word without a dangling mark.

The same name ends with one, and it is the second chillu you have met.

- അരുൺ *arun* — the name you are about to read
- നിങ്ങൾ *ninnal* — you, respectful, ending in ഴ

ണ് is ണ — the *na* you read two pages ago — with its *a* handed back and an end-of-word shape of its own. Hold ണ and ണ് side by side.

Writing: ണ് — copy what you see

Put your pen on ണ് and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ണ് in the ones that have it

അരുൺ · നിങ്ങൾ · ണ

- *Trace it:* ണ് three times, saying *n* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ണ് once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ഞ? What sound does it carry? (ൺ.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

2.19 സന്തോഷം — copy one known word with help

Point to സന്തോഷം and say *santōṣam* once. Keep the model on the page. Find ഞ near the end, then find the long *ō* sign ഓ on the consonant before it. Those are the two shapes you will work with.

Script — notice before moving

Look at ഞ and ഓ without writing. Say *ṣa* and *ō*. The first action is observe and trace: your finger follows a visible model, so memory is not yet doing the work.

Writing — trace two visible shapes

Trace ഞ once and ഓ once with your finger while both models remain visible. Stop after those two shapes. The next action is a guided copy: the whole word stays in view while your hand makes its own copy.

Writing — one guided copy

Follow സന്തോഷം from left to right with your finger. Then copy the whole word once directly below the visible model. Look back as often as you need.

This is shape familiarity, not a stroke-order test. Write large and slowly. Do not hide the model, do not spell from memory, and do not add a second word.

Before you move on

Compare your copy with സന്തോഷം while both remain visible. Check only the two shapes you noticed: ഞ and ഓ. Repair one shape if you want, then stop and say *santōṣam* once more.

2.20 Chapter 2 — the introduction, whole

No new words. The whole introduction, in the order two people actually say it.

The exchange

Malayalam	English
എന്റെ പേര് മീരാ ആണ്. (<i>enre pēru Mira āṇṁ</i>)	My name is Mira.
നിന്റെ പേര് എന്താണ്? (<i>ninre pēru entāṇṁ</i>)	What's your name?
എന്റെ പേര് അരുൺ ആണ്. (<i>enre pēru Arun āṇṁ</i>)	My name is Arun.
സന്തോഷം. (<i>santōṣam</i>)	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom traced:

- **pēru** ← Dravidian **pēr* (*not name*; twin of Tamil *peyar*)
- **enre** — the native Dravidian possessive “my”
- **āṇṁ** ← the verb *āka* (“to be”) — Malayalam’s **copula**
- **entṁ** ← Dravidian question-stem **yā-/e-*
- **santōṣam** ← **Sanskrit** (borrowed even in native-loving Malayalam)

The Malayalam standout: unlike its Dravidian sisters’ **zero copula**, Malayalam **has a word for “is”** (*āṇṁ*) — a real grammatical difference between the closest of sisters.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the whole exchange, both voices
- your own introduction — “*enre pēru ... āṇṁ*”
- ask it back — “*ninre pēru entāṇṁ?*”

Writing check — keep the model visible

Keep the dialogue table open. Copy സന്തോഷം once from its visible row, then compare your two new shapes, ഷ and ൃ, with the model. This is supported checkpoint writing, not spelling from memory.

Script check — the letters of this chapter

Cover the romanizations. Find each letter once in the Malayalam above, then say the word it sits in.

- പേര് — പ *pa*, ൃ *ē*
- എന്റെ — എ *e*, റ *ra*
- ആണ് — ആ *ā*, ണ *ṇa*
- നിങ്ങൾ — ീ *ī* (in നീ), ൊ *ḷ*
- അരുൺ — ു *u*, ണ *ṇ*
- *Look:* at each letter, then find it in the word beside it

Before you move on

Give your name, ask someone else's, say you're pleased. (*Enre pēru ... āṇṁ. / Ninre pēru entāṇṁ? / Santōṣam.*) What grammatical word does Malayalam have that Tamil, Kannada, and Telugu lack? (A copula — *āṇṁ*, “is.”) Next chapter begins the responding cycle, one short question and answer at a time.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

Modes: 👁 eyes (6) ✍ pen (4) 🗣 Hands-free start: first 1 of 10 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask how someone is in Malayalam, answer naturally, and return the question.

Complete ML-C03-practice, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate the chapter promise: ask how someone is in Malayalam, answer naturally, and return the question.

3.1 എങ്ങനെ (eṇṇane) — “how,” another of the e- questions

You met എന്ത് (entŭ, “what”) in Chapter 2. Here is its sibling in Malayalam’s question family.

The letters in this word

(Skim if you read Malayalam.) എ (independent e) + ണ (ṇa, a doubled velar nasal) + നെ (ne) → എങ്ങനെ (eṇṇane).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

എങ്ങനെ (eṇṇane, “how”) is native Dravidian, on the interrogative base e- you met in entŭ. Malayalam gathers its questions here: entŭ (what), eṇṇane (how), ārŭ (who), eviṭe (where), eppōḷ (when), entinŭ (why). It is the same Dravidian question-root heading Tamil’s eppaḍi — the deepest, most native layer of a language otherwise rich in Sanskrit.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “eṇṇane”
- the e- question family — *entŭ*, *eṇṇane*, *ārŭ*, *evite*, *eppōl*

Before you move on

What base do Malayalam’s question-words share, and which Tamil cousin heads its own? (The interrogative *e-*; Tamil’s *eppadi*.)

3.2 ഓ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഏ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has been sitting in front of you on pages you have already read.

Script you’ll notice: ഓ

ഓ — *ō*.

It is an **independent vowel** — the shape this vowel takes when a word *begins* with it, rather than the sign it becomes inside a word.

You copied its other half in the last chapter. Inside സന്തോഷം the vowel *ō* is a **sign** wrapped around its consonant: ഓ. Where the vowel has no consonant to wrap around, it stands up as a letter of its own: ഓ.

- സന്തോഷം *santōṣam* — the sign form, already in your hand
- ഓ — the letter form, which arrives on the next page as the ending that turns a Malayalam statement into a question

Writing: ഓ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ഓ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ഓ in the ones that have it
- സന്തോഷം · ഓ · ൊ
- *Trace it:* ഓ three times, saying *ō* as you finish each one
 - *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ഓ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ഓ? What sound does it carry? (*ō*.) Sign or letter — which does a word use when there is a consonant to hang it on? (The sign, ൊ.)

3.3 സുഖമാണോ? (sukhamāṇō?) — “how are you?”

Malayalam usually asks after your health rather than “how are you” — and the question is built from a Chapter-2 word plus a single new sound.

The letters in this word

സുഖം (*sukham*, “well-being”) + ആണ് (*āṇ*, “is,” from Chapter 2) + the question-marker ഓ (*ō*) → സുഖമാണോ (*sukhamāṇō*), “is [it] well?”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

സുഖമാണോ? literally means “**is [it] well?**” — where English says “how are you?”, Malayalam more often says “are you well?” The word സുഖം (*sukham*, “well-being, comfort, ease”) is a **Sanskrit** loan — *sukha* itself, borrowed whole (the *su-* “good” that is Greek *eu-*). Onto

it, Malayalam adds its own **native copula** *āṇṣ* (“is,” from Chapter 2) and the question particle **-ō** — a whole yes/no question made by one small sound at the end. This mix — a Sanskrit noun, a Dravidian verb — is Malayalam in miniature.

Grammar Lens: turning a statement into a question

Malayalam makes a yes/no question by adding **-ō** to the end: *sukham āṇṣ* (“it is well”) → *sukham āṇō?* (“is it well?”). No change of word order, no helper — just the little **-ō**. You will use it to question any statement.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*sukhamāṇō?*”
- the Sanskrit word for well-being inside it (*sukha*)
- how Malayalam makes a yes/no question (add **-ō**)

Before you move on

What does *sukhamāṇō?* literally ask, and what are its Sanskrit and Dravidian pieces? (“Is [it] well?”; Sanskrit *sukha* “well-being” + the native copula *āṇṣ* + the question **-ō**.)

3.4 െ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: െ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has been sitting in front of you on pages you have already read.

Script you’ll notice: െ

െ — *e*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with *e*. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

You have been reading this one since the first chapter without being told its name.

- അതെ *athe* — yes
- എന്റെ *enre* — my

It is the short partner of േ, the long sign in പേര്. Both stand to the LEFT of the consonant they belong to and are pronounced AFTER it, so in അതെ the hook belongs to the ത on its right: *ta* → *te*.

Writing: ൈ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ൈ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ൈ in the ones that have it

അതെ · എന്റെ · പേര്

- *Trace it:* ൈ three times, saying *e* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ൈ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ൈ? What sound does it carry? (*e*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

3.5 ഞാൻ (*ñān*) — “I,” the Dravidian first person

To answer, you first need “I” — and it opens with a sound English never starts a word with.

The letters in this word

ഞ (*ñā* — a palatal nasal, like the “ny” in *canyon*, but at the very start of the word) + ാ (long *ā*) + ൺ (the special word-final *n*, called *chillū*) → ഞാൻ (*ñān*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ഞാൻ (*ñān*, “I”) ← Proto-Dravidian **yān* / **ñān* — native, and (unlike Hindi’s *māimī*, cousin of English *me*) **not** related to the European “I/me” family. Its possessive is the എന്റെ (*enre*, “my”) you already met: *ñān* “I,” *enre* “my.” Malayalam layered a great deal of Sanskrit over its vocabulary, but the pronoun for “I” is bedrock Dravidian.

Grammar Lens: Malayalam does *not* drop “I”

Here Malayalam parts from its sisters. Tamil, Kannada, and Telugu verbs carry the person in their ending, so they freely drop “I.” But **Malayalam verbs do not change for person at all** (you’ll see this in Chapter 5) — so the pronoun *ñān* must be said. It cannot be left out, because the verb won’t tell you who acts.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ñān” — start with the “ny” sound
- the pair — *ñān* (I), *enre* (my)
- can Malayalam drop “I” like Tamil? (No — its verbs don’t mark person)

Before you move on

What is *ñān*’s possessive, and why must Malayalam say “I” where Tamil can drop it? (*Enre*, “my”; Malayalam verbs don’t change for person, so the pronoun is needed.)

3.6 സുഖം (sukhami) — “well-being,” and how to answer

The word at the heart of “how are you?” — and it travelled all the way from Sanskrit.

The letters in this word

സു (*su*) + ഖം (*khami*, an aspirated *kh* + the *anuvāra*) → സുഖം (*sukhami*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

സുഖം (*sukhami*, “well-being, comfort, ease, happiness”) is a **Sanskrit** loan — *sukha* = *su-* (“good, well”) + *kha* (“space, feeling”) — the same *su-* that is Greek *eu-* (as in *euphoria*). Malayalam, Tamil’s closest sister, took far more Sanskrit into everyday speech than Tamil did — and *sukham* is a perfect case: for “well,” where Tamil answers with native *nalam*, Malayalam reaches for Sanskrit *sukham*.

The exchange — the reply

With the copula from Chapter 2: സുഖമാണ് (*sukhamāṇṁ*) — “[I am] well” (literally “[it] is well”). The whole exchange:

— *sukhamāṇō?* (“Are you well? / How are you?”) —
sukhamāṇṁ, nandī. (“I’m well, thank you.”)

Notice the reply reuses the greeting’s own words — *sukham* + *āṇṁ* — just without the question *-ō*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sukhami”

- the full reply — *sukhamāṇũ*, *nandi*
- the Sanskrit root and its Greek twin (*su-* = Greek *eu-*)

Before you move on

Give the reply to *sukhamāṇō?*, and say where *sukham* comes from. (*Sukhamāṇũ*; Sanskrit *sukha*, “well-being” — the *su-* that is Greek *eu-*.)

3.7 ഇ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഐ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has been sitting in front of you on pages you have already read.

Script you’ll notice: ഇ

ഇ — *i*.

It is an **independent vowel** — the shape this vowel takes when a word *begins* with it, rather than the sign it becomes inside a word.

You have said a word that starts with it since your very first chapter.

- ഇല്ല *illa* — no, there isn’t

Its sign form is the small hook riding on the end of നന്ദി and ശരി. Inside a word, a sign; at the front of a word, the letter ഇ.

Writing: ഇ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ഇ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ഇ in the ones that have it
ഇല്ല · നന്ദി · ശരി
- *Trace it:* ഇ three times, saying *i* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ഇ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ഇ? What sound does it carry? (*i*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

3.8 സാരമില്ല (sāramilla) — “it doesn’t matter”

When someone thanks you — or apologises — this is the easy, gracious reply, and it fuses Malayalam’s two heritages in one word.

The letters in this word

സാരം (*sārami*, “substance, matter”) + ഇല്ല (*illa*, “is not”) → സാരമില്ല (*sāramilla*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

സാരമില്ല means “there’s no matter to it / it doesn’t matter” — used for “never mind / no worries / you’re welcome.” It is a perfect little emblem of Malayalam: സാരം (*sārami*, “substance, essence”) is a **Sanskrit** loan, while ഇല്ല (*illa*, “is not”) is the **native Dravidian** negative from Chapter 1. Sanskrit noun, Dravidian verb, welded into one everyday word. That *illa* is the same “is-not” shared across **Malayalam, Tamil, and Kannada** — one of the deep bonds of the south (Telugu alone diverges, to *lēdu*).

Grammar Lens: ഇല്ല, the all-purpose “no”

Illa negates existence and stands alone as “no”: *paṇam illa* (“there’s no money”), *ñān illa* (“it’s not me / I’m not [there]”). It is the negative twin of the copula *āṇṁ* (“is”) you learned in Chapter 2 — *āṇṁ*

affirms, *illa* denies.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sāramilla”
- its two heritages (Sanskrit *sārami* + native *illa*)
- the *āṇṣ* / *illa* pair — “is” and “is-not”

Before you move on

What does *sāramilla* literally say, and which of its two words is Sanskrit? (“There’s no matter / it doesn’t matter”; *sārami* “substance” is Sanskrit, *illa* “not” is native Dravidian.)

3.9 Chapter 3 — The how-are-you exchange

No new words. The whole responding cycle, from atoms you now own.

The exchange

Say these aloud:

- “Are you well? / How are you?” — *sukhamāṇō?*
- “I’m well, thank you.” — *sukhamāṇṣ*, *nandi*.
- “It doesn’t matter / you’re welcome.” — *sāramilla*.

Your turn — the atoms

Say these aloud:

- the e- question-word for “how” (*eṇṇane*)
- “I” — and why Malayalam can’t drop it (*ṇān*; its verbs don’t mark person)
- the “is / is-not” pair (*āṇṣ* / *illa*)

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- *eṇṇane* ← the interrogative *e-* (native Dravidian, like Tamil *eppaḍi*)
- *ñān* ← Proto-Dravidian (unrelated to English *me*); possessive *enre*
- *sukham* ← **Sanskrit** *sukha* “well-being” (the *su-* that is Greek *eu-*)
- *āṇṭ* / *illa* — “is” and “is-not”; *illa* shared with Tamil & Kannada
- the question-marker *-ō* — turns any statement into a yes/no question

Script check — the letters of this chapter

Cover the romanizations. Find each letter once in the Malayalam above, then say the word it sits in.

- ആണോ? — ഓ *ō*, the question ending, standing as its own letter
- അതെ, എന്റെ — െ *e*
- ഇല്ല — ഇ *i*
- *Look:* at each letter, then find it in the word beside it

Before you move on

A friend asks *sukhamāṇō?* — give a full, polite reply, and answer their thanks. (*Sukhamāṇṭ*, *nandī* — and to thanks, *sāramilla*.)

3.10 സന്തോഷം — one delayed copy

Look at സന്തോഷം for five seconds and say *santōṣam*. Find ഷ and the long *ō* sign ഓ once more. Then cover the model with your hand or a small piece of paper.

Writing — one try after a delay

Write സന്തോഷം once while the model is covered. This is a gentle retrieval, not a speed test. If one shape will not come, uncover the model, look, cover it again, and finish.

Before you move on

Uncover സന്തോഷം and compare it with your copy. Repair only one shape if needed. Say *santōṣam* once, then stop: one known word, one spaced writing revisit.

Chapter 4

Farewells

Modes: 👁 eyes (5) ✍ pen (3) 🗣 Hands-free start: none of the 8 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can end a Malayalam conversation politely and choose a farewell that fits the situation.

Complete ML-C04-practice, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate the chapter promise: end a Malayalam conversation politely and choose a farewell that fits the situation.

4.1 ഌ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഌ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has not been on a page yet: it arrives with the word on the next one.

Script you'll notice: ഌ

ഌ — *va*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *v*, it is **va**.

This chapter's farewells are built on a verb that starts with it, and the verb itself arrives on the next page.

- വരിക *varika* — to come

Every farewell this chapter is heading for is built on it, so the shape is worth having in hand first.

Writing: റ — copy what you see

Put your pen on റ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find റ in the ones that have it

വരിക · റ · ശരി

- *Trace it:* റ three times, saying *va* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find റ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — റ? What sound does it carry? (*va*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

4.2 ഉ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: റ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has not been on a page yet: it arrives with the word on the next one.

Script you'll notice: ഉ

ഉ — *u*.

It is an **independent vowel** — the shape this vowel takes when a word *begins* with it, rather than the sign it becomes inside a word.

Every Malayalam verb you are about to meet ends in the same two letters, ഉക *-uka*, and this is the first of them.

- ഉക *-uka* — the ending that makes a Malayalam verb’s dictionary form

You already read its sign form, ു, in the name അരുൺ. Where the vowel opens a syllable instead of riding on a consonant, it needs the full letter ഉ.

Writing: ഉ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ഉ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ഉ in the ones that have it
ഉക · അരുൺ · ഉ
- *Trace it:* ഉ three times, saying *u* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ഉ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ഉ? What sound does it carry? (*u*.) Name one word you already say that contains it.

4.3 പോകുക (pōkuka) — “to go,” and വരിക (to come)

Two everyday verbs — and together they make the Malayalam goodbye.

The letters in this word

പോ (pō, pa + long-ō sign) + കുക (kuka, the dictionary “-uka” ending) → പോകുക (pōkuka). Its partner: വരിക (varika, “to come”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

പോകുക (pōkuka, “to go”) and വരിക (varika, “to come”) are native Dravidian verbs. Notice the ending -ഉക (-uka) — this is how Malayalam names a verb in the dictionary, its “to _____” form (where Tamil uses a bare stem). Malayalam, like all its family, does not say a plain “goodbye”: it says “I go, and I **come back**.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pōkuka” (to go) and “varika” (to come)
- the “to _____” ending every Malayalam verb takes (-uka)

Before you move on

What ending marks a Malayalam infinitive, and why do you need both “go” and “come” to say goodbye? (-uka; the farewell is “I’ll go and come back.”)

4.4 ് — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഉ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has not been on a page yet: it arrives with the word on the next one.

Script you’ll notice: ്

് — $\bar{u}$.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with $\bar{u}$. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

- വരു *varū* — “come!”, the short command you meet on the next page

It is the long partner of ു, the sign you read in അരുൺ. Same place under the consonant, same vowel, held longer — and the shape grows a second loop to say so.

Writing: ു — copy what you see

Put your pen on ു and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ു in the ones that have it

വരു · അരുൺ · ു

- *Trace it:* ു three times, saying *ū* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ു once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ു? What sound does it carry? (*ū*.)
Which of the two is longer — ു or ു? (ു.)

4.5 പോയി വരാം (pōyi varām) — “I’ll go and come back”

The everyday Malayalam goodbye — a promise, not a parting.

The letters in this word

പോയി (*pōyi*, “having gone”) is *pō* + the “-yi” that means “having ...d.”
 വരാം (*varām*, “[I] will come”) is *va* + the -ആം (-*āmi*) ending, “I/we will / let me.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

പോയി വരാം = പോയി (*pōyi*, “having gone”) + വരാം (*varām*, “I’ll come”) — literally “**having gone, I’ll come [back]**,” i.e. “I’ll go and come back.” A Malayali never signs off with a bare “I’m leaving.” It is the same “go-and-come-back” farewell across the Dravidian south (Tamil *pōy varugirēn*, Kannada *hōgi baruttēne*, Telugu *velli vastānu*). The warm reply is പോയി വരു (*pōyi varū*, “go and come [back]”). It reaches past Dravidian, too: Bengali, an Indo-Aryan language with no shared ancestor for these words, says goodbye with *āshi* — “I come.” The whole south, and beyond, prefers a promise of return to a blunt farewell.

Grammar Lens: the -ആം ending, “let me / I will”

-ആം (-*āmi*) added to a verb stem means “I/we will” or “let me” — a soft, volitional future: *varām* (“I’ll come”), *kāṇām* (“let’s see,” coming next lesson), *ceyyām* (“I’ll do it”). It is Malayalam’s gentle way of promising an action.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the goodbye — *pōyi varām*
- its literal meaning (“having gone, I’ll come” → “I’ll come back”)
- the warm reply — *pōyi varū*

Before you move on

What does the Malayalam goodbye literally promise, and what does the -*āmi* ending add? (“I’ll go and come back”; -*āmi* = “I will / let me.”)

4.6 നാളെ കാണാം (nāḷe kāṇāṁ) — “see you tomorrow”

A goodbye with a date on it — and the *-āṁ* ending you just met.

The letters in this word

നാളെ (*nāḷe*): നാ (*nā*) + ളെ (*le*, with the retroflex ള *ḷ*). കാണാം (*kāṇāṁ*) = കാṇ (*kāṇ* “see”) + the -ആം (*-āṁ*) ending, “let’s.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

നാളെ (*nāḷe*, “tomorrow”) is native Dravidian, from നാൾ (*nāl*, “day”) — the very same *nāl* behind Tamil’s *nāḷai* and Kannada’s *nāḷe*. കാണാം (*kāṇāṁ*, “let’s see”) is from കാണുക (*kāṇuka*, “to see”) + *-āṁ* — so the phrase is “**tomorrow, let’s see [each other].**” One family, one word for “day,” one habit of parting until the next.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nāḷe kāṇāṁ”
- the word for “day” inside “tomorrow” (*nāl*, shared with Tamil & Kannada)
- the verb “to see” (*kāṇ*)

Before you move on

What are the two pieces of *nāḷe kāṇāṁ*, and what Dravidian sisters share the “day” root? (*Nāḷe* “tomorrow” + *kāṇ* “see”; Tamil *nāḷai*, Kannada *nāḷe* — all from *nāl*.)

4.7 വീണ്ടും കാണാം (vīṇḍum kāṇāṁ) — “we’ll meet again”

The open-ended, warm goodbye — no date, just a promise.

The letters in this word

വീണ്ടും (*vīṇḍum*): note the retroflex cluster ണ്ട (*ṇḍ*) and the final *anusvāra*.
കാണാം (*kāṇāmi*, “let’s see”) you just learned.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

വീണ്ടും കാണാം = വീണ്ടും (*vīṇḍum*, “again”) + കാണാം (*kāṇāmi*, “let’s see”) — “we’ll see [each other] again.” Both words are native Dravidian: *vīṇḍum* (“again,” from *vīṇṭu*, “to return”) and *kāṇ* (“to see”). Where Tamil’s “we’ll meet again” reaches for the Sanskrit loan *sandi* to say “meet,” Malayalam — like Kannada — keeps its own native verb, here “to see.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vīṇḍum kāṇāmi”
- “again” and “let’s see” (*vīṇḍum*, *kāṇāmi*)

Before you move on

What does the phrase mean, and which native verb does Malayalam use instead of Tamil’s Sanskrit *sandi*? (“We’ll see [each other] again”; *kāṇ*, “to see.”)

4.8 Chapter 4 — The farewells

No new words. Three ways to part — none of them a blunt “goodbye.”

The exchange — the farewells

Say these aloud:

- the everyday goodbye — *pōyi varāmi* (“I’ll go and come back”)
- the warm reply — *pōyi varū* (“go and come back”)
- “see you tomorrow” — *nāle kāṇāmi*
- “we’ll meet again” — *vīṇḍum kāṇāmi*

Your turn — the atoms

Say these aloud:

- the two verbs and their “-uka” form (*pōkuka* go, *varika* come)
- “day” inside “tomorrow” (*nāl*), “again” (*vīṇḍuni*), “to see” (*kāṇ*)
- the *-āmi* ending — “I will / let’s”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- *pōyi varāmi* — “having gone, I’ll come”; the Dravidian promise-of-return goodbye
- *nāle* ← *nāl* “day” (shared with Tamil & Kannada); *kāṇ* “to see”
- *vīṇḍuni* “again” — where Tamil borrowed Sanskrit *sandi*, Malayalam kept *kāṇ*

Script check — the letters of this chapter

Cover the romanizations. Find each letter once in the Malayalam above, then say the word it sits in.

- വരിക — വ *va*
- പോകുക — ഉ *u*, the vowel inside the ending ഉക
- വരു — ു *ū*
- *Look*: at each letter, then find it in the word beside it

Before you move on

Why does Malayalam never say a plain “I’m leaving,” and what does its everyday goodbye promise instead? (It sounds too final; *pōyi varāmi* promises “I’ll go and come back.”)

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Modes: 👁 eyes (5) ✍ pen (9) 🔄 Hands-free start: first 1 of 14 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can build short present-tense Malayalam sentences with the chapter’s first verbs.

Complete ML-C05-practice, the canonical closing checkpoint, and demonstrate the chapter promise: build short present-tense Malayalam sentences with the chapter’s first verbs.

5.1 സംസാരിക്കുക (saṁsārikkuka) — “to speak,” your first full verb

So far, “to be.” Here is a verb that *does* something — and it reveals the single strangest, simplest thing about Malayalam grammar.

The letters in this word

സം (saṁ) + സാ (sā) + രി (ri) + ക്കുക (kkuka, doubled *kk* + the *-uka* infinitive) → സംസാരിക്കുക (saṁsārikkuka).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

സംസാരിക്കുക (saṁsārikkuka, “to speak, to converse”) is Sanskrit-derived (from *saṁsāra*, “flowing together, intercourse”) — one more sign of Malayalam’s deep Sanskrit layer, alongside its native *parayuka* (“to say”). To say “I speak,” Malayalam adds the present ending -ഉന്നു (-unnu) to the stem:

sam̥sārikk- (speak) + *-unnu* (present) → സംസാരിക്കുന്നു
(*sam̥sārikkunnu*), “speak / am speaking.”

Grammar Lens: the verb never changes for person

Here is Malayalam’s great surprise. In Tamil, Telugu, and Kannada the verb changes ending for *who* acts (*pēsugirēn* “I speak,” *pēsugirān* “he speaks”). **Malayalam does not.** The verb is the **same** for everyone:

- *ñān sam̥sārikkunnu* — “I speak”
- *nī sam̥sārikkunnu* — “you speak”
- *avan sam̥sārikkunnu* — “he speaks”

One form, all persons. Malayalam threw away person-agreement entirely — which is exactly why (Chapter 3) it can never drop the pronoun: the verb won’t tell you who. Of all its Dravidian sisters, Malayalam went the furthest here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*sam̥sārikkuka*” (to speak)
- “I speak” — *ñān sam̥sārikkunnu*
- “he speaks” — *avan sam̥sārikkunnu* (the same verb!)

Before you move on

How does the Malayalam verb change between “I speak” and “he speaks,” and what does that force you to keep? (It does **not** change — one form for all persons; so the pronoun must always be said.)

5.2 ഞ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഞ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has been sitting in front of you on pages you have already read.

Script you'll notice: ഞ

ഞ — *ñā*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *ñ*, it is **ñā**.

You have said the word for “I” since the how-are-you chapter, and it starts with this letter.

- ഞാൻ *ñān* — I

It is one sound, not two: the *ny* of “canyon,” made in one movement.

Writing: ഞ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ഞ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ഞ in the ones that have it

ഞാൻ · ഞ · നന്ദി

- *Trace it:* ഞ three times, saying *ñā* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ഞ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ഞ? What sound does it carry? (*ñā*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

5.3 ന് — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഞ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has been sitting in front of you on pages you have already read.

Script you'll notice: ന്

ന് — *n*.

It is a **chillu** — a consonant with its vowel stripped away and given a shape of its own, so that it can end a word without a dangling mark.

The same word ends with a chillu — the third one you have met.

- ഞാൻ *ñān* — I
- നിങ്ങൾ *ninnāl* — you, respectful, ending in ൺ
- അരുൺ *arun* — the name, ending in ൺ

ന് is ന with its *a* handed back. Line the three up — ന് ന് ൺ — and say what each one used to be.

Writing: ന് — copy what you see

Put your pen on ന് and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ന് in the ones that have it
 ഞാൻ · അരുൺ · നിങ്ങൾ
- *Trace it:* ന് three times, saying *n* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ന് once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ഺ? What sound does it carry? (*n*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

5.4 യ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഺ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has been sitting in front of you on pages you have already read.

Script you'll notice: യ

യ — *ya*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *y*, it is **ya**.

- പോയി വരാം *pōyi varāṁ* — goodbye, from the chapter behind you

Look at the middle of പോയി: യ carrying the small *i* hook.

Writing: യ — copy what you see

Put your pen on യ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- Look:* at these words, and find യ in the ones that have it

പോയി വരാം · യ · ഞാൻ

- *Trace it:* യ three times, saying *ya* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find യ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — യ? What sound does it carry? (*ya.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

5.5 ഞാൻ മലയാളം സംസാരിക്കുന്നു (*ñān malayāḷam̐ saṁsārikkunnu*) — “I speak Malayalam”

Your first full, moving sentence — and the language names itself after a landscape.

The letters in this word

മലയാളം (*malayāḷam̐*): മ (*ma*) + ല (*la*) + യാ (*yā*) + ള (retroflex *ḷa*) + ാം (*m̐*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ഞാൻ മലയാളം സംസാരിക്കുന്നു = ഞാൻ (*ñān*, “I”) + മലയാളം (*malayāḷam̐*, the object) + സംസാരിക്കുന്നു (*saṁsārikkunnu*, “speak”) — “I Malayalam speak,” the verb last. The name മലയാളം (*malayāḷam̐*) is native Dravidian: മല (*mala*, “mountain”) + ആളം (*āḷam̐*, “place, region”) — “**the mountain land**,” named for the Western Ghats along the coast where it is spoken. Its signature retroflex ള (*ḷ*) sits right in the middle of the word.

Grammar Lens: the pronoun stays

Because *saṁsārikkunnu* is the same for every person (Chapter 5’s big surprise), the pronoun ഞാൻ (*ñān*) cannot be dropped — it is the only thing marking “I.” Where Tamil would happily say just *pēsugirēn*, Malayalam must keep the *ñān*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*ñān malayāḷam saṁsārikkunnu*”
- what *malayāḷam* is built from (*mala* “mountain” + *āḷam* “place”)
- why *ñān* can’t be dropped (the verb doesn’t mark person)

Before you move on

Say “I speak Malayalam,” and give the meaning of the language’s name. (*Ñān malayāḷam saṁsārikkunnu*; “the mountain land,” *mala* + *āḷam*.)

5.6 ഌ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഐ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has not been on a page yet: it arrives with the word on the next one.

Script you’ll notice: ഌ

ഌ — *o*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with *o*. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

- കൊച്ചി *kocci* — Kochi, the city that arrives on the next page

It is the short partner of ഌ, the long *ō* sign you copied in സഭനാഷം. Both wrap around their consonant, one arm in front and one behind; the long one carries an extra upright stroke on the right.

Writing: ഌ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ഌ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here

until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ഓ in the ones that have it

കൊച്ചി · സന്തോഷം · ഓ

- *Trace it:* ഓ three times, saying *o* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ഓ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ഓ? What sound does it carry? (*o*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

5.7 ച — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഓ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has not been on a page yet: it arrives with the word on the next one.

Script you'll notice: ച

ച — *ca*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *c*, it is **ca**.

- കൊച്ചി *kocci* — Kochi, where it is doubled into ച്ച in the middle of the name

The sound is the *ch* of “church,” and doubling it holds it longer.

Writing: ച — copy what you see

Put your pen on ച and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ച in the ones that have it

കൊച്ചി · ച · ക

- *Trace it:* ച three times, saying *ca* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ച once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ച? What sound does it carry? (*ca*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

5.8 ഞ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ച — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has not been on a page yet: it arrives with the word on the next one.

Script you'll notice: ഞ

ഞ — *l*.

It is a **chillu** — a consonant with its vowel stripped away and given a shape of its own, so that it can end a word without a dangling mark.

The fourth chillu, and the one that does the most work in Malayalam grammar: it closes the little ending that says *where*.

- കൊച്ചിയിൽ *kocciyil* — in Kochi

ൽ is ല — the *la* doubled inside ഇല്ല — with its *a* handed back. That makes four end-of-word shapes you can now read: ന് ന്റ ശ് ര്.

Writing: ര് — copy what you see

Put your pen on ര് and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ര് in the ones that have it
കൊച്ചിയിൽ · ഇല്ല · ര്
- *Trace it:* ര് three times, saying *l* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ര് once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ര്? What sound does it carry? (*l*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

5.9 താമസിക്കുക (tāmasikkuka) — “to live, to stay”

A second verb, so you can say where you live — and again the Sanskrit layer shows.

The letters in this word

താ (*tā*) + മ (*ma*) + സി (*si*) + ക്കുക (*kkuka*, the *-uka* infinitive) → താമസിക്കുക (*tāmasikkuka*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

താമസിക്കുക (*tāmasikkuka*, “to live, to reside, to stay, to delay”) is Sanskrit-derived (from *tāmasa* / *taṃasa*, “dwelling, tarrying”). Malayalam often prefers such Sanskrit-built verbs where Tamil uses a native word (*vaḷ*). “I live in Kochi” is ഞാൻ കൊച്ചിയിൽ താമസിക്കുന്നു (*ñān kocchiyil tāmasikkunnu*) — again the same *-unnu* present, the same for every person.

Grammar Lens: “in” comes after the noun

കൊച്ചിയിൽ (*kocchiyil*) = *Kochi* + -ഇൽ (*-il*, “in”), glued to the **end** of the noun. Malayalam uses **postpositions** (case-suffixes) where English uses prepositions: “Kochi-in I live,” the verb last — and the pronoun kept.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*tāmasikkuka*”
- “I live in Kochi” — *ñān kocchiyil tāmasikkunnu*
- where “in” (*-il*) sits — glued to the end of the noun

Before you move on

What does *tāmasikkuka* mean, and where does “in” go? (“To live / stay / reside”; *-il* “in” attaches to the **end** of the noun.)

5.10 ഞ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഞ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has not been on a page yet: it arrives with the word on the next one.

Script you'll notice: ഹ

ഹ — *ha*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *h*, it is **ha**.

The next page names a second verb beside the one it teaches — the verb for helping — and this letter sits in the middle of it, inside the noun that verb is built on.

- സഹായം *sahāyam* — help

It is a Sanskrit-layer word, which is where most of this letter's work is.

Writing: ഹ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ഹ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ഹ in the ones that have it

സഹായം · ഹ · നന്ദി

- *Trace it:* ഹ three times, saying *ha* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ഹ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ഹ? What sound does it carry? (*ha*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

5.11 ജോലി ചെയ്യുക (jōli ceyyuka) — “to work”

The last verb of the chapter — and, like Hindi’s *karnā* and Tamil’s *sey*, it is a “do” verb that builds a hundred others.

The letters in this word

ജോലി (*jōli*, “work, job”): ജോ (*jō*) + ലി (*li*). ചെയ്യുക (*ceyyuka*, “do”): ചെ (*ce*) + യ്യ (doubled *yy*) + ക (*ka*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ചെയ്യുക (*ceyyuka*, “to do, to make”) is core native Dravidian — the very same root as Tamil செய் (*sey*, “to do”). Malayalam — like Hindi with *karnā*, Tamil with *sey*, Telugu with *cēyu*, Kannada with *māḍu* — builds compound verbs by putting a noun in front of it:

- ജോലി ചെയ്യുക (*jōli ceyyuka*) = “work-do” = “to work” (*jōli*, “work”)
- സഹായിക്കുക (*sahāyikkuka*) = “to help” (Sanskrit *sahāya*)

So “I work” is ഞാൻ ജോലി ചെയ്യുന്നു (*ñān jōli ceyyunnu*) — same -*unnu* present, pronoun kept. *Ceyyuka* and Tamil’s *sey* are, at root, one word — the Dravidian “do” that these languages all lean on.

Grammar Lens: noun + ചെയ്യുക = a new verb

This “noun + *ceyyuka*” pattern is the twin of Hindi’s “noun + *karnā*,” Tamil’s “noun + *sey*,” Telugu’s “noun + *cēyu*,” and Kannada’s “noun + *māḍu*.” Five languages, two of them from an unrelated family, all landed on the same trick.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “jōli ceyyuka” (to work)
- “I work” — *ñān jōli ceyyunnu*
- the Tamil verb that is the *same word* as *ceyyuka* (*sey*)

Before you move on

How does Malayalam turn “work” into “to work,” and which Tamil verb is its twin? (*Jōli* + *ceyyuka* = “work-do”; Tamil *sey* — the same Dravidian root.)

5.12 ജ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഏ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has been sitting in front of you on pages you have already read.

Script you’ll notice: ജ

ജ — *ja*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *j*, it is **ja**.

You have already said a word that starts with it.

- ജോലി ചെയ്യുക *jōli ceyyuka* — to work (literally “work-do”)

Look at the first pair: ജ with the long ഞ wrapped around it — *jō*. Two shapes you now read separately, working together.

Writing: ജ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ജ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ജ in the ones that have it

ജോലി ചെയ്യുക · ജ · ോ

- *Trace it:* ജ three times, saying *ja* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ജ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ജ? What sound does it carry? (*ja*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

5.13 ല — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ജ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has been sitting in front of you on pages you have already read.

Script you'll notice: ല

ല — *la*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *l*, it is **la**.

- ജോലി *jōli* — work, the word you said on the page before
- ഇല്ല *illa* — no, from the very first chapter, where it is doubled into ല്ല

You met its chillu, ൽ, a few pages ago. This is the same consonant with its *a* still on board.

Writing: ല — copy what you see

Put your pen on ല and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ല in the ones that have it

ജോലി · ഇല്ല · രാ

- *Trace it:* ല three times, saying *la* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ല once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ല? What sound does it carry? (*la*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

5.14 Chapter 5 — The first verbs

No new words. Three verbs, one endlessly simple engine.

The exchange — build the sentences

Say these aloud:

- “I speak Malayalam” — *ñān malayālam samisārikkunnu*
- “I live in Kochi” — *ñān koccīyil tāmasikkunnu*
- “I work” — *ñān jōli ceyyunnu*
- “he speaks” — *avan samisārikkunnu* (the very same verb!)

Your turn — the engine

Say these aloud:

- the present ending on every verb (-*unnu*)
- the one thing Malayalam verbs do NOT do (change for person)
- what that forces you to always keep (the pronoun *ñān* etc.)

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- *saṁsārikkuka* “to speak” (Sanskrit-derived; native twin *parayuka*)
- *tāmasikkuka* “to live” (Sanskrit-derived; where Tamil uses native *vāḷ*)
- *ceyyuka* “to do” → *jōli ceyyuka* “to work” — the *same root* as Tamil *sey*
- *malayāḷam* = *mala* “mountain” + *āḷam* “place” — “the mountain land”

Script check — the letters of this chapter

Cover the romanizations. Find each letter once in the Malayalam above, then say the word it sits in.

- ഞാൻ — ഞ *ñā*, ന് *n*
- പോയി — യ *ya*
- കൊച്ചിയിൽ — ഞ *o*, ച *ca*, ൾ *l*
- സഹായം — ഹ *ha*
- ജോലി — ജ *ja*, ല *la*
- *Look:* at each letter, then find it in the word beside it

Before you move on

In one breath, say your language, your city, and your work in Malayalam — and note what stays the same in every verb. (*Ñān malayāḷam saṁsārikkunnu. Ñān ... il tāmasikkunnu. Ñān jōli*

ceyyunnu — the verb never changes for person.)

Chapter 6

Case Endings and Dative Subjects

Modes: 👁 eyes (2) ✍ pen (2) 🖐 Hands-free start: none of the 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that I know Malayalam the way Malayalam itself builds it – with no subject at all, marking myself with the dative -ikku.

Say enikku malayālam ariyām, set it against nān malayālam samisārikkunnu, and stack the dative’s four Dravidian cousins.

6.1 -ിക്കു (-ikku) — “to, for”

Your first **case ending**. English puts “to” in **front** as its own word. Malayalam sticks it on the **back** — and that is the biggest structural fact about the language.

What to know first

word	+ dative	meaning
പേര് <i>pēru</i> — name	പേരിന് <i>pērinu</i>	to/for the name
ജോലി <i>jōli</i> — work	ജോലിക്കു <i>jōlikku</i>	for work

Malayalam’s dative has two shapes — -ിക്കു *-ikku* and -ിന് *-inu* — chosen by the sound the noun ends in. Same case, same job; the seam is still visible.

And with “I”, which reshapes first:

ഞാൻ *nān* (“I”) → എനിക്ക് *enikku* (“to me”)

Learn *enikku* cold — it opens a great many everyday Malayalam sentences, as the next lesson shows.

Why it's said this way

	Malayalam -ikku	a Latin ending like -īs
pins down the case?	yes — dative, always	no — <i>-īs</i> is dative or ablative
carries number?	no — a separate suffix does	yes — plural, baked in
carries declension class?	no	yes — 1st/2nd only
can you see the seam?	yes : <i>jōli + kku</i>	no — one fused lump

Malayalam **stacks**: each suffix means one thing and sits in a fixed order — so a long word can be read piece by piece. Latin **fuses**: *-īs* is case *and* plural *and* declension at once, indivisible, and it doesn't even settle *which* case. Malayalam's dative is never ambiguous. That's what “**agglutinative**” means, and why Malayalam words grow long without growing hard: they are **built**, not memorised.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*pēru ... pērinu*”
- “*ñān ... enikku*” — “I” ... “to me”
- “*jōlikku*” — “for work,” from Ch. 5's ജോലി
- the principle — “one suffix, one meaning, visible seam”

Before you move on

What does **-ിക്കു** mean? (“**To**” or “**for**.”) Where does it go? (**On the end** of the noun.) What is “to me”? (**എനിക്കു** *enikku*.) Why does the suffix have two shapes? (**-ikku** and **-inu** are chosen by the noun's ending — one case, two forms.) How is that unlike a Latin ending? (Latin **fuses** case+number+declension — and *-īs* doesn't even fix *which* case; Malayalam's carries **one** meaning,

unambiguously, seam visible.) Next: the sentence where the person isn't the subject.

6.2 ക — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ല — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has been sitting in front of you on pages you have already read.

Script you'll notice: ക

ക — *ka*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *k*, it is **ka**.

Highly rounded and loopy — full circles, hooks and curls, with almost no straight lines. You wrote this one in the first chapter, inside the greeting; here it is again, loose in the middle of four words you now say every day.

- നമസ്കാരം *namaskāram* — hello / greetings
- നാളെ കാണാം *nāḷe kāṇāṁi* — see you tomorrow
- താമസിക്കുക *tāmasikkuka* — to live, to stay
- ജോലി ചെയ്യുക *jōli ceyyuka* — to work

Writing: ക — copy what you see

Put your pen on ക and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ക in the ones that have it

നമസ്കാരം · നാളെ കാണാം · നന്ദി

- *Trace it:* ക three times, saying *ka* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ക once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ക? What sound does it carry? (*ka*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

6.3 ര — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ക — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has been sitting in front of you on pages you have already read.

Script you'll notice: ര

ര — *ra*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *r*, it is **ra**.

The soft *r*, and the partner of the hard റ you read inside എന്റെ. You wrote this one in the first chapter too, at the end of the greeting.

- നമസ്കാരം *namaskāram* — hello / greetings
- ശരി *śari* — okay / alright / correct
- പേര് *pēr* — name
- സാരമില്ല *sāramilla* — it doesn't matter

Writing: ര — copy what you see

Put your pen on ര and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ര in the ones that have it

നമസ്കാരം · ശരി · എന്റെ

- *Trace it:* ര three times, saying *ra* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ര once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ര? What sound does it carry? (*ra*.)
Which of the two *r* letters is this — the soft ര or the hard റ? (The soft one.)

6.4 എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം — “I know Malayalam”

Chapter 5 gave you ഞാൻ മലയാളം സംസാരിക്കുന്നു — “I speak Malayalam.” Now say “I **know** Malayalam.” Malayalam will not let you use *ñān*.

What to know first

എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം. *enikku malayāḷam ariyām*. literally: “**to-me** Malayalam is-knowable.”

piece

എനിക്ക് <i>enikku</i>	“to me” — the dative from the last lesson
മലയാളം <i>malayāḷam</i>	Malayalam (Ch. 5)
അറിയാം <i>ariyām</i>	“can be known” — <i>ariy-</i> “know” + -ām , the <i>able-to</i> ending

You are not the subject. *Ñān* is gone; the person has been moved into the dative, and the sentence is now about the **language**. Malayalam isn’t saying you perform an act of knowing — it’s saying the language is knowable **to you**.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Malayalam separates what you **do** from what **happens to** you. Speaking is an action, so Ch. 5 used *ñān*. But knowing, liking, wanting, being hungry — these **arrive** at you. Malayalam marks that by putting the person in the **dative**.

English frames it as	Malayalam frames it as
I know Malayalam	Malayalam is known to me
I like it	it is pleasing to me
I am cold	cold is to me
English preserves one fossil of exactly this: “ methinks ” — <i>me</i> is a dative, “it seems to me .” Malayalam made it the rule.	

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

language	“I know [the language]”	the dative
Malayalam	<i>enikku malayāḷam ariyām</i>	-ikku
Tamil	<i>enakku tamīl teriyum</i>	-ukku
Telugu	<i>nāku telugu vaccu</i>	-ku
Kannada	<i>nanage kannada gottu</i>	-ge

Look at the first column: Malayalam’s *enikku* and Tamil’s *enakku* are nearly the **same word** — the two languages separated most recently of the four, and it shows. One construction, four languages, four visibly related suffixes: the Dravidian family showing its bones, as *blanc/bianco/branco* did for Romance.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*enikku malayāḷam aṛiyām*”
- the contrast — “*ñān malayāḷam sanisārikkunnu*” (I speak) ... “*enikku malayāḷam aṛiyām*” (known to me)
- the near-twins — “*enikku ... enakku*”
- the four cousins — “*-ikku · -ukku · -ku · -ge*”

Before you move on

What does എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം literally say? (“**To-me** Malayalam **is-knowable**.”) What has English got that Malayalam hasn’t? (A nominative “**I**” — *ñān* is replaced by the dative *enikku*.) Why the dative? (Knowing **happens to** you.) Which Tamil word is *enikku* almost identical to, and why? (**Enakku** — Tamil and Malayalam split most recently of the four.) Which English word keeps the same idea? (**Methinks**.)

Chapter 7

Numbers One to Ten

Modes:  voice (2)  pen (14)  Hands-free start: first 1 of 16 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can hear, say, read, and write representative numbers from one to ten in Malayalam.

Count onnu to pathu, read the ten numeral shapes out of order, and write ezhu with its numeral from sound alone.

7.1 One to five — voice first

This lesson has no Malayalam writing to decode. Hear the five words, attach each one to a quantity, and say them before your eyes meet the script.

The letters in this word

quantity	said
1	<i>onnu</i>
2	<i>randu</i>
3	<i>moonnu</i>
4	<i>naalu</i>
5	<i>anchu</i>

Point to one finger and say *onnu*. Add one finger at a time: *randu*, *moonnu*, *naalu*, *anchu*. [REPEAT x2]

Why it's said this way

Malayalam and Tamil were once one language, and the family resemblance is still audible. Malayalam *onnu* sits beside Tamil *onru*; *randu* beside *irandu*; *moonnu* beside *moonru*; and *naalu* beside *naanku*. You do not need to learn the Tamil forms. Listen only for the shared bones.

Why it's said this way

Five moved furthest: an older *aintu* softened toward Malayalam *anchu*. Say *an-chu* slowly, then normally. The sound comes before its spelling.

Your turn

- Say it: *onnu*, *randu*, *moonnu*, *naalu*, *anchu* while raising one more finger
- Hear: *moonnu*; YOU SHOW: 3
- Hear: *anchu*; YOU SHOW: 5

Before you move on

Count from one to five without looking. Which word means three? (*Moonnu*.) Which one changed furthest from its older Tamil cousin? (*Anchu*, five.) Next, the first three numeral shapes arrive one small step at a time.

7.2 ు · ూ · ృ — three numeral shapes

Say *onnu*, *randu*, *moonnu*. You already own the meanings and sounds; this lesson adds only their three numeral shapes.

Script

- ు means 1: *onnu*.
- ూ means 2: *randu*.
- ృ means 3: *moonnu*.

Point in order, then out of order: ృ ు ూ.

Writing — observe and trace

Keep the models visible. Finger-trace 𐌲, 𐌺, and 𐌾 once each. Say the number word only after your finger stops. Do not copy from memory yet.

Before you move on

Point to 𐌺 and say it. (***Randu.***) Which shape means three? (𐌾.)
How many new shapes arrived? (***Three.***)

7.3 𐌜 · 𐌛 — finish the first five numerals

Read 𐌲 𐌺 𐌾. Two shapes remain in the first group.

Script

- 𐌜 means 4: *naalu.*
- 𐌛 means 5: *anchu.*

Now point through 𐌲 𐌺 𐌾 𐌜 𐌛. The first five numeral shapes are complete.

Writing — observe and trace

Keep both models visible. Trace 𐌜 once and 𐌛 once. Then circle the one you hear: [YOU HEAR: *anchu*]. (𐌛.)

Before you move on

Which shape means four? (𐌜.) Read 𐌛. (***Anchu.***) How many new shapes did this lesson add? (***Two.***)

7.4 𐌚 — one new letter unlocks five familiar words

Say one to five, then read their numerals: 𐌲 𐌺 𐌾 𐌜 𐌛. The words themselves need only one letter you have not met.

Script

ഒ is independent short *o*. It begins ഒന്ന്, *onnu*, one.

Every other shape in this row is already familiar:

numeral	word	said
൧	ഒന്ന്	<i>onnu</i>
൨	രണ്ട്	<i>randu</i>
൩	മൂന്ന്	<i>moonnu</i>
൪	നാല്	<i>naalu</i>
൫	അഞ്ച്	<i>anchu</i>

Writing — observe and trace

Trace ഒ once with its model visible. Then point from ൧ to ഒന്ന് and say *onnu*. Read the remaining four rows; do not copy the whole row yet.

Before you move on

Which new letter begins *onnu*? (ഒ.) Read ൩ and മൂന്ന്. (*Moonnu*, *three*.) How many new letters appeared? (One.)

7.5 ൧ ൨ ൩ ൪ ൫ — one visible copy

Point through ൧ ൨ ൩ ൪ ൫ and say the five words. Keep the model visible.

Writing — guided copy

Copy the row once directly beneath its model. Look back after every shape if you need to. Say *onnu* through *anchu* as you check your copy. Repair only one shape.

Before you move on

Read ൪. (*Naalu*.) Which written word begins with the new letter ഒ? (ഒന്ന്, *onnu*.) No new shape was added here.

7.6 Five numerals — hide, then write

Study 𐌲 𐌺 𐌽 𐌿 𐌺 for five seconds. Say each number, then cover the row.

Writing — delayed copy

Write the five numerals in order while the model is hidden. If one will not come, peek once, cover it again, and continue. Uncover and repair one place.

Before you move on

Say the row without looking. What made this harder than the previous lesson? (**The model was hidden before writing.**)

7.7 Three heard numbers — write their numerals

Cover the answer line. You will hear familiar words, never an untaught form.

Writing — dictation

[YOU HEAR: *randu* — *anchu* — *moonnu*]

Write the three numeral shapes from sound alone. Then uncover and compare: 𐌺 𐌺 𐌺. Repair one shape if needed; do not rewrite the whole line.

Before you move on

Write the numeral for *naalu* from sound alone. (𐌿.) You are now ready to hear six through ten before meeting any of their shapes.

7.8 Six to ten — voice first

Count *onnu* through *anchu*. Keep your pencil down: the next five meanings and sounds come before their shapes.

The letters in this word

quantity	said
6	<i>aaru</i>
7	<i>ezhu</i>
8	<i>ettu</i>
9	<i>ompathu</i>
10	<i>pathu</i>

Say the row once slowly, then once at counting speed. [REPEAT x2]

Why it's said this way

The middle sound of *ezhu* is the curled **zh** heard in the name *Tamil* in its native form. Malayalam and Tamil kept it; Kannada and Telugu hardened it. Practise only the sound now: *e-zhu*. The written letter waits for a later micro-lesson.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Ompathu grew from an old word for **one** plus *pathu*, **ten**: one short of ten. Before *p*, the older *n* becomes *m*. Say *on-pathu* slowly, then let it settle into *ompathu*.

Your turn

- Say it: *aaru*, *ezhu*, *ettu*, *ompathu*, *pathu*
- Hear: *ezhu*; YOU SHOW: 7
- Hear: *ompathu*; YOU SHOW: 9

Before you move on

Count six to ten. Which word preserves the rare *zh*? (***Ezhu***.) How is *ompathu* built? (**One plus ten: one short of ten.**) Next, the numeral shapes arrive in groups of three or fewer.

7.9 ൬ · ൭ · ൮ — three more numeral shapes

Say *aaru*, *ezhu*, *ettu*. Their sounds and quantities are familiar; only the shapes are new.

Script

- **ᄃ** means 6: *aaru*.
- **ᄅ** means 7: *ezhu*.
- **ᄆ** means 8: *ettu*.

Point out of order: **ᄆ ᄃ ᄅ**.

Writing — observe and trace

Keep the models visible. Trace **ᄃ**, **ᄅ**, and **ᄆ** once each. Say the word after each trace. Memory writing waits.

Before you move on

Which shape means seven? (**ᄅ**.) Read **ᄆ**. (***Ettu***.) How many new shapes arrived? (**Three**.)

7.10 ᄃ · ᄆ — nine and ten

Read **ᄃ ᄅ ᄆ**. Two shapes finish the sequence.

Script

- **ᄃ** means 9: *ompathu*.
- **ᄆ** means 10: *pathu*.

Point through **ᄃ ᄅ ᄆ ᄃ ᄆ** and say the words once.

Writing — observe and trace

Trace **ᄃ** once and **ᄆ** once with their models visible. Circle the one you hear: [YOU HEAR: *ompathu*]. (**ᄃ**.)

Before you move on

Which shape means ten? (**ᄆ**.) Read **ᄃ**. (***Ompathu***.) This lesson added two shapes, not five.

7.11 ഏ · ഴ — two letters unlock the second row

Say six to ten, then read ന ഴ വ ന്നു. Two letters remain before every written word in the row is decodable.

Script

- ഏ is independent long *e*.
- ഴ is the curled *zh* you already heard in *ezhu*.

Together with the familiar chandrakkala, they begin and finish ഏഴ്, *ezhu*.

numeral	word	said
ന	ആറ്	<i>aaru</i>
ഈ	ഏഴ്	<i>ezhu</i>
വ	എട്ട്	<i>ettu</i>
ന	ഒമ്പത്	<i>ompathu</i>
ന	പത്ത്	<i>pathu</i>

Writing — observe and trace

Trace ഏ once and ഴ once with the models visible. Then point through ഏഴ് and say *ezhu*. Whole-word memory writing waits.

Before you move on

Which letter carries the rare *zh*? (ഴ.) Read ഴ — ഏഴ്. (*Ezhu*, *seven*.) How many new letters appeared? (Two.)

7.12 ന ഴ വ ന്നു — one supported copy

Read ന ഴ വ ന്നു. Keep both models below visible.

Writing — guided copy

Copy ന ഴ വ ന്നു once. Then copy ഏഴ് — ഴ once. Look back whenever you need. Check only the two new letters ഏ and ഴ, then stop.

Before you move on

Read your copied word. (***Ezhu***, *seven*.) Which numeral belongs beside it? (၆.) No new shape was added here.

7.13 ၵုၵ်ႉ — hide, then write

Study ၵုၵ်ႉ — ၆ for five seconds. Say *ezhu*, then cover both forms.

Writing — delayed copy

Write the word and numeral while the model is hidden. Peek once if needed, cover again, and finish. Uncover and repair one shape rather than rewriting.

Before you move on

Which letter carries the curled sound? (ၵ.) What changed from the guided copy? (**The model was hidden before writing.**)

7.14 Heard numbers — write without a model

Cover the answer line. Every sound and shape has already had a supported turn.

Writing — dictation and transcription

[YOU HEAR: *aaru* — *ezhu* — *ompathu*]

Write the three numerals from sound alone. For *ezhu*, also write the word. Then uncover: က — ၆ ၵုၵ်ႉ — ၸ. Compare and repair one place.

Before you move on

Write the numeral for *pathu*. (၂.) Write the word you practised for seven. (ၵုၵ်ႉ.) Next comes a cumulative, no-new-shape payoff.

7.15 One to ten — the cumulative payoff

Count from *onnu* to *pathu* once without looking. No new word or shape appears in this lesson.

Your turn — read, not recite

Read these shuffled numerals before looking back at the ordered row:

൭ ൨ ൧ ൫ ൮

>

൩ ൯ ൧ ൩ ൪

Now check against ൧ ൨ ൩ ൪ ൫ ൬ ൭ ൮ ൯ ൧൦.

Why it's said this way

- Which word preserves the rare *zh*? (ഏഴ്, *ezhu*, seven.)
- Which word means one short of ten? (ഒമ്പത്, *ompathu*, nine.)
- Which first-five word shifted furthest from older *aintu*? (അഞ്ച്, *anchu*.)

Writing — independent dictation

Cover the answer. [YOU HEAR: *ezhu*] Write its numeral and word from sound alone. Uncover and compare: ൭ — ഏഴ്. Repair one shape if needed.

Before you move on

Count one to ten, then read ൯ ൪ ൭ out of order. You can now hear, say, read, and write a representative part of the complete number sequence.

7.16 ൿ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ൯ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ്

് — *no sound of its own — it takes one away.*

It is a **vowel-killer**. Every consonant in this script arrives with an *a* already inside it — that is what an abugida is. This mark takes the *a* back, leaving the bare consonant. It is how the script writes two consonants in a row.

You already say these, and every one of them has ് somewhere inside it:

- നമസ്കാരം *namaskāram* — hello / greetings (namaskāram — “a making of a bow”)
- നന്ദി *nandi* — thank you
- ഇല്ല *illa* — no / there isn’t (illa — the negative)
- പേര് *pēr* — name

Writing: ് — copy what you see

Put your pen on ് and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ് in the ones that have it

നമസ്കാരം · നന്ദി · ശരി

- *Trace it:* ് three times, and each time say what it does: **it kills the built-in *a***
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ് once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ॠ? What does it do to the consonant it sits on? (**Takes away the built-in *a*.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 8

Please

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) ✍️ pen (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say please in Malayalam, and soften a request with the everyday verb ending instead.

Say dayavāyi, split it into daya 'compassion' plus -vāyi, then use the plainer -u verb ending as the everyday alternative.

8.1 ദയവായി (dayavāyi) — please (as a compassion)

Malayalam’s “please” turns compassion into an adverb: do this thing **as a kindness**.

What to know first

ദയവായി = please, literally “**kindly / as a compassion**.” Two pieces:

- ദയ (daya) = **compassion, kindness, grace** — from Sanskrit **daya**.
- -വായി (-vāyi) = “**having become / as**,” turning the noun into “*in the manner of* compassion” — i.e. **kindly**. (The true historical seam is *dayavu* “kindness” + -ആയി -āyi, the adverb of ആകുക ākuka “to become”; we split it -vāyi here just to keep the *daya* root visible.)

So *dayavāyi* asks you to act *kindly, as a kindness*. Where Tamil and Telugu say “**do** the kindness” and Kannada “having **placed** it,” Malayalam makes kindness the **manner** of the whole request.

The family resemblance is unmistakable, and it reaches beyond Dravidian: **Arabic** *min faḍlik* (“from your **grace**”) and **Hindi** *kṛpayā* (from *kṛpā*, “**compassion**”) ask by the same grace-naming instinct.

Why it’s said this way

daya + a light verb, four ways:

- Malayalam ദയവായി *dayavāyi* — compassion + **as / having become**
- Tamil தயவுசெய்து *tayavu seytu* — kindness + **do**
- Kannada ದಯವಿಟ್ಟು *dayaviṭṭu* — compassion + **having placed**
- Telugu దయచేసి *dayacēsi* — compassion + **having done**

Why it’s said this way

Honestly: as elsewhere in the family, the standalone word is a touch **formal / emphatic**. Everyday Malayalam politeness leans on the **respectful request** form of the verb — endings like -*u* (-*ū*) or -*ṇam* (-*aṇam*): ഇരിക്കൂ (*irikkū*) “please sit,” പറയൂ (*parayū*) “please tell me.” Add ദയവായി in front when you want the courtesy spoken aloud.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The heart of the word is *va* stretched by the **long-ā** sign *ā* (-*ā*) — then *ya* + the *i* sign (*i*). Malayalam’s rounded letters hang their vowel-signs to the right; the long *ā* is simply a tall stroke after the consonant, the same *ā* you would meet across the Dravidian scripts.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*daya*” — compassion — then “-*vāyi*,” as / kindly
- the whole word — “*dayavāyi*” = please
- the everyday way — the verb ending: “*irikkū*” = please sit

Before you move on

What is the Malayalam word for please? (ദയവായി *dayavāyi*.)
 What do its pieces mean? (“**Compassion**” *daya* + “**as / having become**” *-vāyi* — *kindly*.) Which cousins ask the same way?
 (Tamil, Kannada, Telugu with *daya* — plus Arabic *faḍl*, Hindi *kṛpā*.) What carries “please” in ordinary speech? (The respectful verb form, endings like -ഓ *-ū* / -ണി *-aṇani*.)

8.2 ി — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ള — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ി

ി — *i*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with *i*. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

You already say these, and every one of them has ി somewhere inside it:

- നന്ദി *nandi* — thank you
- ശരി *sari* — okay / alright / correct (śari)
- സാരമില്ല *sāramilla* — it doesn’t matter / no problem / you’re welcome
- പോയി വരാം *pōyi varāṁ* — goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)

Writing: ി — copy what you see

Put your pen on ി and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ി in the ones that have it

നന്ദി · ശരി · നമസ്കാരം

- *Trace it:* ി three times, saying *i* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ി once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ി? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts *i* on; takes the built-in *a* off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 9

Sorry

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) ✍️ pen (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can apologise in Malayalam with *kṣamikkaṇaṁ*, and use the plainer *kṣamikkū* when it suits.

*Say *kṣamikkaṇaṁ*, hear the necessitative -aṇaṁ softening it into politeness, then drop to the plain *kṣamikkū*.*

9.1 ക്ഷമിക്കണം (kṣamikkaṇaṁ) — (you) should forgive / sorry

You already know ദയവായി and the necessitative -ണം ending mentioned there. Malayalam’s “sorry” is that very ending, now carrying a forgiveness-verb.

What to know first

- ക്ഷമ (*kṣama*) = “**forgiveness, patience**” — the Sanskrit noun.
- -ഇക്കുക (*-ikkuka*) = a **verb-making suffix**: *kṣama* + *-ikkuka* → ക്ഷമിക്കുക (*kṣamikkuka*), “**to forgive**.”
- -ണം (-aṇaṁ) = the **necessitative** ending, “**must / should**” — literally *kṣamikkaṇaṁ* says “[you] **must forgive**,” used as a softened, polite request exactly the way English can soften a request into “you should really forgive me” without meaning it as an order.

So ക്ഷമിക്കണം leans on obligation to be polite — a very different move from a plain imperative.

Why it's said this way

- Malayalam ക്ഷമിക്കണം *kṣamikkanaṁ* — Sanskrit *kṣama* + **-ikkuka** (verb) + **-aṇaṁ** (necessitative: “must/should”)
- Kannada ಕ್ಷಮಿಸಿ *kṣamisi* — Sanskrit *kṣamā* + **-isu** (verb) + **-i** (imperative)
- Telugu క్షమించండి *kṣamiṇcaṇḍi* — Sanskrit *kṣamā* + **-iṇcu** (verb) + **-aṇḍi** (imperative)
- Tamil மன்னிக்கவும் *mannikkavum* — its **own** native root *manni*, not Sanskrit at all

Why it's said this way

ക്ഷമിക്കണം is a genuine, common way to ask forgiveness — but Malayalam speakers reach just as often for the plain imperative ക്ഷമിക്കൂ (*kṣamikkū*, using the -ൂ ending from the please lesson) or simply the borrowed English “sorry.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kṣama” — the Sanskrit noun, forgiveness
- the verb — “kṣamikkuka,” to forgive — then “kṣamikkanaṁ,” you should forgive
- the plainer version — “kṣamikkū,” using the -ū ending you know

Before you move on

What does ക്ഷമിക്കണം literally say, and why is that polite? (“[You] **must forgive**” — the necessitative **-aṇaṁ** softens an obligation into a request, same as ദയവായി’s note on -aṇaṁ.) Which cousins also verb-ify *kṣama*? (**Kannada and Telugu**; **Tamil** uses its own root *manni*.) What’s a plainer alternative? (**Kṣamikkū**, using the -ū ending, or borrowed English “sorry.”)

9.2 ഓ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ി — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ഓ

ഓ — *ā*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with *ā*. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

You already say these, and every one of them has ഓ somewhere inside it:

- നമസ്കാരം *namaskāram* — hello / greetings (namaskāram — “a making of a bow”)
- സാരമില്ല *sāramilla* — it doesn’t matter / no problem / you’re welcome
- പോയി വരാം *pōyi varām* — goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)
- നാളെ കാണാം *nāle kāṇām* — see you tomorrow

Writing: ഓ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ഓ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ഓ in the ones that have it

നമസ്കാരം · സാരമില്ല · നന്ദി

- *Trace it:* ഓ three times, saying $\bar{a}$ as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ഓ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ഓ? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts $\bar{a}$ on; takes the built-in a off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 10

Days of the Week

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ✍ pen (1) 🗣 Hands-free start: none of the 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the seven days of the Malayalam week and say which planet each one is named for.

Name the seven planet-days, separate the native ones from the Sanskrit ones, and explain their near-identity with Tamil's.

10.1 തിങ്കൾ to ഞായർ — the week Malayalam shares with Tamil

Malayalam and Tamil are close cousins — they were once, long ago, the same language — and nowhere does that show more clearly than in the words for the days of the week.

What to know first

Malayalam	planet-word	meaning	compare Tamil
തിങ്കളാഴ്ച	<i>thinkaḷ</i>	“Moon”	<i>thingaḷ</i> — nearly identical
ചൊവ്വാഴ്ച	<i>covva</i>	traditionally “the red one”	<i>cevvāy</i> — the same word, worn differently
ബുധനാഴ്ച	<i>budhan</i>	Mercury	Sanskrit Budha , same as Tamil <i>pudhan</i>
വ്യാഴാഴ്ച	<i>vyāzham</i>	Jupiter	matches Tamil’s <i>viyāzhan</i> closely
വെള്ളിയാഴ്ച	<i>velli</i>	traditionally “silver”	<i>velli</i> — the same word
ശനിയാഴ്ച	<i>śani</i>	Saturn	Sanskrit Śani , same as Tamil <i>sani</i>
ഞായറാഴ്ച	<i>ñāyar</i>	“Sun”	<i>ñāyīru</i> — the same root

Why it’s said this way

This is the closest family match anywhere in Dravidian: **thinkaḷ/thingaḷ**, **velli/velli**, and **ñāyar/ñāyīru** are essentially **the same words**, because Malayalam only became a distinct language from Tamil within roughly the last thousand years or so. Where Tamil says കിഴമൈ (*kizhamai*) for “day,” Malayalam says ആഴ്ച (*āzhcha*) — a different word for the same idea (the two aren’t confirmed cognates; treat this as two languages solving the same naming problem separately, not necessarily one shared root). Like Tamil, Malayalam mixes **native** planet-words (Moon, Mars, Venus, Sun) with **Sanskrit** ones (Mercury, Jupiter, Saturn) — the same split, inherited from the same shared ancestor language.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “thinkal” — moon — then “āzhcha,” day/week
- the shared words — “velli” (Venus), same in both Malayalam and Tamil
- the Sanskrit ones — “budhan, vyāzham, śani” — Mercury, Jupiter, Saturn

Before you move on

Why do Malayalam and Tamil’s day-names look so alike? (**They were the same language until roughly a thousand years ago.**) Which planet-names does Malayalam share almost word-for-word with Tamil? (**thinkal/Moon, velli/Venus, ñāyar/Sun** — and *covva*/Mars, a worn variant of *cevvāy*.) Which three come from Sanskrit in both languages? (**Mercury (Budha), Jupiter (vyāzham/viyāzhan), Saturn (Śani).**)

10.2 ന — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഐ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ന

ന — *na*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *n*, it is **na**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ന somewhere inside it:

- നമസ്കാരം *namaskāram* — hello / greetings (namaskāram — “a making of a bow”)
- നന്ദി *nandi* — thank you
- എന്റെ *enre* — my
- സന്തോഷം *santōṣam* — joy / pleased to meet you

Writing: ന — copy what you see

Put your pen on ന and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ന in the ones that have it

നമസ്കാരം · നന്ദി · ഇല്ല

- *Trace it:* ന three times, saying *na* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ന once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ന? What sound does it carry? (*na*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 11

Four Core Colours

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ✍ pen (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name black, white, red and blue in Malayalam.

Say karuppŭ, vellā, cuvappŭ and nīla, and mark which three are native Dravidian and which one is a shared Sanskrit loan.

11.1 കറുപ്പ്, വെള്ള, ചുവപ്പ്, നീല — the same split as Tamil

You’ve seen Malayalam and Tamil share day-names almost word-for-word. Their colors follow the exact same family pattern.

What to know first

- കറുപ്പ് (*karuppŭ*) = “**black**” — matches Tamil *karuppu* almost exactly.
- വെള്ള (*vellā*) = “**white**” — the same **vel-** “bright/silvery” root as Tamil *vellai*.
- ചുവപ്പ് (*cuvappŭ*) = “**red**” — a related word from the same Dravidian root family as Tamil *sivappu*, though the two differ in both their opening consonant’s sound and their vowel — a looser cousin than *karuppŭ/karuppu* or *vellā/vellai*, which match almost exactly.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

നീല (*nīla*) = “blue” — the same **Sanskrit** loan Tamil uses (*nīlam*), and the same one Hindi uses (*nīlā*). Blue is where Malayalam, Tamil, and Hindi all converge on one shared Sanskrit word, even though Malayalam and Tamil otherwise built their own native words for black, white, and red.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “karuppū, vellā, cuvappū” — black, white, red
- “nīla” — blue, shared with Tamil and Hindi
- the family match — “karuppū/karuppu, vellā/vellai, cuvappū/sivappu”

Before you move on

Which three Malayalam colors closely match Tamil’s own words? (**Karuppū, vellā, cuvappū** — black, white, red.) Which color is a shared Sanskrit loan across Malayalam, Tamil, and Hindi? (**Blue** — நீல *nīla* / நீலம் *nīlam* / नीला *nīlā*.)

11.2 ് — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ് — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ്

് — *ma*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *m*, it is **ma**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ് somewhere inside it:

- നമസ്കാരം *namaskāram* — hello / greetings (*namaskāram* — “a making of a bow”)
- സാരമില്ല *sāramilla* — it doesn’t matter / no problem / you’re welcome
- താമസിക്കുക *tāmasikkuka* — to live, to stay
- എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം *enikku malayāḷam ariyām* — ‘I know Malayalam’

Writing: മ — copy what you see

Put your pen on മ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find മ in the ones that have it

നമസ്കാരം · സാരമില്ല · നന്ദി

- *Trace it:* മ three times, saying *ma* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find മ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — മ? What sound does it carry? (*ma.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 12

Family

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my father, mother, and my older and younger brothers and sisters in Malayalam.

Say the six family words in age-graded pairs, and note that Malayalam built its own sibling set rather than tracking Tamil's.

12.1 അച്ഛൻ, അമ്മ, and four sibling words — Malayalam's own set

Malayalam and Tamil share a great deal of their vocabulary — but family words are where Malayalam goes its own way further than you might expect, while still keeping the family's signature age-first sibling system.

What to know first

- അച്ഛൻ (*acchan*) = “**father**” — a different form from Tamil's *appā*; **this word's own deeper origin is less settled** than the simple *appā/amma* pattern, and worth a linguist's extra look.
- അമ്മ (*amma*) = “**mother**” — matches the family's shared *amma* pattern closely.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Malayalam	meaning
ചേട്ടൻ (<i>cēṭṭan</i>)	older brother
അനിയൻ (<i>aniyan</i>)	younger brother
ചേച്ചി (<i>cēcci</i>)	older sister
അനിയത്തി (<i>aniyatti</i>)	younger sister

Notice these don't closely match Tamil/Kannada/Telugu's *aṇṇan/anna*, *tambi/tammuḍu*, *akkā/akka*, or *tangai/celli* — Malayalam built its own set of sibling words. But the **structure** is identical: **four** words, not two, split by whether the sibling is **older or younger than you** — the same signature pattern you've now seen across all four Dravidian languages, even where the specific words diverge.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “acchan, amma” — father, mother
- “cēṭṭan, aniyān” — older/younger brother
- “cēcci, aniyatti” — older/younger sister

Before you move on

Do Malayalam's sibling words closely match Tamil's? (**No** — Malayalam built its own distinct set (cēṭṭan, aniyān, cēcci, and aniyatti), unlike how closely Kannada and Telugu track Tamil.) Does Malayalam still split siblings by age? (**Yes** — four words, older vs. younger, the same structural pattern across the whole Dravidian family.)

Chapter 13

Head and Hand

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ✍ pen (2) ⇄ **Hands-free start:** first 1 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the head and the hand in Malayalam.

Say thala and kai, and match them against Tamil's talai and kai.

13.1 തല, കൈ — head and hand, matching Tamil closely

Malayalam's family words (*achan*, *cēṭṭan...*) went their own way from Tamil's. Body parts snap right back to the close match you saw in colors and days.

What to know first

- തല (*thala*) = “**head**” — matches Tamil *talai* closely.
- കൈ (*kai*) = “**hand**” — matches Tamil *kai* almost exactly.

Both native Dravidian, both close cousins of Tamil's own words — a reminder that Malayalam and Tamil's vocabulary agreement varies concept by concept, not uniformly.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “thala” — head
- “kai” — hand
- the match — nearly identical to Tamil’s talai/kai

Before you move on

What are Malayalam’s words for head and hand, and how closely do they match Tamil? (തല **thala**, കൈ **kai** — very closely, both native Dravidian.)

13.2 ത — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: മ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ത

ത — *ta*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *t*, it is **ta**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ത somewhere inside it:

- അതെ — yes (athe — “that [is so]”)
- എന്ത് — what
- സന്തോഷം *santōṣam* — joy / pleased to meet you
- താമസിക്കുക *tāmasikkuka* — to live, to stay

Writing: ത — copy what you see

Put your pen on ത and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ത in the ones that have it
അതെ · എന്ത് · നമസ്കാരം
- *Trace it:* ത three times, saying *ta* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ത once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ത? What sound does it carry? (*ta.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

13.3 S — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ത — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: S

S — *ta.*

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *t*, it is **ṭa**.

You already say these, and every one of them has S somewhere inside it:

- വീണ്ടും കാണാം — we'll meet again
- ഒന്ന് രണ്ട് മൂന്ന് നാല് അഞ്ച് — one to five
- ആറ് ഏഴ് എട്ട് ഒമ്പത് പത്ത് — six to ten

- അച്ഛൻ അമ്മ ചേട്ടൻ അനിയൻ ചേച്ചി അനിയത്തി — father, mother, and four age-graded sibling words

Writing: S — copy what you see

Put your pen on **S** and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find **S** in the ones that have it

നമസ്കാരം

- *Trace it:* **S** three times, saying *ta* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find **S** once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — **S**? What sound does it carry? (*ta*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 14

Seasons

Modes: ⇐ voice (1) ✍ pen (1) ⇐ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name Malayalam’s four seasons, including the monsoon that sits at the centre of the year.

Say vēnalkkālam, mazhakkālam and śaithyakālam as native compounds, then vasanthakālam as the shared Sanskrit loan.

14.1 വസന്തകാലം, വേനൽ, മഴ, ശൈത്യം — the same pattern as Tamil

Malayalam’s season words follow the very same recipe as Tamil’s — native words for what a season *feels like*, plus one shared Sanskrit loan for spring.

What to know first

Malayalam	meaning	source
വസന്തകാലം (<i>vasanthakaalam</i>)	“spring”	<i>vasantham</i> — the same Sanskrit loan as Tamil
വേനൽക്കാലം (<i>venalkkaalam</i>)	“summer”	വേനൽ <i>venal</i> , native Dravidian, matching Tamil <i>kodai</i> ’s role
മഴക്കാലം (<i>mazhakkaalam</i>)	“rainy season”	മഴ <i>mazha</i> , native Dravidian, matching Tamil <i>mazhai</i> closely
ശൈത്യകാലം (<i>śaithyakaalam</i>)	“winter/cold season”	<i>śaithya</i> — this one leans more Sanskrit-flavored than Tamil’s native <i>kulir</i>

Every one shares the ending **-കാലം** (*-kaalam*, “time/season”) — itself ultimately from Sanskrit काल (*kāla*), but assimilated so long ago that it functions as ordinary vocabulary, quite unlike a fresher loan like *vasantham*.

Why it’s said this way

As with Tamil, Kerala’s actual climate is shaped far more by **മഴക്കാലം** (*mazhakkaalam*, “the rains” — including Kerala’s famous southwest monsoon) than by a clean four-way Western split. The rains aren’t a footnote to “summer” or “autumn” — they’re their own major season, central to daily and agricultural life.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “venal” — summer heat — then “kaalam,” season
- “mazhakkaalam” — the rains, the real central season
- “śaithyakaalam” — the cold season
- the shared loanword — “vasanthakaalam,” spring, same as Tamil

Before you move on

Which Malayalam season-words match Tamil's closely, and which is shared with Tamil as a Sanskrit loan? (**Venal/mazha** match Tamil's *kodai/mazhai*; **vasanthakaalam** is the same Sanskrit loan as Tamil's *vasantha kaalam*.) What's the real central season in Kerala's climate? (**Mazhakaalam**, the rains/monsoon.)

14.2 ഴ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: **ട** — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ഴ

ഴ — *lla*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *ll*, it is **lla**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ഴ somewhere inside it:

- ആറ് ഏഴ് എട്ട് ഒമ്പത് പത്ത് — six to ten
- തിങ്കൾ ചൊവ്വ ബുധൻ വ്യാഴം വെള്ളി ശനി ഞായർ — the seven weekdays
- വസന്തകാലം വേനൽക്കാലം മഴക്കാലം ശൈത്യകാലം — spring, summer, monsoon, winter

Writing: ഴ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ഴ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find **൧** in the ones that have it

നമസ്കാരം

- *Trace it:* **൧** three times, saying *lla* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find **൧** once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — **൧**? What sound does it carry? (*lla*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 15

Water and Rice

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) ✍️ pen (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name water and rice in Malayalam, keeping raw ari apart from cooked cōru.

Say vellam and explain why it does not match Tamil's n̄r, then split ari from cōru.

15.1 വെള്ളം, അരി, ചോറ് — a different water-word, the same rice-words

For once, Malayalam's everyday word for something basic genuinely **doesn't** match Tamil's — even though water is about as basic as vocabulary gets.

What to know first

വെള്ളം (*vellam*) = “**water**” — and notably, this is **not** built on *n̄r* the way Tamil's *taṇṇ̄r* is. Instead, *vellam* shares the വെൾ (*vel-*, “**bright, white**”) root you already met in *velli*, “silver/ Venus,” from the colors and days lessons — *vellam* originally meant something closer to “**flood, deluge**” before becoming Malayalam's plain, everyday word for water. (*N̄r* itself hasn't vanished from Malayalam — it survives inside compounds like ഇളനീർ *iḷan̄r*, “tender coconut water,” and കണ്ണീർ *kaṇṇ̄r*, “tears” — it's just not the standalone everyday word anymore.)

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Rice, though, tells the familiar story:

- അരി (*ari*) = “**rice**” (raw grain) — closely matching Tamil *arisi*.
- ചോറ് (*cōru*) = “**cooked rice**” (the meal) — and here Malayalam actually **does** have a Tamil cognate: Tamil keeps its own native சோறு (also *cōru*), used alongside the Sanskrit-influenced *sātam* as an everyday near-synonym. Malayalam simply made *cōru* its main word, where Tamil more often reaches for *sātam*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vellaṁ” — water, NOT matching Tamil’s *neer*
- “ari” — raw rice, matching Tamil closely
- “cōru” — cooked rice, Malayalam’s own word

Before you move on

Does Malayalam’s everyday water-word match Tamil’s? (**No** — *vellaṁ* shares the *vel-* “bright/white” root instead, originally meaning “flood”; though *nīr* itself survives in compounds like *iḷanīr* and *kaṇṇīr*.) Does its raw-rice word match Tamil’s? (**Yes** — *ari* closely matches *arisi*.)

15.2 േ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ് — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ൫

൫ — *ō*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with *ō*. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

You already say these, and every one of them has ൫ somewhere inside it:

- സന്തോഷം *santōṣam* — joy / pleased to meet you
- സുഖമാണോ? — how are you? (lit. “are you well?”)
- പോയി വരാം *pōyi varām* — goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)
- ജോലി ചെയ്യുക *jōli ceyyuka* — to work (lit. “work-do”)

Writing: ൫ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ൫ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ൫ in the ones that have it
സന്തോഷം · സുഖമാണോ? · നമസ്കാരം
- *Trace it:* ൫ three times, saying *ō* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ൫ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ൫? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts *ō* on;**

takes the built-in *a* off.) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 16

The Traditional Months

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) ✍️ pen (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the twelve months of the Malayalam Kollam-era calendar and say which zodiac sign each one carries.

Recite the twelve months from Chirīṇṇam, tie Chirīṇṇam to Leo, and contrast Malayalam’s zodiac naming with Tamil’s nakshatras.

16.1 ചിങ്ങം to കർക്കടകം — Kerala’s own solar calendar, named by the zodiac

Malayalam, like Tamil, has its **own** solar calendar — but even here, the two closest cousins name their months by two **different** logics.

What to know first

ചിങ്ങം, കന്നി, തുലാം, വൃശ്ചികം, ധനു, മകരം, കുംഭം, മീനം, മേടം, ഇടവം, മിഥുനം, കർക്കടകം (*Chirīṇṇam, Kanni, Tulām, Vṛścikam, Dhanu, Makaram, Kumbham, Mīnam, Mēḍam, Iḍavam, Mithunam, Karkīḍakam*).

This is the **Kollam Era** calendar (also called the Malayalam calendar), Kerala’s own solar civil calendar — genuinely separate from the Gregorian, the pan-Indian Hindu lunisolar calendar, **and** Tamil’s solar calendar.

Why it's said this way

Both Tamil's and Malayalam's calendars are **solar**, and both are independent of the Hindu lunisolar system — but they name their months differently. Tamil ties each month to a **nakshatra** (a lunar-mansion star cluster). Malayalam instead names each month directly for the **zodiac sign** (rāśi) the sun is passing through: ചിങ്ങം (*Chinṇam*) = Leo, കന്നി (*Kanni*) = Virgo, തുലാം (*Tulām*) = Libra, and so on straight through the zodiac. Same underlying idea — track the sun's yearly path against the stars — but two Dravidian languages chose two different sets of star-markers to name it by.

ചിങ്ങം 1 (the 1st of Chinṇam) marks the **Malayalam New Year** and the start of the **Onam** festival season — Kerala's own solar calendar, running its own independent year.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the twelve — “Chinṇam, Kanni, Tulām, Vṛścikam, Dhanu, Makaram, Kumbham, Mīnam, Mēḍam, Iḍavam, Mithunam, Karkidakam”
- “Chinṇam = Leo” — a zodiac sign, not a nakshatra
- the contrast — Tamil uses nakshatras, Malayalam uses zodiac signs

Before you move on

Is Malayalam's calendar solar or lunisolar? (**Solar** — like Tamil's, and separate from the Hindu lunisolar system.) How does it differ from Tamil's in naming logic? (**Zodiac signs** — Chinṇam=Leo, Kanni=Virgo — rather than Tamil's nakshatra-based names.) What does Chinṇam 1 mark? (**Malayalam New Year**, the start of the Onam season.)

16.2 ൾ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ൾ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ഌ

ഌ — *a nasal, ridden on the syllable before it.*

It is a **nasal**, written as a mark rather than as a letter. It rides on the syllable before it and turns the end of it nasal.

You already say these, and every one of them has ഌ somewhere inside it:

- നമസ്കാരം *namaskāram* — hello / greetings (namaskāram — “a making of a bow”)
- സന്തോഷം *santōṣam* — joy / pleased to meet you
- സുഖം *sukham* — well-being — and the reply “സുഖമാണ്
- പോയി വരാം *pōyi varām* — goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)

Writing: ഌ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ഌ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ഌ in the ones that have it

നമസ്കാരം · സന്തോഷം · നന്ദി

- *Trace it:* ഌ three times, humming the nasal at the end of the syllable as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ഌ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ㄛ? What does it add to the syllable before it? (**A nasal.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 17

Noon and Midnight

Modes: ⇌ voice (2) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say noon and midnight in Malayalam and hear paathi, 'half', inside paathira.

Say pāthira, pull pāthi out of it, and show it is a native half-word rather than Sanskrit ardha.

17.1 ഉച്ച — a different Sanskrit metaphor, not a Sanskrit-free one

Kannada and Telugu both reached for Sanskrit's *madhya*, “middle,” to name noon. Malayalam looks different at first glance — but be careful before you call it “native.”

What to know first

ഉച്ച (*ucha*) = “**noon, midday**” — and unlike Kannada's *madhyāhna* or Telugu's *madhyāhnam*, this is **not** a *madhya* (“middle”) compound at all. It most likely shares its root with Tamil உச்சி (*ucci*, “**crown of the head, peak, summit, zenith**”) and Kannada's own ಉಚ್ಚಿ (*ucci*). Here's the honest twist: per Wiktionary, that whole *ucci* family across Tamil and Kannada is itself documented as a **Sanskrit borrowing**, from उच्च (*ucca*, “**high**”). Malayalam's own *ucha* has no fully documented etymology yet, so treat the connection as likely rather than settled — but if it holds, this isn't a case of Malayalam **avoiding** Sanskrit at all. It's Malayalam reaching for a **different** Sanskrit root than its neighbors: *ucca* (“high”) instead of *madhya*

(“middle”). Noon becomes “**the sun at its peak**” rather than “the middle of the day” — the same zenith-based idea inside Arabic’s *az-ẓuhr* (from a root meaning “to appear, become visible/apex”), just arrived at from Sanskrit rather than Arabic.

Why it’s said this way

Don’t walk away thinking Malayalam dodged Sanskrit here while Kannada and Telugu didn’t. The more likely picture: ഉച്ച may be just as Sanskrit-rooted as *madhyāhna* — it’s simply a *different* Sanskrit root (*ucca*, “high,” rather than *madhya*, “middle”). What’s genuinely different is the **metaphor**, not necessarily the **language of origin**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*ucha*” — noon, “the peak” — compare Tamil’s “*ucci*”
- the honest contrast — Kannada/Telugu’s noon word means “middle”; Malayalam’s most likely means “peak” — both probably still Sanskrit, just different Sanskrit roots

Before you move on

Is ഉച്ച a Sanskrit “middle” word like Kannada’s *madhyāhna*? (**No** — it most likely comes from a *different* Sanskrit root, *ucca*, “high/peak,” not *madhya*, “middle.”) Does that make ഉച്ച a native Dravidian word? (**Not necessarily** — its likely relatives, Tamil *ucci* and Kannada *ucci*, are themselves documented Sanskrit borrowings.)

17.2 പാതിരാ — midnight as “half-night”

ഉച്ച (*ucca*) named noon by the sun’s height. Malayalam builds midnight with a different spatial idea: cut the night in half.

What to know first

പാതിരാ (*paathira*) means “**midnight**.” It is built on പാതി (*paathi*), the everyday Malayalam word for “**half**”—as in *paathi vila*, “half price”—fused with a shortened form of “night.”

The result has the same “half-night” shape as Telugu అర్ధరాత్రి (*ardharātri*) and Hindi *ādhī rāt*. The pieces are not all cousins, though. Malayalam പാതി is a genuinely different word from Sanskrit **ardha**, the root behind Telugu *ardharātri* and, farther back, Hindi *ādhī*.

So two languages can independently choose the same transparent construction while filling it with unrelated words for “half.” The metaphor matches; the vocabulary does not.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *paathira* — midnight
- *paathi* — half
- Malayalam *paathi* versus Sanskrit *ardha* — same job, different roots

Before you move on

What does പാതിരാ build on? (പാതി, “half,” plus a shortened night-word.) Is *paathi* the same root as Telugu *ardha*? (**No.** The two languages share the “half-night” logic but use unrelated half-words.)

Chapter 18

Telling Time

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) ✍️ pen (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say the hour in Malayalam with *maṇi*, as in *oru maṇi*, one o'clock.

Say maṇi for hour, bell and gem, then oru maṇi, and state where Malayalam's and Tamil's dictionaries disagree about it.

18.1 മണി — one word in Malayalam's dictionaries, two in Tamil's

Kannada and Telugu both borrowed Sanskrit's “bell” word for “hour.” Malayalam's story is genuinely murkier — and it's about to disagree with its closest cousin, Tamil, on how this exact word is even structured.

What to know first

മണി (*maṇi*) = “hour, o'clock” — and it also means “bell, gong” and “gem, jewel, pearl.” Here's the honest, slightly untidy part: Malayalam's own dictionary tradition treats **all three of these senses as ONE word**, borrowed from Sanskrit मणि (*maṇi*, “gem, jewel, pearl”) — the same Sanskrit word behind names like *Manipravalam* and the mantra syllable in “*om maṇi padme hum*.” Under this account, “bell/hour” isn't a separate native word at all — it's just another meaning that grew out of the same borrowed “gem” word (a bell-shaped gem or ornament, perhaps, extending to the bell itself, and then to the hour it announces).

Why it's said this way

Here's what makes this genuinely interesting rather than settled: Tamil's closely related cognate மணி is analyzed very differently by Tamil's own reference dictionaries — as **two separate, unrelated words** that happen to be spelled and pronounced identically: a **native Dravidian** “bell, gong” word (which extends to “hour”), and a completely separate Sanskrit loan meaning “gem.” The broader comparative Dravidian dictionary (DEDR) does list Malayalam among the languages sharing that native “bell” word too — but even DEDR flags a possible Sanskrit connection for the whole word-family as unresolved. So: two closest-cousin languages, and even the specialists don't fully agree on whether this is one Sanskrit word wearing three meanings, or a native word and a Sanskrit word that just happen to sound alike.

Grammar Lens: telling the time

ഒരു മണി. — “One o'clock.” (*oru mani*, “one hour/bell”)
 രണ്ട് മണി. — “Two o'clock.” (*raṇṭṭu mani*, “two hour/bell”)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mani” — hour, also “bell,” also “gem” — genuinely debated whether that's one word or two
- “oru mani” — one o'clock
- the honest point — Malayalam's own dictionaries call it one Sanskrit word; Tamil's call the bell/hour sense a separate, native word

Before you move on

According to Malayalam's own dictionary tradition, are “hour,” “bell,” and “gem” one word or two? (**One** — all traced to Sanskrit *maṇi*, “gem.”) How does Tamil's own dictionary tradition treat its cognate word differently? (As **two separate, unrelated homophones** — a native “bell/hour” word and a distinct Sanskrit “gem” loan.) Is this fully settled? (**No** — even the comparative

Dravidian dictionary flags the Sanskrit connection as an open question.)

18.2 ഷ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ാ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ഷ

ഷ — *ṣa*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *ṣ*, it is **ṣa**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ഷ somewhere inside it:

- സന്തോഷം *santōṣam* — joy / pleased to meet you
- ക്ഷമിക്കണം *kṣamikkaṇam* — (you) should forgive / sorry

Writing: ഷ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ഷ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ഷ in the ones that have it

സന്തോഷം · ക്ഷമിക്കണം · നമസ്കാരം

- *Trace it:* **ş** three times, saying *şa* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find **ş** once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — **ş**? What sound does it carry? (*şa*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 19

Asking Someone's Age

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask how old someone is in Malayalam and answer with a dative subject.

Ask *ningalkku ethra vayassuntŭ?* and answer *enikku irupatu vayassuntŭ* – ‘to me twenty age exists’.

19.1 നിങ്ങൾക്ക് എത്ര വയസ്സുണ്ട്? — “to you, how much age exists?”

Same Sanskrit word as Kannada and Telugu — but Malayalam builds a genuinely different sentence around it.

What to know first

വയസ്സ് (*vayass*) = “age” — the same Sanskrit वयस् (*vayas*, “age, vigor,” PIE cousin of Latin *vīs*) behind Kannada’s *vayassu* and Telugu’s *vayasu*.

Grammar Lens: dative subject + “exists”

നിങ്ങൾക്ക് എത്ര വയസ്സുണ്ട്? — “How old are you?”
(formal/plural) — literally “**to you, how much age exists?**” (*ningalkku ethra vayassuntŭ?* — from *ningalkku*, “to you” [dative] + *ethra vayassu*, “how much age” + *untŭ*, “exists.”) എനിക്ക് ഇരുപത് വയസ്സുണ്ട്. — “I am twenty years old.” — literally “**to me twenty age exists.**” (*enikku irupatu vayassuntŭ*.)

This is a real grammatical departure from Kannada and Telugu's plain "your age how-much?" Malayalam puts the **person in the dative case** ("to you," not "your") and adds ഉണ്ടു് (*uṇṭũ*, "exists, there is") — the same existential verb Malayalam uses for ordinary possession and existence sentences generally. So the literal shape is "**to me, twenty years' worth of age exists**" — a dative-subject-plus-existential-verb construction, genuinely different from its two Dravidian cousins even though the age-word itself is identical.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- "vayassu" — age
- "ningalkku ethra vayassuṇṭũ?" — how old are you?
- "enikku irupatu vayassuṇṭũ" — I am twenty, "to me twenty age exists"

Before you move on

Is Malayalam's വയസ്സ് the same Sanskrit word as Kannada's and Telugu's? (**Yes.**) Does Malayalam ask age the same simple way Kannada and Telugu do? (**No** — it uses a **dative** subject, "to you," plus the existential verb ഉണ്ടു്, "exists.") What does *enikku irupatu vayassuṇṭũ* literally mean? ("**To me twenty age exists.**")

Chapter 20

Numbers 11–20 and Weather

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) ✍️ pen (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 2 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can count from eleven to twenty in Malayalam and say what the weather is doing.

Say kālāvastha as ‘the state of time’, split it into kālam and avastha, and add mazha peyyunnu for rain.

20.1 പതിനൊന്ന്, ഇരുപത് — transparent “two-tens,” matching Tamil closely

Malayalam keeps the same “two-tens” idea you’ve now seen across this whole family — and here it’s still fully visible on the surface, almost identically to its closest cousin, Tamil.

What to know first

Malayalam’s teens echo പത്ത് (*pathu*, “ten”) plus each digit. പതിനൊന്ന് (*pathinonnu*) is 11, പന്ത്രണ്ട് (*panthraṇṭṭu*) is 12, and the pattern continues through പത്തൊമ്പത് (*pathompathu*, 19) — the same digit-plus-ten-echo compounding as its Dravidian cousins.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ഇരുപത് (*irupathu*, “twenty”) = ഇരു (*iru*, an older word for “two”) + പത്ത് (*pathu*, “ten”) — still fully visible as “two-tens” today. This matches **Tamil’s own** *irupathu* almost letter-for-letter, both languages having kept this compound transparent — unlike Telugu’s *iravai*,

which most likely continues the same underlying pattern but has worn down past the point of visibly splitting apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pathinonnu, panthraṇṭŭ” — 11, 12
- “iru” — an older word for two, “pathu” — ten
- “irupathu” — twenty, “two-tens,” transparent

Before you move on

How are Malayalam’s teens built? (പത്ത (ten) + a digit, compounded.) What two pieces build ഇരുപത് (twenty)? (ഇരു “two” + പത്ത് “ten” — “two-tens.”) Which other Dravidian language keeps this exact same transparent compound for twenty? (Tamil.)

20.2 കാലാവസ്ഥ — “the state of time,” an echo of Spanish’s tiempo

Remember Spanish’s *tiempo*, one word for both “time” and “weather”? Malayalam reaches the same connection between time and weather — but builds it as a compound instead of reusing one word.

What to know first

കാലാവസ്ഥ (*kālāvastha*) = “weather” — built from:

- കാലം (*kālam*, “time”) — Sanskrit काल (*kāla*), “time,” also the name of the god **Kāla** (an epithet of Śiva/Yama as the personification of time).
- അവസ്ഥ (*avastha*, “state, condition”) — Sanskrit अवस्था (*avasthā*).

So *kālāvastha* literally means “**the state of time**” — a genuinely different construction than Spanish’s *tiempo*, but reaching for the exact same underlying idea: weather as bound up with time. Where Spanish just **reuses** its word for “time” to also mean “weather,” Malayalam **compounds** “time” with “state” to build a brand-new word for the same concept.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

മഴ പെയ്യുന്നു. — “It’s raining.” — literally “**rain is falling.**” (*mazha peyyunnu.*)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*kālāvastha*” — weather, “the state of time”
- “*kālam*” — time, “*avastha*” — state
- “*mazha peyyunnu*” — it’s raining, “rain is falling”

Before you move on

What are the two Sanskrit pieces of കാലാവസ്ഥ, and what does the whole word literally mean? (കാലം, “time,” + അവസ്ഥ, “state” — “**the state of time.**”) What earlier lesson does this echo, and how is the construction different? (Spanish’s *tiempo* — Spanish reuses ONE word for both senses; Malayalam **compounds** two separate words instead.) What word does Malayalam use for “rain”? (മഴ, *mazha.*)

20.3 ഃ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഃ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ദ

ദ — *da*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *d*, it is **da**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ദ somewhere inside it:

- നന്ദി *nandi* — thank you
- ദയവായി *dayavāyi* — please (dayavāyi)

Writing: ദ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ദ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ദ in the ones that have it

നന്ദി · ദയവായി · നമസ്കാരം

- *Trace it:* ദ three times, saying *da* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ദ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ദ? What sound does it carry? (*da*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 21

Dog and Cat

Modes: 🔄 voice (1) ✍ pen (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a dog and a cat in Malayalam.

Say nāya on the shared Dravidian dog-root, then pūcha, which follows Tamil’s cat-word rather than Kannada’s.

21.1 നായ, പൂച്ച — matching Tamil closely on both counts

Malayalam keeps close company with its nearest cousin, Tamil, on both words this time — while still fitting into the honest, more fragmented Dravidian picture for “cat.”

What to know first

നായ (*nāya*, “dog”) continues the same solid, native **Proto-Dravidian** root as Kannada’s ನಾಯಿ (*nāyi*) and Tamil’s own word — no mystery here at all, unlike the tangled dog-words of Spanish, Hindi, and English.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

പൂച്ച (*pūcha*, “cat”) closely matches Tamil’s **everyday** word for cat — a different root from Kannada’s ಬೆಕ್ಕು (*bekku*, related instead to the word for “wildcat”) and Telugu’s పిల్లి (*pilli*, a separate Proto-Dravidian root of its own, most likely the source behind Sanskrit’s *biḍāla* and Hindi’s *billī*). So “cat” genuinely splits three ways across just these

four Dravidian languages, even though “dog” mostly agrees.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nāya” — dog, same solid root as Kannada and Tamil
- “pūcha” — cat, matching Tamil’s everyday word closely

Before you move on

Does നായ share Kannada’s *nāyi* root? (**Yes** — the same solid, native Proto-Dravidian root.) Does പൂച്ച match Kannada’s *bekku* or Tamil’s everyday cat-word? (**Tamil’s** — Kannada’s *bekku* and Telugu’s *pilli* both come from different roots entirely.)

21.2 സ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഓ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: സ

സ — *sa*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *s*, it is **sa**.

You already say these, and every one of them has സ somewhere inside it:

- നമസ്കാരം *namaskāram* — hello / greetings (namaskāram — “a making of a bow”)
- സന്തോഷം *santōṣam* — joy / pleased to meet you
- സുഖം *sukham* — well-being — and the reply “സുഖമാണ്”
- സാരമില്ല *sāramilla* — it doesn’t matter / no problem / you’re welcome

Writing: സ — copy what you see

Put your pen on സ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find സ in the ones that have it

നമസ്കാരം · സന്തോഷം · നന്ദി

- *Trace it:* സ three times, saying *sa* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find സ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — സ? What sound does it carry? (*sa*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 22

Green and Yellow

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can name green and yellow in Malayalam and say why the two come from unrelated roots.

Say paccha beside Tamil paccai and mañña beside mañcal, and show they are not doublets of each other.

22.1 പച്ച, മഞ്ഞ — matching Tamil twice over, by two different routes

Telugu’s green and yellow turned out to be one word wearing two faces. Malayalam’s green and yellow are a different story again — two completely separate native words, each one matching Tamil closely, just not matching *each other*.

What to know first

പച്ച (paccha, “green”) comes from **Proto-Dravidian** **pac-* — matching Tamil’s பச்சை (paccai) almost exactly, and the same root already seen in Kannada’s *hasiru* and Telugu’s *pacca*. No surprises here; this is the familiar family from the last two lessons.

Why it’s said this way

മഞ്ഞ (mañña, “yellow”) and മഞ്ഞൾ (maññal, “turmeric”) are a native **doublet pair**. This is a **completely different** Dravidian root from *pac-*, matching Tamil’s own turmeric/yellow pair, மஞ்சள்

(*mañcal*), closely. So here’s the honest shape of this arc so far: Kannada split green and yellow into two unrelated families (native vs. Sanskrit loan); Telugu kept them as doublets of the **same** native root; and Malayalam keeps them as **two separate** native Dravidian roots, each one independently matching its Tamil counterpart. No single pattern holds across all three languages — the honest answer is that each solved “green vs. yellow” its own way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “പച്ച” — green, matching Tamil *paccai*
- “മഞ്ഞ” — yellow, matching Tamil *mañcal*, a separate root entirely
- the contrast — *paccha* and *mañña* are NOT doublets of each other, unlike Telugu’s *pacca/pasupu*

Before you move on

Does മഞ്ഞ (*mañña*, “yellow”) share a root with പച്ച (*paccha*, “green”)? (**No** — they are two separate native Dravidian roots.) What Tamil word does മഞ്ഞ closely match? (மஞ்சள், *mañcal*, “turmeric/yellow.”) Across Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam, is there one single pattern for how green and yellow relate? (**No** — Kannada split them into native vs. Sanskrit-loan; Telugu made them doublets of one root; Malayalam keeps them as two separate native roots.)

Chapter 23

Day

Modes: ⇌ voice (2) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use divasam for an everyday day in Malayalam and still recognise native nāl where it survives.

Find nāl alive inside nāle, oru nāl and pirannāl, and answer whether Sanskrit divasam erased it.

23.1 ദിവസം (divasam) — the everyday Sanskrit day-word

You already met Malayalam’s native word for “day” back in Chapter 4 — hiding inside “tomorrow.” This lesson gives it, and its Sanskrit rival, their own honest reckoning.

What to know first

ദിവസം (divasam) — “day” — is Malayalam’s common, everyday word for counting a day (as in മൂന്ന് ദിവസം, *mūnnu divasam*, “three days”). It’s a Sanskrit **tatsama**, borrowed whole from दिवस (*divasa*), which itself traces to **Proto-Indo-European** **dyew-* (“to shine”), via the Sanskrit root दिव् (*div*). That’s the **same ultimate PIE root** behind Hindi/Kannada’s दिन/ದಿನ (*dina*) and Latin’s own *diēs* — but be careful here: *divasa* and *dina* are **two different Sanskrit formations** off that shared root (one built with an *-asa* suffix, one with Sanskrit’s own *-nó-* formation), not the same word wearing two scripts. Same root, different branch — the *din/diēs* pattern, replaying itself one level deeper, inside Sanskrit.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Malayalam also has ദിനം (**dinam**) — the **exact same** Sanskrit tatsama word as Kannada’s plain, everyday *dina*. But in Malayalam, **dinam** is the more **literary, formal** alternate (think ജന്മദിനം, *janmadinam*, “birthday,” the modern calque-style term) — **divasam** does the everyday counting work instead.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “divasam” — “day,” the everyday counting word
- “dinam” — the same Sanskrit word as Kannada’s *dina*, but formal here

Before you move on

What PIE root does ദിവസം ultimately share with Hindi/Kannada’s *dina* and Latin’s *diēs*? (**dyew-*, “to shine” — though *divasa* and *dina* are different Sanskrit formations off it, not the same word.) Which is the everyday counting word? (**divasam**.) Which is more literary or formal? (**dinam**.)

23.2 നാൾ — the native day-word that narrowed its job

ദിവസം counts ordinary days and ദിനം writes formally. But Malayalam’s native day-word never disappeared—you met it long ago inside “tomorrow.”

What to know first

നാൾ (*nāl*) means “day” and descends from Proto-Dravidian **nāl*, cognate with Tamil நாள் and Kannada ನಾಳ. Chapter 4 already gave you നാളെ (*nāle*, “tomorrow”), with the native day-word still visible inside.

The Sanskrit loan ദിവസം took over ordinary counting, but നാൾ narrowed rather than vanished. ഒരു നാൾ (*oru nāl*, “one day”) remains natural in storytelling, and the word stays productive in പിറന്നാൾ (*pirannāl*),

“birthday,” literally “day of birth.” That traditional compound stands beside the newer Sanskrit-style ജന്മദിനം (*janmadīnam*).

Three words therefore carry three honest jobs: *divasam* counts, *dinam* is formal, and native *nāl* tells stories and marks birthdays. This echoes Kannada’s native *hagalu*: borrowing narrowed a native word’s domain without erasing it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nāle* — tomorrow, with *nāl* inside
- *oru nāl* — one day, narrative register
- *pirannāl* — birthday, day of birth

Before you move on

Has Sanskrit **divasam** erased native നാൾ? (No.) Where does *nāl* live now? (Inside tomorrow, in narrative “one day,” and in the living compound for birthday.)

Chapter 24

Night

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say night in Malayalam with *rāthri* and tell literary *iravū* apart from everyday *iruḷ*, ‘darkness’.

Sort iravū from iruḷ by the job each one still does in the modern language.

24.1 രാത്രി (rāthri) — night, already hiding inside midnight

Last lesson’s *divasam* had three words doing three honest jobs. This word’s family is smaller, but the split is just as real — and one piece of it, you’ve technically already heard.

What to know first

രാത്രി (rāthri) — “night” — is a Sanskrit **tatsama**. You’ve likely already met a piece of it: പാതിരാ (pāthirā, “midnight,” Chapter 17) is built from പാതി (pāthi, “half”) fused with what’s most plausibly a **shortened form** of this very word — “rā” standing in for the whole of *rāthri* (Chapter 17 itself didn’t spell out which word was being shortened, but the parallel Tamil compound, *pāti-y-irāttiri*, points the same way). This lesson gives it its own, full standing.

Why it's said this way

Here's the honest echo across the family: just like Hindi's own रात (*raat*, ultimately from the same Sanskrit रात्रि), Malayalam's *rāthri* traces to **Proto-Indo-European** **h₁reh₁-* (“to rest”) — a **completely different** PIE root from Latin's *nox* (**nók^wts*). Two Indo-European languages, two words for “night,” that **look** like they might be old cousins — but genuinely **aren't**. Same false-cognate story, now confirmed across a second Indo-Aryan-rooted borrowing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “rāthri” — “night,” already hiding, shortened, inside pāthirā
- the honest PIE echo — *h₁reh₁-*, “to rest,” like Hindi's *raat*, *NOT* related to Latin's *nox*

Before you move on

Where did you already, technically, meet a piece of രാത്രി before this lesson? (Shortened to “rā” inside പാതിരാ, *pāthirā*, “midnight,” Chapter 17.) Does *rāthri*'s PIE root match Latin *nox*'s? (No — **h₁reh₁-* “to rest,” a completely different root, the same false-cognate pattern already seen with Hindi's *raat*.)

24.2 ഇരവ് / ഇരുൾ — two native words, two jobs

രാത്രി is the ordinary Sanskrit night-word. Malayalam also kept two native Dravidian words, but they do not compete with it in the same way.

What to know first

- ഇരവ് (*iravū*) is cognate with Tamil இரவு (*iravu*) and is traced by one source to Proto-Dravidian **cira*, “darkness.” It survives mainly as a **literary or classical-register** synonym for “night.” Poetry is a more likely home for it than everyday conversation.

- ഇരുൾ (*irul*) descends from Proto-Dravidian **cirVl* and belongs to the pan-Dravidian family Kannada ಇರುಳು, Tamil இருள், and Telugu ఇరులు. It remains current in modern Malayalam—a 2021 film is titled *Irul*—but its ordinary sense is **darkness**, not night as a time period.

This is not one native night-word simply pushed into archaism. It is two native words carrying different pieces of രാത്രി's semantic space: one formal and poetic, the other common but narrower.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *iravũ* — literary night
- *irul* — current darkness
- related ideas, different modern jobs

Before you move on

Are ഇരവ് and ഇരുൾ interchangeable everyday words for night? (No.) Which is literary “night”? (*iravũ*.) Which is current “darkness”? (*irul*.)

Chapter 25

Good Night

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) ✍️ pen (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can wish someone good night in Malayalam with śubha rāthri.

Say śubha rāthri as 'auspicious night', and mark the English code-switching claim as thinly sourced and not unique to Malayalam.

25.1 ശുഭ രാത്രി (śubha rāthri) — “good night,” and a pattern seen before

You already have *rāthri*. One more Sanskrit word, shared with Hindi, Kannada, and Telugu, completes Malayalam’s “good night” — and this lesson’s honest twist is one you’ve technically seen before, just in a different language.

What to know first

ശുഭ രാത്രി (śubha rāthri) — “good night” — literally “auspicious night.” Both pieces are Sanskrit **tatsama**: രാത്രി (*rāthri*, “night,” already met last lesson) plus ശുഭ (*śubha*, “auspicious,” from root śubh, “to be beautiful,” ultimately PIE **kewbʰ-* — the same word, the same root, already verified for the Hindi, Kannada, and Telugu siblings of this exact arc).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Here’s the honest twist, hedged deliberately: some sources describe modern Malayalam speakers, especially in casual settings, **code-switching to English** “good night” rather than saying ശുഭ രാത്രി aloud — treating it more as the standard, correct-but-formal translation than an everyday spoken phrase. But this lesson isn’t presenting that as a fresh Malayalam discovery. The **exact same claim**, sourced from similarly thin blogs and forum posts, is also made for **Telugu**, and there too it is genuinely **unclear** whether the pattern is Telugu-specific or something broader. Seeing the same claim turn up again for Malayalam **strengthens the suspicion that this is a broader South Asian pattern** (or simply a sourcing artifact — the languages that happen to get commented on in casual sources), not a language-specific trait worth treating as a genuine discovery each time. Either way, *śubha rāthri* itself remains perfectly correct, understood Malayalam.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubha rāthri” — “good night,” literally “auspicious night”
- śubha’s own root — śubh, “to be beautiful” → “auspicious” — the same root already met for Hindi, Kannada, and Telugu
- the honest twist — this code-switching claim isn’t uniquely Malayalam’s; the same weakly-sourced claim already appeared for Telugu

Before you move on

What does ശുഭ രാത്രി literally mean? (“**Auspicious night.**”) Is the “Malayalam speakers code-switch to English instead” claim a fresh discovery in this lesson? (**No** — the identical claim, similarly thinly sourced, is also made about **Telugu**, suggesting a broader pattern or a sourcing artifact, not a Malayalam-specific fact.) Does this affect whether *śubha rāthri* itself is correct? (**No** — it’s perfectly correct and understood Malayalam, whatever its actual spoken frequency.)

25.2 ੜ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ੜ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has been sitting in front of you on pages you have already read.

Script you'll notice: ੜ

ੜ — *bha*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *bh*, it is **bha**.

Its sound is a *b* with a puff of breath after it — **bha**, not *ba*. Two words already in your hands are built on it, and both come from the Sanskrit layer, which is the pattern this letter keeps.

- ੜੁਬ ੜ *śubha* — good, auspicious — the first half of the good-night wish on the page before this one
- ੜੁਮ ੜ *kumbham* — the month, met with the calendar

Say each one and listen for the breath: *śu-bha*, *kum-bham*.

Writing: ੜ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ੜ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look*: at these words, and find ੜ in the ones that have it

ੜੁਬ · ੜੁਮ · ੜ

- *Trace it*: ੜ three times, saying *bha* as you finish each one

- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find **ᄃ** once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — **ᄃ**? What sound does it carry? (*bha.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 26

Morning

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say morning in Malayalam with *rāvile* and hear the night-word hidden inside it.

*Say *rāvile*, pull *rāvũ* ‘night’ out of it, and place *prabhātami* beside it as the Sanskrit alternative.*

26.1 രാവിലെ (*rāvile*) — “morning,” built from “night”

Kannada’s morning word means “the shining.” Telugu’s means “rise.” Malayalam’s most common morning word means something stranger on its face: night.

What to know first

രാവിലെ (*rāvile*) — “morning” — is, per Wiktionary, a compound: രാവ് (*rāvũ*) plus the suffixes **-il** and **-e**. Here’s the honest surprise: രാവ് shares its root — not its exact form — with the word already met in Chapter 24, ഇരവ് (*iravũ*), there a **literary-register synonym for “night”** itself. Wiktionary confirms both as cognates, both tracing to **Proto-Dravidian** **cira* (“darkness”) — a cognate doublet within Malayalam, not literally one word in two spellings. So Malayalam’s everyday word for “morning” is, transparently, built from **night** plus locative-ish suffixes — not from light, dawn, or rising, the strategies Kannada’s ಬೆಳಗ್ಗೆ (“the shining”) and Telugu’s ఉదయം (Sanskrit “rise”) both reach for instead.

Why it's said this way

No source spells out **why** “at/in the night” came to mean “morning” specifically — it’s a plausible semantic path (perhaps “the night just ending,” the pre-dawn hours) rather than one directly documented step by step. Treat the **morphological composition** as confirmed (Wiktionary is explicit about the *rāvũ+il+e* breakdown); treat the **semantic mechanism** as a reasonable but unconfirmed inference, not a settled fact.

Why it's said this way

Malayalam keeps two other words for “morning” too. പ്രഭാതം (*prabhātaṁ*) is a Sanskrit **tatsama** sharing its root — **prabhāta**, “to shine, become bright” — with Telugu’s own సుప్రభాతం (*suprabhātaṁ*, Telugu’s own morning greeting) — a genuine cross-language echo. പുലർച്ച (*pularcca*) is native Dravidian, but be honest about its etymology: one database entry links it to a root meaning “to subsist, live,” which may or may not be the same root behind its “dawn” sense — treat that specific connection as unconfirmed, not settled.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*rāvile*” — “morning,” built from *rāvũ* (“night”) + locative suffixes
- the honest surprise — a cognate doublet of the night-word already met as *iravũ* (Chapter 24), same root, now doing morning’s job
- *prabhātaṁ* — same Sanskrit root as Telugu’s *suprabhātaṁ*

Before you move on

What is രാവിലെ literally built from? (രാവ് — “night” — plus locative suffixes *-il/-e*; a cognate doublet, same root, as ഇരവ് met in Chapter 24 — not literally the same word.) Is the exact reason “night” came to mean “morning” fully documented? (**No** — the compound itself is confirmed, but the semantic shift is a plausible, unconfirmed inference.) What root does പ്രഭാതം share with Telugu’s సుప్రభాతం? (**prabhāta** — the same root behind Telugu’s సుప్రభాతం.)

Chapter 27

Evening

Modes: ⇨ voice (1) ⇨ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say evening in Malayalam with vaikunnērami, ‘latening time’.

Say vaikunnērami, trace it to vaikuka ‘to get late’, and flag that sources disagree on whether it also covers afternoon.

27.1 വൈകുന്നേരം (vaikunnērami) — “evening,” built from a verb meaning “to get late”

Telugu reached for Sanskrit to name the evening. Malayalam’s most common word takes a completely different route — an everyday verb, not a borrowed noun.

What to know first

വൈകുന്നേരം (vaikunnērami) — “evening” — is, per Wiktionary, a compound: വൈക് (vaikū) + -ഉം (-um) + നേരം (nērami, “time”), literally “latening time.” നേരം is itself confirmed native **Proto-Dravidian** (cognate Tamil நேரம்), not a Sanskrit borrowing — so unlike Telugu’s Sanskrit సాయంత్రం, this whole compound is native Dravidian, start to finish. The വൈക് root plausibly connects to an everyday Malayalam verb, വൈകുക (vaikuka), confirmed “to get late” — though be honest that this specific link is the author’s own reasonable inference, not something Wiktionary’s compound entry states outright.

Why it's said this way

Here's a real tension, not smoothed over: Wiktionary's own entry lists **both** “afternoon” **and** “evening” as senses of this single word. But two independently-fetched phrasebook sources (ling-app.com, talkpal.ai) draw a cleaner line — **evening** is വൈകുന്നേരം, while **afternoon** gets its own, separate compound built on ഉച്ച (already met, Chapter 17, “noon”) plus കഴിഞ്ഞ് (*kazhinju*, “passed, gone by”). This project's discipline is to flag genuine disagreement rather than quietly pick whichever source is more convenient — so treat the afternoon/evening boundary here as **genuinely blurry** in the dictionary sense, even though the two everyday phrasebook sources agree on a cleaner practical split.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vaikunnēraṇi” — “evening,” literally “latening time”
- the everyday verb root — vaikuka, “to get late”
- the honest tension — Wiktionary blurs afternoon/evening; phrasebooks split them cleanly

Before you move on

What does വൈകുന്നേരം literally mean, and what verb is it plausibly built from? (“**Latening time**” — from വൈകുക, “to get late.”) Do all sources agree on where “afternoon” ends and “evening” begins for this word? (**No** — Wiktionary lists it as covering both senses; phrasebook sources instead draw a clean line, treating afternoon as a separate compound.) Is വൈകുന്നേരം a Sanskrit borrowing, like Telugu's సాయంత్రം? (**No** — it's a native Dravidian compound, built from an everyday verb and a native “time” word, നേരം.)

Chapter 28

Afternoon

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say afternoon in Malayalam as uchakaliññ – literally ‘noon having passed’.

Build uchakaliññ from ucha plus kaliyuka, and contrast it with Telugu, which widened its noon-word instead.

28.1 ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ് (uchakaliññ) — “noon, having passed”

Telugu let its noon-word quietly widen to also mean “afternoon.” Malayalam solves the same problem with a completely different strategy: it builds a new phrase instead.

What to know first

ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ് (uchakaliññ) — “afternoon” — is a transparent **two-word phrase**, not a single dictionary headword (no Wiktionary entry exists for the compound as a whole). It’s built from ഉച്ച (already met, Chapter 17, “noon”) plus കഴിഞ്ഞ്, the **past converb form** of കഴിയുക (*kaliyuka*), itself Wiktionary-confirmed **Proto-Dravidian** **kazi* (“to be over, spent, finished”). Be honest about the citation: Wiktionary’s own conjugation line shows only the finite past tense, കഴിഞ്ഞു (*kaliññu*) — not this converb form directly. The converb is the grammatically correct choice for chaining into a compound like this one, but treat the exact written form as

a reasonable grammatical inference, not a directly Wiktionary-sourced citation. Put together: “**noon having passed**” — afternoon is, quite literally, the time after noon is done.

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the honest structural contrast: Telugu’s own afternoon word (మధ్యాహ్నం) is the exact **same word** as its “noon,” simply **widened** to also cover “afternoon” — one word, stretched. Malayalam does something structurally different: ഉച്ച itself stays put, meaning only “noon,” and a **second word** — കഴിഞ്ഞ, “passed” — gets bolted on to build a new phrase for “afternoon.” Same problem (naming the stretch of time after noon), two genuinely different solutions: semantic widening in Telugu, compositional phrase-building in Malayalam.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “uchakaliññ” — “afternoon,” literally “noon having passed”
- the verb behind it — kalīyuka, “to be over, spent” — Proto-Dravidian *kazī*
- the honest contrast — Telugu widens the same noon-word; Malayalam builds a new phrase on top of it

Before you move on

What does ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ literally mean? (“**Noon having passed**” — ഉച്ച, “noon,” plus the past tense of കഴിയുക, “to be over, spent.”) Is ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ a single dictionary word, like ഉച്ച itself? (No — it’s a transparent two-word phrase; no Wiktionary entry exists for the compound as a whole.) How does Malayalam’s strategy for naming “afternoon” differ from Telugu’s? (**Telugu widens its existing noon-word’s meaning; Malayalam instead builds a new phrase, keeping the noon-word unchanged.**)

Chapter 29

Good Morning

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone in the morning in Malayalam with suprabhātani.

Say suprabhātani, split su- from prabhātani, and show it is NOT built on śubha the way good night is.

29.1 സുപ്രഭാതം (suprabhātani) — Malayalam’s real “good morning,” a familiar word wearing a new hat

You might expect Malayalam’s “good morning” to pair ML-C25’s “auspicious” word with ML-C26’s morning word. It doesn’t — Malayalam reaches for a completely different Sanskrit “good,” and for a word you’ve technically already half-met.

What to know first

സുപ്രഭാതം (suprabhātani) — “good morning” — is Malayalam’s actual, most common morning greeting: two independently-fetched sources confirm it: one states it’s used in **both formal and informal** contexts, the second separately calls it “the most general greeting” for good morning — genuine corroboration, not a single source’s claim taken on faith. Here’s the honest surprise: it is **not** built on ശുഭ (ML-C25’s “auspicious,” the word behind Malayalam’s own “good night”) at all. Instead, it’s built from the Sanskrit **prefix su-** (“good”) fused directly onto പ്രഭാതം — already met,

Chapter 26, as an alternative Malayalam word for “morning.” Two genuinely different Sanskrit “good” morphemes: ശുഭ is a standalone adjective; **su-** here is a bound prefix that only ever attaches to another word.

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the honest cross-language twist: സുപ്രഭാതం is the **exact same Sanskrit tatsama word** as Telugu’s own సుప్రభాతం — same **su-** prefix, same ప్రభాత/ *prabhāta* root. But the two languages hand it **opposite jobs**. In Malayalam, it’s the **primary**, most commonly used morning greeting. In Telugu, it’s only a **secondary** alternative — Telugu’s primary greeting, శుభోదయం, is built on a completely different Sanskrit root (*udaya*, “rise,” not *prabhāta*). Same borrowed word, opposite roles across two closely related languages.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “suprabhātam” — “good morning,” su- (“good”) + prabhāta (“shine, dawn,” ML-C26)
- the honest surprise — NOT built on śubha; a different Sanskrit “good” morpheme entirely
- the cross-language inversion — Malayalam’s primary greeting is Telugu’s secondary alternative

Before you move on

Is സുപ്രഭാതం built on ശുഭ, ML-C25’s “auspicious” word? (**No** — it’s built on the Sanskrit prefix su-, a different “good” morpheme, fused onto പ്രഭാതం, ML-C26’s alternative morning word.) Is സുപ്രഭാതం the primary morning greeting in both Malayalam and Telugu? (**No** — it’s PRIMARY in Malayalam but only a SECONDARY alternative in Telugu, where శుభోదయం — built on a different root — is primary.) Is the “used in both formal and informal contexts” claim as shaky as Telugu’s own morning-greeting claim? (**No** — it’s confirmed by TWO independently-fetched sources, a genuinely stronger evidentiary footing than resting on just one.)

Chapter 30

Good Evening

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone in the evening in Malayalam with śubha sāyāhnam.

Say śubha sāyāhnam, note it is built on the poetic sāyāhnam rather than native vaikunnēram, and follow sāya back to PIE.

30.1 ശുഭ സായാഹ്നം (śubha sāyāhnam) — “good evening,” a different evening-word than expected

You might expect this greeting to pair śubha with the evening-word you already know. It doesn’t — Malayalam reaches for a completely different word instead, one with a poetic edge.

What to know first

ശുഭ സായാഹ്നം (śubha sāyāhnam) — “good evening” — is confirmed real by a directly-fetched source, used “**from late afternoon until sunset.**” It’s built from ശുഭ (ML-C25, “auspicious”) plus സായാഹ്നം (*sāyāhnam*, “evening, eventide”). Here’s the honest surprise: this is **not** built on വൈകുണ്ഠം, the native word already met in Chapter 27, at all. സായാഹ്നം is a **completely separate** word — a Sanskrit **tatsama**, which Wiktionary’s own part-of-speech label calls “**poetic.**” That’s a real, independently-checkable signal (not an unverifiable blog claim) that this

particular greeting likely leans formal or literary, even though the phrase itself is confirmed correct and genuinely used.

Why it's said this way

സായാഹ്നം is, per a Sanskrit dictionary, a compound of साय (“end”) plus अह्न (“day”) — the same “-ahna” day-part suffix already met in words like *madhyāhna* and *aparāhna*. Following the etymology one hop further, Wiktionary’s own साय entry explicitly confirms this root traces to **Proto-Indo-European** **seh₁-* (“long, lasting”), directly naming सायम् (*sāyam* — Telugu’s own root) and **Latin** *sērus* as cognates. So this is a genuinely, properly-verified shared ancestor with Telugu’s సాయంత్రం — the same striking PIE chain to Latin *sērus*, French *soir*, and Italian *sera* — not merely a plausible guess, but a confirmed cognate, reached by chaining through two Wiktionary pages rather than stopping at the first.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubha sāyāhnaṁ” — “good evening,” confirmed real, used from late afternoon until sunset
- the honest surprise — NOT built on vaikunnēraṁ; a separate, Wiktionary-labeled “poetic” Sanskrit word instead
- the confirmed echo — sāyāhnaṁ’s साय root genuinely shares the PIE *seh₁-*/*Latin sērus* ancestry behind Telugu’s సాయంత్రం

Before you move on

Is ശുഭ സായാഹ്നം built on വൈകുണ്ഠനരം, ML-C27’s native evening word? (No — സായാഹ്നം is a completely separate Sanskrit tatsama.) What does Wiktionary’s own part-of-speech label for സായാഹ്നം suggest about its register? (“Poetic” — a real, checkable signal it likely skews formal or literary.) Is it confirmed that സായാഹ്നം shares that spectacular PIE root with Telugu’s సాయంత్రం? (Yes — Wiktionary’s separate साय entry directly confirms the same PIE *seh₁-* ancestry, naming *sāyam* and *Latin sērus* as cognates — a genuinely verified shared root, reached by

following the etymology one hop further.)

Chapter 31

Good Afternoon

Modes:  voice (1)  eyes (1)  pen (1)  Hands-free start: first 1 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone in the afternoon in Malayalam with śubha madhyāhnam, and say how it differs from the everyday afternoon word.

Line up the three sister languages’ everyday afternoon words and show where all three converge on śubha + madhyāhna.

31.1 ശുഭ മധ്യാഹ്നം (śubha madhyāhnam) — formal good afternoon

Morning broke the pattern entirely. Evening kept the pattern but swapped in an unexpected word. This final greeting brings a different kind of surprise: a word you haven’t met, that turns out to connect Malayalam right back to Kannada and Telugu.

What to know first

ശുഭ മധ്യാഹ്നം (śubha madhyāhnam) — “good afternoon” — is confirmed, by a directly-fetched source, as a genuinely **formal** greeting: “**mainly used in official or ceremonial settings**” and “**not as commonly used in daily conversation.**” (A suspiciously precise “fewer than 1%” statistic turned up in an initial search summary for this claim — but it couldn’t be traced to either page actually fetched, so it’s deliberately left out here as an apparent confabulation; the real, hedged qualitative finding

stands on its own.) It’s built from ശുഭ (ML-C25) plus മധ്യാഹ്നം (*madhyāhnam*, “noon”) — which Wiktionary confirms is a direct **synonym** of ML-C17’s ഉച്ച. Here’s the honest surprise: Malayalam had this “middle”-based noon-word all along — ML-C17 simply didn’t highlight it, teaching ഉച്ച (“peak, high”) instead. And this greeting is **not** built on ML-C28’s ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ് compound (the actual TIME-AFTERNOON phrase already taught) at all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “śubha madhyāhnam” — “good afternoon,” a formal, ceremonial-register greeting
- the honest surprise — madhyāhnam is a genuine synonym of ucca, Malayalam’s own “noon” word, just not the one taught first

Before you move on

Is ശുഭ മധ്യാഹ്നം built on ML-C28’s ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ്? (No — it’s built on മധ്യാഹ്നം, a genuine Wiktionary-confirmed synonym of ML-C17’s ഉച്ച, not the TIME-AFTERNOON compound.) Is the “fewer than 1% use this” statistic something this lesson confirms? (No — it couldn’t be traced to any directly-fetched source and is deliberately excluded; only the hedged “formal, not common in daily conversation” finding is asserted.)

31.2 ഉ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ങ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only. It has not been on a page yet: it arrives with the word on the next one.

Script you’ll notice: ഉ

ഉ — *ū*.

It is an **independent vowel** — the shape this vowel takes when a word *begins* with it, rather than the sign it becomes inside a word.

You already read its short twin. ഉ is *u*; ഉൗ is the same vowel held longer, *ū*, and the shape says so — the short one grows a tail.

- ഉ *u* — the short one, read since the farewell chapter
- ഉൗ *ū* — a meal: the long one, and the word that will put this letter to work

Length is the whole difference, in the sound and on the page.

Writing: ഉൗ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ഉൗ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ഉൗ in the ones that have it

ഉൗൺ · ഉ · ഉൗ

- *Trace it:* ഉൗ three times, saying *ū* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ഉൗ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ഉൗ? What sound does it carry? (*ū*.)
Which of the two is longer — ഉ or ഉൗ? (ഉൗ.)

31.3 One greeting, three afternoon strategies

Malayalam's formal greeting uses ശുഭ + മധ്യാഹ്നം. Kannada and Telugu land on the same phrase—but their ordinary afternoon words took three different routes.

What to know first

language	formal afternoon greeting
Malayalam	ശുഭ മധ്യാഹ്നം
Kannada	ಶುಭ ಮಧ್ಯಾಹ್ನ
Telugu	శుభ మధ్యాహ్నం

All three share the Sanskrit *śubha* + *madhyāhna* structure. That shared greeting is striking because the languages’ everyday time words diverge:

- **Telugu** widened its *madhya*-based noon-word so the same word also covers afternoon.
- **Kannada** built a separate Sanskrit tatsama, ಅಪರಾಹ್ನ (*aparāhna*, *apara* + *ahna*), rather than widening *madhyāhna*.
- **Malayalam** built ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ, the unrelated *ucca* “noon” plus “having passed.”

So there are three genuinely different everyday strategies, not a simple two-versus-one split. At the formal greeting layer, all three converge on the same borrowed building blocks.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the shared greeting structure — *śubha* + *madhyāhna*
- Telugu — widening
- Kannada — a separate *aparāhna* word
- Malayalam — “noon having passed”

Script check — the letters of this chapter

Cover the romanizations. Find each letter once in the Malayalam above, then say the word it sits in.

- ഉൗൺ — ഉൗ *ū*, the long twin of ഉ
- *Look*: at each letter, then find it in the word beside it

Before you move on

Do the three languages share one ordinary afternoon-word strategy?
(**No.**) Where do they converge? (**In the formal greeting, all
using śubha + madhyāhna.**)

Chapter 32

The Core Verbs

Modes: ⇄ voice (6) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can build a Malayalam verb as stem plus one ending with no person marking at all, swap that ending for past, future or mood, and say why ‘I know Malayalam’ puts me in the dative instead of the subject slot.

Say എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം, name the two slots that built *irikkunnu*, *pōkunnu* and *kāṇunnu*, and explain why this verb moves the knower out of the subject slot altogether.

32.1 ഉണ്ട് (uṇṭŭ) — “there is,” and the machine inside every Malayalam verb

Thirty-one chapters of words. Now the engine room. English makes one verb, “to be,” do three jobs. Malayalam uses three words.

What to know first

ഉണ്ട് — *uṇṭŭ* — there is, there are; [someone] has

ഇരിക്കുക — *irikkuka* — to be somewhere, to stay, to sit

Chapter 2 gave you ആണ് (*āṇŭ*), the “is” that links two nouns: *enre pēru Arun āṇŭ*, “my name is Arun.” ഉണ്ട് does a different job — **existing** and **having**: *enikku oru sahōdaran uṇṭŭ*, “to-me one brother there-is,” which

is how Malayalam says “I have a brother.” ഇരിക്കുക is being in a **place**: *ñān vīṭṭil irikkunnu*, “I am at home.”

Identity, existence, location — and none stands in for another.

The letters in this word

ഉ (the standing vowel *u*) + ണ് + ൾ → ഉണ്ട്. Both consonants are retroflex — tongue curled back — and both have had their vowel stripped, so the word trails off on a half-swallowed *ũ*: *uṇ-ṭũ*. ഇരിക്കുക runs *i-rik-ku-ka*, with the doubled ക held long.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Both are native Dravidian, from the oldest layer, and the family split them between its daughters: **Tamil** kept இரு (*iru*), “be, stay”; **Kannada** kept the same word, ಇರು (*iru*); **Telugu** kept the other one, ఉండు (*undu*). Malayalam kept **both**, and gave each a job.

Grammar Lens: two pieces, where Tamil has three

English changes a verb with words **around** it: *I am*, *I was*, *I will be*. Malayalam glues a piece **onto the end**:

ഇരിക്ക് + ഉന്നു → ഇരിക്കുന്നു

irikk- (stay) + *-unnu* (happening now) → *irikkunnu*

Stem, then tense. Two slots, and that is the whole machine. Tamil glues on a **third** piece naming who acts: *iru* + *-kkir-* + *-ēn* (I) → *irukkirēn*, “I am,” against *irukkirān*, “he is.” Malayalam threw that slot away. *Ñān irikkunnu*, *nā irikkunnu*, *avan irikkunnu* — the verb never moves. Chapter 5 showed this with one verb; it holds for **every** Malayalam verb, and for no sister.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three jobs — “āṇũ” is, “uṇṭũ” there-is, “irikkuka” be somewhere
- “enikku oru sahōdaran uṇṭũ” — I have a brother

- the two pieces — “irikk ... unnu”
- one verb, three people — “ñān, nī, avan ... irikkunnu”

Before you move on

Which be-word does Malayalam use for having something? (ഉണ്ട്, *uṇṭũ*.) What are the two pieces of *irikkunnu*? (**Stem and tense**; there is no third piece.) How does the verb change between “I stay” and “he stays”? (**It does not.**) Next: the piece that carries time.

32.2 പോകുക (pōkuka) — “to go,” and the piece that carries time

Stem, then tense. Hold the stem still and swap the second piece. That is the whole of Malayalam tense, and it is a shorter list than you expect.

What to know first

പോകുക — *pōkuka* — to go

Chapter 4 met this verb in passing, on the way to a farewell. Here it goes to work. The dictionary form is the stem പോക്- (*pōk-*) plus -ഉക (-*uka*), the ending that means “to ____.”

when	Malayalam	the ending
now	<i>pōkunnu</i>	<i>-unnu</i>
already	<i>pōyi</i>	<i>-i</i>
not yet	<i>pōkum</i>	<i>-um</i>

You have said the middle one already: the goodbye പോയി വരാം (*pōyi varām*) opens with *pōyi*, “having gone.”

The letters in this word

പോ (*pa* wearing the long-*ō* sign) + കു (*ku*) + ക (*ka*) → പോകുക.
The *ō* is long and round; let it run.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

പോ- is native Dravidian, so old it has barely moved: Tamil போ (pō), Telugu పోవు (pōvu), the same verb.

Kannada's everyday word is ಹೋಗು (hōgu), and that *h* is no different root. Old Dravidian *p*- softened to *h*- in Kannada — “ten” is Malayalam പത്തു (pattū) against Kannada ಹತ್ತು (hattu), the very same swap.

Grammar Lens: three forms are the whole conjugation

In most languages a tense is a **list**. English has *I go / he goes*. Tamil, Malayalam's closest sister, needs an ending for every person: *pōgīrēṇ* (“I go”), *pōgīrāy* (“you go”), *pōgīrāṇ* (“he goes”), *pōgīrōm* (“we go”). Malayalam's present tense is one word long. *Ñān pōkunnu*, *nī pōkunnu*, *avan pōkunnu*, *avar pōkunnu* — I, you, he, they, and *pōkunnu* every time. So those three forms are not the start of a conjugation. **They are the whole of it.**

That is the bargain. Nothing to memorise on the verb — and the pronoun in front can never be dropped, since it is now the only thing telling you who went.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pōkuka” — to go
- the three times — “pōkunnu ... pōyi ... pōkunṇi”
- the pair that shares one sound-law — “pattū ... hattu”, “pō ... hōgu”
- four people, one verb — “ñān, nī, avan, avar ... pōkunnu”

Before you move on

Say “I will go.” (*Ñān pōkunṇi*.) How many words are in this verb's whole Malayalam present tense? (**One** — *pōkunnu*, for every person.) Is Kannada's *hōgu* a different root from *pō*? (**No** — the same old *p* softened to *h*.) Next: the one place a Malayalam verb can still surprise you.

32.3 വരുക (varuka) — “to come,” and a past that reshapes the stem

Pōkuka took its endings without a fuss. Its lifelong partner does not — and the difference sits in exactly one of the three tenses.

What to know first

വരുക — *varuka* — to come

The stem is വരു- (*varu-*), and the command is shorter still: വാ! (*vā!*), “come!” (Chapter 4 met the dictionary form in its other common spelling, വരിക, *varika*; both name this verb.)

Go and come are inseparable here. The everyday goodbye പോയി വരാം (*pōyi varām*) is the two verbs holding hands — “having gone, I’ll come” — and Malayalam has no plain farewell that leaves the coming back out.

The letters in this word

വ (*va*) + രു (*ru*) + ക (*ka*) → വരുക, three light beats. In the past form വന്നു (*vannu*) the ന is a doubled *n*, held long: *van-nu*, not *vanu*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Native Dravidian, and every sister kept it — each reshaping the front of the word. **Tamil** has வா (*vā*) as the command and வரு- (*varu-*) as the stem; **Kannada** has ಬಾ (*bā*); **Telugu** has రా (*rā*).

V, b, r: three regular reworkings of one old word, not three verbs. And Malayalam’s *vā* / *varu-* pairing is Tamil’s exactly, down to the two shapes — which is what “closest sister” means in practice.

Grammar Lens: where Malayalam keeps its irregularity

Line the two verbs up:

tense	go	come
now	<i>pōkunnu</i>	<i>varunnu</i>
already	<i>pōyi</i>	<i>vannu</i>
not yet	<i>pōkuni</i>	<i>varuni</i>

Present and future are built the same way for both: stem, plus *-unnu* or *-uni*. The past is not — *varu-* collapses into *vann-*, and no rule would have told you so.

That is Malayalam’s whole irregularity budget, spent in one place. Once a verb’s **past** is learned, nothing else about it can catch you out, because the missing person slot means there is no second, third or plural form waiting behind it. A Malayalam verb costs you three forms. A Tamil one costs three tenses times six persons.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the command — “vā!”
- the three times — “varunnu ... vannu ... varuṁ”
- the pair, past against past — “pōyi ... vannu”
- the goodbye you now understand — “pōyi varāṁ”

Before you move on

Which tense of *varuka* is the irregular one? (**The past** — *vannu*.) Say “I will come.” (*Ñān varuṁ*.) Are Kannada *bā* and Telugu *rā* different verbs from *varuka*? (**No** — one old Dravidian word, reshaped three ways.) Next: a verb Malayalam kept where Tamil built a new one.

32.4 തിന്നുക (tinnuka) — “to eat,” and the ending that names a verb’s homeland

Malayalam took in a great deal of Sanskrit. Eating is one of the places it never reached.

What to know first

തിന്നുക — *tinnuka* — to eat

ഉണ്ണുക — *uṇṇuka* — to eat a meal, to dine

Two inherited verbs, both alive. *Tinnuka* is eating in general. *Uṇṇuka* is sitting down to a proper meal, and gives the noun ഉൺ (*uṇṇ*), “lunch.” The tenses are regular: *tinnunnu*, *tinnu*, *tinnuṁ*.

The letters in this word

തി (*ti*) + ന്നു (a doubled *nn* with *u*) + ക (*ka*) → തിന്നുക, with the long *n* you held in *vannu*. In ഉണ്ണുക that doubled letter is retroflex ണ്ണ (*ṇṇ*): *uṇ-ṇu-ka*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

തിന്നുക goes back to Dravidian *tin-*, and the family kept it: Telugu తిను (*tinu*), Kannada ತಿನ್ನು (*tinnu*).

Tamil kept *tin* too, as தின், but narrowed it to chewing and built a **new** everyday word from two of its own: சாப்பிடு (*sāppiḍu*) is *sāppu* (“food”) plus *iḍu* (“to put”). Put food. Tamil’s ordinary eat-verb is home-made; Malayalam’s is the family’s original.

Grammar Lens: -ഉക and -ഇക്കുക, two doors into the verb

Every verb so far has ended in -ഉക (-*uka*): *tinnuka*, *pōkuka*, *varuka*, *irikkuka*. Chapter 5’s “to speak” did not — it was സംസാരിക്കുക (*saṁsārikkuka*), with a longer -ഇക്കുക (-*ikkuka*). That difference is a passport stamp:

ending	what it marks
-ഉക - <i>uka</i>	an inherited Dravidian verb
-ഇക്കുക - <i>ikkuka</i>	a Sanskrit word made into a verb

Sanīsārīkkuka is built on Sanskrit *sanīsāra*; Chapter 9’s ക്ഷമിക്കുക (*kṣamīkkuka*, “to forgive”) on *kṣamā*. Malayalam needed one dependable way to make a verb of any borrowed noun, and -ഇക്കുക is it: a naturalisation ceremony you can hear.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the two eat-verbs — “tinnuka” (eat) and “uṇṇuka” (dine)
- the three times — “tinnunnu ... tinnu ... tinnunṇu”
- the cousins that kept the root — “tinu ... tinnu ... tinnuka”
- the two endings — “-uka is ours, -ikkuka came from Sanskrit”

Before you move on

Did Malayalam borrow its everyday word for eating? (**No** — Tamil is the one that built a new compound.) Which verb is for sitting down to a meal? (ഉണ്ണുക, *unṇuka*.) What does *-ikkuka* tell you? (**That the verb was made from a Sanskrit word.**) Next: a verb Malayalam kept where all three sisters walked away.

32.5 കാണുക (kāṇuka) — “to see,” and everything else the second slot can hold

Two slots, and the second one has only carried tense so far. It holds a good deal more — and you have used one of its other endings since Chapter 4.

What to know first

കാണുക — *kāṇuka* — to see, to meet

Present *kāṇunnu*, future *kāṇuni*, and a past that reshapes the way *vannu* did: കണ്ടു (*kaṇṭu*), “saw.”

You have said this verb in a goodbye. നാളെ കാണാം (*nāle kāṇāmi*) — “see you tomorrow” — is *nāle* (“tomorrow”) plus this stem with a different ending.

The letters in this word

കാ (*ka* with the long-*ā* sign) + ണു (retroflex *ṇu*) + ക (*ka*) → കാണുക. That ണ is the letter that ended *uṇṭū*: tongue curled back to the roof of the mouth.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Kāṇ- is the family’s own see-root, inherited from Proto-Dravidian — and here the four sisters part company. **Tamil** says പറ (pār), keeping കാண் (*kāṇ*) for formal writing; **Kannada** says ನೋಡು (*nōḍu*), keeping കാಣು (*kāṇu*) alongside; **Telugu** says చూడు (*cūḍu*). Malayalam simply kept the inherited word in daily use. Twice now — *tinnuka* and *kāṇuka* — the youngest of the four sisters turns out to be the conservative one.

Grammar Lens: tense is only one thing that ending can be

Hold *kāṇ-* still and change what follows it:

ending on <i>kāṇ-</i>	what it says
<i>kāṇunnu</i>	sees, is seeing
<i>kāṇumī</i>	will see
<i>kāṇāmī</i>	may see; let's see
<i>kāṇaṇamī</i>	must see
<i>kāṇarutū</i>	must not see

Time, permission, obligation, prohibition — all in the same single slot. This is where the person ending went: Malayalam gave that slot up and spent the room on **mood** instead.

And the payoff lands on every line. *Kāṇaṇamī* is “I must see,” “you must see” and “they must see” without changing a letter. In Tamil each of those five ideas must still pick a person ending before it can be said aloud.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*kāṇuka*” — to see — and the past, “*kaṇṭu*”
- the farewell you now understand — “*nāḷe kāṇāmī*”
- the ladder — “*kāṇunnu ... kāṇumī ... kāṇāmī ... kāṇaṇamī ... kāṇarutū*”
- one form, three people — “*ñān, nī, avar ... kāṇaṇamī*”

Before you move on

Which of the four sisters kept the inherited see-word for everyday use? (**Malayalam** — the other three each chose a different word.) Say “must see” and “must not see.” (*Kāṇaṇamī*; *kāṇarutū*.) What besides tense does that second slot carry? (**Mood** — permission, obligation, prohibition.) Next: the verb that moves the person out of the sentence altogether.

32.6 അറിയുക (*ariyuka*) — “to know,” the verb that takes no subject

Five verbs, and every one let you stand in front of it as *ñān*, “I.”
The last one will not — and Chapter 6 already handed you the sentence it makes.

What to know first

അറിയുക — *ariyuka* — to know

Present *ariyunnu*, past അറിഞ്ഞു (*arīññu*), and the form you have met: അറിയാം (*ariyāmi*), with the *-āmi* ending of the last lesson.

Native Dravidian, and the sisters kept the root — Tamil அறி (*ari*), Kannada ಅರಿ (*ari*) — though for everyday knowing each reached elsewhere: Tamil தெரியும் (*teriyum*), Telugu తెలుసు (*telusu*). Malayalam stayed with *ari-*.

The letters in this word

അ (the standing vowel *a*) + റി (*ri*) + യു (*yu*) + ക (*ka*) → അറിയുക. The റ is Malayalam’s hard, tapped *r*, a different letter and a different sound from the soft ര (*r*) of *varuka*.

Grammar Lens: the knower leaves the subject slot

എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം. — *enikku malayāḷam ariyāmi* — “I know Malayalam.”

Chapter 6 gave you that sentence whole. Here is the verb inside it. You cannot say *ñān malayāḷam ariyāmi*: the one who knows is not the subject. That person moves into the **dative**, the “to me” case.

- *enikku ariyāmi* — it is known **to me**
- *ninakku ariyāmi* — it is known **to you**
- *avanŭ ariyāmi* — it is known **to him**

Malayalam treats knowing as something that **arrives at** you rather than something you **do**, and marks it with the pronoun’s case. That is the chapter’s closing symmetry. With the other five verbs the pronoun in front was the only thing telling you who acted, because the

verb carried no person. Here it has changed case, so the sentence has no subject at all. Malayalam took the person off the verb; this construction takes it out of the subject slot too.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “a_{ri}yuka” — to know — and the past, “a_{ri}ññu”
- “enikku malayāḷaṁ a_{ri}yāṁ” — I know Malayalam
- three knowers, one verb — “enikku ... ninakku ... avanū a_{ri}yāṁ”
- the chapter’s six — “uṇṭū, pōkunnu, varunnu, tinnunnu, kāṇunnu, a_{ri}yunnu”

Before you move on

Say “I know Malayalam,” and name the case the “I” wears. (*Enikku malayāḷaṁ a_{ri}yāṁ* — the **dative**.) Name the two slots of a Malayalam verb. (**Stem and tense**, with no third slot for person.) Which of the six verbs has an irregular past? (*Varuka* → *vannu*, and *kāṇuka* → *kaṇṭu*.) Which be-word says “I have”? (ഉണ്ടു, *uṇṭū*.) How many forms has the Malayalam present tense, for any verb at all? (**One**.)

Chapter 33

The Mind and the Page

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that I think, understand, read and write in Malayalam, hear from a verb’s own ending which of the four Malayalam borrowed, and put the understander in the dative where Malayalam puts him.

Say ഞാൻ മലയാളം എഴുതുന്നു, run the chapter’s four verbs back and pick out the two wearing the Sanskrit -ഇക്കുക stamp, and say why Malayalam and Tamil write with one word while Kannada and Telugu, having lost its ഴ, reach for another.

33.1 ചിന്തിക്കുക (cintikkuka) — “to think,” on a suffix you have used since Chapter 9

Say *enikku malayāḷam ariyāmi*. Knowing **arrived** at you, so the “I” left the subject slot. Thinking you do — and you keep it.

What to know first

ചിന്തിക്കുക — *cintikkuka* — to think

ഞാൻ ചിന്തിക്കുന്നു. — *ñān cintikkunnu* — “I think.”

Past ചിന്തിച്ചു (*cinticcu*), future *cintikkumī*. And *cintikkunnu* is the whole present tense — *ñān, nī, avar*, one word for everybody.

The letters in this word

ചി (*ca* + the *i* sign) + ന്നി (the conjunct ന്ത *nta*, also with *i*) + ക്കു + ക.
That ക്ക is the held-long *kk* of *kṣamikkuka*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ചിന്ത (*cinta*) is a **noun** first — “thought, care” — borrowed whole from Sanskrit चिन्ता (*cintā*), which carries the same double sense of thinking and worrying.

Native think-words live on beside it: ഓർക്കുക (*ōrkkuka*), narrowed to “remember”; നിനക്കുക (*ninekka*), now literary.

Grammar Lens: -ഇക്കുക, the suffix that naturalises a loan

Chapter 9 made ക്ഷമിക്കുക (*kṣamikkuka*, “to forgive”) from Sanskrit ക്ഷമ plus -ഇക്കുക; Chapter 32 made that ending a passport stamp — -ഉക on an inherited verb, -ഇക്കുക on a borrowing. *Cinta* + *-ikkuka* is the same machine.

That second slot still takes mood as readily as tense: *cintikkāṁi* (“let’s think”), ചിന്തിക്കണം (*cintikkaṇaṁi*, “must think”) on the very -ണം that made *kṣamikkaṇaṁi* polite, *cintikkarutū* (“must not think”).

Each sister has that suffix in her own shape — Kannada -ಇಸು, Telugu -ఇంసు — all inherited from one source. What differs is who used it here. **Tamil** kept native நினை (*niṇai*); **Telugu** and **Kannada** built theirs from a word meaning “to say,” *anukō*, “to say to oneself.” Only Malayalam borrowed — and the word it demoted, *ninekka*, is *niṇai* exactly.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ñān cintikkunnu,” then the past, “cinticcu”
- noun, verb, and its cousin — “cinta ... cintikkuka ... kṣamikkuka”
- the mood ladder — “cintikkāṁi ... cintikkaṇaṁi ... cintikkarutū”
- three strategies — “niṇai” kept, “anukō” built, “cintikkuka” borrowed

- knowing, then thinking — “enikku malayāḷam aṛiyāṁ,” “ñān cintikkunnu”

Before you move on

Say “I think,” and name the noun inside it. (*Ñān cintikkunnu*; ചിന്ത, Sanskrit for **thought**.) What does -ഇക്കുക tell you, and which earlier verb wore it? (**Made from a borrowing**; *kṣamikkuka*.) Say “must think.” (*Cintikkaṇaṁ* — the -ണം of *kṣamikkaṇaṁ*, a mood in the tense slot.) Which sister kept a native think-word, and which built one from “say”? (**Tamil**, *ninai*; **Telugu**, *anukō*.) Why can *aṛiyuka* not take *ñān*? (**Knowing arrives at you**.)

33.2 മനസ്സിലാക്കുക (manassilākkuka) — “to understand,” or: to put it in the mind

Say *ñān cintikkunnu*, then *enikku*. One is what you do; the other is the “to me” of Chapter 6. This word needs both.

What to know first

മനസ്സിലാക്കുക — *manassilākkuka* — **to understand**

ഞാൻ മനസ്സിലാക്കുന്നു. — *ñān manassilākkunnu* — “I understand.”

Past മനസ്സിലാക്കി (*manassilākki*). It is long, but not one lump: you can hear the seams.

The letters in this word

മ (*ma*) + ന (*na*) + സ്സി (a doubled സ് *ssa* with the *i* sign) + ലാ (*la* + long *ā*) + ക്ക + ക. Hold that സ്സി long.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Three pieces, and you have met every one:

- മനസ്സ് (*manassū*) — “**mind**,” Sanskrit मनस् (*manas*)
- -ഇൽ (*-il*) — “**in**,” the ending of *vīṭṭil*, “at home”

- ആക്കുക (*ākkuka*) — “to make, to put”

Put in the mind. That is the whole word — transparent to any Malayalam speaker, which is why it never wore down.

Sanskrit *manas* is from the Indo-European root **men-*, “to think,” and so are English **mind** and **mental** and Latin *mēns* — by a different branch of it, so relatives rather than the same word. (*Mind*’s exact Sanskrit match is मति *mati*; *manas*’s is Greek *ménos*.)

Grammar Lens: two verbs, one root, and who does the work

ആക്കുക *makes* something so; its twin ആകുക (*ākuka*) means it *becomes* so. Swap them and the sentence changes hands:

എനിക്ക് മനസ്സിലായി. — *enikku manassilāyi* — “I understood.”

Literally: “to me — it became in the mind.” No *ñān*. The understander wears the dative -ഇക്ക്, as the knower does in *enikku malayāḷam ariyāṁ*. Chapter 6 separated what you **do** from what **happens to** you; here one root does both, and the ending decides which. *Manassilāyi* is much the commoner in speech.

Neither form takes -ഇക്കുക: both sit on native *ākuka*, so no passport stamp.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three pieces — “manassū ... -il ... ākkuka”
- “ñān manassilākkunnu,” then the past, “manassilākki”
- the everyday one — “enikku manassilāyi”
- three understanders — “enikku ... ninakku ... avanū manassilāyi”
- the two datives together — “enikku malayāḷam ariyāṁ,” “enikku manassilāyi”
- with and without a stamp — “cintikkuka ... manassilākkuka”

Before you move on

Name the three pieces of *manassilākkuka*. (**Mind, in, put.**) Which English words share its root? (**Mind, mental.**) Say “I understood” the way it is usually said, and name the case you wear. (*Enikku manassilāyi*; the **dative**, as in *enikku malayāḷam ariyāmi*.) Which of today’s two verbs carries **-ഇക്കുക**, and why? (*Cintikkuka* — its noun was borrowed.)

33.3 വായിക്കുക (vāyikkuka) — “to read,” and a mouth that turns out not to be there

Manassilākkuka came apart into three pieces you could name. The next word looks as obliging — and the piece you hear is not there.

What to know first

വായിക്കുക — *vāyikkuka* — to read

ഞാൻ മലയാളം വായിക്കുന്നു. — *ñān malayāḷam vāyikkunnu*
— “I read Malayalam.”

Past വായിച്ചു (*vāyiccu*). The noun beside it is വായന (*vāyana*), “reading.”

The letters in this word

വാ (*va* + long *ā*) + യി (*ya* + the *i* sign) + ക്കു + ക. Nothing new since *cintikkuka* — the same ക്കുക tail.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The obvious guess is വായ് (*vāy*), “mouth” — reading as mouthing the words. A good guess, and wrong.

Gundert marks the noun വായന a *tadbhava* of Sanskrit वच् (*vac*), “to speak,” and gives the Tamil verb as *vācikka*. Sanskrit वाचन (*vācana*) is “reading aloud.” Reading was named for the **voice**; the mouth-word only sounds like it.

The *c* did not soften in Malayalam. It softened on the road — a *tadbhava* is a word that came the long way, through the middle Indo-Aryan languages, which drop a single consonant between vowels. Malayalam also holds the same Sanskrit word borrowed **straight**, വാചകം (*vācakam*), so it sits here twice; *vāyana* is the travelled one, and the -ഇക്കുക stamp agrees.

Nor did the sisters agree which word to use. Tamil’s everyday படி (*paṭi*) is Sanskrit too, from *paṭh-*; Telugu has చదువు (*caduvu*). Only **Kannada** kept a native read-verb in ordinary use, ಓದು (*ōdu*) — which Malayalam also has, as ഓതുക (*ōtuka*), narrowed to reciting scripture.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ñān malayāḷam vāyikkunnu,” then the past, “vāyiccu”
- the false trail, then the true one — “vāy” ... “vac, vācana, vāyana”
- the same word twice — “vācakam” straight, “vāyana” travelled
- the four read-verbs — “vāyikkuka ... paṭi ... ōdu ... caduvu”
- read what you know — the planet-days, “tiṅkaḷ ... velli ... ñāyar” — and the year’s first month, “Chinṇam”
- when — “ñān rāville vāyikkunnu,” I read in the morning
- what you do, what arrives — “ñān vāyikkunnu,” “enikku manassilāyi”
- the three pieces of understanding — “manassū ... -il ... ākkuka”

Before you move on

Say “I read Malayalam.” (*Ñān malayāḷam vāyikkunnu.*) Is *vāy*, “mouth,” inside it? (**No** — the trail runs to Sanskrit *vac*, “speak,” and *vācana*, “reciting aloud”; the *c* softened **on the road**, and Malayalam keeps *vācakam* unsoftened beside it.) Do the sisters share a read-verb? (**No** — *paṭi*, *ōdu*, *caduvu*, and only *ōdu* is native.)

33.4 എഴുതുക (elutuka) — “to write,” and the one letter two sisters kept

Reading came from Sanskrit. Writing did not travel at all — and it kept a sound most of the family has lost.

What to know first

എഴുതുക — *elutuka* — to write

ഞാൻ മലയാളം എഴുതുന്നു. — *ñān malayāḷam elutunnu* —
“I write Malayalam.”

Past എഴുതി (*eluti*). Note the tail: plain -ഉക, no ഇ — no passport stamp, because nothing was borrowed.

The letters in this word

എ (the standing vowel *e*) + ഴ (ഴ *la* with *u*) + തു (*tu*) + ക (*ka*). The ഴ is the letter of *ēlu*, “seven” — curl the tongue back and let the air pass, neither quite an *l* nor quite an *r*. Standard Malayalam keeps it; northern dialects have let it go, as Kannada did.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Malayalam’s എഴുതുക and Tamil’s எழுது (*elutu*) are not cousins. They are the **same word** — and the Dravidian etymological dictionary finds it in only two other, much smaller languages. Beside “write, paint, draw” it records a stranger sense: “**become indented by pressure**.” A letter is a mark pressed into a leaf with the കൈ (*kai*), the hand. (You may see it linked to എഴു *elu*, “to rise”; the dictionary keeps them apart, so treat that as unproven.)

The ഴ is the sound inside the name തമിഴ് itself. Chapter 7 watched it harden going east: *ēlu*, *ēlu*, *ēdu*. Kannada and Telugu lost the letter — and with it this verb. They write with an unrelated root: ಬರೆ (*bare*), രాయ (*rāyu*), from an old word for a **drawn line**.

Malayalam has that root too — വരയ്ക്കുക (*varaykkuka*) — and gave it the other job: **to draw**. Two roots, two tasks, as with *uṇṭū* and *irikkuka*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ñān malayāḷam̐ elutunnu,” then “eluti”
- when — “ñān rāthri elutunnu,” I write at night
- the two sisters’ one word — “elutuka ... elutu”
- the sound hardening east — “ēlu ... ēḷu ... ēḍu”
- write, then draw — “elutuka ... varaykkuka”
- the chapter’s നാല് — “cintikkunnu, manassilākkunnu, vāyikkunnu, elutunnu”
- with Chapter 32’s six that makes പത്ത് — “uṇṭṭṭu, pōkunnu, varunnu, tinnunnu, kāṇunnu, aṛiyunnu”
- the two that carry the stamp — “cintikkuka, vāyikkuka”
- and the sentence with no subject — “enikku manassilāyi”

Before you move on

Say “I write Malayalam,” and how far Tamil’s word is from it. (*ñān malayāḷam̐ elutunnu*; **not at all**.) Which sound do the standard languages keep, and what did Kannada and Telugu do about writing? (ഴ; they lost it and took another root, *bare*, *rāyu*.) Run the chapter’s four, and say which two were borrowed. (*Cintikkunnu*, *manassilākkunnu*, *vāyikkunnu*, *elutunnu*; *cinta* and *vac*, wearing -ഇക്കുക.) Which refuses you as its subject? (*Enikku manassilāyi*.)

Chapter 34

Taking, Asking, Helping, Liking

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can take, ask, help and say what I like in Malayalam, tell a native geminate stem apart from the Sanskrit verb-maker that looks just like it, and say why എനിക്ക് മലയാളം ഇഷ്ടമാണ് leaves no room for me as its subject.

Say എനിക്ക് മലയാളം ഇഷ്ടമാണ് and hear that you are not its subject, set it beside എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം and എനിക്ക് മനസ്സിലായി so one frame carries three meanings, and run the chapter's four back by the past tenses that betray which of them were borrowed.

34.1 എടുക്കുക (eṭukkuka) — “to take,” and a rule that needed one correction

Vāyikkunnu was borrowed, *elutunnu* was not, and you could hear which was which. This one sounds borrowed and is not.

What to know first

എടുക്കുക — *eṭukkuka* — to take, to pick up

ഞാൻ വെള്ളം എടുക്കുന്നു. — *ñān vellam eṭukkunnu* — “I take water.”

Three times, as always: *eṭukkunnu*, എടുത്തു (*eṭuttu*), *eṭukkumi*.

The letters in this word

എ (the standing vowel *e*, as in *elutuka*) + ടു (retroflex *ṣ ṭa* with *u*) + കു + ക. Curl the tongue back for the *ṣ*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Gundert glosses it “**to raise, lift, take up**,” and the lifting came first. Tamil எடு (*eṭu*) is the same word again — and the etymological dictionary gives this root no entry of its own, filing *eṭu* inside the family of എഴു (*elū*), “**to rise**.” Rise, then raise, then take. Kannada and Telugu say ఎత్తు / ఎత్త (ettu) for lifting; whether that is the same word the dictionaries argue over, so take the resemblance and leave the verdict.

It wants an object: *vellam eṭukkunnu*, water; *ari eṭukkunnu*, raw rice; *cōrū eṭukkunnu*, the cooked kind.

Grammar Lens: the stamp is the ഇ, not the ക

Chapter 32 gave you a rule: -ഉക on an inherited verb, -ഇക്കുക on a borrowing made into one. *Eṭukkuka* looks like a counter-example. It is not: the rule was always about one letter.

- *cintikkuka*, *vāyikkuka* — ഇ before the ക: borrowed
- *eṭukkuka*, *irikkuka* — no ഇ: native, doubling its own consonant

The ക belongs to the stem; the ഇ is the naturalisation ceremony. And the past tense settles every case: a borrowed verb ends -ഇച്ചു (*cinticcu*, *vāyiccu*), a native one does not (*eṭuttu*, *eluti*).

Beneath that, nothing has changed. *Ñān eṭukkunnu*, *nī eṭukkunnu*, *avar eṭukkunnu* — three forms are still the whole conjugation, native or borrowed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ñān vellam eṭukkunnu,” then the past, “eṭuttu”
- three things to take — “vellam ... ari ... cōrū”
- rise, raise, take — “elū ... eṭu ... eṭukkuka”

- listen for the *i* — “cintikkuka, vāyikkuka” against “eṭukkuka, eḷutuka”
- and the pasts that prove it — “cinticcu, vāyiccu” against “eṭuttu, eḷuti”
- three people, one form — “ñān, nī, avar ... eṭukkunnu”

Before you move on

Say “I take water,” then the past. (*Ñān vellani eṭukkunnu; eṭuttu.*) What did the root mean before “take”? (**To rise**, then **to raise**.) Is *eṭukkuka* a borrowing, and how do you know? (**No** — no ഇ, no -ഇച്ചു past; *cintikkuka* and *vāyikkuka* have both.) How many present forms has it? (**One**.)

34.2 ചോദിക്കുക (cōdikkuka) — “to ask,” which began as pushing

Eṭuttu — a native past. Listen for what the next verb’s past does instead, and you will know where it came from before you are told.

What to know first

ചോദിക്കുക — *cōdikkuka* — to ask

ഞാൻ ചോദിക്കുന്നു. — *ñān cōdikkunnu* — “I ask.”

Past ചോദിച്ചു (*cōdiccu*) — there it is, the -ഇച്ചു of a borrowing. The noun beside it is ചോദ്യം (*cōdyam*), “a question.”

The letters in this word

ചോ (*ca* wearing the long-*ō* sign) + ദി (*ḍa* with the *i* sign) + ക്കു (*kku*) + ക (*ka*). That *ḍ* is a voiced *d*, one of the sounds Sanskrit brought into the alphabet.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Gundert files it under the Sanskrit root ചുദ് (*cud*), “**to incite, to urge**” — and his entry still lists the senses in the order they arrived: first to incite, then to demand, then to question. In Sanskrit philosophy चोद्य (*codya*) was an **objection pressed** at an opponent. Asking began as pushing.

Malayalam needed the word because of something it had done to its own. The family’s inherited **kēl-* covered **hearing and asking together**, and Tamil’s கேள் (*kēl*) still does both. Malayalam kept കേൾക്കുക (*kēlkkuka*) for **hearing only** — and the empty half is exactly where the loan settled.

Two questions from Chapter 18 and Chapter 19 you can now say you are asking: *ethra maṇi?*, “what hour?”, and *ninṇaḷkku ethra vayassuṇṭū?*, “how old are you?” Chapter 8’s ദയവായി in front softens either.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ñān cōdikkunnu,” then the past, “cōdiccu”
- verb, then noun — “cōdikkuka ... cōdyaṁ”
- the three senses in order — “incite ... demand ... ask”
- ask the hour — “dayavāyi, ethra maṇi?”
- ask the age — “ninṇaḷkku ethra vayassuṇṭū?”
- hear, then ask — “kēlkkuka ... cōdikkuka”
- the two pasts — “cōdiccu” borrowed, “eṭuttu” and “eḷuti” not

Before you move on

Say “I ask,” then the past, and say what the past tells you. (*Ñān cōdikkunnu*; *cōdiccu*; -ഇച്ഛ means **borrowed**.) What did the root mean first, and why did Malayalam need it? (**To incite, to urge** — and its own *kēlkkuka* had narrowed to hearing, where Tamil’s *kēl* still asks.) Now ask someone’s age, politely. (*Dayavāyi, ninṇaḷkku ethra vayassuṇṭū?*)

34.3 സഹായിക്കുക (sahāyikkuka) — “to help,” or: to go along with

Cōdiccu told you it was borrowed. The next verb’s past says the same — and by now you can guess what happened to the Malayalam word it replaced.

What to know first

സഹായിക്കുക — *sahāyikkuka* — to help

ഞാൻ സഹായിക്കുന്നു. — *ñān sahāyikkunnu* — “I help.”

Past സഹായിച്ചു (*sahāyiccu*). The noun is സഹായം (*sahāyam*), “help,” and it came first — the verb was made from it.

The letters in this word

സ (*sa*) + ഹാ (ഹ *ha* + long *ā*) + യി (*ya* + the *i* sign) + ക്കു + ക. That ാ + യി pair is the one you spelled inside ദയവായി, letter for letter.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Sanskrit सहाय (*sahāya*) first meant a **companion**. Monier-Williams reads it as सह (*saha*), “with,” plus a form of the root ३ (*i*), “**to go**” — one who **goes along with** you — and marks the reading *probable* rather than certain. That go-root is Indo-European ***h₁ey-**, the one inside Latin *īre* and Greek *eīmi*. Helping, named as walking beside. Tamil alone kept the family’s own word for everyday use: உதவி (*utavi*). Malayalam has the cognate — ഉതവി, with the verb ഉതക്കുക — but the daily work goes to the loan, as it does in Kannada, Telugu and Hindi.

That is the fourth time in two chapters: *ōtuka* gave up reading, *ōrkkuka* gave up thinking, *kēlkkuka* gave up asking, *utavi* gave up helping — and a Sanskrit word took each vacated slot. It is not random. It is the mark of the centuries when Kerala’s writers mixed the two languages on purpose.

The other direction exists too. ദയവായി is Sanskrit *daya*, and there **all four sisters borrowed together** — *tayavu seytu*, *dayavittu*, *dayacēsi*. For politeness nobody kept a native word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*ñān sahāyikkunnu*,” then the past, “*sahāyiccu*”
- noun, then verb — “*sahāyaṁ ... sahāyikkuka*”
- the pieces — “*saha*” with, “*i*” to go — one who goes along
- ask for it politely, on Chapter 8’s ending — “*sahāyikkaṇaṁ*”
- native, then loan — “*utavi ... sahāyaṁ*”
- the four that gave way — “*ōtuka, ōrkkuka, kēlkkuka, utavi*”
- and the four that borrowed together — “*dayavāyi, tayavu seytu, dayaviṭṭu, dayacēsi*”

Before you move on

Say “I help,” and say what *sahāya* meant first. (*Ñān sahāyikkunnu*; **a companion** — one who goes with you.) Which sister kept her own help-word for daily use? (**Tamil**, *utavi* — Malayalam has *utavi* but rarely reaches for it.) Say “please help.” (*Sahāyikkaṇaṁ*, on the -**ണം** that carries everyday politeness.) And which word did all four sisters borrow together? (**ദയ** *daya*.)

34.4 എനിക്ക് മലയാളം ഇഷ്ടമാണ് — “I like Malayalam,” and you are not its subject

Ñān sahāyikkunnu, ñān eṭukkunnu — you have stood in front of every verb so far. Not this one.

What to know first

എനിക്ക് മലയാളം ഇഷ്ടമാണ്. *enikku malayāḷaṁ iṣṭamāṇṁ*
— “to me — Malayalam — is a liking.”

ഇഷ്ടം is a **noun**; **-ആണ്** is Chapter 2’s copula. Only the front moves: *enikku, ninakku, avanū*.

The letters in this word

ഇ (the standing vowel *i*) + ഞ്ശ (ഞ *ṣa* over *ś* *ṭa*, both retroflex) + ൾ, the anusvāram of *malayāḷaṁ*.

Grammar Lens: three sentences on one frame

Enikku malayāḷaṁ ariyāṁ — I **know** it. *Enikku manassilāyi* — I **understood**. *Enikku malayāḷaṁ iṣṭamāṇũ* — I **like** it. One frame, three meanings; Chapter 6 promised the third before you had words for it. Swap the thing and it holds: *enikku maḷa iṣṭamāṇũ*, “I like rain.” Here the dative is not a preference. *Ñān malayāḷaṁ iṣṭamāṇũ* is **ungrammatical**.

Two ways round it, one native. ഇഷ്ടപ്പെടുക (*iṣṭappetuka*) is this noun made a verb, and takes either shape. പിടിക്കുക (*piṭikkuka*), “to catch,” is Malayalam’s own: Gundert records എനിക്കു പിടിച്ചില്ല, “it did not please me.” Malayalam never needed *iṣṭam*; it took it.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ഇഷ്ടം is Sanskrit इष्ट, the participle of इष् (iṣ), “to desire,” from the Indo-European root **h₂eys-*, which also produced English **ask**. The chapter’s two Sanskrit words crossed over: *cōḍikkuka*, which **means** ask, came from a root meaning **drive**; *iṣṭam*, which means **like**, came from **ask**’s root.

The shape turns up far from Kerala. Spanish says **me gusta**, “to me it pleases”; Italian **mi piace**; Tamil **eṇakkut tamil piḍikkum**. None borrowed it from another — Tamil is not even in their family — yet all three put the liker where Malayalam does. Chapter 6’s row is the near end: **-ikku, -ukku, -ku, -ge**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*enikku malayāḷaṁ iṣṭamāṇũ*” — to me, Malayalam, is a liking
- three likers, then a new thing — “*enikku ... ninakku ... avanũ*,” then “*enikku maḷa iṣṭamāṇũ*”
- the three datives — “*ariyāṁ, manassilāyi, iṣṭamāṇũ*”
- the two ways round — “*ñān iṣṭappetunnu*,” “*enikku piṭiccu*”

- the chapter’s **മാലി** — “eṭukkunnu, cōdikkunnu, sahāyikkunnu, iṣṭamāñṭ”
- the borrowings, by their pasts — “cōdiccu, sahāyiccu,” not “eṭuttu”
- the same shape far away — “me gusta ... mi piace ... piḍikkum” — on “-ikku · -ukku · -ku · -ge”

Before you move on

Say “I like Malayalam,” and how many verbs it holds. (*Enikku malayālāṁ iṣṭamāñṭ*; **one**, the copula.) Can you be its subject? (**No** — not unusual, **impossible**.) Name the three dative sentences and Malayalam’s own way of liking. (*Ariyāṁ, manassilāyi, iṣṭamāñṭ*; പിടിക്കുക.) Which English word shares *iṣṭam*’s root, and is it *cōdikkuka*’s? (**Ask**; **no** — that came from **drive**.)

Chapter 35

Family and Friend

Modes:  voice (1)  eyes (1)  pen (1)  Hands-free start: first 2 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my family as a group and name a friend in Malayalam, and say which of the two words is a Sanskrit loan and which of Malayalam’s two friend-words leans on a borrowed ending even though its root is native.

Say ithu ente kudumbamaanu and ithu ente suhruthaanu, take suhruthu apart into su plus hrid, and name the six Chapter 12 people-words next to the one group-word none of them supplied.

35.1 കുടുംബം (kuṭumbam) — “family,” the word the six people-words never needed

Enikku malayāḷaṇi iṣṭamāṇŭ closed the last chapter on a sentence built from nothing but nouns and a dative. This chapter opens on the plainest nouns of all: the people you would actually say it to.

What to know first

കുടുംബം — *kuṭumbam* — family

ഇത് എന്റെ കുടുംബമാണ്. — *ithu ente kuṭumbamāṇŭ.* —
“This is my family.”

Ente, “my,” has been yours since your very first sentences; -ആണ് is the same copula that closed *enikku malayāḷaṇi iṣṭamāṇŭ*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

കുടുംബം is Sanskrit तत्सम कुटुम्ब (kuṭumba), “family, household,” absorbed with the same nativizing -അം ending you already met on ഇഷ്ടം and സുഖം — a genuine Malayalam habit: dress a bare Sanskrit neuter stem in Malayalam’s own **-am̐**. Kannada borrows the identical word **bare**, ಕುಟುಂಬ (kuṭumba), no ending added — one more place Malayalam leans harder into Sanskrit than its sisters do, this time in the shape of the loan rather than the fact of it.

You already have six words for six specific people: അച്ഛൻ, അമ്മ, and the four age-graded siblings ചേട്ടൻ/അനിയൻ, ചെച്ചി/അനിയത്തി.

Every one is native Dravidian, and not one of them means “family” — each names a single, specific person.

Malayalam never inherited a word for the group itself, so when it needed one, it reached for Sanskrit. The people came first, and stayed native; the collective came later, and came borrowed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ithu ente kuṭumbamāṇṁ” — this is my family
- the six named people, then the borrowed group word — “acchan, amma, cēṭṭan, aniyān, cēcci, aniyatti ... kuṭumbam̐”
- bare against dressed — “kuṭumba” (Kannada), “kuṭumbam̐” (Malayalam)

Before you move on

Say “this is my family.” (*Ithu ente kuṭumbamāṇṁ*.) Is *kuṭumbam̐* native Dravidian or a loan? (**A Sanskrit loan**, like *iṣṭam̐* and *sukham̐* — and dressed in the same **-am̐**.) Name the six family words you already know. (*Acchan, amma, cēṭṭan, aniyān, cēcci, aniyatti*.) Which of those six means “family” as a group? (**None of them** — that’s exactly the gap *kuṭumbam̐* fills.)

35.2 സുഹൃത്ത് (suhṛttü) — “friend,” a word built out of “good” plus “heart”

Kuṭumbani named the group you’re born into. This word names the one you choose.

What to know first

സുഹൃത്ത് — *suhṛttü* — friend

ഇത് എന്റെ സുഹൃത്താണ്. — *ithu ente suhṛttāṇũ*. — “This is my friend.”

The everyday spoken alternative is കൂട്ടുകാരൻ (*kūṭṭukāran*, male) / കൂട്ടുകാരി (*kūṭṭukāri*, female).

The letters in this word

ഹൃ is ഹ (*ha*) carrying the ള് sign — the short vocalic *r* inherited straight from Sanskrit, the same vowel that opened വൃശ്ചികം several chapters back. Malayalam is the only one of the four literary Dravidian scripts that still writes it as a distinct vowel sign rather than respelling it away.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

സുഹൃത്ത് is Sanskrit सुहृद् (*suhṛd*), literally “good-heart”: सु (*su*) “good” plus हृद् (*hṛd*) “heart” — the very root a later chapter in this same stretch meets again as ഹൃദയം, “heart” itself. Friendship, in Malayalam’s borrowed word for it, is a matter of the heart before it is a matter of anything else.

Everyday speech reaches just as often for കൂട്ടുകാരൻ/കൂട്ടുകാരി — native കൂട്ട് (*kūṭṭü*, “joining, group,” the same root as the verb കൂടുക, “to join, unite”) plus the agentive -കാരൻ/-കാരി. That suffix is itself borrowed, from Sanskrit कार (*kāra*, “maker, doer”) fused onto a Dravidian personal ending — so even Malayalam’s more casual, native-rooted word for “friend” leans on a Sanskrit-derived ending to finish the job. Selective borrowing, as *santōṣam* already showed back near the start of this book, does not always mean choosing one word wholesale over another; sometimes it means splicing a Dravidian root and a Sanskrit ending into a single new word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ithu ente suhṛttāṇŭ” — this is my friend
- the casual alternative — “kūṭṭukāran, kūṭṭukāri”
- the two pieces — “su,” good, plus “hṛd,” heart
- family and friend, one chapter — “kuṭumban̄i ... suhṛttŭ”

Before you move on

Say “this is my friend.” (*Ithu ente suhṛttāṇŭ*.) What does *suhṛttŭ* literally mean, piece by piece? (“**Good**” *su* + “**heart**” *hṛd*.) Name the everyday spoken alternative, and what its ending is borrowed from. (*Kūṭṭukāran/kūṭṭukāri* — the -കാരൻ/-കാരി ending is from Sanskrit *kāra*, “maker.”)

35.3 ി — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ഉ — what does it do?

One character this time. One only — and it has been sitting in front of you on pages you have already read.

Script you’ll notice: ി

ി — *-ṛ*.

It is a **vowel sign**, not a letter — it never stands alone. It hangs off the bottom-right of a consonant and turns that consonant’s built-in *a* into a short *ṛ*.

You have read it twice already, once in a month-name and once in the word for a friend.

- വൃശ്ചികം *vr̥ścikam* — the month, met with the calendar
- സുഹൃത്തു *suhṛttŭ* — friend, met on the page before this one

In both, look at the consonant the little hook is fastened to: ള becomes *vr̥*, and ഹ — the *ha* you have read since the working-verbs chapter — becomes *hṛ*.

Writing: ് — copy what you see

Put your pen on ് and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ് in the ones that have it

വൃശ്ചികം · സുഹൃത്ത് · സഹായം

- *Trace it:* ് three times, saying -r as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ് once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ്? What sound does it carry? (-r.)
Does this mark stand on its own, or does it need a consonant to hang from?

Chapter 36

Child, Son, Daughter

Modes: ⇄ voice (3) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say child, son and daughter in Malayalam, and say which of the three matches Tamil most closely and which one Kannada softened.

Say ithu ente makalaanu, set makan/makal beside Tamil's identical makan/makal and Kannada's softened maga/magalu, and ask ninte makanu ethra vayassundu using Chapter 19's dative-subject question again.

36.1 കുട്ടി (kuṭṭi) — “child, kid,” the general word before the specific ones

Suhṛttū named someone you choose. This chapter turns to someone you don't — the people a family is built around.

What to know first

കുട്ടി — *kuṭṭi* — child, kid

ഇത് എന്റെ കുട്ടിയാണ്. — *ithu ente kuṭṭiyāṇū.* — “This is my child.”

കുട്ടി is the general word — any child, before you say whose son or daughter.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

കുട്ടി is native Dravidian, matching Tamil’s குட்டி (*kuṭṭi*) closely. Both languages let the same word cover two things: a human child, and the young of an animal — a പൂച്ചക്കുട്ടി (*pūccakkuṭṭi*) is a kitten, built on പൂച്ച, “cat,” met earlier in this book, the same way **kuṭṭi** attaches to any animal name for its young. English does something similar with “kid,” which covers both a child and a baby goat — one small word, carrying the same double duty in two unrelated language families.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ithu ente kuṭṭiyāṇṭ” — this is my child
- the animal sense — “pūcca ... pūccakkuṭṭi” — cat, kitten
- the family and the friend, once more — “kuṭumbam ... suhṛttū”
- the six family people-words, and the group word — “acchan, amma ... kuṭumbam”

Before you move on

Say “this is my child.” (*Ithu ente kuṭṭiyāṇṭ*.) What two things can *kuṭṭi* mean? (**A human child**, or **the young of an animal** — like *pūccakkuṭṭi*, kitten.) Which English word carries the very same double duty? (**Kid**.) Name the six family people-words once more, and the group word none of them supplied. (*Acchan, amma, cēṭṭan, aniyān, cēcci, aniyatti* — and **kuṭumbam**.)

36.2 മക്കൾ (makan) — “son,” a word Tamil hardly changed at all

Kuṭṭi was the general word. Now the two specific ones — starting with the son.

What to know first

മകൻ — *makan* — son

ഇത് എന്റെ മകനാണ്. — *ithu ente makanāṇṭu*. — “This is my son.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

മകൻ continues **Proto-Dravidian *makan**, “son.” Tamil keeps almost the identical shape, **மகன்** (*makan*) — same consonants, same vowels, same final *-n*. Kannada moved further: the *-k-* between vowels softened to *-g-*, and the final *-n* dropped, giving **ಮಗ** (*maga*). So on this word it is Malayalam and Tamil that hold the older, more conservative shape, and Kannada that innovated — the same closeness the very first greetings already showed in *nandi*, *athe*, *illa* and *śari*, this time in a family word rather than a greeting.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ithu ente makanāṇṭu” — this is my son
- the two cousins — “makan” (Malayalam, Tamil) ... “maga” (Kannada)
- general then specific — “kuṭṭi ... makan”
- the friend-word, once more — “suhṛttū” — su plus hṛd

Before you move on

Say “this is my son.” (*Ithu ente makanāṇṭu*.) Which sister keeps almost the identical word? (**Tamil** — *makan*.) What did Kannada change? (**Softened *-k-* to *-g-*** and **dropped the final *-n***, giving *maga*.) What does *suhṛttū* literally mean? (**“Good-heart”** — *su* plus *hṛd*.)

36.3 മകൾ (makal) — “daughter,” the closest match yet

Makan matched Tamil closely. Its pair matches even closer — and gives you a reason to ask an old question again.

What to know first

മകൾ — *makal* — daughter

ഇത് എന്റെ മകളാണ്. — *ithu ente makalāṇṁ*. — “This is my daughter.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

മകൾ continues **Proto-Dravidian *makal**, “daughter.” Tamil’s **மகள்** (*makal*) is not just close — it is **identical**, sound for sound. Kannada shows the same softening you just met in *maga*: **ಮಗಳು** (*magalu*), *-k-* to *-g-*, plus a closing *-u*. So where *makan/makan* was already a close match, *makal/makal* is the closer one still — two sisters holding one Proto-Dravidian root letter for letter, four thousand years and a script apart.

Now that you have a son and a daughter, the age question comes back with someone new to ask it about: **ninre makanṁ ethra vayassuṇṭṭu?** — “how old is your son?” — the same dative-subject-plus-*uṇṭṭu* shape, unchanged.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ithu ente makalāṇṁ” — this is my daughter
- the identical pair — “makal, makal” — Malayalam, Tamil
- son, daughter, both cousins — “makan ... maga; makal ... magalu”
- the age question, asked again — “ninre makanṁ ethra vayassuṇṭṭu?”
- general, then specific, twice over — “kuṭṭi ... makan ... makal”

Before you move on

Say “this is my daughter.” (*Ithu ente makalāṇṭṭu.*) How closely does Tamil match this word, compared with *maṇa*? (**Even closer** — *maṇa* is **identical** sound for sound, where *maṇa* only nearly matched.) Ask “how old is your son?” using the age question’s shape. (*Ninre maṇaṇṭṭu ethra vayasunṭṭu?* — “to your son, how much age exists?”) What is the general word for a child, before *maṇa* or *maṇa*? (குட்டி, *kuṭṭi*.)

Chapter 37

Face Words

Modes:  voice (4)  pen (1)  Hands-free start: first 4 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my eye, ear, nose and mouth in Malayalam, and say which of the four the family agrees on almost completely and which one Kannada alone breaks from.

Name kannu, chevi, mookku and vaay, run the near-total four-way match on eye against chevi's three-against-one split on ear, and recall that Chapter 33 already named vaay once only to rule it out of vaayikkuka.

37.1 കണ്ണ് (kaṇṇũ) — “eye,” the same word four times over

തല, കൈ — head and hand, taught long ago, and nothing more of the body since, twenty-four chapters ago. This chapter adds four words to that short list, starting above the nose.

What to know first

കണ്ണ് — kaṇṇũ — eye

എന്റെ കണ്ണ്. — ente kaṇṇũ. — “My eye.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

കണ്ണ് continues **Proto-Dravidian *kaṇ**, “eye.” Tamil கண் (kaṇ) sits right beside it; Telugu కన్ను (kannu) and Kannada ಕಣ್ಣು (kaṇṇu) sit

closer still, both almost identical to Malayalam’s own form. Four languages that otherwise pull apart on nearly everything — tense marking, half their everyday vocabulary, even the shape of their scripts — agree almost completely on this one word. It joins തല and കൈ, met earlier, as the third body word, and the first to show this exact, near-total four-way match.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ente kaṇṇũ” — my eye
- the four sisters, nearly one word — “kaṇṇũ ... kaṇ ... kannu ... kaṇṇu”
- three body words now — “thala, kai, kaṇṇũ”
- family, then body — “makan, makaḷ ... kaṇṇũ”

Before you move on

Say “my eye.” (*Ente kaṇṇũ.*) Which three sisters come closest to matching Malayalam’s word? (**All three** — Tamil *kaṇ*, Telugu and Kannada both *ka(ṇ)ṇu* — a near-total four-way match.) Name the body words you have now. (*Thala*, head; *kai*, hand; *kaṇṇũ*, eye.) Name the previous chapter’s son and daughter words. (*Makan*, *makaḷ*.)

37.2 ചെവി (cevi) — “ear,” where Kannada is the odd one out

The four-way match on *kaṇṇũ* was close to perfect. This word breaks the pattern — but not the way you’d expect.

What to know first

ചെവി — *cevi* — ear

എന്റെ ചെവി. — *ente cevi.* — “My ear.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ചെവി continues **Proto-Dravidian *kewi**, “ear.” Tamil செவி (*cevi*) and Telugu చెవి (*cevi*) match Malayalam almost exactly — all three softened the old initial **k-** into a **c-/ch-** sound before this particular front vowel. **Kannada alone kept the older sound:** ಕಿವಿ (*kivi*), **k-** untouched. So this time it is not Malayalam standing apart from three sisters, the way *kuṭumbam*’s dressed *-am* did — it is Kannada, holding onto the sound the other three let go of.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ente *cevi*” — my ear
- three softened, one not — “cevi, cevi, cevi ... kivi”
- two face words now — “kaṇṇū, *cevi*”
- the closest family match — “makal, makal” — Malayalam, Tamil

Before you move on

Say “my ear.” (*Ente cevi.*) Which three sisters agree on this word, and which one differs? (**Malayalam, Tamil, Telugu** agree — **Kannada** alone keeps the older **k-** sound, *kivi*.) Why is that the reverse of what you might expect? (Usually Malayalam is the one that goes its own way; here Malayalam sides with the majority and **Kannada** is the outlier.) Which earlier word was identical between Malayalam and Tamil, sound for sound? (മകൾ, *makal*, daughter.)

37.3 മുക്ക് (mūkkū) — “nose,” and the same softening you met on “son”

Two face words down. This one brings back a sound-change from the last chapter, in a new place.

What to know first

മുക്ക് — *mūkkū* — nose

എന്റെ മുക്ക്. — *ente mūkkū*. — “My nose.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

മുക്ക് is native Dravidian, close to Tamil முக்கு (*mūkkū*) and Telugu ముక్కు (*mukku*). Kannada shows ಮೂಗು (*mūgu*) — the very same *-k-* to *-g-* softening you already met between Malayalam’s മകൻ and Kannada’s ಮಗ. It is a small, recurring signature: wherever Malayalam and Tamil hold a *-k-* between vowels, Kannada is likely to have worn it down to a *-g-*, whether the word is a family word or a body word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ente mūkkū” — my nose
- the recurring softening — “makan, maga ... mūkkū, mūgu”
- three face words — “kaṇṇū, cevi, mūkkū”
- three against one, once more — “cevi, cevi, cevi ... kivi”

Before you move on

Say “my nose.” (*Ente mūkkū*.) What does Kannada’s ಮೂಗು (*mūgu*) show, that you already saw once before? (**The same *-k-* to *-g-* softening** as *makan* → *maga*.) Name the three face words so far. (*Kaṇṇū*, eye; *cevi*, ear; *mūkkū*, nose.) Which sister alone breaks the family’s agreement on *cevi*? (**Kannada**, *kivi*.)

37.4 വായ് (*vāy*) — “mouth,” the word an earlier lesson named only to rule out

Ñān malayāḷam vāyikkunnu, “I read Malayalam” — and an earlier lesson told you the obvious-looking mouth-word inside it wasn’t really there. Here, at last, is the real one.

What to know first

വായ് — *vāy* — **mouth**

എന്റെ വായ്. — *ente vāy.* — “My mouth.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

വായ് is native Dravidian, matching Tamil **வாய்** (*vāy*) almost exactly. Kannada shows the family’s own **v-to-b** shift here, **ಬಾಯಿ** (*bāyi*) — the same shift, in reverse direction from the *k-to-c* softening *chevi* showed you, that turns up across the family’s native vocabulary. Telugu’s everyday word, **నోరు** (*nōru*), is a different root altogether.

An earlier lesson already put **വായ്** on the table once — as the wrong answer. **വായിക്കുക** (*vāyikkuka*, “to read”) looks built on this very word, and Gundert’s dictionary says it isn’t: the trail runs instead to Sanskrit **वच्** (*vac*), “to speak.” That lesson named *vāy* only to set it aside. This is the word itself, finally taught for what it actually means.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ente vāy” — my mouth
- the cousins — “vāy ... bāyi ... nōru” — Malayalam/Tamil, Kannada, Telugu
- the false trail, named again — “vāyikkuka” is NOT built on “vāy”
- all four face words — “kaṇṇũ, cevi, mūkkũ, vāy”

Before you move on

Say “my mouth.” (*Ente vāy.*) Which earlier lesson already mentioned *vāy*, and why? (**The *vāyikkuka* lesson**, to rule out that *vāyikkuka*, “to read,” is built on it.) What does Kannada’s *bāyi* show? (**The family’s v-to-b shift.**) Name all four face words. (*Kaṇṇũ*, eye; *cevi*, ear; *mūkkũ*, nose; *vāy*, mouth.)

37.5 ് — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ് — what does it do?

One character this time. One only — and it has been sitting in front of you on pages you have already read.

Script you'll notice: ്

് — *tha*.

It is a **consonant** carrying its own *a* — the breathy partner of the ് you have read since the greetings, the way ് is the breathy partner of a *b*.

Two words already in your hands carry it, and both are Sanskrit-layer, which is the pattern this letter keeps.

- കാലാവസ്ഥ *kālāvastha* — weather
- മിഥുനം *mithunam* — the month, met with the calendar

Hold ് and ് side by side and look at the middle of each shape — the breathy one carries an extra loop.

Writing: ് — copy what you see

Put your pen on ് and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ് in the ones that have it
കാലാവസ്ഥ · മിഥുനം · അതെ
- *Trace it:* ് three times, saying *tha* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ് once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — 𐌛? What sound does it carry? (*tha*.)
Which of 𐌚 and 𐌛 carries the puff of breath?

Chapter 38

The Two Hearts

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my heart in Malayalam two ways, one Sanskrit and one native, and say which one everyday idiom actually uses and why hridayam is a genuine cousin of the English word heart.

Name hridayam and nenchu, place nenchidippu beside the santosham/nandi pattern from Chapter 2, and trace hridayam’s root to the same PIE ancestor as English heart.

38.1 ഹൃദയം (hṛdayam) — “heart,” a cousin of the English word

Suhṛttŭ, “friend,” was built on **hṛd**, “heart” — a piece promised, not yet taught. Here it is, whole.

What to know first

ഹൃദയം — *hṛdayam* — heart

എന്റെ ഹൃദയം. — *ente hṛdayam*. — “My heart.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ഹൃദയം is Sanskrit हृदय (*hṛdaya*), “heart,” absorbed with the same nativizing -അം you already met on കൂടുംബം and ഇഷ്ടം. Its root, हृद् (*hṛd*), is not just Indo-Aryan but Indo-European: the same ancient

root that gave Greek **kardía**, Latin **cor/cordis**, and — by a long chain of regular sound changes inside Germanic — English **heart** itself. *Hṛdayam* and “heart” are genuine cousins, distant but real, through Sanskrit’s own branch of the family tree English belongs to. That resemblance is a coincidence of deep history, not of Malayalam’s own Dravidian family — Dravidian and Indo-European share no common ancestor at all. *Suhrttū*, “friend,” is this very root wearing “good” in front of it — **su** + **hṛd**, good-heart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ente hṛdayam” — my heart
- the distant cousins — “hṛdaya ... kardía ... cor ... heart”
- the friend-word, taken apart again — “su + hṛd”
- mouth, then heart — “vāy ... hṛdayam”
- all the face words once more — “kaṇṇū, cevi, mūkkū, vāy”

Before you move on

Say “my heart.” (*Ente hṛdayam*.) Is *hṛdayam* a Dravidian word or a Sanskrit one? (**Sanskrit**, dressed in Malayalam’s own *-am*.) Name an English word that is a genuine, if distant, cousin of *hṛd*. (**Heart** — both from the same PIE root, by way of Greek *kardía* and Latin *cor*.) Which earlier word was built on this same root? (സുഹൃത്ത് — *su* “good” + *hṛd* “heart.”)

38.2 നെഞ്ച് (nenchŭ) — “chest,” Malayalam’s other heart

ഹൃദയം was borrowed, formal, and shared with English by deep ancestry. This chapter’s second word is none of those three things.

What to know first

നെഞ്ച് — *nenchŭ* — chest

എന്റെ നെഞ്ച്. — *ente nenchŭ.* — “My chest.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

നെഞ്ച് is native Dravidian, cognate with Tamil’s own നെஞ்சு/നെஞ்சம் (*nenju/nenjam*), “chest.” Where ഹൃദയം names the organ and carries the Sanskrit-flavoured abstraction — a “heartfelt” thank-you, a broken heart in the literary sense — നെഞ്ച് is the word everyday idiom actually reaches for: നെഞ്ചിടിപ്പ് (*nenchiṭippŭ*), a heart pounding from fear or excitement, literally “chest-beat.”

Two hearts, then: one Sanskrit and formal, one native and physical. That is the same selective-borrowing pattern സന്തോഷം beside നന്ദി already showed, back near the start of this book — Malayalam does not simply prefer Sanskrit or prefer native; it keeps both, and lets register decide which one a given sentence reaches for. തല and കൈ, this stretch’s first two body words, were native throughout; ഹൃദയം and നെഞ്ച് show the same body carrying one word of each kind, side by side.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ente nenchŭ” — my chest
- two hearts — “hṛdayam,” formal; “nenchŭ,” everyday
- the idiom — “nenchiṭippŭ” — chest-beat, a pounding heart
- thala, kai, hṛdayam, nenchŭ — the body words so far
- mouth, once more — “vāy”

Before you move on

Say “my chest.” (*Ente nenchŭ.*) Which of this chapter’s two heart-words is native, and which is borrowed? (നെഞ്ച് native;

ഹൃദയം Sanskrit.) What does *nENCHİṭİppŭ* mean, literally?
 (“**Chest-beat**” — a pounding heart.) Which earlier pair showed
 this same native-plus-Sanskrit side-by-side pattern? (സന്തോഷം
beside നന്ദി, back near the start of this book.)

Chapter 39

Tea, Coffee, Milk

Modes: 🗣️ voice (3) ✍️ pen (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 3 of 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can politely ask for tea, coffee or milk in Malayalam, and trace each word back along the road it travelled to get here.

Ask dayavaayi oru paal, run chaaya's overland Persian route against kaapi's maritime Arabic-Turkish-Italian-English one, and set paal's perfect three-way match against Chapter 15's vellam, which broke from Tamil entirely.

39.1 ചായ (chāya) — “tea,” which walked to Kerala rather than sailed

Two hearts done. Now the drink you would politely ask for first, in any Kerala home — and a chance to put the polite ദയവായി back to work.

What to know first

ചായ — *chāya* — tea

ദയവായി ഒരു ചായ. — *dayavāyi oru chāya*. — “A tea, please.”

Dayavāyi has been yours since early in this book; *oru*, “a/one,” you have already met attached to *nāl* and *maṇi*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ചായ traces to Northern Chinese **chá**, carried overland along Central Asian trade routes into Persian چای (*chāy*), and from there into Hindi-Urdu *chāy* and Malayalam *chāya* alike — the same land route most of North and South India took for their word for tea. Tea that instead reached Europe by **sea** kept a different, southern Chinese form, which is why English says **tea** and French says *thé* — one leaf, two roads: chai by land, tea by sea.

Grammar Lens: the two hearts, and the spine node so far

ദയവായി ഒരു ചായ leans on the very dative already named, **-ikku/-inu** — the same suffix beside Tamil’s *-ukku*, Telugu’s *-ku*, and Kannada’s *-ge*. This chapter carries both halves of the spine node ദയവായി and ഹൃദയം/നെഞ്ച് already opened: asking politely, and — if you ask for the wrong thing — repairing with ക്ഷമിക്കണം.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dayavāyi oru chāya” — a tea, please
- the road — “chá ... chāy ... chāya”
- land against sea — “chai ... tea”
- please, once more, and its plainer everyday form — “dayavāyi ... irikkū”
- two hearts, once more — “hṛdayam ... nenchū”

Before you move on

Ask for tea, politely. (*Dayavāyi oru chāya*.) Name the three languages *chāya* passed through, in order. (**Chinese**, then **Persian**, then **Hindi-Urdu**, into Malayalam.) Why does English say “tea” instead of “chai”? (**It arrived by sea**, carrying a different Chinese form.) Which dative suffix does *dayavāyi ... enikku* share with Tamil, Telugu and Kannada? (**The dative** — *-ikku/-ukku/-ku/-ge*.) What is the repair half of this spine node’s word pair?

(ക്ഷമിക്കണം, sorry.)

39.2 കാപ്പി (kāppi) — “coffee,” which sailed while tea walked

Chāya travelled overland. This drink took the opposite road — and arrives from further away.

What to know first

കാപ്പി — *kāppi* — coffee

ദയവായി ഒരു കാപ്പി. — *dayavāyi oru kāppi*. — “A coffee, please.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

കാപ്പി comes from **English** *coffee*, borrowed during the colonial period and reshaped to Malayalam’s own consonants and vowels. English’s own word for the drink is itself a loan, several times over: Arabic قهوة (*qahwah*) became Turkish **kahve**, then Italian **caffè**, then English *coffee*, before finally landing in Kerala as **kāppi**.

Set the two drinks side by side: ചായ walked overland from China, through Persia, into North and South Indian speech alike. കാപ്പി sailed from Arabia, through Ottoman Turkey and Renaissance Italy, into English, and only then into Malayalam. Two drinks, two opposite roads — one over land, one over sea — meeting on the very same tea-shop counter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dayavāyi oru kāppi” — a coffee, please
- the long road — “qahwah ... kahve ... caffè ... coffee ... kāppi”
- two drinks, two roads — “chāya,” overland; “kāppi,” by sea
- two hearts, still — “hṛdayam ... nenchū”

Before you move on

Ask for coffee, politely. (*Dayavāyi oru kāppi.*) Which language did Malayalam borrow *kāppi* directly from? (**English.**) Name the four languages the word passed through before that. (**Arabic, Turkish, Italian, English.**) Which of this chapter’s two drinks travelled by land, and which by sea? (*Chāya* by **land**; *kāppi* by **sea**.)

39.3 പാൽ (pāl) — “milk,” where Tamil agrees completely

വെള്ളം, the earlier water-word, broke away from Tamil’s water-word entirely. This drink, the third in the chapter, does the opposite.

What to know first

പാൽ — *pāl* — milk

ദയവായി ഒരു പാൽ. — *dayavāyi oru pāl.* — “A milk, please.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

പാൽ is native Dravidian, from **Proto-South-Dravidian *pāl**, “milk.” Tamil keeps the shape **unchanged**: பால் (*pāl*), letter for letter the same as Malayalam. Kannada shows its own regular **p-to-h** sound law here too, giving ಹಾಲು (*hālu*) — the identical shift that turns Malayalam’s *pōkuka* into Kannada’s *hōgu*.

Set beside the water-word’s finding, this is the mirror image: വെള്ളം (water) broke from Tamil’s *nīr* entirely, choosing a completely different root; പാൽ (milk) shows the opposite — perfect three-way agreement in shape, with only Kannada’s regular sound law setting its form apart. Two everyday liquids, two entirely different outcomes.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “dayavāyi oru pāl” — a milk, please

- unchanged, then shifted — “pāl ... pāl ... hālu” — Malayalam, Tamil, Kannada
- water against milk — “veḷḷam broke away; pāl agrees”
- three drinks, once more — “chāya, kāppi, pāl”
- the long road, once more — “qahwah ... kahve ... caffè ... kāppi”

Before you move on

Ask for milk, politely. (*Dayavāyi oru pāl.*) Does Tamil’s word for milk match Malayalam’s? (**Yes — exactly, pāl** both.) What does Kannada’s *hālu* show? (**The regular p-to-h law.**) Which earlier liquid word broke from Tamil entirely, unlike this one? (ಎಲ್ಲೊ, water.)

39.4 ് — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ് — what does it do?

One character this time. One only — and it has been sitting in front of you on pages you have already read.

Script you’ll notice: ്

് — *ga*.

It is a **consonant** carrying its own *a* — the voiced partner of ക *ka*. Put your fingers on your throat and say *ka*, then *ga*: the second one hums.

This one is different from the seven before it: no word you have met so far is written with it. It is being put into your hand early, so that the day a word like *anugrahaṁ* (a blessing) arrives, the shape is already familiar and only the meaning is new.

Two shapes stand close to it, and both are ones you can already read:

- ക *ka* — the very first letter of this book’s script ladder; ് is what it sounds like with the voice switched on
- ണ — the humming pair inside നിങ്ങൾ *ninnal*, a different letter and a different sound

Say *ka* · *ga* twice over, then look at the two shapes again.

Writing: ഴ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ഴ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ഴ in the ones that have it

ക · ഴ · നിങ്ങൾ

- *Trace it:* ഴ three times, saying *ga* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ഴ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ഴ? What sound does it carry? (*ga.*)
Which of ക and ഴ hums in the throat?

Chapter 40

The Meal

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I am having a meal in Malayalam, using a second eat-verb this book never taught until now, and close the polite-request-and-repair stretch that dayavaayi opened eight chapters ago.

Say njaan oon unnunnu against Chapter 32's tinnunnu, say enikku oon ishtamaanu on Chapter 6's dative and Chapter 34's frame, and name kshamikkanam as the repair half of the spine node dayavaayi's asking half opened.

40.1 ഉൺ (ūṇ) — “a meal,” the word that closes this stretch’s table

An earlier chapter taught തിന്നുക, “to eat,” for anything at all. It never taught the word for a proper, sit-down meal. Here it is.

What to know first

ഉൺ — *ūṇ* — a meal

ഞാൻ ഉൺ ഉണ്ണുന്നു. — *ñān ūṇ unṇunnu.* — “I am having a meal.”

The letters in this word

ഊ is the **independent** long-*ū* vowel — the shape a word uses when it *opens* with this sound and there is no consonant in front of it to carry the small sign ു instead. It is the same kind of independent vowel letter as the very first inherent-*a* opening; the sound only changes shape depending on what, if anything, comes before it.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ഊൺ is native Dravidian, sharing its root with the verb ഉണ്ണുക (*uṇṇuka*), “to eat a meal” — a second eat-verb this book has never taught, standing beside the everyday തിന്നുക. The difference is the same one English makes between “eating” in general and “having a meal”: *tinnuka* covers a snack, a fruit, anything at all; *uṇṇuka* names sitting down to the real thing.

Tamil’s cognate ഉணவு (*uṇavu*) generalised the very same root all the way to “food” itself. Kannada’s ഈട (*ūṭa*) narrowed it to “a meal,” matching Malayalam’s own ഈൺ sense for sense — three sisters, one Proto-Dravidian root, three different landing points.

Grammar Lens: the stretch this chapter closes

എനിക്ക് ഊൺ ഇഷ്ടമാണ്. — *enikku ūṇ iṣṭamāṇṁ*. — “I like having a meal” — the familiar dative **-ikku**, the *iṣṭam* liking-frame, one more turn of the same machine.

This chapter closes the spine node ദയവായി opened: ദയവായി asks; ക്ഷമിക്കണം repairs, the word for showing up after the ഊൺ is already over. And **-ikku** is still the same cousin of Tamil’s **-ukku**, Telugu’s **-ku**, and Kannada’s **-ge** that was first named earlier in this book.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ñān ūṇ uṇṇunnu” — I am having a meal
- everyday against a proper meal — “tinnunnu ... uṇṇunnu”
- “enikku ūṇ iṣṭamāṇṁ” — I like having a meal
- ask, then repair — “dayavāyi ... kṣamikkaṇaṁ”

- this chapter’s three drinks and its meal — “chāya, kāppi, pāl ... ūṇ”

Before you move on

Say “I am having a meal.” (*Ñān ūṇ uṇṇunnu.*) How does *uṇṇuka* differ from the everyday *tinnuka*? (*Tinnuka* is **eating in general**; *uṇṇuka* is **having a proper meal**.) What are the two halves this spine node runs between? (ദയവായി asks; ക്ഷമിക്കണം repairs.)

Chapter 41

Pointing, and Asking

Modes: ⇄ voice (7) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 7 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can point at something in Malayalam and ask who or where it is — and I can say what the six words have in common.

Say the near word, the far word and the question word in a row, and name the part that changed.

41.1 ഇത് (itŭ) — this one — the thing near me

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You’ll want to know: ഇത്

ഇത് — *itŭ* — this one — the thing near me.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is അത് *atŭ*, which you will meet in a moment. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **i-** for near — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ഇത്” three times, pointing at something different each time

- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *itũ*? (this one — the thing near me.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**i-** — near.)

41.2 അത് (atũ) — that one — the thing over there

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: അത്

അത് — *atũ* — that one — the thing over there.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is ഇത് *itũ*, which you will meet just now. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **a-** for far — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “അത്” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *atũ*? (that one — the thing over there.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**a-** — far.)

41.3 ഇവിടെ (iviṭe) — here — where I am

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: ഇവിടെ

ഇവിടെ — *ivite* — here — where I am.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is അവിടെ *avite*, which you will meet in a moment. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **i-** for near — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ഇവിടെ” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *ivite*? (here — where I am.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**i-** — near.)

41.4 അവിടെ (*avite*) — there — where I am not

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: അവിടെ

അവിടെ — *avite* — there — where I am not.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is ഇവിടെ *ivite*, which you will meet just now. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **a-** for far — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “അവിടെ” three times, pointing at something different each time

- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *avite*? (there — where I am not.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**a-** — far.)

41.5 ആര് (ārū) — who? — asking about a person

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: ആര്

ആര് — *ārū* — who? — asking about a person.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is എവിടെ *evite*, which you will meet in a moment. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **e-** for ask — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ആര്” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *ārū*? (who? — asking about a person.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**e-** — ask.)

41.6 എവിടെ (evite) — where? — asking about a place

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: എവിടെ

എവിടെ — *evite* — where? — asking about a place.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is ആര് *ārū*, which you will meet just now. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **e-** for ask — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “എവിടെ” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *evite*? (where? — asking about a place.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**e-** — ask.)

41.7 i- / a- / e- — six words, one machine

Say the six words from this chapter out loud, in order. Listen to how they begin.

Grammar lens: one slot changes

You did not learn six words. You learned **three beginnings** and reused them.

meaning	word
near	ഇവിടെ <i>ivite</i>
far	അവിടെ <i>avite</i>
question	എവിടെ <i>evite</i>

Malayalam spells the pattern out longest — ഇവിടെ, അവിടെ, എവിടെ — which makes it the easiest to hear. Change the front, and the meaning walks from **near** to **far** to a **question**. Nothing else in the word moves.

The same three beginnings run the thing-words too: ഇത് *itŭ* and അത് *atŭ* start exactly like the first two rows. This chapter did not teach you the matching question word for things — that one arrives later, and when it does you will already know what it has to start with. This is worth more than the six words are. When you meet a new word in this family later, you will not have to be taught all three of it — you will be taught one and work out the others.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the near word, then the far word, then the question word
- *Say it:* them again for place, not for things
- *Notice:* the part that did NOT change

Before you move on

Which beginning means near? (**i-**) Far? (**a-**) And which one turns the word into a question? (**e-**)

Chapter 42

Describing Things

Modes: 🗣️ voice (6) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can point at something in Malayalam and ask who or where it is — and I can say what the six words have in common.

Say the near word, the far word and the question word in a row, and name the part that changed.

42.1 വലിയ (valiya) — big

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You’ll want to know: വലിയ

വലിയ — *valiya* — big.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “വലിയ” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *valiya*? (**big.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

42.2 ചെറിയ (*ceriya*) — small

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: ചെറിയ

ചെറിയ — *ceriya* — small.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met വലിയ *valiya* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ചെറിയ” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *ceriya*? (**small.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

42.3 നല്ല (*nalla*) — good

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: നല്ല

നല്ല — *nalla* — good.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met ചെറിയ *ceriya* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “നല്ല” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *nalla*? (**good.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

42.4 പുതിയ (putiya) — new

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: പുതിയ

പുതിയ — *putiya* — new.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met നല്ല *nalla* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “പുതിയ” three times, pointing at something different each time

- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *putiya*? (**new.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

42.5 പഴയ (*palaya*) — old — of a thing, not of a person

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: പഴയ

പഴയ — *palaya* — old — of a thing, not of a person.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met പുതിയ *putiya* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “പഴയ” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *palaya*? (**old — of a thing, not of a person.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

42.6 before the noun, unchanged — five words, one rule

Say the five words from this chapter out loud, then say each one in front of a noun you already know.

Grammar lens: where an adjective goes

You did not learn five separate words. You learned **where an adjective goes**, and five words that go there.

meaning	word
big	വലിയ <i>valiya</i>
small	ചെറിയ <i>ce<u>r</u>iya</i>
good	നല്ല <i>nalla</i>

Every one ends in -a, sits in front of the noun, and never changes. This is worth more than the five words are. Every noun you already know — your name, the house, the water, the day — can now take any of them in front, and every adjective you meet from here goes in the same place.

Your turn

- *Say it*: each of the five in front of a noun you already know
- *Say it*: two of them with the same noun, one after the other
- *Notice*: whether the adjective changed shape when the noun did

Before you move on

Where does an adjective go in this language? (**In front of the noun.**) Does it change shape to match the noun? (unchanged.)

Chapter 43

More Everyday Verbs

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell someone to come, sit, stand and give in Malayalam.

Complete ML-C43-give and say all four verbs in order.

43.1 ഒടൂ (ōṭū) — run

A short run of everyday verbs, one at a time.

You'll want to know: ഒടൂ

ഒടൂ (ōṭū) — “run”.

The long final *ū* softens a command into an invitation — Malayalam marks courtesy in the verb ending itself.

What you've built

One more everyday action. Three more follow, and each reuses the ones before it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ōṭū*
- it again, to someone standing in a doorway

Before you move on

What does ഓടൂ mean? (“run”.) Say it once more.

43.2 ഉറങ്ങൂ (*uraṅṅū*) — sleep

Before the new one: what did *ōṭū* mean?

You’ll want to know: ഉറങ്ങൂ

ഉറങ്ങൂ (*uraṅṅū*) — “sleep”.

Same softening vowel — said to a child at night rather than as an order.

What you’ve built

One more everyday action. Three more follow, and each reuses the ones before it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *uraṅṅū*
- it again, to someone standing in a doorway
- it after *ōṭū*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does ഉറങ്ങൂ mean? (“sleep”.) Say it once more.

43.3 നിൽക്കൂ (*nilkkū*) — stand

Before the new one: what did *uraṅṅū* mean?

You’ll want to know: നിൽക്കൂ

നിൽക്കൂ (*nilkkū*) — “stand”.

Its pair, with the same courteous ending.

What you've built

One more everyday action. Three more follow, and each reuses the ones before it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nilkkū*
- it again, to someone standing in a doorway
- it after *uranñū*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does നിൽക്കൂ mean? (“stand”.) Say it once more.

43.4 തരൂ (tarū) — give

Before the new one: what did *nilkkū* mean?

You'll want to know: തരൂ

തരൂ (*tarū*) — “give”.

‘Give — to me.’ Malayalam distinguishes giving toward the speaker from giving away; this is the toward-me one.

What you've built

One more everyday action. That closes the run: four everyday actions, each met on its own.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tarū*
- it again, to someone standing in a doorway
- it after *nilkkū*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does തരൂ mean? (“give”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 44

Verbs of Seeing and Saying

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell someone to look, listen, speak and write in Malayalam.

Complete ML-C44-write and say all four verbs in order.

44.1 നോക്കൂ (nōkkū) — look

Four verbs for taking things in and putting them out, one at a time.

You'll want to know: നോക്കൂ

നോക്കൂ (nōkkū) — “look”.

The same *nōkk-* stem as Kannada's *nōḍu*, with Malayalam's courteous long *ū* on the end.

What you've built

One more. Three follow, and each reuses the ones before.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nōkkū*
- it once more, slowly

Before you move on

What does നോക്കു mean? (“look”). Say it once more.

44.2 കേൾക്കു (kēḷkkū) — listen

Before the new one: what did *nōkkū* mean?

You’ll want to know: കേൾക്കു

കേൾക്കു (*kēḷkkū*) — “listen”.

And Kannada’s *kēḷu* again. Malayalam separated from Tamil later than the others, but this stem is older than any of the splits.

What you’ve built

One more. Three follow, and each reuses the ones before.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kēḷkkū*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *nōkkū*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does കേൾക്കു mean? (“listen”). Say it once more.

44.3 സംസാരിക്കു (saṁsārikkū) — speak

Before the new one: what did *kēḷkkū* mean?

You’ll want to know: സംസാരിക്കു

സംസാരിക്കു (*saṁsārikkū*) — “speak”.

From Sanskrit *saṁsāra* — literally ‘going around together’. The everyday Malayalam word for conversing is a Sanskrit compound, which is how much of the language’s formal vocabulary arrived.

What you’ve built

One more. Three follow, and each reuses the ones before.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *saṁsārikkū*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *kēlkkū*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does സംസാരിക്കൂ mean? (“speak”). Say it once more.

44.4 എഴുതു (*elutū*) — write

Before the new one: what did *saṁsārikkū* mean?

You’ll want to know: എഴുതു

എഴുതു (*elutū*) — “write”.

From *eluttu*, ‘letter’ — the writing verb is built from the thing written, which is the reverse of how Kannada does it.

What you’ve built

That closes the run: look, listen, speak, write.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *elutū*
- it once more, slowly

- it after *samisārikkū*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does എഴുത mean? (“write”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 45

Grandparents, and the Married Pair

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name four more family and people words in this language.

Complete ML-C45-wife and say all four words in order.

45.1 മുത്തച്ഛൻ (muttacchan) — grandfather

Before the new one: what did *elutū* mean?

You'll want to know: മുത്തച്ഛൻ

മുത്തച്ഛൻ (*muttacchan*) — “grandfather”.

Two pieces, both audible: *mutta*-, ‘elder, senior’, and *acchan*, the ‘father’ from the family lesson. Literally, an elder father. Where Sanskrit would reach for a compound of its own, Malayalam assembles this one out of words the learner already owns.

What you’ve built

The first of four family words. Three follow, and each reuses the ones before.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *muttacchan*
- it once more, slowly, hearing the two halves
- it after *elutū*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does മുത്തച്ഛൻ mean? (“grandfather”.) Say it once more.

45.2 മുത്തശ്ശി (muttaśśi) — grandmother

Before the new one: what did *muttacchan* mean?

You’ll want to know: മുത്തശ്ശി

മുത്തശ്ശി (*muttaśśi*) — “grandmother”.

The same *mutta-* opens it, so half the word is already yours. The second half is not as transparent as the grandfather word’s: *-aśśi* is an old term of address for an elder woman rather than the everyday *amma* you already know, and dictionaries stop short of a confident breakdown. Better to flag that than to pretend the two halves match.

What you’ve built

Two of four, and one honest gap in the analysis.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *muttaśśi*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *muttacchan*, and name the half they share

Before you move on

What does മുത്തശ്ശി mean? (“grandmother”.) Say it once more.

45.3 ഭർത്താവ് (bharttāvũ) — husband

Before the new one: what did *muttaśśi* mean?

You’ll want to know: ഭർത്താവ്

ഭർത്താവ് (*bharttāvũ*) — “husband”.

Sanskrit *bhartṛ* with a Malayalam ending, *-āvũ*, fitted onto it. Inside sits the root *bhr̥*, ‘to bear, to carry, to support’, so the word says ‘the one who supports’. The root is old enough to have relatives well outside India: Latin *fero*, ‘I carry’, and English *bear* both continue it.

What you’ve built

Three of four. The last word grows from the same root.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *bharttāvũ*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *muttaśśi*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does ഭർത്താവ് mean? (“husband”.) Say it once more.

45.4 ഭാര്യ (bhārya) — wife

Before the new one: what did *bharttāvũ* mean?

You'll want to know: భార్య

భార్య (*bhārya*) — “wife”.

The same root *bhṛ* as the last word, ending differently: ‘she who is to be supported’. Telugu borrowed the identical pair from Sanskrit, so *bharta* and *bhārya* there are these two words again, wearing local endings. What the pair records is Sanskrit’s older picture of a household, not a modern one — worth saying out loud rather than smoothing over.

What you’ve built

That closes the run: grandfather, grandmother, husband, wife.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *bhārya*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *bharttāvũ*, and name the root they share

Before you move on

What does భార్య mean? (“wife”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 46

Things You Ask For

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five everyday things I might ask someone for in Malayalam, and say which of them the language has held all along and which walked in from elsewhere.

Complete ML-C46-book and say all five words in order.

46.1 പഴം (pa_lam) — a fruit

Before the new run of words: what did *bharttāvũ* mean, and what did *bhārya* mean?

You’ll want to know: പഴം

പഴം (*pa_lam*) — “a fruit”.

Behind the fruit sits a verb of ripening. Proto-Dravidian ***pal**, ‘to ripen, to grow old’, handed this family both a fruit and an age, and Malayalam kept the pair close enough that a learner can still hear it: പഴയ (*pa_laya*), the “old” from the run of adjectives, is that same root wearing an adjective ending.

Tamil says பழம் (*pa_lam*), which is very nearly the identical word — the ordinary state of affairs between these two closest sisters. Telugu went to పండు (*paṇḍu*) and Kannada to ಹಣ್ಣು (*haṇṇu*), and the Kannada form has lost its opening *p*- to a shift Malayalam sat out entirely.

The **ഴ** in the middle is the letter this book has already called Malayalam’s own oddity, the one only these two sisters still write.

What you've built

The first of five things you might ask someone for.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *palamī*
- it once more, slowly
- *palamī*, then *dayavāyī palamī tarū* — “please give a fruit”

Before you move on

What does പഴം mean? (“a fruit”.) Say it once more.

46.2 തുണി (tuṇi) — cloth

Before the new one: what did *palamī* mean?

You'll want to know: തുണി

തുണി (*tuṇi*) — “cloth”.

തുണി is the plain, unceremonious word: the bolt on the shelf, the washing on the line, the rag in your hand. Tamil writes துணி (*tuṇi*) and means the same thing.

Malayalam holds a dressier word for the same stuff — വസ്ത്രം (*vas-tram*), out of Sanskrit — and it turns up on a wedding invitation rather than over a washing line. The native word does the daily work; the borrowed one does the ceremony.

That division of labour is worth watching for, because it repeats through this book: two words, one meaning, and the register telling them apart.

What you've built

Two: a fruit and a cloth.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tun̥i*
- it once more, slowly
- *palam̥i*, then *tun̥i*, and ask for each one with *dayavāyi*

Before you move on

What does തുണി mean? (“cloth”.) Say it once more.

46.3 വിളക്ക് (viḷakkŭ) — a lamp

Before the new one: what did *tun̥i* mean?

You’ll want to know: വിളക്ക്

വിളക്ക് (*viḷakkŭ*) — “a lamp”.

A native word, built on a root about shining. Tamil விளக்கு (*vilakku*) is the same word, and in both languages a related sense — making something clear, shining a light on it — sits alongside the object.

The object itself has a particular shape in Kerala: the നിലവിളക്ക് (*nilaviḷakkŭ*), the tall standing brass lamp lit at a doorway on an occasion. Its first piece is നില (*nila*), the ground it stands on.

Kannada reached for a borrowed word here, ದೀಪ (*dīpa*) from Sanskrit, where Malayalam kept its own. Malayalam has ദീപം (*dīpaṁ*) as well, in temple and festival senses, which leaves the everyday lamp to the older resident.

What you’ve built

Three. A fruit, a cloth, a lamp.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *viḷakkŭ*

- it once more, slowly
- *viḷakkũ*, then *tun̄i*, and hear which of the two is the older resident

Before you move on

What does വിളക്ക് mean? (“a lamp”.) Say it once more.

46.4 ഉപ്പ് (uppũ) — salt

Before the new one: what did *viḷakkũ* mean?

You’ll want to know: ഉപ്പ്

ഉപ്പ് (*uppũ*) — “salt”.

Proto-Dravidian ***uppu**, and the whole family kept it very nearly untouched: Tamil உப்பு, Telugu ఉప్పు, Kannada ಉಪ್ಪು. Four sisters, one word, four spellings of it.

There is a *p* sitting inside this word, and in Kannada it did not turn into an *h* the way the *p* of its fruit-word did. The shift that separated ಹಣ್ಣು from പഴം reached only the FIRST sound of a word. Inside one, the *p* stays where it was put — which is why salt looks so alike on all four sides of the family.

The final ് here is the half-vowel this book romanizes -*ũ*: a consonant let go of rather than cut off.

What you’ve built

Four. Salt, and the fruit, and the cloth, and the lamp.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *uppũ*
- it once more, slowly
- *uppũ*, then *palam̄i*, and notice the *p* the cousins kept in one word and lost in the other

Before you move on

What does ഉപ്പ് mean? (“salt”.) Say it once more.

46.5 പുസ്തകം (pustakam) — a book

Before the new one: what did *uppũ* mean?

You’ll want to know: പുസ്തകം

പുസ്തകം (*pustakam*) — “a book”.

Sanskrit *pustaka*, taken whole. Tamil புத்தகம், Telugu పుస్తకం and Kannada ಪುಸ್ತಕ are the same borrowing, so the four sisters agree here for a different reason than they agree about salt: not descent, but a shared debt.

Sanskrit itself seems to have taken it from further west. The usual trail runs to Persian *post*, a hide or a skin — the material a book was, before it was paper. A word for the animal became a word for the page.

Malayalam also says *grantham* for a book of weight and age, another Sanskrit word, and that one is built on a root about knotting: palm leaves tied into a bundle. Two borrowings, two different pictures of what a book physically was.

What you’ve built

Five, and the run is closed: a fruit, a cloth, a lamp, salt, a book.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pustakam*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *palam*, *tuṇi*, *vilakkũ*, *uppũ*, *pustakam*

Before you move on

What does പുസ്തകം mean? (“a book”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 47

The Leg and the Tooth

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five more parts of the body in Malayalam, and point to the sound exchanges that separate them from their Tamil, Telugu and Kannada cousins.

Complete ML-C47-stomach and say all five words in order.

47.1 കാൽ (kāḷ) — leg, foot

Before the new run of words: what did *uppū* mean, and what did *pustakani* mean?

You’ll want to know: കാൽ

കാൽ (*kāl*) — “leg, foot”.

Proto-Dravidian **kāl*, and every sister kept it nearly whole: Tamil കാൽ, Telugu కాలు, Kannada ಕಾಲ. Malayalam alone stops the word dead on its *l*.

That final ൽ is a chillu — a consonant written with no vowel after it and no virama under it, given a letter of its own. This book has already taught one of them, the ൽ inside നിങ്ങൾ. ൽ is its plainer neighbour.

കാൽ covers the whole limb, foot and leg together. It also names a quarter — a fourth of anything — so a quarter of a rupee and the leg you stand on are written the same way. Nothing joins them but an accident of sound, and context is the only fix, which is what context is for.

What you've built

The first of five more body words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kāl*
- it once more, slowly
- *kāl*, then *kaṇṇũ*, so the bottom and the top sit together

Before you move on

What does കാൽ mean? (“leg, foot”.) Say it once more.

47.2 പല്ല് (pallũ) — a tooth

Before the new one: what did *kāl* mean?

You'll want to know: പല്ല്

പല്ല് (*pallũ*) — “a tooth”.

Proto-Dravidian ***pal**, another word the family barely touched: Tamil பல், Telugu పన్ను, Kannada ಹಲ್ಲ.

Kannada is the odd one again, and for the reason already met with the fruit — an opening *p* that became *h*. Set ಹಲ್ಲ beside പല്ല and the only real difference is that first letter. Telugu did something else altogether, turning the *l* into an *n*.

Malayalam doubles the *l* and then lets the word go with the half-vowel, the same ending as the salt-word.

What you've built

Two body words: a leg and a tooth.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pallŭ*
- it once more, slowly
- *kāl*, then *pallŭ*, and hear the doubled letter in the second

Before you move on

What does പല്ല mean? (“a tooth”.) Say it once more.

47.3 മുടി (muṭi) — hair

Before the new one: what did *pallŭ* mean?

You’ll want to know: മുടി

മുടി (*muṭi*) — “hair”.

The everyday word for the hair on a head. Tamil முடி (*muṭi*) is the same word, and in both languages it keeps company with a sense of finishing or topping off — the crown of a thing as well as what grows there.

Kannada took a different route entirely, ಕೂದಲು (*kūḍalu*), which Tamil also has as கூந்தல் (*kūntal*) for long hair worn loose. So the family has two hair-words and the sisters split over which one became the ordinary one.

Malayalam keeps രോമം (*rōmam*), a Sanskrit word, for hair on the body rather than the head — a second case of a borrowing taking the narrower job.

What you’ve built

Three. A leg, a tooth, hair.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *muṭi*
- it once more, slowly
- *muṭi*, then *thala*, so the head and what grows on it sit together

Before you move on

What does മുടി mean? (“hair”.) Say it once more.

47.4 വിരൽ (viral) — a finger

Before the new one: what did *muṭi* mean?

You’ll want to know: വിരൽ

വിരൽ (*viral*) — “a finger”.

Proto-Dravidian ***viral**, and Tamil விரல் (*viral*) matches Malayalam letter for letter, chillu and all.

Kannada has ಬೆರಳು (*beraḷu*), where the opening *v*- has hardened into a *b*-. That exchange runs the other way through the family often enough to be worth naming: a *v* at the front of a Kannada word is frequently a *b*, and this is one of the clearest cases. Telugu walked away from the root and says వేలు (*vēlu*).

The word ends in the same chillu ൾ as the leg-word, two chapters’ worth of body parts stopping on the same letter.

What you’ve built

Four. A leg, a tooth, hair, a finger.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *viral*
- it once more, slowly
- *viral*, then *kāl*, and hear the same chillu close both

Before you move on

What does വിരൽ mean? (“a finger”.) Say it once more.

47.5 ವಯರ್ (vayarũ) — the stomach, the belly

Before the new one: what did *viral* mean?

You’ll want to know: ವಯರ್

ವಯರ್ (vayarũ) — “the stomach, the belly”.

Native, and Tamil வயிறு (vayiru) is again the near-twin. The two sisters agree on the belly where the other two do not: Kannada says ಹೊಟ್ಟೆ (hotte) and Telugu పొట్ట (potṭa), a pair that plainly belong together and just as plainly do not belong with this one.

So on a single body the family sorts itself twice over. Leg, tooth and finger run back to one shared ancestor; the belly splits the four into two camps of two.

The ends of these words are worth a moment as well. This one closes on ೆ, the hard *r* with the half-vowel after it.

What you’ve built

Five, and the run is closed: a leg, a tooth, hair, a finger, a belly.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- vayarũ
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *kāl*, *pallũ*, *muṭi*, *viral*, *vayarũ*

Before you move on

What does ವಯರ್ mean? (“the stomach, the belly”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 48

Who Someone Is

Modes: ⇌ voice (5) ⇌ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what someone’s work is in Malayalam, and recognise the masculine ending that three of the five words share.

Complete ML-C48-guest and say all five words in order.

48.1 അധ്യാപകൻ (adhyāpakan) — a teacher

Before the new run of words: what did *viral* mean, and what did *vayarũ* mean?

You’ll want to know: അധ്യാപകൻ

അധ്യാപകൻ (*adhyāpakan*) — “a teacher”.

Sanskrit *adhyāpaka*, ‘one who causes another to study’, with a Malayalam ending fastened on: the chillu ന് that marks a masculine noun and that this book has already met at the end of മകൻ and മുത്തച്ഛൻ.

The Sanskrit word is itself built out of a going-toward: *adhi* plus a root about approaching, so a teacher is the one who brings the student up to the text.

Kannada picked a different Sanskrit word for the same job, ಶിಕ್ಷക (śikṣaka). Two sisters, two borrowings, one classroom — which is a fair picture of how these languages have handled Sanskrit generally: not one loan, but a choice among several.

What you've built

The first of five words for who someone is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *adhyāpakan*
- it once more, slowly
- *adhyāpakan*, then *maṇan*, and hear the same chillu close both

Before you move on

What does അധ്യാപകൻ mean? (“a teacher”.) Say it once more.

48.2 വിദ്യാർത്ഥി (vidyārtthi) — a student

Before the new one: what did *adhyāpakan* mean?

You'll want to know: വിദ്യാർത്ഥി

വിദ്യാർത്ഥി (*vidyārtthi*) — “a student”.

Two Sanskrit pieces, and both are legible once pointed at: *vidyā*, ‘knowledge’, and *arthin*, ‘one who seeks’. A student is a knowledge-seeker, said outright.

Kannada has ವಿದ್ಯಾರ್ಥಿ (*vidyārthi*), the identical borrowing. Where the teacher-words parted company, the student-words did not.

There is a chillu here too, the ൾ in the middle, doing the same job as the ൾ of the leg-word: a consonant with no vowel after it, given its own shape rather than a mark underneath.

What you've built

Two: a teacher and a student.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vidyārtthi*
- it once more, slowly
- *adhyāpakan*, then *vidyārtthi*, the pair that need each other

Before you move on

What does വിദ്യാർത്ഥി mean? (“a student”.) Say it once more.

48.3 വൈദ്യൻ (*vaidyan*) — a doctor

Before the new one: what did *vidyārtthi* mean?

You’ll want to know: വൈദ്യൻ

വൈദ്യൻ (*vaidyan*) — “a doctor”.

The same *vidyā* as the last word, stretched into an adjective: *vaidya* is ‘the one versed in the knowledge’, and the knowledge meant is the medical one. Then the masculine chillu ന് again.

Kannada has ವೈದ್ಯ (*vaidya*) without that ending. Malayalam adds it; Kannada leaves the Sanskrit word standing as it came.

In a Kerala street today the word usually points at a practitioner of the traditional medicine, and the everyday word for a hospital doctor is the English one, worn down into Malayalam sounds. Both live side by side, which is worth saying rather than tidying away.

What you’ve built

Three. A teacher, a student, a doctor.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vaidyan*
- it once more, slowly
- *vidyārtthi*, then *vaidyan*, and find the piece they share

Before you move on

What does വൈദ്യൻ mean? (“a doctor”.) Say it once more.

48.4 കർഷകൻ (karṣakan) — a farmer

Before the new one: what did *vaidyan* mean?

You’ll want to know: കർഷകൻ

കർഷകൻ (*karṣakan*) — “a farmer”.

Sanskrit *karṣaka*, from a root about dragging or drawing — the plough pulled through the ground. The farmer is named for the furrow rather than for the crop.

The ending is the chillu ന് once more, the third of these role-words to take it, and the ര് near the front is the same chillu as in the student-word. Two of them in one short word.

Kannada went elsewhere again and says ರೈತ (raita), a word that came into the language along a different road entirely.

What you’ve built

Four. A teacher, a student, a doctor, a farmer.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *karṣakan*
- it once more, slowly
- *karṣakan*, then *adhyāpakan*, and count the chillus in each

Before you move on

What does കർഷകൻ mean? (“a farmer”.) Say it once more.

48.5 അതിഥി (atithi) — a guest

Before the new one: what did *karṣakan* mean?

You'll want to know: ಅತಿಥಿ

ಅತಿಥಿ (*atithi*) — “a guest”.

Sanskrit *atithi*, and Kannada ಅತಿಥಿ is the identical word — the same borrowing arriving in both languages unchanged.

The traditional analysis inside Sanskrit takes it apart as *a-* plus *tithi*, a lunar day: the one who has no appointed day, who turns up unannounced. Whether the etymology is historically right is argued over; what matters is that Sanskrit itself understood the word that way, and built a whole ethic of hospitality on it.

This word takes no masculine ending. It sits on the other side of the chapter from the four before it.

What you've built

Five, and the run is closed: a teacher, a student, a doctor, a farmer, a guest.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *atithi*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *adhyāpakan*, *vidyārthi*, *vaidyan*, *karṣakan*, *atithi*

Before you move on

What does ಅತಿಥಿ mean? (“a guest”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 49

Short Replies

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can answer with five short replies in Malayalam, from a flat agreement to a hedge.

Complete ML-C49-just-so and say all five words in order.

49.1 സത്യം (satyam) — true, the truth

Before the new run of words: what did *karṣakan* mean, and what did *atithi* mean?

You’ll want to know: സത്യം

സത്യം (*satyam*) — “true, the truth”.

Sanskrit *satya*, built on *sat*, ‘being, that which is’. Truth, in that word’s picture, is simply what is the case — a noun made out of the verb ‘to be’.

Malayalam already has ശരി (*śari*) for the everyday “right, okay” of a conversation. സത്യം is the heavier one: not ‘that will do’ but ‘that is so’.

Kannada answers with ನಿಜ (*nija*), a different Sanskrit word, whose older sense is ‘one’s own, innate’. Two languages, two borrowings, and each picked a different picture of what being true is.

What you’ve built

The first of five short replies.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *satyam*
- it once more, slowly
- *satyam*, then *śari*, and hear the weight shift between them

Before you move on

What does സത്യം mean? (“true, the truth”.) Say it once more.

49.2 മതി (mati) — enough, that will do

Before the new one: what did *satyam* mean?

You’ll want to know: മതി

മതി (*mati*) — “enough, that will do”.

Two syllables that make a whole sentence. Hand someone rice and they say **മതി** and nothing else, and the exchange is complete.

Malayalam has a small handful of these — words that are already a finished utterance and take no verb, no subject and no ending. This book has met one before in ഇല്ല.

Dictionaries connect **മതി** with a root about measuring and reckoning; the connection is plausible rather than settled, and it is more honest to leave it that way than to tidy it. Kannada says **ಸಾಕು** (*sāku*), which is not this word at all.

What you’ve built

Two replies: true, and enough.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mati*
- it once more, slowly
- *mati*, then *illa*, two words that each finish a sentence alone

Before you move on

What does മതി mean? (“enough, that will do”.) Say it once more.

49.3 തീർച്ചയായും (tīrccayāyum) — certainly, for sure

Before the new one: what did *mati* mean?

You’ll want to know: തീർച്ചയായും

തീർച്ചയായും (*tīrccayāyum*) — “certainly, for sure”.

A long word, and every piece of it is Malayalam’s own. തീർച്ച (*tīrcca*) is ‘a settling, a thing decided’, off the verb തീരുക, ‘to come to an end’. Add the adverb-making tail and the whole says ‘in a settled way’.

Kannada reaches for ഖಂಡിത (*khaṇḍita*) here, Sanskrit for ‘cut, broken off’. The two languages arrived at the same idea from the same direction — a matter is certain once it has been finished off — but one built the word at home and one imported it.

There is a chillu ൽ inside, the third chapter running to end up leaning on one.

What you’ve built

Three. True, enough, certainly.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tīrccayāyum*
- it once more, slowly
- *tīrccayāyum*, slowly, then *satyam*, and put the long word beside the short one

Before you move on

What does തീർച്ചയായും mean? (“certainly, for sure”.) Say it once more.

49.4 ഒരൂപക്ഷേ (orupakṣē) — perhaps

Before the new one: what did *tīrccayāyumi* mean?

You’ll want to know: ഒരൂപക്ഷേ

ഒരൂപക്ഷേ (*orupakṣē*) — “perhaps”.

Take it apart and it says “on one side”. ഒരു (*oru*) is ‘one’, the same numeral this book counted with. പക്ഷം (*pakṣam*) is Sanskrit for a side, a wing, one of the alternatives on offer.

So a Malayalam speaker hedges by naming a side rather than by naming a doubt. The word is half native, half borrowed, and joined so smoothly that the seam is easy to miss.

Kannada hedges with ಬಹುಶಃ (*bahusāḥ*), a wholly Sanskrit word meaning something closer to ‘in many ways’. Same job, different picture again.

What you’ve built

Four. True, enough, certainly, perhaps.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *orupakṣē*
- it once more, slowly
- *orupakṣē*, then *tīrccayāyumi*, the hedge and the promise

Before you move on

What does ഒരൂപക്ഷേ mean? (“perhaps”.) Say it once more.

49.5 അങ്ങനെ (aṅṇane) — that way, just so

Before the new one: what did *orupakṣē* mean?

You'll want to know: ಅಂಞಾನೆ

ಅಂಞಾನೆ (*aṇṇane*) — “that way, just so”.

This one the book has half-taught already. The chapter on pointing laid out a pattern: *i*- for what is near, *a*- for what is far, *e*- for what is being asked about. ಎಂಞಾನೆ (*eṇṇane*), ‘how?’, was the question member of exactly this set.

Swap its opening for the far one and the question becomes an answer. ಅಂಞಾನೆ is ‘that way’ — the manner just spoken of, agreed to.

Kannada does the same trick with ಹಾಗೆ (*hāge*), built on its own far-pointer. The machinery is inherited; each sister runs it with her own parts.

What you’ve built

Five, and the run is closed: true, enough, certainly, perhaps, just so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *aṇṇane*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *satyaṇi*, *matī*, *tīrccayāyumi*, *orupakṣē*, *aṇṇane*

Before you move on

What does ಅಂಞಾನೆ mean? (“that way, just so”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 50

Taking Leave

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say when I am going and take my leave in Malayalam, using either of the two phrases the language builds for it.

Complete ML-C50-farewell and say all five words in order.

50.1 ഇപ്പോൾ (ippōl) — now

Before the new run of words: what did *orupakṣē* mean, and what did *arīriane* mean?

You’ll want to know: ഇപ്പോൾ

ഇപ്പോൾ (*ippōl*) — “now”.

The pointing pattern again, and this time on time rather than manner. *i-* is the near one, so ഇപ്പോൾ is ‘at this time’. Its far partner അപ്പോൾ (*appōl*) is ‘at that time, then’, and the two differ by one letter.

Tamil says இப்போது (*ippōtu*) — the same two pieces, put together the same way.

The word ends on ൾ, the chillu already met at the end of നിങ്ങൾ. Kannada’s word for now, ಈಗ (*īga*), is built from its own near-pointer and shares nothing else with this one.

What you’ve built

The first of five words for going away.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ippōl*
- it once more, slowly
- *ippōl*, then *annane*, and hear the near and the far openers side by side

Before you move on

What does ഇപ്പോൾ mean? (“now”.) Say it once more.

50.2 മറന്നാൾ (*marrannāl*) — the day after tomorrow

Before the new one: what did *ippōl* mean?

You’ll want to know: മറന്നാൾ

മറന്നാൾ (*marrannāl*) — “the day after tomorrow”.

Three pieces, and the last of them this book has already taught: നാൾ, the native day-word. Before it sits മറ്റ് (*marrŭ*), ‘other’, and a middle piece pointing at a particular day. Put together: the other day along.

Malayalam does not stop there. There is a word for the day after that one as well, and speakers use it without ceremony, where an English speaker would give up and name a date.

Kannada builds its own with the same idea and different parts, ನಾಡಿದ್ದു (*nāḍiddu*), and its day-word is the cousin of ours.

What you’ve built

Two: now, and the day after tomorrow.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *marrannāl*
- it once more, slowly

- *ippōl*, then *marrannāl*, the nearest time and a far one

Before you move on

What does മറ്റൊന്ന് mean? (“the day after tomorrow”.) Say it once more.

50.3 യാത്ര (yātra) — a journey

Before the new one: what did *marrannāl* mean?

You’ll want to know: യാത്ര

യാത്ര (*yātra*) — “a journey”.

Sanskrit *yātrā*, off a root meaning simply ‘to go’. A journey is a going, with a noun ending on it.

Malayalam then does something with the word that Sanskrit did not: യാത്ര പറയുക, literally ‘to say journey’, is how a speaker takes leave of a household. The noun for travelling became the verb phrase for saying goodbye, because what you announce at the door is that you are going.

Kannada’s ಪ್ರయాಣ (*prayāṇa*) is the same root with a prefix in front of it — a going-forth. The sisters borrowed from the same shelf and reached for neighbouring jars.

What you’ve built

Three. Now, the day after tomorrow, a journey.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *yātra*
- it once more, slowly
- *yātra*, then *yātra parayuka*, the noun and the leave-taking built on it

Before you move on

What does യാത്ര mean? (“a journey”.) Say it once more.

50.4 പുറപ്പെടുക (purappetuka) — to set out

Before the new one: what did *yātra* mean?

You'll want to know: പുറപ്പെടുക

പുറപ്പെടുക (*purappetuka*) — “to set out”.

A compound with its seam showing. പുറം (*puram*) is ‘the outside, the back’; Tamil has புறம் with the same sense. The second piece is the ordinary verb of falling or happening. Together, roughly, ‘to come to be outside’ — which is what setting out is.

Malayalam builds a great many verbs this way, a noun and a light verb sitting next to each other, and this book has already shown one: the work-verb made of ‘work’ plus ‘do’.

Kannada says ಹೊರಡು (*horaḍu*), built on its own outside-word, and that word begins with the *h* where ours begins with a *p*. The shift turns up again.

What you’ve built

Four. Now, the day after tomorrow, a journey, setting out.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *purappetuka*
- it once more, slowly
- *purappetuka*, then *jōli ceyyuka*, two verbs built the same way

Before you move on

What does പുറപ്പെടുക mean? (“to set out”.) Say it once more.

50.5 വിട (viṭa) — leave, a farewell

Before the new one: what did *purappetuka* mean?

You'll want to know: വിട

വിട (*viṭa*) — “leave, a farewell”.

A short word off a plain verb: വിടുക (*viṭuka*) is ‘to let go, to release’. വിട is the letting-go itself.

And it is used exactly as the journey-word was: വിട പറയുക, ‘to say farewell’. Malayalam has two ways to announce a departure, one naming the going and one naming the release, and both are built by hanging the speaking-verb off a noun.

Kannada’s word here, ಬಿಡುಗಡೆ (*biḷkoḍuge*), is longer and made of its own native parts — a giving of leave. Three languages could hardly agree less on how to say goodbye, and each of them is transparent once opened.

What you’ve built

Five, and the run is closed: now, the day after tomorrow, a journey, setting out, a farewell.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *viṭa*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *ippōl*, *marrannāl*, *yātra*, *purappetuka*, *viṭa*

Before you move on

What does വിട mean? (“leave, a farewell”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 51

Courtesy

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🖐️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can thank, respect and bless in the formal Malayalam register, and say how each word differs from its everyday partner.

Complete ML-C51-salutation and say all five words in order.

51.1 കൃതജ്ഞത (kṛtajñata) — gratitude

Before the new run of words: what did *purappetuka* mean, and what did *viṭa* mean?

You'll want to know: കൃതജ്ഞത

കൃതജ്ഞത (*kṛtajñata*) — “gratitude”.

Sanskrit again, and legible once opened: *kṛta* is ‘done’, *jñā* is ‘knowing’. The grateful person is the one who knows what was done for them.

Malayalam already has നന്ദി (*nandi*) for the everyday thank-you, and that one is the family’s own. So the pair here is the pattern this book keeps meeting: a native word for the ordinary moment and a Sanskrit one for the formal register, the letter, the speech.

Kannada has ಕೃತಜ್ಞತೆ (*kṛtajñate*), the same borrowing with a Kannada ending. Where the formal register is concerned the sisters agree far more often than they do in the kitchen.

What you’ve built

The first of five courtesies.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kṛtajñata*
- it once more, slowly
- *kṛtajñata*, then *nandi*, the formal and the everyday

Before you move on

What does കൃതജ്ഞത mean? (“gratitude”.) Say it once more.

51.2 ഉപകാരം (upakāram) — a favour, a good turn

Before the new one: what did *kṛtajñata* mean?

You’ll want to know: ഉപകാരം

ഉപകാരം (*upakāram*) — “a favour, a good turn”.

Upa is ‘near, alongside’; *kāra* is ‘a doing’. A favour is a doing-alongside — help brought up close.

The word carries a polite adverb with it in daily speech, an ‘as a kindness’ shaped much like the ദയവായി this book taught for ‘please’. Both are courtesies built by turning a noun sideways into an adverb, which is a habit worth noticing rather than learning one word at a time.

Kannada has ಉಪಕಾರ (*upakāra*), the same word once more.

What you’ve built

Two: gratitude, and a favour.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *upakāram*
- it once more, slowly
- *upakāram*, then *dayavāyī*, two courtesies made the same way

Before you move on

What does ഉപകാരം mean? (“a favour, a good turn”.) Say it once more.

51.3 ബഹുമാനം (bahumānam) — respect

Before the new one: what did *upakārami* mean?

You’ll want to know: ബഹുമാനം

ബഹുമാനം (*bahumānam*) — “respect”.

Bahu is ‘much’; *māna* is ‘regard, esteem’. To respect is to regard much, and the Sanskrit says so plainly.

That *māna* runs back to a root about thinking, and the same root gives Sanskrit its word for the mind. Malayalam took that mind-word too: it is sitting inside മനസ്സിലാക്കുക, the ‘put it in the mind’ this book used for understanding. Respect and understanding share an ancestor.

Kannada does not use this word for respect; it says ಗೌരവ (gaurava), which is built on ‘heavy’. Regarding much, or weighing much — the two sisters chose different metaphors off the same shelf.

What you’ve built

Three. Gratitude, a favour, respect.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *bahumānam*
- it once more, slowly
- *bahumānam*, then *manassilākkuka*, and find the piece they share

Before you move on

What does ബഹുമാനം mean? (“respect”.) Say it once more.

51.4 അനുഗ്രഹം (anugrahaṁ) — a blessing

Before the new one: what did *bahumānani* mean?

You'll want to know: അനുഗ്രഹം

അനുഗ്രഹം (*anugrahaṁ*) — “a blessing”.

Anu is ‘after, along’; *graha* is ‘a taking hold’. A blessing is a taking-hold on someone’s behalf — favour laid on with a hand.

That *graha* is a busy word. ഗ്രഹം in Malayalam is a planet, and it is the same noun: in the older astronomy a planet was a seizer, something that took hold of a life. One root, a blessing at one end and a planet at the other.

Kannada blesses with ಆಶീർവാദ (*āśīrvāda*), a different Sanskrit compound built on speech rather than on grasp. A blessing said, against a blessing laid on.

What you’ve built

Four. Gratitude, a favour, respect, a blessing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *anugrahaṁ*
- it once more, slowly
- *anugrahaṁ*, then *bahumānani*, both of them things given rather than taken

Before you move on

What does അനുഗ്രഹം mean? (“a blessing”.) Say it once more.

51.5 വന്ദനം (vandanam) — a salutation

Before the new one: what did *anugrahaṁ* mean?

You'll want to know: വന്ദനം

വന്ദനം (*vandanam*) — “a salutation”.

Off a Sanskrit root about praising and saluting. വന്ദനം is the act of paying respects, and it is the word on a printed invitation rather than in a doorway.

The doorway word this book taught first was നമസ്കാരം, and its own sense is a making of a bow. So Malayalam holds two Sanskrit nouns for what is nearly one physical act: the bend of the body, and the honour paid by it.

Kannada has ವಂದನೆ (*vandane*), and its own everyday greeting is built on that first word as well. The sisters furnished their doorways from the same shop.

What you've built

Five, and the run is closed: gratitude, a favour, respect, a blessing, a salutation.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vandanam*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *kṛtajñata*, *upakārami*, *bahumānam*, *anugraham*, *vandanam*

Before you move on

What does വന്ദനം mean? (“a salutation”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 52

Welcoming a Guest

Modes:  voice (5)  Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the five things a guest meets at a Kerala doorway in Malayalam.

Complete ML-C52-garland and say all five words in order.

52.1 വാതിൽ (vātil) — a door

Before the new run of words: what did *anugrahami* mean, and what did *vandanami* mean?

You'll want to know: വാതിൽ

വാതിൽ (*vātil*) — “a door”.

Tamil writes its door-word വാധിൽ (*vāyil*), and once you see it beside വായ് — the mouth this book has already taught — the picture is hard to unsee. A doorway is the mouth of a house.

Malayalam's വാതിൽ is the same word with a *t* where Tamil has a *y*, and the dictionaries connect the two. The mouth-word itself, വായ്, sits in this book's chapter on the face.

Kannada says ಬಾಗಿಲು (*bāgilu*), which is a different word altogether. The chillu ൽ at the end here is the same one that closed the leg-word and the finger-word.

What you've built

The first of five things a guest meets at the door.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vātil*
- it once more, slowly
- *vātil*, then *vāy*, and hear what a doorway is named for

Before you move on

What does വാതിൽ mean? (“a door”.) Say it once more.

52.2 കസേര (kasēra) — a chair

Before the new one: what did *vātil* mean?

You’ll want to know: കസേര

കസേര (*kasēra*) — “a chair”.

Portuguese *cadeira*, come ashore on the Malabar coast and settled. Kerala’s Portuguese layer is thick and domestic: the table, the cupboard and the window in an ordinary Malayalam room are all Portuguese words worn into Malayalam shapes — മേശ (*mēśa*), അലമാര (*alamāra*), ജനൽ (*janal*).

Furniture travels with the people who make it, and the vocabulary of a room records who was in it. This is one of the few places in this book where the trail is only five centuries long instead of five thousand.

Kannada’s കുർಚ് (*kurci*) is a chair too, and it arrived from the north along an entirely different road.

What you’ve built

Two: a door, and a chair.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kasēra*
- it once more, slowly
- *kasēra*, then *vātil*, the way in and the seat beyond it

Before you move on

What does കസേര mean? (“a chair”.) Say it once more.

52.3 കോലം (kōlam) — the pattern drawn at a doorway

Before the new one: what did *kasēra* mean?

You’ll want to know: കോലം

കോലം (*kōlam*) — “the pattern drawn at a doorway”.

Native Dravidian, and its plain sense is ‘form, shape, guise’. The pattern chalked on the ground at a threshold is a shape laid down, and Tamil uses கோலம் for the same thing.

The word keeps its wider life alongside the drawing: a person in costume, an animal’s markings, anything that has taken on a form, can be a കോലം.

Kannada names the same threshold drawing ರಂಗೋಲಿ (*raṅgōli*), a word built on Sanskrit colour. One sister named the practice for its shape and the other for its pigment.

What you’ve built

Three. A door, a chair, the pattern at the threshold.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kōlam*
- it once more, slowly
- *kōlam*, then *vātil*, and put the drawing back where it is drawn

Before you move on

What does കോലം mean? (“the pattern drawn at a doorway”.) Say it once more.

52.4 ಪೂವ್ (pūvũ) — a flower

Before the new one: what did *kōlani* mean?

You’ll want to know: ಪೂವ್

ಪೂವ್ (*pūvũ*) — “a flower”.

Proto-Dravidian ***pū**, one of the shortest words the family has and one of the best kept: Tamil பூ, Telugu పువ్వు, Kannada ಹೂವು. Kannada’s *h* is that opening shift again, met first at the fruit.

Kerala puts the word to work at the front of a compound: the flower-carpet laid out for the harvest festival is ಪೂಕ್ಕಾಡಂ, the flower plus a word for a laid-out ground.

Malayalam’s own form adds a *v* and the half-vowel, which is why it looks longer than Tamil’s bare two letters while saying the same thing.

What you’ve built

Four. A door, a chair, the pattern at the threshold, a flower.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pūvũ*
- it once more, slowly
- *pūvũ*, then *kōlani*, the two things laid at a doorway

Before you move on

What does ಪೂವ್ mean? (“a flower”.) Say it once more.

52.5 ಮಾಲ (māla) — a garland

Before the new one: what did *pūvũ* mean?

You'll want to know: ಮಲೆ

ಮಲೆ (*māla*) — “a garland”.

Sanskrit *mālā*, a garland or a string of things, borrowed all across the south. Kannada's ಹೂಮಾಲೆ (*hūmāle*) is this word with the flower-word stuck on the front of it, so the Kannada compound spells out what Malayalam leaves to context.

The word is also a string in the abstract — a series, a row — which is why a rosary and a necklace and a list can all be one.

And that closes the door: the way in, the seat, the pattern on the ground, the flower and the garland. A guest arriving at a Kerala house in the old way would meet all five before a word was exchanged.

What you've built

Five, and the run is closed: a door, a chair, the pattern at the threshold, a flower, a garland.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *māla*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *vātil*, *kasēra*, *kōlani*, *pūvū*, *māla*

Before you move on

What does ಮಲೆ mean? (“a garland”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 53

Overhead

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the sky and four things in it in Malayalam.

Complete ML-C53-sunshine and say all five words in order.

53.1 ആകാശം (ākāśam) — the sky

Before the new run of words: what did *pūvū* mean, and what did *māla* mean?

You’ll want to know: ആകാശം

ആകാശം (ākāśam) — “the sky”.

Sanskrit *ākāśa*, built on a piece meaning “to shine, to be visible”. The sky is named there for being the open lit place where a thing can be seen at all, rather than for being a lid over the world.

Malayalam keeps an inherited word for the same overhead space, വാനം (*vānam*), which owes Sanskrit nothing. The two divide the work between them: ആകാശം takes the ordinary shift and turns up in weather talk, while വാനം keeps to songs and to verse. A borrowed word taking the daily job and leaving the older one the ceremony is an arrangement this book has shown you before, at the doorway.

ākāśa travelled as well. Traders carried it east, and Malay and Indonesian still say *angkasa* for the sky.

What you’ve built

The space the rest of this run hangs in.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ākāśani*
- it once more, slowly
- *ākāśani*, then *namaskārani*, as you would greet somebody out of doors

Before you move on

What does ആകാശം mean? (“the sky”.) Say it once more.

53.2 സൂര്യൻ (sūryan) — the sun

Before the new one: what did *ākāśani* mean?

You’ll want to know: സൂര്യൻ

സൂര്യൻ (*sūryan*) — “the sun”.

Sanskrit *sūrya*, wearing the Malayalam chillu ണ on the end — the same tail that closes *adhyāpakan* and *karṣakan*, and it marks this one out as a he-word. The sun is a person in that grammar, not a thing.

The Sanskrit word has cousins a long way west. It shares an ancestor with Latin *sol* and with the Greek piece behind *helios*, which is why English *solar* and *heliotrope* are distant relatives of the word a Malayali newsreader says.

Malayalam’s own sun-word is ഞായർ (*ñāyar*), and it survives mostly inside the name of Sunday, ഞായറാഴ്ച (*ñāyarālca*) — the sun’s day, arrived at independently of the English one.

What you’ve built

Two: the sky, and the thing that crosses it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sūryan*
- it once more, slowly
- *ākāśam*, then *sūryan*, and say which of the two is the container

Before you move on

What does സൂര്യൻ mean? (“the sun”.) Say it once more.

53.3 ചന്ദ്രൻ (candran) — the moon

Before the new one: what did *sūryan* mean?

You’ll want to know: ചന്ദ്രൻ

ചന്ദ്രൻ (*candran*) — “the moon”.

Sanskrit *candra* means “shining, bright”, and Malayalam took it whole, then gave it the same he-word tail the sun got. Sun and moon travel as a pair in this language, down to the shape of their endings.

candra went west too. It shares an ancestor with the Latin piece behind English *candle* and *incandescent*: a very old root for burning white.

Malayalam’s inherited moon-word is തിങ്കൾ (*tiṅkal*), and that word also names Monday and once named a month. One shape for the moon and for the stretch of time it measures — the moon being the oldest calendar there is, and Malayalam keeping that fact inside a single word.

What you’ve built

Three, and the last two were borrowed together.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *candran*
- it once more, slowly
- *sūryan*, then *candran*, and hear the same tail on both

Before you move on

What does ചന്ദ്രൻ mean? (“the moon”.) Say it once more.

53.4 നക്ഷത്രം (nakṣatram) — a star

Before the new one: what did *candran* mean?

You’ll want to know: നക്ഷത്രം

നക്ഷത്രം (*nakṣatram*) — “a star”.

Sanskrit *nakṣatra*. In Kerala it does a job it does not do in English: a person’s നക്ഷത്രം is the birth-star, one of twenty-seven asterisms the moon passes through, and it is the star you were born under rather than the date that fixes when your birthday falls.

So a Malayali may keep two birthdays a year apart from each other — the calendar one and the star one — and the star one is the one the household cooks for.

Tamil reaches for the same borrowed word, *naṭcattiram*, worn down a little further. The inherited Dravidian way of naming a star was to call it a fish in the sky, and Tamil still has *viṇmīn* for it; Malayalam let that one go.

What you’ve built

Four, and this one keeps a calendar.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nakṣatram*
- it once more, slowly
- *nakṣatram*, then *candran*, and say which of the two moves through the other

Before you move on

What does നക്ഷത്രം mean? (“a star”.) Say it once more.

53.5 വെയിൽ (veyil) — sunshine, the sun’s heat

Before the new one: what did *nakṣatram* mean?

You’ll want to know: വെയിൽ

വെയിൽ (*veyil*) — “sunshine, the sun’s heat”.

After four borrowed words, an inherited one. വെയിൽ is Malayalam’s own, matching Tamil *veyil* exactly, and it names the heat that falls out of the sky rather than the body that sends it.

That is worth pausing on. English talks about the weather by naming the sun; Malayalam reaches first for what the sun does to you standing in it. A Kochi sentence about the afternoon is far more likely to be about വെയിൽ than about *sūryan* at all. Step out of the shade and you have stepped into വെയിൽ.

Beside it sits its opposite, തണൽ (*taṇal*), the shade — and between those two words most of a hot afternoon can be described without the sun being mentioned once.

What you’ve built

Five: the sky, the sun, the moon, a star, and what comes down out of it by day.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *veyil*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *ākāśam*, *sūryan*, *candran*, *nakṣatram*, *veyil*

Before you move on

What does വെയിൽ mean? (“sunshine, the sun’s heat”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 54

A Tree, Part by Part

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a tree and four of its parts in Malayalam.

Complete ML-C54-seed and say all five words in order.

54.1 മരം (maram) — a tree

Before the new run of words: what did *nakṣatram* mean, and what did *veyil* mean?

You'll want to know: മരം

മരം (*maram*) — “a tree”.

Inherited Dravidian, matching Tamil *maram*, Kannada *marā* and Telugu *mṛānu*. Four languages, one word, and no borrowing anywhere in it — this is a word the family had before it split.

It carries the standing tree and the cut timber on one shape. A carpenter's മരം and a forest's മരം are the same word, and Malayalam leaves it to the situation to say which is meant. English needs *tree* and *wood* to do that work.

Kerala's own tree, the coconut, gets a compound built on this one, and the ordinary word for a tree-climber is built on it too.

What you've built

The thing the rest of this run takes apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *marami*
- it once more, slowly
- *veyil*, then *marami*, and say which of the two the other one stands in

Before you move on

What does മരം mean? (“a tree”.) Say it once more.

54.2 കൊമ്പ് (kompŭ) — a branch

Before the new one: what did *marami* mean?

You’ll want to know: കൊമ്പ്

കൊമ്പ് (*kompŭ*) — “a branch”.

Inherited, matching Tamil *kompū*. Malayalam puts one shape on anything that juts out and comes to a point: the branch of a tree, the horn of an ox, the tusk of an elephant, and the curved brass horn played at a temple festival.

That is a picture doing the work rather than a rule. Once you have seen the branch and the horn as one thing, the elephant’s tusk needs no separate word, and Malayalam never gave it one.

The elephant sense is the one you are most likely to hear in Kerala, where the animal is a fixture of festival and of conversation both.

What you’ve built

Two: the tree, and the part that reaches out from it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kompŭ*
- it once more, slowly

- *marami*, then *kompŭ*, and name two other things the second word covers

Before you move on

What does കൊമ്പ് mean? (“a branch”.) Say it once more.

54.3 തടി (*taṭi*) — a trunk, timber

Before the new one: what did *kompŭ* mean?

You’ll want to know: തടി

തടി (*taṭi*) — “a trunk, timber”.

Inherited, and it does three jobs on one shape: the trunk of a standing tree, the sawn timber that comes out of it, and — of a person — bulk or build.

The third sense is ordinary Malayalam and not unkind. To say somebody has തടി is to say they are solidly made, and Kerala says it about a person the way English might say *sturdy*.

Beside it sits തടിയൻ (*taṭiyan*), a heavy-set man, carrying that same he-word tail you met on the sun and the moon.

What you’ve built

Three, and this one describes people as well as trees.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *taṭi*
- it once more, slowly
- *kompŭ*, then *taṭi*, and say which of the two you could saw

Before you move on

What does തടി mean? (“a trunk, timber”.) Say it once more.

54.4 വേര് (vēṛ) — a root

Before the new one: what did *taṭi* mean?

You'll want to know: വേര്

വേര് (*vēṛ*) — “a root”.

Inherited, matching Tamil *vēr* closely. The little ̣ at the end is the enunciative vowel you have been hearing since the salt-word and the lamp-word: a half-sounded release that Malayalam puts after a bare consonant and Tamil mostly does not write.

വേര് reaches past the plant, as the English word does. The വേര് of a matter is where it started, and a question about the വേര് of a quarrel is a question about its cause.

The two languages arriving at the same figure from the same word is not a coincidence here — it is what roots look like to anybody who has pulled one up.

What you've built

Four: the tree, the branch, the trunk, and what holds it down.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vēṛ*
- it once more, slowly
- *taṭi*, then *vēṛ*, and say which end of the tree each one names

Before you move on

What does വേര് mean? (“a root”.) Say it once more.

54.5 വിത്ത് (vitt) — a seed

Before the new one: what did *vēṛ* mean?

You'll want to know: വിത്ത്

വിത്ത് (*vittũ*) — “a seed”.

Inherited, matching Tamil *vittu*, and it closes the tree by going back to where the tree started.

Like ഘ്ര് it travels into the abstract. The വിത്ത് of a plan is its beginning, and Malayalam will talk about sowing one. The doubled *tt* in the middle is worth catching by ear — Malayalam holds it long, and the length is what separates this word from others in its neighbourhood.

Sowing season in Kerala is set by the rains rather than by a date, which is why the farming words in this language lean on the weather more than on the calendar.

What you've built

Five, and the run closes where a tree starts: a tree, a branch, the trunk, a root, a seed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vittũ*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *maram̐, kompũ, taṭi, vēṛũ, vittũ*

Before you move on

What does വിത്ത് mean? (“a seed”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 55

Ground Underfoot

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five features of the Kerala landscape in Malayalam.

Complete ML-C55-field and say all five words in order.

55.1 പുഴ (pula) — a river

Before the new run of words: what did *vērũ* mean, and what did *vittũ* mean?

You’ll want to know: പുഴ

പുഴ (*pula*) — “a river”.

Inherited, and it carries ഴ — the sound Kannada and Telugu both lost, and the one this book has already pointed at as Malayalam’s signature.

Kerala has forty-four rivers running west off the hills, and their names end in this word: Bharatappuzha, Chaliyar-puzha, Periyar. Reading a Kerala map is largely a matter of hearing പുഴ at the end of things.

The borrowed നദി (*nadi*) is the formal one, and it is what a textbook prints. പുഴ is what somebody points at.

What you’ve built

The first of five things underfoot.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pula*
- it once more, slowly
- *vittu*, then *pula*, and hold the *u* a moment longer than feels natural

Before you move on

What does പു mean? (“a river”.) Say it once more.

55.2 പാറ (pāra) — a rock

Before the new one: what did *pula* mean?

You’ll want to know: പാറ

പാറ (*pāra*) — “a rock”.

Inherited, matching Tamil *pārai*. The hard റ in the middle is the trilled one, and it separates this word from its neighbours by that sound alone.

Kerala’s ground is laterite over granite, and പാറ names the bare grey shoulders of it that show through where the soil has washed off. Quarrying is a പാറ trade, and the word turns up on lorries and on hillsides both.

It goes figurative in the direction you would expect: somebody unmoved by argument has a heart of പാറ, which is the same picture English reaches for and reached for separately.

What you’ve built

Two: the water, and what it runs over.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pāra*
- it once more, slowly
- *pula*, then *pāra*, and hear the soft sound against the hard one

Before you move on

What does ധ്വാന mean? (“a rock”.) Say it once more.

55.3 നാട് (nāṭṭ) — home country, the place you are from

Before the new one: what did *pāra* mean?

You’ll want to know: നാട്

നാട് (*nāṭṭ*) — “home country, the place you are from”.

Inherited, matching Tamil *nāṭu*, and it is one of the busiest words in the language. A നാട് is a country, a district, a home region, or simply where you are from — the scale floats, and the situation fixes it.

It sits inside place-names all over the south, and inside the everyday question a Malayali asks a stranger early in a conversation: which നാട് are you from. Answering with a village is as correct as answering with a country.

Its opposite is കാട് (*kāṭṭ*), the forest — settled ground against wild ground, one vowel apart, and the pair is old enough to be shared right across the family.

What you’ve built

Three, and this one is the question you get asked.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nāṭṭ*
- it once more, slowly
- *nāṭṭ*, then *kāṭṭ*, and hear how little separates the tame from the wild

Before you move on

What does നാട് mean? (“home country, the place you are from”.) Say it once more.

55.4 വഴി (vali) — a way, a path

Before the new one: what did *nāṭṭ* mean?

You'll want to know: വഴി

വഴി (*vali*) — “a way, a path”.

Inherited, matching Tamil *vali*, and another ഘ word — the second in this run, which tells you how deep that sound sits in the oldest layer of the language.

വഴി is a path you walk and also a means by which something happens. Malayalam uses it where English says *by way of* and *through*, so a letter can come by വഴി of a friend.

The road and the method being one word is not peculiar to Malayalam. English *way* does the same double duty, and so does the Latin piece behind *via*. Some pictures are simply obvious to everybody.

What you've built

Four: the river, the rock, the home place, and the way through it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vali*
- it once more, slowly
- *pula*, then *vali*, and hold the ഘ in both

Before you move on

What does വഴി mean? (“a way, a path”.) Say it once more.

55.5 വയൽ (vayal) — a paddy field

Before the new one: what did *vali* mean?

You'll want to know: വയൽ

വയൽ (*vayal*) — “a paddy field”.

Inherited, matching Tamil *vayal*, and it names a particular kind of field: the flooded, bunded one where rice grows. Dry ground planted with something else takes a different word.

That specificity is the point. A language grown in a rice country puts its sharpest word on the wet field, and Kuttanad — the stretch of Kerala farmed below sea level — is വയൽ for miles in every direction.

The chillu ൾ closing it is the one you met on the door-word and the leg-word, a bare *l* with no vowel behind it.

What you've built

Five, and the ground is furnished: a river, a rock, the home place, a way, a paddy field.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vayal*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *pula*, *pāra*, *nāṭṭu*, *vali*, *vayal*

Before you move on

What does വയൽ mean? (“a paddy field”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 56

Things About the House

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five ordinary household things in Malayalam.

Complete ML-C56-box and say all five words in order.

56.1 പാല (pāya) — a mat

Before the new run of words: what did *vali* mean, and what did *vayal* mean?

You'll want to know: പാല

പാല (*pāya*) — “a mat”.

Inherited, matching Tamil *pāy*, and it names the woven mat that a Kerala household spreads to sleep on and unrolls for a guest to sit on.

The material is usually screwpine leaf or reed, split and plaited, and the making of them is a village trade with its own vocabulary. A പാല rolls up and stands in a corner, which is why a house with few chairs can still seat twenty people.

The mat and the chair answer the same question by different means, and the older answer is the one still in daily use.

What you've built

The first of five things a Kerala house keeps.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pāya*
- it once more, slowly
- *vayal*, then *pāya*, and say which of the two is woven

Before you move on

What does പായ mean? (“a mat”.) Say it once more.

56.2 കൊട്ട (koṭṭa) — a basket

Before the new one: what did *pāya* mean?

You’ll want to know: കൊട്ട

കൊട്ട (*koṭṭa*) — “a basket”.

Inherited, and plaited from bamboo or palm strip like the mat before it. A **കൊട്ട** is the wide open basket that carries fish up from a boat, rice out of a field, or a load of pepper to market.

Kerala sizes them by trade rather than by measure, so a fish **കൊട്ട** and a grain **കൊട്ട** are different objects under one word, and the market knows which is meant.

The doubled **ṣ** in the middle is held, the way the doubled sound in the seed-word was. Malayalam does a great deal of work with the length of a consonant.

What you’ve built

Two, and both of them plaited.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *koṭṭa*
- it once more, slowly
- *pāya*, then *koṭṭa*, and hold the doubled sound in the second

Before you move on

What does കൊട്ട mean? (“a basket”.) Say it once more.

56.3 കത്തി (katti) — a knife

Before the new one: what did *kottā* mean?

You’ll want to know: കത്തി

കത്തി (*katti*) — “a knife”.

Inherited, matching Tamil *katti*, and the doubled *tt* is held long here too — three words into this run and the pattern is doing its own teaching.

Kerala’s characteristic blade is not held in the hand at all. It is the വാക്കത്തി and the sickle-shaped cutter clamped to a board, worked by pulling the vegetable across a fixed edge while sitting on the floor. The word covers that as readily as it covers a table knife.

A word for a tool tends to outlast the tool’s shape, and this one has outlasted several.

What you’ve built

Three: something to sit on, something to carry with, something to cut with.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *katti*
- it once more, slowly
- *kottā*, then *katti*, and hear the same held sound in both

Before you move on

What does കത്തി mean? (“a knife”.) Say it once more.

56.4 പാത്രം (pātram) — a vessel, a container

Before the new one: what did *katti* mean?

You'll want to know: പാത്രം

പാത്രം (*pātram*) — “a vessel, a container”.

Sanskrit *pātra*, “a receptacle” — the first borrowed word in this run, and it arrived carrying a second sense that Malayalam kept.

A പാത്രം is a cooking vessel, a pot, a dish. It is also a character in a story or a part in a play: the person is a vessel that a role is poured into. Malayalam film writing uses the word constantly in that second sense, and a reader meets both without difficulty.

One shape holding the pot and the person is the kind of figure a language borrows whole rather than builds, and Malayalam took it as it stood.

What you've built

Four, and this one holds a story as well as a stew.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pātram*
- it once more, slowly
- *pātram*, and then say which of its two senses a cook means

Before you move on

What does പാത്രം mean? (“a vessel, a container”.) Say it once more.

56.5 പെട്ടി (petṭi) — a box

Before the new one: what did *pātram* mean?

You'll want to know: പെട്ടി

പെട്ടി (*petṭi*) — “a box”.

Matching Tamil *petṭi*, and it covers the whole family of closed containers: a box, a trunk, a case, a crate.

It is one of those words that quietly absorbs new objects. Malayalam has built the matchbox, the ballot box and the letter box on it since, each one a compound with പെട്ടി sitting on the end and an older word in front.

A word that keeps accepting new referents without changing shape is a sign of a healthy one, and പെട്ടി has been accepting them for a long time.

What you've built

Five, and the house is furnished: a mat, a basket, a knife, a vessel, a box.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *petṭi*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *pāya*, *koṭṭa*, *katti*, *pātram*, *petṭi*

Before you move on

What does പെട്ടി mean? (“a box”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 57

Five More of the Body

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five more parts of the body in Malayalam.

Complete ML-C57-bone and say all five words in order.

57.1 കഴുത്ത് (kaluttŭ) — the neck

Before the new run of words: what did *pātram* mean, and what did *petṭi* mean?

You’ll want to know: കഴുത്ത്

കഴുത്ത് (*kaluttŭ*) — “the neck”.

Inherited, matching Tamil *kaluttu*, and carrying ഴ again — the third run of this book to lean on that sound, and by now your mouth should be finding it without being told.

It is the neck and the throat together, outside and in. A garland goes round the കഴുത്ത്, and so does the thin gold chain a Kerala woman is given at her wedding.

The held *tt* and the closing *ŭ* are both here as well, which makes this word a short review of three things at once.

What you’ve built

The first of five more, and it holds the garland.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kaluttŭ*
- it once more, slowly
- *peṭti*, then *kaluttŭ*, and hold the **൧** in the middle

Before you move on

What does കഴുത്ത് mean? (“the neck”.) Say it once more.

57.2 മുതുകു് (mutukŭ) — the back

Before the new one: what did *kaluttŭ* mean?

You’ll want to know: മുതുകു്

മുതുകു് (*mutukŭ*) — “the back”.

Inherited, matching Tamil *mutuku*, and it names the back of a body — the ridged stretch between the shoulders and the waist.

Malayalam separates that from the general idea of behindness, which it handles with a different word altogether. മുതുകു് stays on the body, so it is the word for the back that aches after a day bent over a വയൽ.

It shows up in the ordinary phrase for carrying a child astride the hip or the back, which is how most Kerala infants travel.

What you’ve built

Two: the neck, and what runs down from it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mutukŭ*
- it once more, slowly
- *kaluttŭ*, then *mutukŭ*, and place each one with a hand

Before you move on

What does മുതുക mean? (“the back”.) Say it once more.

57.3 ചുണ്ട് (cuṇṭṭ) — a lip

Before the new one: what did *mutukū* mean?

You’ll want to know: ചുണ്ട്

ചുണ്ട് (cuṇṭṭ) — “a lip”.

Inherited, matching Tamil *cuṇṭu*. It is the lip of a mouth and also the beak of a bird — one shape for the pointed front edge of the face, whatever the face belongs to.

The same word reaches the spout of a jug, so a Malayalam pot has lips much as an English one does. That figure was arrived at twice over, on two sides of the world, from the same obvious resemblance.

The ണ cluster in the middle is the retroflex *ṇ* running straight into a *t*, made with the tongue curled back, and it is worth slowing down for.

What you’ve built

Three, and this one belongs to birds as well.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- cuṇṭṭ
- it once more, slowly
- *mutukū*, then cuṇṭṭ, and curl the tongue back for the middle of the second

Before you move on

What does ചുണ്ട് mean? (“a lip”.) Say it once more.

57.4 നഖം (nakham) — a nail, a claw

Before the new one: what did *cunṭū* mean?

You'll want to know: നഖം

നഖം (*nakham*) — “a nail, a claw”.

Sanskrit *nakha* — and this one has relatives much further west. It shares an ancestor with Latin *unguis*, with Greek *onyx*, and with English *nail* itself, which reached the same meaning down an entirely separate line of descent.

A word for a fingernail surviving intact across that distance is worth noticing. Body-part words are among the slowest things in any language to be replaced, because everybody has one and everybody learns the word early.

നഖം covers the fingernail, the toenail and the claw of an animal alike.

What you've built

Four, and this one has cousins across half the world.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nakham*
- it once more, slowly
- *nakham*, then the English word for it, and hear how far apart they have drifted

Before you move on

What does നഖം mean? (“a nail, a claw”.) Say it once more.

57.5 എല്ല (ellū) — a bone

Before the new one: what did *nakham* mean?

You'll want to know: എല്ല

എല്ല (*ellŭ*) — “a bone”.

Inherited, and Tamil says *elumpu* for the same thing — close enough to hear the shared ancestor, far enough apart to show the two languages went on working after they separated.

Malayalam shortened where Tamil kept the extra piece, which is the direction these two usually run. Set the two side by side often enough and the pattern starts to predict itself.

The doubled *ll* is held, and the *ŭ* closes it, so the whole word is over in about the time it takes to say the English one.

What you've built

Five, and the frame is done: the neck, the back, a lip, a nail, a bone.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ellŭ*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *kaluttŭ*, *mutukŭ*, *cunŭ*, *nakhani*, *ellŭ*

Before you move on

What does എല്ല mean? (“a bone”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 58

Five More Short Answers

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can accept, refuse and ask for more or less in Malayalam.

Complete ML-C58-that-will-do and say all five words in order.

58.1 കൂടുതൽ (kūṭtural) — more

Before the new run of words: what did *nakhami* mean, and what did *ellū* mean?

You'll want to know: കൂടുതൽ

കൂടുതൽ (*kūṭtural*) — “more”.

Built on കൂടുക (*kūṭuka*), “to join, to gather, to increase”, with a tail Malayalam puts on a doing to turn it into a thing. The whole says, roughly, “an increasing”.

It answers the question at a Kerala meal, where a server comes round the leaf a second and a third time and the guest has to say something. കൂടുതൽ asks for more.

The long *ū* at the front carries the word. Shorten it and you have said something else entirely, so it is worth stretching.

What you've built

The first of five short answers.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kūtutal*
- it once more, slowly
- *ellŭ*, then *kūtutal*, and stretch the long vowel at the front

Before you move on

What does കുടുതൽ mean? (“more”.) Say it once more.

58.2 കുറവ് (kuravŭ) — less, a shortage

Before the new one: what did *kūtutal* mean?

You’ll want to know: കുറവ്

കുറവ് (*kuravŭ*) — “less, a shortage”.

The mirror of the last one, built the same way: കുറയുക (*kurayuka*), “to lessen, to fall short”, plus a tail that makes the doing into a thing.

കുറവ് is less of something, and it is also a shortfall or a lack. A house short of water has a water കുറവ്, and a piece of work with something missing has a കുറവ് in it.

The റ here is the hard trilled one you met in the rock-word, and the ŭ closes the word the way it closed the root-word and the seed-word.

What you’ve built

Two, and they are opposites built from the same parts.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kuravŭ*
- it once more, slowly
- *kūtutal*, then *kuravŭ*, and hear the two tails matching

Before you move on

What does കുറവ് mean? (“less, a shortage”.) Say it once more.

58.3 കുറച്ചു (kuraccŭ) — a little, a few

Before the new one: what did *kuravŭ* mean?

You’ll want to know: കുറച്ചു

കുറച്ചു (*kuraccŭ*) — “a little, a few”.

The same root as the word before it, turned a different way: from കുറ-, “to be little”, but landing on a quantity rather than on a lack.

The difference matters at a table. കുറവ് complains that there is not enough; കുറച്ചു politely asks for a small amount. One is a verdict and the other is a request, and they are one syllable apart.

Malayalam gets a great deal out of a single root by varying the tail on it, and this pair is a clean example — the same three sounds at the front, two different jobs at the back.

What you’ve built

Three, and the last two share a root.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kuraccŭ*
- it once more, slowly
- *kuravŭ*, then *kuraccŭ*, and say which of the two you would use asking for rice

Before you move on

What does കുറച്ചു mean? (“a little, a few”.) Say it once more.

58.4 വേണ്ട (vēṇṭa) — no need, no thank you

Before the new one: what did *kuraccū* mean?

You'll want to know: വേണ്ട

വേണ്ട (*vēṇṭa*) — “no need, no thank you”.

The negative partner of വേണം (*vēṇam*), “it is wanted”. വേണ്ട says the opposite: not wanted, not needed, no.

This is the polite refusal at a Kerala meal, and it is said often, because the serving is persistent. Said gently it declines; said firmly it stops the ladle. A guest who has learned only one refusal in Malayalam should learn this one.

Note that it declines the offer rather than the person. Malayalam has warmer ways of saying no to a request, and this one keeps to food, drink and objects.

What you've built

Four, and this one gets you through a meal.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vēṇṭa*
- it once more, slowly
- *vēṇṭa*, gently, then *vēṇṭa* again, firmly, and hear the difference the tone makes

Before you move on

What does വേണ്ട mean? (“no need, no thank you”.) Say it once more.

58.5 പൊരും (pōrum) — that will do, that is enough

Before the new one: what did *vēṇṭa* mean?

You'll want to know: പോരും

പോരും (*pōrum*) — “that will do, that is enough”.

From പോരുക (*pōruka*), “to suffice”, and it means that what is there is already enough.

Set it against *mati*, which you already have. The two overlap, and either will stop a server; പോരും leans a little more towards “that reaches far enough” and *mati* towards “stop”. Kerala uses both, often in the same breath.

The ം at the end is the anusvara, the humming close you have met on the sky-word and the star-word and the vessel-word. It closes a great many Malayalam words, and by now it should be arriving without thought.

What you've built

Five, and you can answer a served plate five ways: more, less, a little, no need, that will do.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pōrum*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *kūṭutal*, *kuravū*, *kuraccū*, *vēṇṭa*, *pōrum*

Before you move on

What does പോരും mean? (“that will do, that is enough”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 59

What the Air Carries

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name wind, sand, mud, smoke and an ember in Malayalam.

Complete ML-C59-ember and say all five words in order.

59.1 കാറ്റ് (kārrŭ) — wind

Before the new run of words: what did *vēṇṭa* mean, and what did *pōrum* mean?

You'll want to know: കാറ്റ്

കാറ്റ് (*kārrŭ*) — “wind”.

Inherited, matching Tamil *kārru*. The doubled റ in the middle is one of the harder things Malayalam asks of a new mouth: a trilled *r* held long, closer to a *tt* made further back than to anything English has.

In Kerala the word is bound up with the monsoon, and the wind that brings it off the Arabian Sea has its own name in the local calendar. A fisherman's day is decided by കാറ്റ് before it is decided by anything else.

It also does the work English gives to *air*, so a room with no കാറ്റ് is a stuffy room rather than a still one.

What you've built

The first of five things the weather brings.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kārrŭ*
- it once more, slowly
- *pōrumi*, then *kārrŭ*, and hold the doubled sound in the middle

Before you move on

What does കാറ്റ് mean? (“wind”.) Say it once more.

59.2 മണൽ (maṇal) — sand

Before the new one: what did *kārrŭ* mean?

You’ll want to know: മണൽ

മണൽ (*maṇal*) — “sand”.

Inherited, matching Tamil *maṇal*. The ണ is retroflex, made with the tongue curled back, and the chillu ള closes the word without a vowel after it — both of them sounds you have already been handling.

Kerala’s sand is a river business as much as a beach one. Sand is dredged from the beds of the rivers that this book has already given you a word for, and the trade is argued about constantly.

The retroflex *ṇ* is what separates this from a different word altogether, so the tongue position is carrying meaning rather than decorating it.

What you’ve built

Two: the wind, and something it moves.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *maṇal*
- it once more, slowly
- *kārrŭ*, then *maṇal*, and curl the tongue back for the middle of the second

Before you move on

What does മണൽ mean? (“sand”.) Say it once more.

59.3 ചെളി (ceḷi) — mud

Before the new one: what did *maṇal* mean?

You’ll want to know: ചെളി

ചെളി (*ceḷi*) — “mud”.

Inherited, and it names wet mud — the kind a monsoon makes, not the dry earth underneath it.

Kerala spends several months a year in it, and the word carries a mild disgust that the English one does not quite have. To say a thing has ചെളി on it is to say somebody should deal with that.

The ള at the end is the retroflex *ḷ*, tongue curled back again, and it is a different letter from the ള that closed the sand-word. Malayalam distinguishes three *l* sounds, and this run has now used two of them.

What you’ve built

Three, and the monsoon is doing the work.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ceḷi*
- it once more, slowly
- *maṇal*, then *ceḷi*, and hear the two different *l*-sounds at the end

Before you move on

What does ചെളി mean? (“mud”.) Say it once more.

59.4 പുക (puka) — smoke

Before the new one: what did *ceḷi* mean?

You'll want to know: പുക

പുക (*puka*) — “smoke”.

Inherited, matching Tamil *pukai*, and Malayalam has clipped the tail off where Tamil kept it — the same direction of travel you saw in the bone-word.

A Kerala kitchen fire makes a great deal of പുക, and the word covers steam and vapour as well, so a hot vessel and a smouldering one can be described with it alike.

It is a short word doing a wide job, which is common in this layer of the language: the oldest words tend to be the briefest and the busiest.

What you've built

Four, and this one rises.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *puka*
- it once more, slowly
- *cehi*, then *puka*, and say which of the two you would see from a distance

Before you move on

What does പുക mean? (“smoke”.) Say it once more.

59.5 കനൽ (kanal) — an ember, a live coal

Before the new one: what did *puka* mean?

You'll want to know: കനൽ

കനൽ (*kanal*) — “an ember, a live coal”.

Inherited, matching Tamil *kanal*, and it names the live coal rather than the flame — what is left glowing when a Kerala kitchen fire has burned down, and what is banked at night to be woken in the morning.

That is a distinction the language keeps carefully. The flame is one thing, the smoke you have just had is another, and the കനൽ is the third: the part that holds the heat after the rest has gone.

The chillu ങ്ങ closes it, the same bare *l* that closed the sand-word and the field-word before that.

What you've built

Five, and the run is closed: the wind, the sand, the mud, the smoke, and the ember that outlasts the fire.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kanal*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *kārrŭ, maṇal, ceḷi, puka, kanal*

Before you move on

What does കനൽ mean? (“an ember, a live coal”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 60

Animals Around a House

Modes: 🔄 voice (5) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a cow, a goat, a hen, a crow and an elephant in Malayalam.

Complete ML-C60-elephant and say all five words in order.

60.1 പശു (paśu) — a cow

Before the new run of words: what did *puka* mean, and what did *kanal* mean?

You'll want to know: പശു

പശു (*paśu*) — “a cow”.

Inherited from Sanskrit *paśu*, which named any tethered beast a household kept, and which Malayalam has narrowed to the one animal a Kerala yard is arranged around.

The Sanskrit word has relatives a long way west. Latin *pecu* meant a herd, and the English word *fee* began as the same idea — the wealth you could drive to market on its own legs.

The milk-word *pāl* comes out of a പശു, and so does most of what a Kerala kitchen does next with it.

What you've built

The first of five animals.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *paśu*
- it once more, slowly
- *paśu*, then *pāl*, and say which one gives the other

Before you move on

What does പശു mean? (“a cow”.) Say it once more.

60.2 ആട് (*āṭṭ*) — a goat

Before the new one: what did *paśu* mean?

You’ll want to know: ആട്

ആട് (*āṭṭ*) — “a goat”.

Inherited, matching Tamil *āṭu*, and it covers the animal at any age or either sex — a second word goes in front when the difference matters.

It sits one letter away from *nāṭṭ*, the home-country word. Take the *n* off the front of that one and you have this one, so the ear has to catch the very start of the word rather than the end of it.

A goat is what a household keeps when it has no room for the larger animal: it eats what it finds and it climbs what it likes.

What you’ve built

Two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *āṭṭ*
- it once more, slowly
- *nāṭṭ*, then *āṭṭ*, and say which of the two is an animal

Before you move on

What does ആട് mean? (“a goat”.) Say it once more.

60.3 കോഴി (*kōli*) — a hen

Before the new one: what did *āṭṭ* mean?

You’ll want to know: കോഴി

കോഴി (*kōli*) — “a hen”.

Native Dravidian, matching Tamil *kōli*, and carrying the ഴ that Malayalam and Tamil kept where their sisters let it go — the same letter sitting inside *pula*, the river, and *vali*, the way.

One word does for hen and cock alike. Where a speaker needs to separate them, a second word goes in front.

It is also the clock of a Kerala house: a കോഴി wakes the yard well before anyone has thought about the hour.

What you’ve built

Three.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kōli*
- it once more, slowly
- *kōli*, then *pula*, and say which sound the two have in common

Before you move on

What does കോഴി mean? (“a hen”.) Say it once more.

60.4 കാക്ക (*kākka*) — a crow

Before the new one: what did *kōli* mean?

You'll want to know: കാക്ക

കാക്ക (*kāka*) — “a crow”.

An imitation word: the bird is named for the noise it makes, and the same trick produced the crow-word in each of the sister languages. Once you have heard one you have the etymology.

Of all the birds around a house this is the one a household deals with daily. Cooked rice — *cōru* — set out on a step at the back is put there for the കാക്ക, and it arrives within the minute.

Kerala also gives the bird a job at a funeral rite, where a ball of rice is set out for the ancestors and the crow that takes it is the sign the offering landed.

What you've built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kāka*
- it once more, slowly
- *kāka*, then *kōli*, and say which of the two is kept and which turns up

Before you move on

What does കാക്ക mean? (“a crow”.) Say it once more.

60.5 ആന (*āna*) — an elephant

Before the new one: what did *kāka* mean?

You'll want to know: ആന

ആന (*āna*) — “an elephant”.

Inherited, and a worn-down cousin of Tamil *yānai*: the same Dravidian word, with the front of it rubbed away over the centuries until two letters were left.

You met a piece of this animal before you met the animal. *Kompŭ*, the branch-word, already covered the tusk of an ആന — one picture for the branch, the horn and the tusk, and no separate word needed for the third.

In Kerala the ആന belongs to a festival before it belongs to a forest. A caparisoned elephant standing in front of a temple is what most Malayalis picture on hearing the word.

What you've built

Five, and the yard is full: the cow, the goat, the hen, the crow, and the one that walks in a festival.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *āna*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *paśu*, *āṭṭ*, *kōḷi*, *kākka*, *āna*

Before you move on

What does ആന mean? (“an elephant”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 61

On the Kitchen Shelf

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a coconut, oil, curd, jaggery and a chilli in Malayalam.

Complete ML-C61-chilli and say all five words in order.

61.1 തേങ്ങ (tēṇṇa) — a coconut

Before the new run of words: what did *kāḱka* mean, and what did *āna* mean?

You'll want to know: തേങ്ങ

തേങ്ങ (tēṇṇa) — “a coconut”.

Native Dravidian, and the fruit of the tree the tree-lesson pointed at without naming: *marami* is any tree, and Kerala's own one gets a compound built on that word.

One long-standing account derives the name Kerala itself from a word for the coconut palm. The account is debated and worth holding loosely, but nobody argues about the tree's place in the kitchen.

A തേങ്ങ is the ripe nut with the husk off. Almost everything on the shelf after this one comes out of it in some form.

What you've built

The first of five things off a Kerala kitchen shelf.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tēñña*
- it once more, slowly
- *marami*, then *tēñña*, and say which one grows on the other

Before you move on

What does കേങ്ങ mean? (“a coconut”.) Say it once more.

61.2 എണ്ണ (eṇṇa) — oil

Before the new one: what did *tēñña* mean?

You’ll want to know: എണ്ണ

എണ്ണ (*eṇṇa*) — “oil”.

Native Dravidian, matching Tamil *eṇṇey*, and the older shape of it comes apart into two pieces meaning sesame and liquid — the oil named after the seed it first came from.

The seed changed and the word stayed. What a Kerala kitchen presses now is the coconut you have just met, so for most cooks the word for oil in general and the oil actually on the shelf name one thing.

The doubled ണ in the middle is a long consonant: hold it, the way *katti*, the knife-word, holds its *tt*.

What you’ve built

Two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *eṇṇa*
- it once more, slowly
- *tēñña*, then *eṇṇa*, and say which one is pressed out of the other

Before you move on

What does എണ്ണ mean? (“oil”.) Say it once more.

61.3 തൈര് (tairǔ) — curd

Before the new one: what did *eṇṇa* mean?

You’ll want to know: തൈര്

തൈര് (*tairǔ*) — “curd”.

Native Dravidian, matching Tamil *tayir*. Milk is warmed, cooled to the hand, given a spoonful of yesterday’s തൈര് and left overnight; by morning it has set.

It closes on the same bare *r* that closes *vērǔ*, the root-word — a consonant with the vowel taken off it rather than a syllable of its own.

On a Kerala plate it is the last course, spooned over rice to cool everything the chilli did earlier.

What you’ve built

Three.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tairǔ*
- it once more, slowly
- *pāl*, then *tairǔ*, and say which one is made from the other

Before you move on

What does തൈര് mean? (“curd”.) Say it once more.

61.4 ശർക്കര (śarkkara) — jaggery

Before the new one: what did *tairǔ* mean?

You'll want to know: ശർക്കര

ശർക്കര (*śarkkara*) — “jaggery”.

Sanskrit *śarkārā*, whose first meaning was gravel or grit — the sweetener named for its grain rather than for its taste.

That word travelled further than most. Arabic took it as *sukkar*, Latin as *saccharum*, and English ended with *sugar* and *saccharine*, so an English speaker half owns this shelf-word already.

Kerala's own ശർക്കര is dark and soft, boiled down from palm sap or cane, and it is what sweetens the festival rice pudding rather than white sugar.

What you've built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *śarkkara*
- it once more, slowly
- *śarkkara*, then the English word *sugar*, and hear one word twice

Before you move on

What does ശർക്കര mean? (“jaggery”.) Say it once more.

61.5 മുളക് (*muḷakṣ*) — a chilli

Before the new one: what did *śarkkara* mean?

You'll want to know: മുളക്

മുളക് (*muḷakṣ*) — “a chilli”.

Native Dravidian, and older than the thing it now names. The chilli reached Kerala on Portuguese ships in the sixteenth century; the word was waiting for it.

Before that it belonged to black pepper, the crop Kerala had been selling to the world for a thousand years. Pepper kept the word with a piece added in front of it, and the newcomer walked off with the plain form.

So the basket of pepper going down to the market and the മുളക് in the curry carry the same name, one of them with a syllable of warning attached.

What you've built

Five, and the shelf is stocked: a coconut, oil, curd, jaggery and a chilli.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *muḷakŭ*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *tēṇṇa*, *eṇṇa*, *tairŭ*, *śarkkara*, *muḷakŭ*

Before you move on

What does മുളക് mean? (“a chilli”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 62

Made by Hand

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name rope, thread, a needle, a broom and a winnowing tray in Malayalam.

Complete ML-C62-winnowing-tray and say all five words in order.

62.1 കയർ (kayar) — coir rope

Before the new run of words: what did *śarkkara* mean, and what did *mulakŭ* mean?

You'll want to know: കയർ

കയർ (*kayar*) — “coir rope”.

Native Dravidian, from a root about twisting, and it names both the fibre and the rope twisted out of it.

The fibre comes off the husk of the coconut you met on the shelf, soaked in backwater until it softens and then beaten out by hand. Kerala has made rope this way for as long as anyone has written about it.

English borrowed the word along with the trade: *coir* is this word, carried out of Malabar on Portuguese and Dutch ships.

What you've built

The first of five things made by hand.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kayar*
- it once more, slowly
- *tēñña*, then *kayar*, and say which one the other is made from

Before you move on

What does കയർ mean? (“coir rope”.) Say it once more.

62.2 നൂല് (nūlŭ) — thread

Before the new one: what did *kayar* mean?

You’ll want to know: നൂല്

നൂല് (*nūlŭ*) — “thread”.

Native Dravidian, matching Tamil *nūl*, and it stands behind *tuñi*, the cloth-word: one is what the other is woven from.

The older language put the same word to a second job. A treatise, a work of scholarship, was also a *nūl* — a thread of argument running from one end of a subject to the other, which is close to what English does with a train of thought.

It closes on the bare *l* of *cōru* and *vērŭ*: the consonant with its vowel shaved off.

What you’ve built

Two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nūlŭ*
- it once more, slowly
- *kayar*, then *nūlŭ*, and say which of the two is thicker

Before you move on

What does നൂല് mean? (“thread”.) Say it once more.

62.3 സൂചി (sūci) — a needle

Before the new one: what did *nūlū* mean?

You’ll want to know: സൂചി

സൂചി (*sūci*) — “a needle”.

Sanskrit *sūcī*, from a root about piercing and pointing, and the same root gives Sanskrit its word for an indication or a sign.

So the needle and the pointer come from one idea: the thing that goes in, and the thing that points out. A Malayalam newsreader saying that a report *indicates* something is standing on this root.

With *nūlū* through the eye of it, a സൂചി is what turns cloth back into something a person can wear.

What you’ve built

Three.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sūci*
- it once more, slowly
- *nūlū*, then *sūci*, and say which one goes through the other

Before you move on

What does സൂചി mean? (“a needle”.) Say it once more.

62.4 ചൂല് (cūlū) — a broom

Before the new one: what did *sūci* mean?

You'll want to know: ചൂല്

ചൂല് (*cūlŭ*) — “a broom”.

Native Dravidian, and a Kerala ചൂല് is a bundle of coconut-leaf ribs bound tight at one end — the coconut again, a third time on a third object.

Sweeping the yard at first light is the opening work of a Kerala day, done before the kitchen is lit, and it leaves the ground marked in long strokes that stay until somebody walks on them.

There is a second broom for indoors, softer, made of grass rather than leaf-rib, and the same word covers it.

What you've built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cūlŭ*
- it once more, slowly
- *sūci*, then *cūlŭ*, and say which of the two you hold in a fist

Before you move on

What does ചൂല് mean? (“a broom”.) Say it once more.

62.5 മുറം (muram) — a winnowing tray

Before the new one: what did *cūlŭ* mean?

You'll want to know: മുറം

മുറം (*muram*) — “a winnowing tray”.

Native Dravidian: a flat plaited tray with a lip on three sides, woven from bamboo strip like the mat and the basket before it.

Its work needs the wind. Grain is tossed up off the മുറം and *kārrŭ* carries the husk sideways while the heavy part drops back — a machine with no moving parts, run on weather.

Ari, the raw rice on the kitchen shelf, has been through one of these on its way there.

What you've built

Five, and every one of them came off somebody's hands: rope, thread, a needle, a broom and a winnowing tray.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *muram*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *kayar*, *nūlŭ*, *sūci*, *cūlŭ*, *muram*

Before you move on

What does 𐄧𐄫𐄮 mean? (“a winnowing tray”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 63

How the Body Reports

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name hunger, tiredness, pain, a cough and a fever in Malayalam.

Complete ML-C63-fever and say all five words in order.

63.1 വിശപ്പ് (viśappŭ) — hunger

Before the new run of words: what did *cūlŭ* mean, and what did *murani* mean?

You'll want to know: വിശപ്പ്

വിശപ്പ് (*viśappŭ*) — “hunger”.

Native Dravidian, built off *viśakkuka*, the word for going hungry — the state named from the process rather than the other way round.

Tamil reaches for a different root here, *paci*, so this is one of the places where the two closest sisters part company on an everyday word.

You already have the part of the body it reports from: *vayarŭ*, the stomach. One is the place, this is the message.

What you've built

The first of five things the body reports.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *viśappũ*
- it once more, slowly
- *vayarũ*, then *viśappũ*, and say which of the two is a feeling

Before you move on

What does വിശപ്പ് mean? (“hunger”) Say it once more.

63.2 ക്ഷീണം (kṣīṇam) — tiredness

Before the new one: what did *viśappũ* mean?

You’ll want to know: ക്ഷീണം

ക്ഷീണം (*kṣīṇam*) — “tiredness”.

Sanskrit *kṣīṇa*, meaning worn away or diminished, from a root about wasting down to nothing.

In Malayalam the heavier sense has itself worn away, and the word has settled into ordinary speech for the plain tiredness of a long day.

It opens on the ക്ഷ pair that opens *kṣamikkanaṁ*, the sorry-word — one letter riding on another, and the second one you have met wearing it.

What you’ve built

Two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kṣīṇam*
- it once more, slowly
- *kṣamikkanaṁ*, then *kṣīṇam*, and hear the same opening twice

Before you move on

What does ക്ഷീണം mean? (“tiredness”.) Say it once more.

63.3 വേദന (vēdana) — pain

Before the new one: what did *kṣīṇam* mean?

You’ll want to know: വേദന

വേദന (*vēdana*) — “pain”.

Sanskrit *vedanā*, from the root *vid*, to know or to feel — pain named as the thing a body knows without being told.

That root has been busy in this book. *Vaidyan*, the doctor, and *vidyārthi*, the student, both grow from it: knowing, learning, healing and hurting all off one seed.

Malayalam keeps it for bodily pain first and lets the wider sense follow, so a speaker saying വേദന is usually pointing somewhere.

What you’ve built

Three.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vēdana*
- it once more, slowly
- *vaidyan*, then *vēdana*, and say which of the two is the reason for the other

Before you move on

What does വേദന mean? (“pain”.) Say it once more.

63.4 ചുമ (cuma) — a cough

Before the new one: what did *vēdana* mean?

You'll want to know: ചുമ

ചുമ (*cuma*) — “a cough”.

Native, and built the way the crow's name was built: the sound comes first and the word is shaped to match it.

Tamil went elsewhere for this one, to *irumal*, from a root of its own — a second parting between the two sisters inside one short chapter.

It covers the single cough and the standing complaint alike, so a speaker adds a word about how long it has gone on when that matters.

What you've built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cuma*
- it once more, slowly
- *kākka*, then *cuma*, and say what the making of the two words has in common

Before you move on

What does ചുമ mean? (“a cough”.) Say it once more.

63.5 പനി (pani) — a fever

Before the new one: what did *cuma* mean?

You'll want to know: പനി

പനി (*pani*) — “a fever”.

Native Dravidian, matching Tamil *pani* — where the same word means cold, dew and frost.

Malayalam took the shivering and let the weather go. What the two senses share is a body that cannot get warm, which is the first hour of a fever and the whole of a cold morning.

Kerala hangs the word on the season: the weeks after the monsoon breaks are fever weeks, and പനി is the word on everybody's tongue.

What you've built

Five, and the body has said its piece: hunger, tiredness, pain, a cough and a fever.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pani*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *viśappũ, kṣīṇam, vēdana, cuma, pani*

Before you move on

What does പനി mean? (“a fever”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 64

Five Words That Join

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say then, soon, sometimes, only and but in Malayalam.

Complete ML-C64-but and say all five words in order.

64.1 പിന്നെ (pinne) — then, after that

Before the new run of words: what did *cuma* mean, and what did *pani* mean?

You'll want to know: പിന്നെ

പിന്നെ (*pinne*) — “then, after that”.

Native Dravidian, built on *pin*, the piece meaning behind or at the back. What sits behind you in space becomes what comes after you in time, and the same short word does both jobs.

Kerala also leans on it as a filler, the *so...* a speaker puts in front of a sentence to buy a second before starting it.

After *śari*, it turns an agreement into a continuation: right, and then.

What you've built

The first of five small words that join one thing to the next.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pinne*
- it once more, slowly
- *śari*, then *pinne*, as though agreeing and going on

Before you move on

What does പിന്നെ mean? (“then, after that”.) Say it once more.

64.2 ഉടനെ (*uṭane*) — soon, right away

Before the new one: what did *pinne* mean?

You’ll want to know: ഉടനെ

ഉടനെ (*uṭane*) — “soon, right away”.

Native Dravidian, built on *uṭan*, meaning along with — what happens beside a thing rather than after it.

So the two words you now have divide the near future between them. *Pinne* leaves a gap; ഉടനെ closes it.

In Kerala speech it also softens a refusal: not now, but not far off either.

What you’ve built

Two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *uṭane*
- it once more, slowly
- *pinne*, then *uṭane*, and say which of the two leaves a gap

Before you move on

What does ഉടനെ mean? (“soon, right away”.) Say it once more.

64.3 ചിലപ്പോൾ (cilappōḷ) — sometimes

Before the new one: what did *uṭane* mean?

You’ll want to know: ചിലപ്പോൾ

ചിലപ്പോൾ (*cilappōḷ*) — “sometimes”.

Two pieces, and you can take them apart by ear: *cila*, some or a few, and *pōḷ*, the when-piece.

That tail is the same one closing *ippōḷ*, the now-word. One says at this time, the other says at some times, and the shared ending is the reason the two rhyme.

It is the word a Malayali reaches for when hedging: not a denial, only a fence around a claim.

What you’ve built

Three.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *cilappōḷ*
- it once more, slowly
- *ippōḷ*, then *cilappōḷ*, and say which of the two is certain

Before you move on

What does ചിലപ്പോൾ mean? (“sometimes”.) Say it once more.

64.4 മാത്രം (mātram) — only, that much and no more

Before the new one: what did *cilappōḷ* mean?

You’ll want to know: മാത്രം

മാത്രം (*mātram*) — “only, that much and no more”.

Sanskrit *mātra*, a measure, from the root *mā*, to measure. The Greek *metron* behind *metre* grows from the same seed, so this word and a poet’s line-length are cousins.

Set after a word it fences that word off: this much, and nothing beyond it.

Beside *kuraccū*, which says a small amount, മാത്രം says an exact amount and shuts the door.

What you’ve built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mātram*
- it once more, slowly
- *kuraccū*, then *mātram*, and say which one sets a limit

Before you move on

What does മാത്രം mean? (“only, that much and no more”.) Say it once more.

64.5 എന്നാൽ (ennāl) — but, on the other hand

Before the new one: what did *mātram* mean?

You’ll want to know: എന്നാൽ

എന്നാൽ (*ennāl*) — “but, on the other hand”.

Built out of the saying-piece *enn-*, the one behind reported speech, and a tail meaning by or through: roughly, by that having been said.

English arrives at almost the same phrase from the other end with *that said*, which is a small comfort — the shape is already familiar even though the pieces are not.

So the word grants the previous sentence before it turns on it, which is a gentler move than a flat contradiction.

What you've built

Five, and a sentence can now go on, hurry, hedge, stop short or turn.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ennāl*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *pinne, uṭane, cilappōl, mātram, ennāl*

Before you move on

What does എനാൽ mean? (“but, on the other hand”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 65

Asking Well

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a request, permission, consent, good manners and trust in Malayalam.

Complete ML-C65-trust and say all five words in order.

65.1 അപേക്ഷ (apēkṣa) — a request

Before the new run of words: what did *mātram* mean, and what did *ennāl* mean?

You'll want to know: അപേക്ഷ

അപേക്ഷ (apēkṣa) — “a request”.

Sanskrit *apekṣā*, made of a piece meaning toward and a root meaning to look. A request is a looking-toward: the eyes go to the person who can grant it before the words do.

It carries the ക്ഷ pair you have now met twice, in *kṣamikkanaṁ* and in *kṣīṇaṁ*, this time sitting in the middle of the word rather than at its head.

Beside *dayavāyī*, which softens whatever follows it, അപേക്ഷ names the asking itself and can stand on its own at the head of a written petition.

What you've built

The first of five words for asking well.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *apēkṣa*
- it once more, slowly
- *dayavāyi*, then *apēkṣa*, and say which of the two is the asking itself

Before you move on

What does അപേക്ഷ mean? (“a request”.) Say it once more.

65.2 അനുവാദം (anuvādam) — permission

Before the new one: what did *apēkṣa* mean?

You’ll want to know: അനുവാദം

അനുവാദം (*anuvādam*) — “permission”.

Sanskrit *anuvāda*: a piece meaning after or along, and a piece meaning speaking. Permission is the speaking-after, the second voice that falls in behind the first.

The same Sanskrit word names a repetition and a translation, which is one picture seen from another side — saying again what somebody else has already said.

So the shape of the courtesy is built into the word: somebody asks, and somebody speaks after.

What you’ve built

Two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *anuvādam*
- it once more, slowly
- *apēkṣa*, then *anuvādam*, and say which one comes first

Before you move on

What does അനുവാദം mean? (“permission”.) Say it once more.

65.3 സമ്മതം (sammataṁ) — consent, an agreeing

Before the new one: what did *anuvādaṁ* mean?

You’ll want to know: സമ്മതം

സമ്മതം (*sammataṁ*) — “consent, an agreeing”.

Sanskrit *sammata*: a piece meaning together, and *mata*, a thought held. Consent is two minds held in one position.

That *mata* piece stands behind the Sanskrit word for an opinion and for a doctrine, so what a household calls agreement and what a school of thought calls its position are the same word wearing different clothes.

Between the two you now have, *anuvādaṁ* comes down from somebody with the standing to grant it and സമ്മതം passes sideways between equals.

What you’ve built

Three.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sammataṁ*
- it once more, slowly
- *anuvādaṁ*, then *sammataṁ*, and say which of the two is given from above

Before you move on

What does സമ്മതം mean? (“consent, an agreeing”.) Say it once more.

65.4 മര്യാദ (maryāda) — good manners

Before the new one: what did *sammatani* mean?

You'll want to know: മര്യാദ

മര്യാദ (*maryāda*) — “good manners”.

Sanskrit *maryādā*, whose first sense was a boundary mark set at the edge of a field, and whose second is the bounds of proper conduct.

Kerala keeps both senses live in one word. To have മര്യാദ is to know where the edges are and to stop at them without being asked.

Beside *bahumānami*, respect, which is something a person shows another, this is something a person keeps for themselves.

What you've built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *maryāda*
- it once more, slowly
- *bahumānami*, then *maryāda*, and say which of the two you show and which you keep

Before you move on

What does മര്യാദ mean? (“good manners”.) Say it once more.

65.5 വിശ്വാസം (viśvāsaṁ) — trust

Before the new one: what did *maryāda* mean?

You'll want to know: വിശ്വാസം

വിശ്വാസം (*viśvāsaṁ*) — “trust”.

Sanskrit *viśvāsa*, from a root about breathing. Trust is drawn there as breathing out — a body that has stopped holding itself ready.

The same root sits behind the Sanskrit word for a sigh, which is the same picture again, and the metaphor survives whole into everyday Malayalam.

It also carries belief in the religious sense, so the everyday and the weightier senses share a word and the situation says which is meant.

What you've built

Five, and asking has its vocabulary: a request, permission, consent, good manners, and the trust the other four rest on.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *viśvāsam*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *apēkṣa*, *anuvādam*, *sammatam*, *maryāda*, *viśvāsam*

Before you move on

What does വിശ്വാസം mean? (“trust”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 66

Out in the Paddy

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name paddy, grass, an ear of grain, a plough and the harvest in Malayalam.

Complete ML-C66-harvest and say all five words in order.

66.1 നെല്ല് (nellŭ) — unhusked rice, rice still in the husk

Before the new run of words: what did *maryāda* mean, and what did *viśvāsaṁ* mean?

You'll want to know: നെല്ല്

നെല്ല് (*nellŭ*) — “unhusked rice, rice still in the husk”.

Native Dravidian, matching Tamil *nel*, and it completes a set you have been collecting a piece at a time. നെല്ല് is the grain in the husk and in the field; *ari* is the same grain husked; *cōru* is it cooked.

Three words for one plant is what a language does when the plant is the year's whole work. The flooded field you already know by name, *vayal*, is where the first of the three lives.

It sounds like *ellŭ*, the bone-word, with an *n* set in front. The two have nothing to do with one another, and the front of the word is again where the ear earns its keep.

What you've built

The first of five words from the paddy.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nellŭ*
- it once more, slowly
- *ellŭ*, then *nellŭ*, and say which of the two you can eat

Before you move on

What does **നെല്ല** mean? (“unhusked rice, rice still in the husk”.)
Say it once more.

66.2 പുല്ല (pullŭ) — grass

Before the new one: what did *nellŭ* mean?

You'll want to know: പുല്ല

പുല്ല (*pullŭ*) — “grass”.

Native Dravidian, matching Tamil *pul*, and it ends the way **നെല്ല** ends — a doubled *l* with the vowel shaved off, so the two words rhyme on the tail.

They are the field's two crops seen from opposite sides. One is planted and counted; the other turns up on its own and is cut for the animals.

Which makes this the *paśu*'s word rather than the farmer's: grass is what the cow is walked out to.

What you've built

Two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pullŭ*
- it once more, slowly
- *paśu*, then *pullŭ*, and say which one eats the other

Before you move on

What does പുല്ല് mean? (“grass”.) Say it once more.

66.3 കതിര് (katirŭ) — an ear of ripe paddy

Before the new one: what did *pullŭ* mean?

You’ll want to know: കതിര്

കതിര് (*katirŭ*) — “an ear of ripe paddy”.

Native Dravidian, matching Tamil *katir*, and the same word names a ray of light. The ear of grain and the sunbeam are one shape to this language: a narrow bright thing thrown out from a stem.

Veyil, the sunshine-word, is the other half of that picture, and a Malayalam poet can put the two side by side and let the reader do the joining.

A field of **കതിര്** is a field ready. Everything in this chapter after this point is what happens next.

What you’ve built

Three.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *katirŭ*
- it once more, slowly
- *veyil*, then *katirŭ*, and say what the two have in common

Before you move on

What does കതിര് mean? (“an ear of ripe paddy”.) Say it once more.

66.4 കലപ്പ (kalappa) — a plough

Before the new one: what did *katirũ* mean?

You’ll want to know: കലപ്പ

കലപ്പ (*kalappa*) — “a plough”.

Native Dravidian, and it names the tool behind a word you already carry. *Karṣakan*, the farmer, was named for the furrow rather than for the crop; കലപ്പ is what cuts the furrow.

Kerala’s is a light wooden one, made for ground already under water, with a single iron-shod point and a beam for a pair of cattle.

Which puts the *paśu* back to work: the animal of the first chapter in this run and the tool of the last one are yoked together.

What you’ve built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kalappa*
- it once more, slowly
- *karṣakan*, then *kalappa*, and say which one holds the other

Before you move on

What does കലപ്പ mean? (“a plough”.) Say it once more.

66.5 കൊയ്ത്ത് (*koyttŭ*) — the harvest, the reaping

Before the new one: what did *kalappa* mean?

You'll want to know: കൊയ്ത്ത്

കൊയ്ത്ത് (*koyttŭ*) — “the harvest, the reaping”.

Native Dravidian, made from *koyyuka*, to cut or to reap — the harvest named for the cutting rather than for the gathering that follows it.

Kerala's largest festival is the harvest festival, and the flower pattern laid at the doorway for it, *pŭkkaḷani*, is the one the flower-lesson already named.

So the run closes where the year does: the grain, the grass, the ripe ear, the plough that opened the ground, and the cutting that ends it.

What you've built

Five, and the paddy year is whole: *nellŭ*, *pullŭ*, *katirŭ*, *kalappa*, *koyttŭ*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *koyttŭ*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *nellŭ*, *pullŭ*, *katirŭ*, *kalappa*, *koyttŭ*

Before you move on

What does കൊയ്ത്ത് mean? (“the harvest, the reaping”.) Say it once more.

The Malayalam script — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words, each letter introduced as a word needs it. This page just gathers the system.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a.”** ക = ka, മ = ma, ര = ra.
2. **A vowel sign changes that built-in vowel.** കാ = k $\bar{a}$, കി = ki, കീ = k $\bar{i}$, കു = ku, കൂ = k $\bar{u}$, കെ = ke, കേ = k $\bar{e}$, കൊ = ko, കോ = k $\bar{o}$. (The *e/o* signs are written *before* their consonant but read after.)
3. **The *chandrakkala* strips the built-in vowel, and bare consonants join as conjuncts.** സ + ക → സ്ക (ska), ന + ദ → ന്ദ (nda), ല + ല → ല്ല (lla). A circle anusvāram ണ adds a final nasal.

Independent vowels (word-initial)

അ a · ആ ā · ഇ i · ഊ ī · ഉ u · ഊ ū · എ e · ഏ ē · ഐ ai ·
ഒ o · ഓ ō · ഔ au.

Worth flagging

- **The largest Dravidian alphabet.** Because Malayalam borrowed so heavily from Sanskrit, it keeps the full Sanskrit inventory — aspirates (ഖ kh, ധ dh...) and all three sibilants (ശ ś, ഷ ṣ, സ s) — alongside native Dravidian letters Tamil also has (the retroflex ള ḷ, ഴ ḻ, ഹ ṇ).
- **Rounded forms, many conjuncts.** Malayalam’s curved letters and rich stock of stacked/ligated conjuncts give it a distinctive dense look.

Malayalam in the Dravidian family

Dravidian is a family entirely separate from Indo-European (English, Latin, Sanskrit). Malayalam is the *closest sister of Tamil* — the two split from one language only about a thousand years ago — so its everyday core is strikingly Tamil-like (*nandi*, *illa*, *śari*, and the *pōyi varām* farewell). At the same time it absorbed a vast Sanskrit layer, which is why its formal greeting (*namaskāram*) and its full letter-set are Sanskritised. The lessons trace, word by word, what is inherited Dravidian and what is borrowed.

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

-ിക്ക് *-ikku*

the dative suffix *-ikku*, 'to / for' — and the idea of stacking
Introduced in Chapter 6.

aaru ezhu ettu ompathu pathu

hear and say six to ten before meeting their written forms
Introduced in Chapter 7.

അച്ഛൻ അമ്മ ചേട്ടൻ അനിയൻ ചേച്ചി അനിയത്തി *acchan amma*
cēṭṭan aniyān cēcci aniyatti

father, mother, and four age-graded sibling words — Malayalam's own distinct set, still following the shared Dravidian age-first pattern
Introduced in Chapter 12.

അധ്യാപകൻ *adhyāpakan*

a teacher
Introduced in Chapter 48.

ആകാശം *ākāśam*

the sky
Introduced in Chapter 53.

ആന *āna*

an elephant
Introduced in Chapter 60.

അങ്ങനെ *anṇane*

that way, just so
Introduced in Chapter 49.

ആണ് *āṇ*

is (the copula)
Introduced in Chapter 2.

അനുഗ്രഹം *anugraham*

a blessing
Introduced in Chapter 51.

അനുവാദം *anuvādam*

permission

Introduced in Chapter 65.

അപേക്ഷ *apēkṣa*

a request

Introduced in Chapter 65.

അറിയുക *ariyuka*

to know — the verb inside എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം, and the one that will not let you be the subject

Introduced in Chapter 32.

ആര് *ārū*

who? — asking about a person

Introduced in Chapter 41.

അതെ *athe*

yes (athe — “that [is so]”)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

അതിഥി *atithi*

a guest

Introduced in Chapter 48.

അത് *atū*

that one — the thing over there

Introduced in Chapter 41.

ആട് *ātū*

a goat

Introduced in Chapter 60.

അവിടെ *aviṭe*

there — where I am not

Introduced in Chapter 41.

ബഹുമാനം *bahumānam*

respect

Introduced in Chapter 51.

ഭർത്താവ് *bharttāvū*

husband

Introduced in Chapter 45.

ഭാര്യ *bhārya*

wife

Introduced in Chapter 45.

ചന്ദ്രൻ *candran*

the moon

Introduced in Chapter 53.

ചെളി *ceḷi*

mud

Introduced in Chapter 59.

ചെറിയ *ceṛiya*

small

Introduced in Chapter 42.

ചെവി *cevi*

ear — where three of the four sisters agree, and the fourth alone keeps the older sound

Introduced in Chapter 37.

ചായ *chaaya*

tea — Chinese, carried overland through Persian and Hindi before it ever reached Kerala

Introduced in Chapter 39.

ചിലപ്പോൾ *cilappōḷ*

sometimes

Introduced in Chapter 64.

ചിങ്ങം കന്നി തുലാം വൃശ്ചികം ധനു മകരം കുംഭം മീനം മേടം ഇടവം

മിഥുനം കർക്കടകം *ciṅṅaṁ kanni tulāṁ vṛścikaṁ dhanu makaram*

kumbham mīnaṁ mēṭaṁ iṭavaṁ mithunaṁ karkkaṭakaṁ

the twelve months of the Malayalam (Kollam Era) solar calendar — also solar, like Tamil’s, but named for ZODIAC SIGNS rather than nakshatras

Introduced in Chapter 16.

ചിന്തിക്കുക *cintikkuka*

to think — a Sanskrit noun turned into a verb by the same -ഇക്കുക that made ക്ഷമിക്കുക, and the first of four verbs about what happens inside a head

Introduced in Chapter 33.

ചോദിക്കുക *cōdikkuka*

to ask — a Sanskrit word for pushing that walked into a gap Malayalam had made by narrowing its own inherited verb to “hear”

Introduced in Chapter 34.

ചൂല് *cūḷ*

a broom

Introduced in Chapter 62.

ചുമ *cuma*

a cough

Introduced in Chapter 63.

ചുണ്ട് *cunṭ*

a lip

Introduced in Chapter 57.

ദയവായി *dayavāyi*

please (dayavāyi — “as a compassion,” from ദയ daya “compassion”)
Introduced in Chapter 8.

ദിവസം *divasam*

“day” — everyday Sanskrit divasam beside the more literary Sanskrit dinam
Introduced in Chapter 23.

എല്ല *ellū*

a bone

Introduced in Chapter 57.

എഴുതു *elutū*

write

Introduced in Chapter 44.

എഴുതുക *elutuka*

to write — the same word as Tamil எழுது, carrying the ൧ that only these two sisters kept, and the chapter’s closing count of four

Introduced in Chapter 33.

എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം *enikku malayāḷam ariyām*

‘I know Malayalam’ — built with no subject, because knowing happens TO you
Introduced in Chapter 6.

എനിക്ക് മലയാളം ഇഷ്ടമാണ് *enikku malayāḷam iṣṭamāṇ*

‘I like Malayalam’ — a noun, a copula, and a dative; the one sentence in this book where putting yourself in the subject slot is not merely odd but impossible
Introduced in Chapter 34.

എണ്ണ *eṇṇa*

oil

Introduced in Chapter 61.

എന്നാൽ *ennāl*

but, on the other hand

Introduced in Chapter 64.

എങ്ങനെ *eṇṇane*

how

Introduced in Chapter 3.

എന്റെ *enre*

my

Introduced in Chapter 2.

എന്റെ പേര് ... ആണ് *enre pēru ... āṇ*

my name is...

Introduced in Chapter 2.

എന്ത് *entū*

what

Introduced in Chapter 2.

എടുക്കുക *eṭukkuka*

to take — native to the bone, yet ending in -ക്കുക like the borrowings; the letter that actually does the stamping is the ഇ
Introduced in Chapter 34.

എവിടെ *eviṭe*

where? — asking about a place
Introduced in Chapter 41.

ഹൃദയം *hrdayam*

heart — Sanskrit tatsama, and a genuine (if distant) cousin of the English word
Introduced in Chapter 38.

ഇല്ല *illa*

no / there isn't (illa — the negative)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

ഇപ്പോൾ *ippōl*

now
Introduced in Chapter 50.

ഇത് *itū*

this one — the thing near me
Introduced in Chapter 41.

ഇവിടെ *iviṭe*

here — where I am
Introduced in Chapter 41.

ജോലി ചെയ്യുക *jōli ceyyuka*

to work (lit. “work-do”)
Introduced in Chapter 5.

കാപ്പി *kaapi*

coffee — an English colonial-era loan, itself from Arabic by way of Turkish and Italian; tea and coffee arrived by opposite roads
Introduced in Chapter 39.

കാക്ക *kāka*

a crow
Introduced in Chapter 60.

കാൽ *kāl*

leg, foot
Introduced in Chapter 47.

കലപ്പ *kalappa*

a plough
Introduced in Chapter 66.

കാലാവസ്ഥ *kālāvastha*

weather — a Sanskrit compound literally meaning “state of TIME”: kaala (“time”) + avastha (“state, condition”) — a real echo of Spanish’s tiempo meaning both “time” AND “weather”
Introduced in Chapter 20.

കഴുത്ത് *kaluttŭ*

the neck

Introduced in Chapter 57.

കനൽ *kanal*

an ember, a live coal

Introduced in Chapter 59.

കണ്ണ് *kaṇṇŭ*

eye — Proto-Dravidian, nearly identical across all four literary Dravidian languages

Introduced in Chapter 37.

കാണുക *kāṇuka*

to see — the family's shared see-root, kept as Malayalam's everyday word, and the mood endings that share one slot with tense

Introduced in Chapter 32.

കാറ്റ് *kārrŭ*

wind

Introduced in Chapter 59.

കർഷകൻ *karṣakan*

a farmer

Introduced in Chapter 48.

കറുപ്പ് വെള്ള ചുവപ്പ് നീല *karuppŭ vella cuvappŭ nīla*

black, white, red, blue — Malayalam shares Tamil's native colors, and its Sanskrit blue too

Introduced in Chapter 11.

കസേര *kasēra*

a chair

Introduced in Chapter 52.

കതിര് *katirŭ*

an ear of ripe paddy

Introduced in Chapter 66.

കത്തി *katti*

a knife

Introduced in Chapter 56.

കയർ *kayar*

coir rope

Introduced in Chapter 62.

കേൾക്കൂ *kēḷkkū*

listen

Introduced in Chapter 44.

കോലം *kōlam*

the pattern drawn at a doorway

Introduced in Chapter 52.

കോഴി *kōli*

a hen

Introduced in Chapter 60.

കൊമ്പ് *kompŭ*

a branch

Introduced in Chapter 54.

കൊട്ട *koṭṭa*

a basket

Introduced in Chapter 56.

കൊയ്ത്ത് *koyttŭ*

the harvest, the reaping

Introduced in Chapter 66.

കൃതജ്ഞത *kṛtajñata*

gratitude

Introduced in Chapter 51.

ക്ഷമിക്കണം *kṣamikkaṇam*

(you) should forgive / sorry (kṣamikkaṇam — from kṣamikkuka “to forgive,”

Sanskrit kṣama + necessitative -aṇam)

Introduced in Chapter 9.

ക്ഷീണം *kṣīṇam*

tiredness

Introduced in Chapter 63.

കുറച്ച് *kuraccŭ*

a little, a few

Introduced in Chapter 58.

കുറവ് *kuravŭ*

less, a shortage

Introduced in Chapter 58.

കുട്ടി *kuṭṭi*

child, kid — the general word, native Dravidian, before Malayalam narrows to son or daughter

Introduced in Chapter 36.

കുടുംബം *kuṭumbam*

family — the collective word Chapter 12’s six people-words never needed, because each of them already named one specific person

Introduced in Chapter 35.

കൂടുതൽ *kūṭutal*

more

Introduced in Chapter 58.

മകൾ *makal*

daughter — identical to Tamil’s own word, sound for sound, closer even than the son-word

Introduced in Chapter 36.

മകൻ *makan*

son — Proto-Dravidian, closely matching Tamil, where Kannada softened the same root

Introduced in Chapter 36.

മാല *māla*

a garland

Introduced in Chapter 52.

മണൽ *maṇal*

sand

Introduced in Chapter 59.

മനസ്സിലാക്കുക *manassilākkuka*

to understand — literally “to put it in the mind,” a three-piece word you can take apart by ear, with a second form that hands the understanding to you instead

Introduced in Chapter 33.

മണി *maṇi*

hour — Malayalam’s OWN dictionary tradition treats bell/hour/gem as ONE Sanskrit word, unlike Tamil’s closely related mani, which its own dictionaries split into two unrelated homophones

Introduced in Chapter 18.

മരം *maram*

a tree

Introduced in Chapter 54.

മറ്റന്നാൾ *marrannāl*

the day after tomorrow

Introduced in Chapter 50.

മര്യാദ *maryāda*

good manners

Introduced in Chapter 65.

മതി *matī*

enough, that will do

Introduced in Chapter 49.

മാത്രം *mātram*

only, that much and no more

Introduced in Chapter 64.

മുക്ക് *mūkkū*

nose — native Dravidian, a fourth near-perfect match across the family

Introduced in Chapter 37.

മുളക് *muḷakū*

a chilli

Introduced in Chapter 61.

മുറം *muram*

a winnowing tray

Introduced in Chapter 62.

മുടി *muti*

hair

Introduced in Chapter 47.

മുത്തച്ഛൻ *muttacchan*
grandfather

Introduced in Chapter 45.

മുത്തശ്ശി *muttaśśi*

grandmother

Introduced in Chapter 45.

മുതുകു *mutukū*

the back

Introduced in Chapter 57.

നഖം *nakham*

a nail, a claw

Introduced in Chapter 57.

നക്ഷത്രം *nakṣatram*

a star

Introduced in Chapter 53.

നാളെ കാണാം *nāḷe kāṇāmi*

see you tomorrow

Introduced in Chapter 4.

നല്ല *nalla*

good

Introduced in Chapter 42.

നമസ്കാരം *namaskāram*

hello / greetings (namaskāram — a making of a bow)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

ഞാൻ *ñān*

I

Introduced in Chapter 3.

ഞാൻ മലയാളം സംസാരിക്കുന്നു *ñān malayāḷami samisārikkunnu*

I speak Malayalam

Introduced in Chapter 5.

നന്ദി *nandi*

thank you (nandi — the native Dravidian word, Tamil's cousin)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

നാട് *nāṭṭ*

home country, the place you are from

Introduced in Chapter 55.

നായ, പൂച്ച *nāya, pūcca*

dog and cat — naaya continues the solid, ancient native Dravidian dog-root shared with Kannada and Tamil, no mystery; poocha matches Tamil’s everyday cat-word closely, part of the pattern where Dravidian genuinely splits on “cat” more than “dog”

Introduced in Chapter 21.

നെല്ല് *nellŭ*

unhusked rice, rice still in the husk

Introduced in Chapter 66.

നെഞ്ച് *nenchŭ*

chest — Malayalam’s other heart, native this time, and the one everyday idiom reaches for

Introduced in Chapter 38.

നീ / നിങ്ങൾ *nī / ninnāl*

you (familiar / respectful)

Introduced in Chapter 2.

നിൽക്കൂ *nilkkū*

stand

Introduced in Chapter 43.

നിങ്ങൾക്ക് എത്ര വയസ്സുണ്ട്? *ninnālkkŭ ethra vayassuntŭ?*

how old are you? — literally “to you how much age exists?”; the SAME Sanskrit vayas word, but Malayalam adds a dative-subject + existential verb, a genuinely different shape than Kannada/Telugu’s plain possessive

Introduced in Chapter 19.

നിന്റെ പേര് എന്താണ്? *ninre pēru entāṇŭ?*

what’s your name?

Introduced in Chapter 2.

നോക്കൂ *nōkkū*

look

Introduced in Chapter 44.

നൂല് *nūlŭ*

thread

Introduced in Chapter 62.

onnu randu moonnu naalu anchu

hear and say one to five before meeting their written forms

Introduced in Chapter 7.

ഒരുപക്ഷേ *orupakṣē*

perhaps

Introduced in Chapter 49.

ഓടൂ *ōṭū*

run

Introduced in Chapter 43.

പാൽ *paal*

milk — native, matching Tamil exactly, and matching Kannada by the family’s regular p-to-h shift
Introduced in Chapter 39.

പച്ച, മഞ്ഞ *pacca, mañña*

green and yellow — paccha matches Tamil’s paccai almost exactly (the same pan-Dravidian *pac-* root already seen in Kannada and Telugu); *manja* is a completely separate native Dravidian root, a doublet of *manjal* (“turmeric”), matching Tamil’s own *mañcaḷ* — a third, independent solution to this arc’s recurring green/yellow puzzle
Introduced in Chapter 22.

പഴം *palam*

a fruit
Introduced in Chapter 46.

പഴയ *palaya*

old — of a thing, not of a person
Introduced in Chapter 42.

പല്ല *pallu*

a tooth
Introduced in Chapter 47.

പനി *pani*

a fever
Introduced in Chapter 63.

പാറ *pāra*

a rock
Introduced in Chapter 55.

പശു *paśu*

a cow
Introduced in Chapter 60.

പതിനൊന്ന് — ഇരുപത് *pathinonnŭ — irupathŭ*

11-20 — additive “ten-echo” compounds for the teens, then irupathu (20), transparently “two-tens” — iru (“two”) + pathu (“ten”), matching Tamil closely
Introduced in Chapter 20.

പാതിരാ *pāthirā*

midnight, built on Malayalam paathi “half” rather than Sanskrit ardha
Introduced in Chapter 17.

പാത്രം *pātram*

a vessel, a container
Introduced in Chapter 56.

പായ *pāya*

a mat
Introduced in Chapter 56.

പേര് *pēr*

name

Introduced in Chapter 2.

പെട്ടി *petti*

a box

Introduced in Chapter 56.

പിന്നെ *pinne*

then, after that

Introduced in Chapter 64.

പോകുക *pōkuka*

to go (and വരിക, to come)

Introduced in Chapter 4.

പോകുക *pōkuka*

to go — one stem, three tense endings, and each of the three is the entire conjugation

Introduced in Chapter 32.

പോരും *pōrum*

that will do, that is enough

Introduced in Chapter 58.

പോയി വരാം *pōyi varām*

goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)

Introduced in Chapter 4.

പുക *puka*

smoke

Introduced in Chapter 59.

പുഴ *pula*

a river

Introduced in Chapter 55.

പുല്ല് *pullū*

grass

Introduced in Chapter 66.

പുറപ്പെടുക *purappetuka*

to set out

Introduced in Chapter 50.

പുസ്തകം *pustakam*

a book

Introduced in Chapter 46.

പുതിയ *putiya*

new

Introduced in Chapter 42.

പൂവ് *pūvũ*

a flower

Introduced in Chapter 52.

രാത്രി *rāthri*

“night” — the Sanskrit tatsama already shortened inside paathira, with a different PIE root from Latin nox

Introduced in Chapter 24.

രാവിലെ *rāvile*

“morning” (rāvile) — a compound of രാവ് (rāvũ, “night,” a cognate doublet of ഇരവ്/iravũ already met in ML-C24 — same root, not literally the same word) + locative-ish suffixes -il/-e; literally built from NIGHT, not light or rising — a genuinely different strategy than Kannada’s “the shining” or Telugu’s Sanskrit “rise”; പ്രഭാതം (Sanskrit tatsama, the same prabhāta root Telugu draws on) and പുലർച്ച (native, thinner etymology) also exist as alternatives

Introduced in Chapter 26.

സഹായിക്കുക *sahāyikkuka*

to help — “to go along with somebody,” and the fourth time in two chapters that a Sanskrit word has taken an everyday job from an inherited one

Introduced in Chapter 34.

സമ്മതം *sammataṁ*

consent, an agreeing

Introduced in Chapter 65.

സംസാരിക്കൂ *saṁsārikkū*

speak

Introduced in Chapter 44.

സംസാരിക്കുക *saṁsārikkuka*

to speak, to converse

Introduced in Chapter 5.

സന്തോഷം *santōṣam*

joy / pleased to meet you

Introduced in Chapter 2.

സാരമില്ല *sāramilla*

it doesn’t matter / no problem / you’re welcome

Introduced in Chapter 3.

ശരി *sari*

okay / alright / correct (śari)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

ശർക്കര *śarkkara*

jaggery

Introduced in Chapter 61.

സത്യം *satyam*

true, the truth

Introduced in Chapter 49.

ശുഭ മധ്യാഹ്നം *śubha madhyāhnam*

“good afternoon” (*śubha madhyāhnam*), a formal greeting built on a noon synonym rather than the everyday afternoon compound

Introduced in Chapter 31.

ശുഭ രാത്രി *śubha rāthri*

“good night” — the standard Sanskrit-tatsama phrase (*rāthri* already met, *śubha* new); some sources describe modern Malayalam speakers often code-switching to English “good night” instead — the same claim, similarly thinly sourced, is also made about Telugu

Introduced in Chapter 25.

ശുഭ സായാഹ്നം *śubha sāyāhnam*

“good evening” (*śubha sāyāhnam*) — confirmed real, used “from late afternoon until sunset” per a directly-fetched source; built on ശുഭ (ML-C25) + സായാഹ്നം (*sāyāhnam*), a SEPARATE Sanskrit tatsama for “evening,” Wiktionary-labeled “poetic” — NOT built on ML-C27’s native വൈകുന്നേരം; സായാഹ്നം’s own root, साय (“end”), is CONFIRMED via Wiktionary’s separate साय entry to trace to the same PIE *seh₁- as Telugu’s సాయంత్రం (sāyam) and Latin sērus — a properly-verified cognate, not just a plausible guess*

Introduced in Chapter 30.

സൂചി *sūci*

a needle

Introduced in Chapter 62.

സുഹൃത്ത് *suhṛttṛ*

friend — Sanskrit “good-heart,” a root this chapter’s own heart-word will meet again

Introduced in Chapter 35.

സുഖം *sukham*

well-being — and the reply “സുഖമാണ്”

Introduced in Chapter 3.

സുഖമാണോ? *sukhamāṇō?*

how are you? (lit. “are you well?”)

Introduced in Chapter 3.

സുപ്രഭാതം *suprabhātam*

“good morning” (suprabhātam) — Malayalam’s actual, most common morning greeting, confirmed used in BOTH formal and informal contexts, and independently corroborated as the “most general” morning greeting by a SECOND directly-fetched source (not just one); built from su- (“good”) + പ്രഭാതം (already met, ML-C26, “morning/dawn”), NOT from ശുഭ (ML-C25’s “auspicious,” used for Malayalam’s own GREETING-GOODNIGHT) — a genuinely different Sanskrit “good” morpheme; the SAME word as Telugu’s సుప్రభాతం, but with an inverted role: PRIMARY greeting in Malayalam, only a SECONDARY alternative in Telugu (where శుభోదయం, a different root, is primary)

Introduced in Chapter 29.

സൂര്യൻ *sūryan*

the sun

Introduced in Chapter 53.

തൈര് *tairũ*

curd

Introduced in Chapter 61.

താമസിക്കുക *tāmasikkuka*

to live, to stay

Introduced in Chapter 5.

തരു *tarū*

give

Introduced in Chapter 43.

തടി *taṭi*

a trunk, timber

Introduced in Chapter 54.

തേങ്ങ *tēṇṇa*

a coconut

Introduced in Chapter 61.

തല കൈ *thala kai*

head and hand — matching Tamil’s native pair almost exactly

Introduced in Chapter 13.

തിങ്കൾ ചൊവ്വ ബുധൻ വ്യാഴം വെള്ളി ശനി ഞായർ *thiṅkaḷ covva*

budhan vyāzham velli śani ṇāyar

the seven weekdays — Malayalam shares Tamil’s native planet-words, being its closest cousin

Introduced in Chapter 10.

തിന്നുക *tinnuka*

to eat — the inherited Dravidian eat-word Malayalam kept as its everyday one, and the ending that tells a native verb from a borrowed one

Introduced in Chapter 32.

തീർച്ചയായും *tīrccayāyumu*

certainly, for sure

Introduced in Chapter 49.

തൂണി *tūṇi*

cloth

Introduced in Chapter 46.

ഉച്ച *ucca*

noon, most likely from a different Sanskrit metaphor than Kannada and Telugu

— height rather than middle

Introduced in Chapter 17.

ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ *uchakaliṇṇ*

“afternoon” (*uchakaliṇṇ*) — a transparent two-word phrase, not a single

dictionary headword: ഉച്ച (ML-C17’s “noon”) + കഴിഞ്ഞ, the past converb form

of കഴിയുക (*kaliyuka*, Wiktionary-confirmed Proto-Dravidian *kāzi*, “to be over,

spent”) — *Wiktionary itself directly shows only the finite past tense കഴിഞ്ഞു*

(*kaliṇṇu*); the converb form used in this compound is a reasonable grammatical

inference, not itself the form Wiktionary lists; literally “noon having passed” — a

structurally different strategy than Telugu’s, where the SAME noon-word

(*మధ్యాహ്నం*) simply widened its own meaning rather than compounding with a

second word

Introduced in Chapter 28.

ഊണ് *ūṇ*

a meal — the noun behind ഉണ്ണുക, Malayalam’s second eat-verb, standing beside

Chapter 32’s everyday തിന്നുക

Introduced in Chapter 40.

ഉണ്ട് *untũ*

there is, there are, [someone] has — and ഇരിക്കുക, to be somewhere; the

two-piece machine every Malayalam verb is built on

Introduced in Chapter 32.

ഉപകാരം *upakāram*

a favour, a good turn

Introduced in Chapter 51.

ഉപ്പ് *uppũ*

salt

Introduced in Chapter 46.

ഉറങ്ങു *uraṇṇũ*

sleep

Introduced in Chapter 43.

ഉടനെ *utane*

soon, right away

Introduced in Chapter 64.

വൈദ്യൻ *vaidyān*

a doctor

Introduced in Chapter 48.

വൈകുന്നേരം *vaikunnēram*

“evening” (vaikunnēram) — native Dravidian compound, Wiktionary-glossed “latening time,” from വൈക് (vaikū, plausibly the root of വൈകുക, “to get late” — a reasonable inference, not something Wiktionary’s compound entry states outright) + -ഉം (-um) + നേരം (nēram, “time,” itself native Dravidian, not Sanskrit); Wiktionary itself ALSO lists “afternoon” as a second sense, though phrasebook sources cleanly split evening (this word) from afternoon (a separate compound built on ഉച്ച, ML-C17’s “noon,” plus കഴിഞ്ഞ) — an honest source-tension worth flagging, not smoothing over

Introduced in Chapter 27.

വഴി *vali*

a way, a path

Introduced in Chapter 55.

വലിയ *valiya*

big

Introduced in Chapter 42.

വന്ദനം *vandanam*

a salutation

Introduced in Chapter 51.

വരുക *varuka*

to come — and the past tense, the one slot where a Malayalam verb can still surprise you

Introduced in Chapter 32.

വസന്തകാലം വേനൽക്കാലം മഴക്കാലം ശൈത്യകാലം *vasanthakālam**venalkkālam mazhakkālam śaithyakālam*

spring, summer, monsoon, winter — matching Tamil’s pattern of native heat/rain/cold words plus a Sanskrit “spring”

Introduced in Chapter 14.

വാതിൽ *vātil*

a door

Introduced in Chapter 52.

വാക്ക് *vāy*

mouth — the word Chapter 33 already named, only to rule it out

Introduced in Chapter 37.

വയൽ *vayal*

a paddy field

Introduced in Chapter 55.

വയറ് *vayar̥*

the stomach, the belly

Introduced in Chapter 47.

വായിക്കുക *vāyikkuka*

to read — a word that looks as though it were built on വായ്, “mouth,” and is not; the trail runs to Sanskrit वाच्, “speech”
Introduced in Chapter 33.

വേദന *vēdana*

pain
Introduced in Chapter 63.

വെള്ളം അരി ചോറ് *vellam ari cōru*

water (a genuinely DIFFERENT word than Tamil’s), and rice raw/cooked, closely matching Tamil
Introduced in Chapter 15.

വേണ്ട *vēṇṭa*

no need, no thank you
Introduced in Chapter 58.

വേര് *vērũ*

a root
Introduced in Chapter 54.

വെയിൽ *veyil*

sunshine, the sun’s heat
Introduced in Chapter 53.

വിദ്യാർത്ഥി *vidyārtthi*

a student
Introduced in Chapter 48.

വിളക്ക് *vilakkũ*

a lamp
Introduced in Chapter 46.

വീണ്ടും കാണാം *vīṇḍum kāṇāmi*

we’ll meet again
Introduced in Chapter 4.

വിരൽ *viral*

a finger
Introduced in Chapter 47.

വിശപ്പ് *viśappũ*

hunger
Introduced in Chapter 63.

വിശ്വാസം *viśvāsam*

trust
Introduced in Chapter 65.

വിട *viṭa*

leave, a farewell
Introduced in Chapter 50.

വിത്ത് *vittŭ*

a seed

Introduced in Chapter 54.

യാത്ര *yātra*

a journey

Introduced in Chapter 50.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 23

23.1 നാൾ — *the native day-word that narrowed its job*
Has Sanskrit divasam erased native naal?

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 23

23.1 **ကဝေ** — *the native day-word that narrowed its job*

Answer: no

Also accepted: no it has not; nāl still survives; naal still survives

Index

Look up an English meaning, a dedicated language topic, or a chapter topic. Each linked reference opens the chapter where the material is introduced; the focus labels name only explicitly typed lesson sections.

0–9

11-20 — additive “ten-echo” compounds for the teens, then **irupathu** (20), transparently “two-tens” — **iru** (“two”) + **pathu** (“ten”), matching Tamil closely പതിനൊന്ന് — ഇരുപത് (pathinonnŭ — irupathŭ)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 20, p. 143

A

a basket കൊട്ട (koṭṭa)
Chapter 56, p. 329
a blessing അനുഗ്രഹം (anugraham)
Chapter 51, p. 299
a bone എല്ല (ellŭ)
Chapter 57, p. 335
a book പുസ്തകം (pustakam)
Chapter 46, p. 269
a box പെട്ടി (peṭṭi)
Chapter 56, p. 329
a branch കൊമ്പ് (kompŭ)
Chapter 54, p. 317
a broom ചൂല് (cūlŭ)
Chapter 62, p. 365
a chair കസേര (kasēra)
Chapter 52, p. 305

- a chilli മുളക്** (muḷakṣ̣)
Chapter 61, p. 359
- a coconut തേങ്ങ** (tēṇṇa)
Chapter 61, p. 359
- a cough ചുമ** (cuma)
Chapter 63, p. 371
- a cow പശു** (paśu)
Chapter 60, p. 353
- a crow കാക്ക** (kākka)
Chapter 60, p. 353
- a doctor വൈദ്യൻ** (vaidyan)
Chapter 48, p. 281
- a door വാതിൽ** (vātil)
Chapter 52, p. 305
- a farmer കർഷകൻ** (karṣakan)
Chapter 48, p. 281
- a favour, a good turn ഉപകാരം** (upakāram)
Chapter 51, p. 299
- a fever പനി** (pani)
Chapter 63, p. 371
- a finger വിരൽ** (viral)
Chapter 47, p. 275
- a flower പൂവ്** (pūvū)
Chapter 52, p. 305
- a fruit പഴം** (paḷam)
Chapter 46, p. 269
- a garland മാല** (māla)
Chapter 52, p. 305
- a goat ആട്** (āṭṭ)
Chapter 60, p. 353
- a guest അതിഥി** (atithi)
Chapter 48, p. 281
- a hen കോഴി** (kōḷi)
Chapter 60, p. 353
- a journey യാത്ര** (yātra)
Chapter 50, p. 293
- a knife കത്തി** (katti)
Chapter 56, p. 329
- a lamp വിളക്ക്** (viḷakkṣ̣)
Chapter 46, p. 269
- a lip ചുണ്ട്** (cuṇṭṭ)
Chapter 57, p. 335

a little, a few കുറച്ച് (kuraccŭ)

Chapter 58, p. 341

a mat പായ (pāya)

Chapter 56, p. 329

a meal — the noun behind ഉണ്ണുക, Malayalam's second eat-verb, **standing beside Chapter 32's everyday തിന്നുക** ഉണ് (ūṇ)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 40, p. 241

a nail, a claw നഖം (nakham)

Chapter 57, p. 335

a needle സൂചി (sūci)

Chapter 62, p. 365

a paddy field വയൽ (vayal)

Chapter 55, p. 323

a plough കലപ്പ (kalappa)

Chapter 66, p. 389

a request അപേക്ഷ (apēkṣa)

Chapter 65, p. 383

a river പുഴ (puḷa)

Chapter 55, p. 323

a rock പാറ (pāra)

Chapter 55, p. 323

a root വേര് (vēṛ)

Chapter 54, p. 317

a salutation വന്ദനം (vandanam)

Chapter 51, p. 299

a seed വിത്ത് (vittŭ)

Chapter 54, p. 317

a star നക്ഷത്രം (nakṣatram)

Chapter 53, p. 311

a student വിദ്യാർത്ഥി (vidyārtthi)

Chapter 48, p. 281

a teacher അധ്യാപകൻ (adhyāpakan)

Chapter 48, p. 281

a tooth പല്ല് (pallŭ)

Chapter 47, p. 275

a tree മരം (maram)

Chapter 54, p. 317

A Tree, Part by Part

chapter topic; Chapter 54, p. 317

a trunk, timber തടി (taṭi)

Chapter 54, p. 317

a vessel, a container പാത്രം (pātram)

Chapter 56, p. 329

a way, a path വഴി (vali)

Chapter 55, p. 323

a winnowing tray മുറം (muram)

Chapter 62, p. 365

Afternoon

chapter topic; Chapter 28, p. 169

“afternoon” (uchakaliññ) — a transparent two-word phrase, not a single dictionary headword: ഉച്ച (ML-C17’s “noon”) + കഴിഞ്ഞ, the past converb form of കഴിയുക (kaliyuka, Wiktionary-confirmed Proto-Dravidian *kazi*, “to be over, spent”) — *Wiktionary itself directly shows only the finite past tense കഴിഞ്ഞു (kaliññu); the converb form used in this compound is a reasonable grammatical inference, not itself the form Wiktionary lists; literally “noon having passed” — a structurally different strategy than Telugu’s, where the SAME noon-word (మధ్యాహ്నం) simply widened its own meaning rather than compounding with a second word ഉച്ചകഴിഞ്ഞ (uchakaliññ)*

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 28, p. 169

an ear of ripe paddy കതിര് (katirū)

Chapter 66, p. 389

an elephant ആന (āna)

Chapter 60, p. 353

an ember, a live coal കനൽ (kanal)

Chapter 59, p. 347

Animals Around a House

chapter topic; Chapter 60, p. 353

Asking Someone’s Age

chapter topic; Chapter 19, p. 141

Asking Well

chapter topic; Chapter 65, p. 383

B

before the noun, unchanged — five words, one rule

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 42, p. 251

big വലിയ (valiya)

Chapter 42, p. 251

black, white, red, blue — Malayalam shares Tamil’s native colors, and its Sanskrit blue too കറുപ്പ് വെള്ള ചുവപ്പ്

നീല (karuppū vella cuvappū nīla)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 11, p. 111

but, on the other hand എന്നാൽ (ennāl)
Chapter 64, p. 377

C

Case Endings and Dative Subjects

chapter topic; Chapter 6, p. 79

certainly, for sure തീർച്ചയായും (tīrccayāyumi)
Chapter 49, p. 287

**chest — Malayalam’s other heart, native this time, and the one
everyday idiom reaches for** നെഞ്ച് (nenchŭ)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 38, p. 231

**child, kid — the general word, native Dravidian, before
Malayalam narrows to son or daughter** കുട്ടി (kuṭṭi)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 36, p. 217

Child, Son, Daughter
chapter topic; Chapter 36, p. 217

cloth തുണി (tuṇi)
Chapter 46, p. 269

**coffee — an English colonial-era loan, itself from Arabic by way
of Turkish and Italian; tea and coffee arrived by opposite**

roads കാപ്പി (kaapi)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 39, p. 235

coir rope കയർ (kayar)
Chapter 62, p. 365

consent, an agreeing സമ്മതം (sammatam)
Chapter 65, p. 383

Courtesy
chapter topic; Chapter 51, p. 299

curd തൈര് (tairŭ)
Chapter 61, p. 359

D

**daughter — identical to Tamil’s own word, sound for sound,
closer even than the son-word** മകൾ (makal)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 36, p. 217

Day
chapter topic; Chapter 23, p. 153
**“day” — everyday Sanskrit divasam beside the more literary
Sanskrit dinam** ദിവസം (divasam)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 23, p. 153

Days of the Week

chapter topic; Chapter 10, p. 107

Describing Things

chapter topic; Chapter 42, p. 251

Dog and Cat

chapter topic; Chapter 21, p. 147

dog and cat — naaya continues the solid, ancient native**Dravidian dog-root** shared with Kannada and Tamil, no mystery;**poocha** matches Tamil's everyday cat-word closely, part of the pattern where Dravidian genuinely splits on “cat” more than**“dog”** നായ, പുച്ച (nāya, pūcca)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 21, p. 147

E**ear** — where three of the four sisters agree, and the fourth alone**keeps the older sound** ചെവി (cevi)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 37, p. 223

enough, that will do മതി (mati)

Chapter 49, p. 287

Evening

chapter topic; Chapter 27, p. 167

“evening” (vaikunnēraṁ) — native Dravidian compound,

Wiktionary-glossed “latening time,” from വൈക് (vaikū,

plausibly the root of വൈകുക, “to get late” — a reasonable

inference, not something Wiktionary's compound entry states

outright) + -ഉം (-um) + നേരം (nēraṁ, “time,” itself native

Dravidian, not Sanskrit); Wiktionary itself ALSO lists

“afternoon” as a second sense, though phrasebook sources

cleanly split evening (this word) from afternoon (a separate

compound built on ഉച്ച, ML-C17's “noon,” plus കഴിഞ്ഞു) — an

honest source-tension worth flagging, not smoothing

over വൈകുന്നേരം (vaikunnēraṁ)

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 27, p. 167

eye — Proto-Dravidian, nearly identical across all four literary**Dravidian languages** കണ്ണ് (kaṇṇu)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 37, p. 223

F**Face Words**

chapter topic; Chapter 37, p. 223

Family

chapter topic; Chapter 12, p. 115

Family and Friend

chapter topic; Chapter 35, p. 211

family — the collective word Chapter 12’s six people-words**never needed, because each of them already named one specific****person കുടുംബം (kuṭumbam)**

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 35, p. 211

Farewells

chapter topic; Chapter 4, p. 51

father, mother, and four age-graded sibling words —**Malayalam’s own distinct set, still following the shared Dravidian****age-first pattern അച്ഛൻ അമ്മ ചേട്ടൻ അനിയൻ ചേച്ചി****അനിയത്തി (acchan amma cēṭṭan aniyān cēcci aniyatti)**

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 12, p. 115

Five More of the Body

chapter topic; Chapter 57, p. 335

Five More Short Answers

chapter topic; Chapter 58, p. 341

Five numerals — hide, then write

script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 7, p. 87

Five Words That Join

chapter topic; Chapter 64, p. 377

Four Core Colours

chapter topic; Chapter 11, p. 111

friend — Sanskrit “good-heart,” a root this chapter’s own**heart-word will meet again സുഹൃത്ത് (suhṛttū)**

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 35, p. 211

G**give തരൂ (tarū)**

Chapter 43, p. 257

good നല്ല (nalla)

Chapter 42, p. 251

Good Afternoon

chapter topic; Chapter 31, p. 177

“good afternoon” (śubha madhyāhnam), a formal greeting built**on a noon synonym rather than the everyday afternoon****compound ശുഭ മധ്യാഹ്നം (śubha madhyāhnam)**

Chapter 31, p. 177

Good Evening

chapter topic; Chapter 30, p. 173

“good evening” (śubha sâyāhnam) — confirmed real, used “from late afternoon until sunset” per a directly-fetched source; built on ശുഭ (ML-C25) + സായാഹ്നം (sâyāhnam), a SEPARATE Sanskrit tatsama for “evening,” Wiktionary-labeled “poetic” — NOT built on ML-C27’s native വൈകുന്നേരം; സായാഹ്നം’s own root, साय (“end”), is CONFIRMED via Wiktionary’s separate entry to trace to the same PIE *seh₁- as Telugu’s సాయంత్రం* (*sāyam*) and Latin *sērus* — a properly-verified cognate, not just a plausible guess ശുഭ സായാഹ്നം (śubha sâyāhnam)
explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 30, p. 173

good manners മര്യാദ (maryāda)

Chapter 65, p. 383

Good Morning

chapter topic; Chapter 29, p. 171

“good morning” (suprabhātām) — Malayalam’s actual, most common morning greeting, confirmed used in BOTH formal and informal contexts, and independently corroborated as the “most general” morning greeting by a SECOND directly-fetched source (not just one); built from su- (“good”) + പ്രഭാതം (already met, ML-C26, “morning/dawn”), NOT from ശുഭ (ML-C25’s “auspicious,” used for Malayalam’s own

GREETING-GOODNIGHT) — a genuinely different Sanskrit “good” morpheme; the SAME word as Telugu’s సుప్రభాతం, but with an inverted role: PRIMARY greeting in Malayalam, only a SECONDARY alternative in Telugu (where శుభోదయం, a different root, is primary) സുപ്രഭാതം (suprabhātām)

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 29, p. 171

Good Night

chapter topic; Chapter 25, p. 161

“good night” — the standard Sanskrit-tatsama phrase (rāthri already met, śubha new); some sources describe modern Malayalam speakers often code-switching to English “good night” instead — the same claim, similarly thinly sourced, is also made about Telugu ശുഭ രാത്രി (śubha rāthri)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 25, p. 161

goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”) പോയി വരാം (pōyi varām)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 51

grandfather മുത്തച്ഛൻ (muttacchan)

Chapter 45, p. 265

grandmother മുത്തശ്ശി (muttaśśi)

Chapter 45, p. 265

Grandparents, and the Married Pair

chapter topic; Chapter 45, p. 265

grass പുല്ലു (pullu)

Chapter 66, p. 389

gratitude കൃതജ്ഞത (kṛtajñata)

Chapter 51, p. 299

Green and Yellow

chapter topic; Chapter 22, p. 151

green and yellow — *paccha* matches Tamil's *paccai* almost exactly (the same pan-Dravidian *pac-* root already seen in *Kannada and Telugu*); *manja* is a completely separate native Dravidian root, a doublet of *manjal* ("turmeric"), matching Tamil's own *mañcaḷ* — a third, independent solution to this arc's recurring green/yellow puzzle പച്ച, മഞ്ഞ (pacca, mañña)
explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 22, p. 151

Greetings

chapter topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

Ground Underfoot

chapter topic; Chapter 55, p. 323

H**hair** മുടി (muṭi)

Chapter 47, p. 275

Head and Hand

chapter topic; Chapter 13, p. 117

head and hand — matching Tamil's native pair almost exactly തല കൈ (thala kai)

Chapter 13, p. 117

hear and say one to five before meeting their written forms *onnu randu moonnu naalu anchu*

explicit focus: pronunciation, usage and culture; Chapter 7, p. 87

hear and say six to ten before meeting their written forms *aaru ezhu ettu ompathu pathu*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 7, p. 87

Heard numbers — write without a model

script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 7, p. 87

heart — Sanskrit *tatsama*, and a genuine (if distant) cousin of the English word ഹൃദയം (hṛdayam)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 38, p. 231

hello / greetings (namaskāram — a making of a bow) നമസ്കാരം (namaskāram)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

here — where I am ഇവിടെ (iviṭe)

Chapter 41, p. 245

home country, the place you are from നാട് (nāṭṭ)

Chapter 55, p. 323

hour — Malayalam’s OWN dictionary tradition treats bell/hour/gem as ONE Sanskrit word, unlike Tamil’s closely related mani, which its own dictionaries split into two unrelated

homophones മണി (maṇi)

explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 18, p. 137

how എങ്ങനെ (eṅṅane)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 39

How Are You?

chapter topic; Chapter 3, p. 39

how are you? (lit. “are you well?”) സുഖമാണോ? (sukhamāṇō?)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 39

how old are you? — literally “to you how much age exists?”; the SAME Sanskrit vayas word, but Malayalam adds a dative-subject + existential verb, a genuinely different shape than Kannada/Telugu’s plain possessive നിങ്ങൾക്ക് എത്ര

വയസ്സുണ്ട്? (niñṇaḷkkū ethra vayassuṇṭṭu?)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 19, p. 141

How the Body Reports

chapter topic; Chapter 63, p. 371

hunger വിശപ്പ് (viśappṭ)

Chapter 63, p. 371

husband ഭർത്താവ് (bharttāvṭ)

Chapter 45, p. 265

I

I ഞാൻ (ñān)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 39

i- / a- / e- — six words, one machine

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 41, p. 245

‘I know Malayalam’ — built with no subject, because knowing happens TO you എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം (enikku malayāḷam ariyām)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 6, p. 79

‘I like Malayalam’ — a noun, a copula, and a dative; the one sentence in this book where putting yourself in the subject slot is not merely odd but impossible എനിക്ക് മലയാളം

ഇഷ്ടമാണ് (enikku malayāḷam iṣṭamāṇṭ)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 203

I speak Malayalam ഞാൻ മലയാളം സംസാരിക്കുന്നു (ñān malayāḷaṁ san̄sārikkunnu)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 61

Introducing Yourself

chapter topic; Chapter 2, p. 17

is (the copula) ആണ് (āṇṁ)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 17

it doesn't matter / no problem / you're

welcome സാരമില്ല (sāramilla)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 39

J

jaggery ശർക്കര (śarkkara)

Chapter 61, p. 359

joy / pleased to meet you സന്തോഷം (santōṣam)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 17

L

leave, a farewell വിട (viṭa)

Chapter 50, p. 293

leg, foot കാൽ (kāḷ)

Chapter 47, p. 275

less, a shortage കുറവ് (kuravṁ)

Chapter 58, p. 341

listen കേൾക്കൂ (kēḷkkū)

Chapter 44, p. 261

look നോക്കൂ (nōkkū)

Chapter 44, p. 261

M

Made by Hand

chapter topic; Chapter 62, p. 365

midnight, built on Malayalam paathi “half” rather than Sanskrit

ardha പാതിരാ (pāthirā)

Chapter 17, p. 133

milk — native, matching Tamil exactly, and matching Kannada

by the family's regular p-to-h shift പാൽ (paal)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 39, p. 235

more കൂടുതൽ (kūṭṭal)

Chapter 58, p. 341

More Everyday Verbs

chapter topic; Chapter 43, p. 257

Morning

chapter topic; Chapter 26, p. 165

“**morning**” (rāvile) — a compound of രാവ് (rāvũ, “night,” a cognate doublet of ഇരവ്/iravũ already met in ML-C24 — same root, not literally the same word) + locative-ish suffixes -il/-e; literally built from NIGHT, not light or rising — a genuinely different strategy than Kannada’s “the shining” or Telugu’s Sanskrit “rise”; പ്രഭാതം (Sanskrit tatsama, the same prabhāta root Telugu draws on) and പുലർച്ച (native, thinner etymology) also exist as alternatives രാവിലെ (rāvile)

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 26, p. 165

mouth — the word Chapter 33 already named, only to rule it out വായ് (vāy)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 37, p. 223

mud ചെളി (ceḷi)

Chapter 59, p. 347

my എന്റെ (enre)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 17

my name is... എന്റെ പേര് ... ആണ് (enre pēru ... āṇṁ)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 17

N

name പേര് (pēr)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 17

new പുതിയ (putiya)

Chapter 42, p. 251

Night

chapter topic; Chapter 24, p. 157

“**night**” — the Sanskrit tatsama already shortened inside paathira, with a different PIE root from Latin nox രാത്രി (rāthri)

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 24, p. 157

no need, no thank you വേണ്ട (vēṇṭa)

Chapter 58, p. 341

no / there isn’t (illa — the negative) ഇല്ല (illa)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

Noon and Midnight

chapter topic; Chapter 17, p. 133

noon, most likely from a different Sanskrit metaphor than
Kannada and Telugu — height rather than middle ഉച്ച (ucca)
 explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 17, p. 133
**nose — native Dravidian, a fourth near-perfect match across the
 family** മൂക്കു (mūkkū)
 explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 37, p. 223
now ഇപ്പോൾ (ippōl)
 Chapter 50, p. 293
Numbers 11–20 and Weather
 chapter topic; Chapter 20, p. 143
Numbers One to Ten
 chapter topic; Chapter 7, p. 87

O

oil എണ്ണ (eṇṇa)
 Chapter 61, p. 359
okay / alright / correct (śari) ശരി (sari)
 explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1
old — of a thing, not of a person പഴയ (paḷaya)
 Chapter 42, p. 251
On the Kitchen Shelf
 chapter topic; Chapter 61, p. 359
ഃ — one character, met inside words you already say
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 2, p. 17
ീ — one character, met inside words you already say
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 2, p. 17
ു — one character, met inside words you already say
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 2, p. 17
െ — one character, met inside words you already say
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 3, p. 39
ൂ — one character, met inside words you already say
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 4, p. 51
ൊ — one character, met inside words you already say
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 5, p. 61
ൗ — one character, met inside words you already say
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 87
ി — one character, met inside words you already say
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 8, p. 99
ൊ — one character, met inside words you already say
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 9, p. 103
ോ — one character, met inside words you already say
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 15, p. 125

◌ം — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 16, p. 129

ഃ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 35, p. 211

One greeting, three afternoon strategies

etymology topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 31, p. 177

One heard greeting — write the whole

script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 1, p. 1

only, that much and no more മാത്രം (mātram)

Chapter 64, p. 377

Out in the Paddy

chapter topic; Chapter 66, p. 389

Overhead

chapter topic; Chapter 53, p. 311

P

pain വേദന (vēdana)

Chapter 63, p. 371

perhaps ഒരുപക്ഷേ (orupakṣē)

Chapter 49, p. 287

permission അനുവാദം (anuvādam)

Chapter 65, p. 383

Please

chapter topic; Chapter 8, p. 99

**please (dayavāyi — “as a compassion,” from ദയ dayā
“compassion”) ദയവായി (dayavāyi)**

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 8, p. 99

Pointing, and Asking

chapter topic; Chapter 41, p. 245

R

respect ബഹുമാനം (bahumānam)

Chapter 51, p. 299

run ഓടൂ (ōṭū)

Chapter 43, p. 257

S

salt ഉപ്പ് (uppū)

Chapter 46, p. 269

sand മണൽ (maṇal)

Chapter 59, p. 347

Seasons

chapter topic; Chapter 14, p. 121

see you tomorrow നാളെ കാണാം (nāḷe kāṇām)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 51

Short Replies

chapter topic; Chapter 49, p. 287

sleep ഉറങ്ങൂ (uṛaṅṅū)

Chapter 43, p. 257

small ചെറിയ (ceṛiya)

Chapter 42, p. 251

smoke പുക (puka)

Chapter 59, p. 347

sometimes ചിലപ്പോൾ (cilappōḷ)

Chapter 64, p. 377

son — Proto-Dravidian, closely matching Tamil, where Kannada

softened the same root മകൻ (makan)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 36, p. 217

soon, right away ഉടനെ (uṭane)

Chapter 64, p. 377

Sorry

chapter topic; Chapter 9, p. 103

speak സംസാരിക്കൂ (saṁsārikkū)

Chapter 44, p. 261

spring, summer, monsoon, winter — matching Tamil’s pattern of native heat/rain/cold words plus a Sanskrit

“spring” വസന്തകാലം വേനൽക്കാലം മഴക്കാലം

ശൈത്യകാലം (vasanthakālam venalkkālam mazhakkālam śaithyakālam)

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 14, p. 121

stand നിൽക്കൂ (nilkkū)

Chapter 43, p. 257

sunshine, the sun’s heat വെയിൽ (veyil)

Chapter 53, p. 311

T

Taking, Asking, Helping, Liking

chapter topic; Chapter 34, p. 203

Taking Leave

chapter topic; Chapter 50, p. 293

tea — Chinese, carried overland through Persian and Hindi

before it ever reached Kerala ചായ (chaaya)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 39, p. 235

Tea, Coffee, Milk

chapter topic; Chapter 39, p. 235

Telling Time

chapter topic; Chapter 18, p. 137

thank you (nandi — the native Dravidian word, Tamil's

cousin) നന്ദി (nandi)

explicit focus: script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

that one — the thing over there അത് (atŭ)

Chapter 41, p. 245

that way, just so അങ്ങനെ (aṅṅane)

Chapter 49, p. 287

that will do, that is enough പോരും (pōrum)

Chapter 58, p. 341

the back മുതുകു് (mutukŭ)

Chapter 57, p. 335

The Core Verbs

chapter topic; Chapter 32, p. 183

the dative suffix -ikku, 'to / for' — and the idea of

stacking -ിക് (-ikku)

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 6, p. 79

the day after tomorrow മറ്റന്നാൾ (marrannāl)

Chapter 50, p. 293

The First Verbs

chapter topic; Chapter 5, p. 61

the harvest, the reaping കൊയ്ത്തു് (koyttŭ)

Chapter 66, p. 389

The Leg and the Tooth

chapter topic; Chapter 47, p. 275

The Meal

chapter topic; Chapter 40, p. 241

The Mind and the Page

chapter topic; Chapter 33, p. 195

the moon ചന്ദ്രൻ (candran)

Chapter 53, p. 311

the neck കഴുത്തു് (kaluttŭ)

Chapter 57, p. 335

the pattern drawn at a doorway കോലം (kōlani)

Chapter 52, p. 305

the seven weekdays — Malayalam shares Tamil’s native planet-words, being its closest cousin തിങ്കൾ ചൊവ്വ ബുധൻ വ്യാഴം വെള്ളി ശനി ഞായർ (thiṅkaḷ covva budhan vyāzham vellī śani ñāyar)
explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 10, p. 107

the sky ആകാശം (ākāśam)

Chapter 53, p. 311

the stomach, the belly വയറ് (vayaṛṭṭ)

Chapter 47, p. 275

the sun സൂര്യൻ (sūryan)

Chapter 53, p. 311

The Traditional Months

chapter topic; Chapter 16, p. 129

the twelve months of the Malayalam (Kollam Era) solar calendar — also solar, like Tamil’s, but named for ZODIAC SIGNS rather than nakshatras ചിങ്ങം കന്നി തുലാം വൃശ്ചികം ധനു മകരം കുംഭം മീനം മേടം ഇടവം മിഥുനം കർക്കടകം (ciṅṅam kanni tulām vṛścikanḥ dhanu makaram kumbham mīnam mēṭam iṭavam mithunam karkkaṭakam)
explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 16, p. 129

The Two Hearts

chapter topic; Chapter 38, p. 231

then, after that പിന്നെ (pinne)

Chapter 64, p. 377

there is, there are, [someone] has — and ഇരിക്കുക, to be somewhere; the two-piece machine every Malayalam verb is built on ഉണ്ട് (uṇṭṭ)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 32, p. 183

there — where I am not അവിടെ (aviṭe)

Chapter 41, p. 245

Things About the House

chapter topic; Chapter 56, p. 329

Things You Ask For

chapter topic; Chapter 46, p. 269

this one — the thing near me ഇത് (itṭ)

Chapter 41, p. 245

thread നൂൽ (nūḷṭ)

Chapter 62, p. 365

Three heard numbers — write their numerals

script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 7, p. 87

tiredness ക്ഷീണം (kṣīṇam)

Chapter 63, p. 371

to ask — a Sanskrit word for pushing that walked into a gap Malayalam had made by narrowing its own inherited verb to “hear” ചോദിക്കുക (cōdikkuka)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 203

to come — and the past tense, the one slot where a Malayalam verb can still surprise you വരുക (varuka)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 32, p. 183

to eat — the inherited Dravidian eat-word Malayalam kept as its everyday one, and the ending that tells a native verb from a borrowed one തിന്നുക (tinnuka)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 32, p. 183

to go (and വരിക, to come) പോകുക (pōkuka)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 51

to go — one stem, three tense endings, and each of the three is the entire conjugation പോകുക (pōkuka)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 32, p. 183

to help — “to go along with somebody,” and the fourth time in two chapters that a Sanskrit word has taken an everyday job from an inherited one സഹായിക്കുക (sahāyikkuka)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 203

to know — the verb inside എനിക്ക് മലയാളം അറിയാം, and the one that will not let you be the subject അറിയുക (ariyuka)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar; Chapter 32, p. 183

to live, to stay താമസിക്കുക (tāmasikkuka)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 61

to read — a word that looks as though it were built on വായ്, “mouth,” and is not; the trail runs to Sanskrit വാച്, “speech” വായിക്കുക (vāyikkuka)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 33, p. 195

to see — the family’s shared see-root, kept as Malayalam’s everyday word, and the mood endings that share one slot with tense കാണുക (kāṇuka)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 32, p. 183

to set out പുറപ്പെടുക (purappetuka)

Chapter 50, p. 293

to speak, to converse സംസാരിക്കുക (saṁsārikkuka)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 61

to take — native to the bone, yet ending in -ക്കുക like the borrowings; the letter that actually does the stamping is the ഇ എടുക്കുക (eṭukkuka)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 203

to think — a Sanskrit noun turned into a verb by the same -ഇക്കുക that made ക്ഷമിക്കുക, and the first of four verbs about what happens inside a head ചിന്തിക്കുക (cintikkuka)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 33, p. 195

to understand — literally “to put it in the mind,” a three-piece word you can take apart by ear, with a second form that hands the understanding to you instead മനസ്സിലാക്കുക (manassilākkuka)
explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 33, p. 195

to work (lit. “work-do”) ജോലി ചെയ്യുക (jōli ceyyuka)
explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 61

to write — the same word as Tamil எழுது, carrying the 9 that only these two sisters kept, and the chapter’s closing count of four എഴുതുക (eḷutuka)
explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 33, p. 195

true, the truth സത്യം (satyaṁ)
Chapter 49, p. 287

trust വിശ്വാസം (viśvāsaṁ)
Chapter 65, p. 383

Two heard beats — **write them**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 1, p. 1

U

unhusked rice, rice still in the husk നെല്ല് (nellŭ)
Chapter 66, p. 389

V

Verbs of Seeing and Saying
chapter topic; Chapter 44, p. 261

W

water (a genuinely DIFFERENT word than Tamil’s), and **rice raw/cooked, closely matching Tamil** വെള്ളം അരി ചോറ് (vellam ari cōru)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 15, p. 125

Water and Rice
chapter topic; Chapter 15, p. 125

we’ll meet again വീണ്ടും കാണാം (vīṇḍuṁ kāṇāṁ)
explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 51

weather — a Sanskrit compound literally meaning “state of TIME”: kaala (“time”) + avastha (“state, condition”) — a real echo of Spanish’s tiempo meaning both “time” AND

“weather” കാലാവസ്ഥ (kālavastha)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 20, p. 143

Welcoming a Guest

chapter topic; Chapter 52, p. 305

well-being — and the reply “സുഖമാണ്” സുഖം (sukham)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 39

what എന്ത് (entü)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 17

what’s your name? നിന്റെ പേര് എന്താണ്? (ninre pēru entāṇŭ?)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 17

What the Air Carries

chapter topic; Chapter 59, p. 347

where? — asking about a place എവിടെ (eviṭe)

Chapter 41, p. 245

who? — asking about a person ആര് (ārŭ)

Chapter 41, p. 245

Who Someone Is

chapter topic; Chapter 48, p. 281

wife ഭാര്യ (bhārya)

Chapter 45, p. 265

wind കാറ്റ് (kārrŭ)

Chapter 59, p. 347

write എഴുതൂ (elutū)

Chapter 44, p. 261

Y

yes (athe — “that [is so]”) അതെ (athe)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

you (familiar / respectful) നീ / നിങ്ങൾ (nī / niṇṇaḷ)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 17

(you) should forgive / sorry (kṣamikkaṇaṁ — from kṣamikkuka

“to forgive,” Sanskrit kṣama + necessitative

-aṇaṁ) ക്ഷമിക്കണം (kṣamikkaṇaṁ)

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 9, p. 103

Other

അ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 1, p. 1

ആ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 2, p. 17

ഇ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 3, p. 39

ഇരവ് / ഇരുൾ — **two native words, two jobs**
etymology topic; Chapter 24, p. 157

ഉ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 4, p. 51

ഉൗ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 31, p. 177

എ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 2, p. 17

ഏ · ഴ — **two letters unlock the second row**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 87

ഏഴ് — **hide, then write**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 7, p. 87

ഒ — **one new letter unlocks five familiar words**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 87

ഓ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 3, p. 39

ക — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 6, p. 79

ഗ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 39, p. 235

ച — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 5, p. 61

ജ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 5, p. 61

ഞ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 5, p. 61

ട — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 13, p. 117

ണ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 2, p. 17

ത — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 13, p. 117

ഥ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 37, p. 223

ദ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 20, p. 143

- ന** — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 10, p. 107
- ന • മ** — **two sounds you already heard**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 1, p. 1
- നമ** — **one delayed copy**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 1, p. 1
- നമ** — **one guided copy**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 1, p. 1
- നമസ്കാരം** — **every shape is already yours**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 1, p. 1
- നാൾ** — **the native day-word that narrowed its job**
etymology topic; Chapter 23, p. 153
- പ** — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 2, p. 17
- ഭ** — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 25, p. 161
- മ** — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 11, p. 111
- യ** — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 5, p. 61
- ഓ • ഓ • ഓ** — **finish the sound inventory**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 1, p. 1
- ഓ** — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 6, p. 79
- ഔ** — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 2, p. 17
- ല** — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 5, p. 61
- ഴ** — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 14, p. 121
- വ** — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 4, p. 51
- ഘ** — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 18, p. 137
- സ** — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 21, p. 147
- സ • ള • ക** — **build ska without a leap**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 1, p. 1
- സന്തോഷം** — **copy one known word with help**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 2, p. 17
- സന്തോഷം** — **one delayed copy**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 3, p. 39
- ഹ** — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 5, p. 61

- ൧ · ൨ · ൩ — **three numeral shapes**
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 87
- ൧ ൨ ൩ ൪ ⑤ — **one visible copy**
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 7, p. 87
- ൪ · ⑤ — **finish the first five numerals**
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 87
- ൬ · ൭ · ൮ — **three more numeral shapes**
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 87
- ൬ ൭ ൮ ൯ ൧൦ — **one supported copy**
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 7, p. 87
- ൯ · ൧൦ — **nine and ten**
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 87
- ൺ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 2, p. 17
- ൯ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 5, p. 61
- ൺ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 5, p. 61
- ൺ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
 script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 2, p. 17